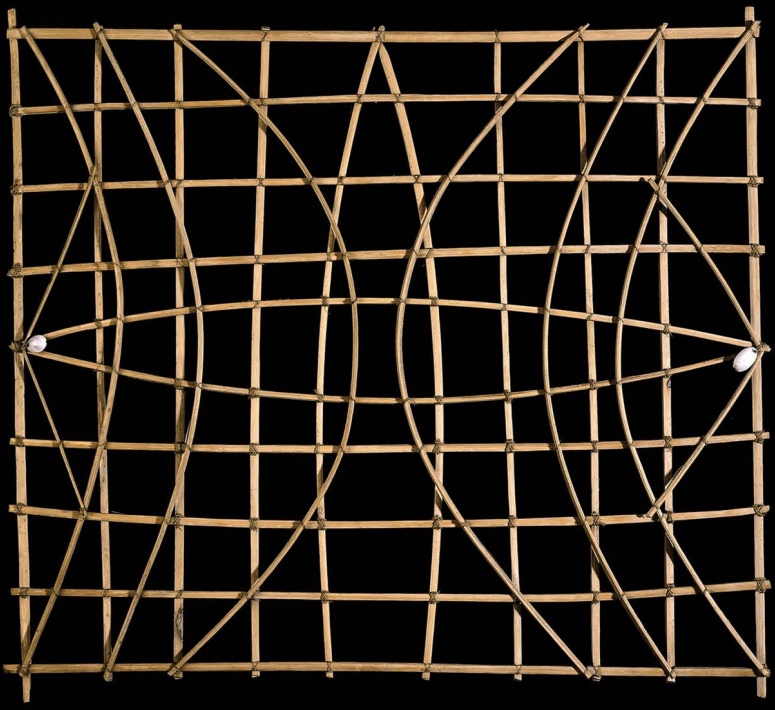


GLOBAL ASIAS

Tactics & Theories

Edited by TINA CHEN
and CHARLOTTE EUBANKS

Global Asias



GLOBAL ASIAS

METHOD, ARCHITECTURE, PRAXIS

Edited by
Tina Chen and Charlotte Eubanks, series editors

Global Asias: Tactics & Theories
Edited by Tina Chen and Charlotte Eubanks

Global Asias

Tactics & Theories

Edited by

Tina Chen and Charlotte Eubanks



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For those who have been looking to be part of a
Global Asias community

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Our families and each other!

About the cover

The image on the cover is of a navigation chart, called a *mattang,* from the Marshall Islands. Centuries ago, the Marshallese developed their own system of piloting and navigation so that they could traverse the ocean in outrigger canoes. Their collective navigational wisdom was recorded in *mattang* stick charts, which were created to index currents and wave and wind patterns, and which marked locations of atolls and islands. The chart featured on the cover of this volume shows the swell of the ocean and how that moves between island groups; it was likely used to instruct beginners in the art of reading and constructing charts.

As an Indigenous epistemological tool, the *mattang* suggests in a powerful way many of the themes and concerns of this volume. As a *mattang* might register larger patterns of oceanic swell and the ways in which islands and outcroppings interact with that swell to subtly shift or steadily

disrupt its patterns, we hope this volume registers some of the ways in which temporary epistemological coalitions of scholars might alter scholarly patterns. Importantly, in Marshallese society, a *mattang* is an intensely personal device, created by and for an individual navigator, and is meant to be used in the actual praxes of navigation. While our praxes in this volume therefore differ from Marshallese forms of knowledge transmission, we nevertheless hope that this book assists you, as readers and as potential interlocutors, in the intensive work of transiting to imaginable a/geographies.

Waymarks

A Reader's Guide

Charlotte Eubanks and Tina Chen

Welcome. We are glad you have picked up this volume and we invite you into its pages, invite you to become a part of the ongoing conversations we stage here, and invite you to begin others. What you will find here is a rich cacophony, the voices of twenty scholars whose conversations, conducted over a full year and more, are here interwoven into a noisy chorus that is, by turns, melismatic, choppy, harmonious, and discordant. So welcome again; there is plenty of room for your voice.

In composing this volume, we have challenged ourselves to engage in extended and extensive acts of suspension. By "acts of suspension" we mean to invoke a method of collaborative thinking that begins by defamiliarizing notions of scholarly expertise and legibility—not in order to discount those things (be they fields, disciplines, or inherited genres of academic prose), but in order to de-exceptionalize them. Grounding oneself in a field or anchoring oneself through a single-author monograph is useful work, to be sure, but it produces knowledge in a specific set of ways. To think about knowledge differently, one must enact it differently. To think about and with something as vast, unwieldy, and mercurial as Global Asias, we explore forms of knowledge production that are collaborative and polyvocal, forms that invite individual scholars to suspend their standard operating

procedures. More specifically, by inviting our collaborators to entangle themselves in conversation with others using different assumptions and working methods, we hope to cultivate new forms of scholarly praxis and to compose scholarship collaboratively in ways that show the seams, synergies, impasses, and surprises of our discussions. Being suspended and being committed to suspension as both a theory and a tactic for a Global Asias praxis enables us to experience the affective dimensions of our approach. We are *in suspense* about what might be possible through such a praxis, and that suspense brings with it many different feelings: apprehension, anticipation, exhilaration.

You will find a more extended consideration of suspension in the editors' introduction, and you will see it enacted across this volume, but as you consider how (or if) you might want to take part, it may be helpful to have some context. Thus, this reader's guide provides four things. First: a limited **genealogy**, some stories of what happened in our local environment, which shaped why and how we built this version of Global Asias, exemplified in this book and the other projects run through the Penn State Global Asias Initiative. Second: a sketch of the broader **ecology**, an account of where this volume fits into the living network of connections, conversations, experiments, and explorations we have fostered over the last decade under the aegis of Global Asias. Third: a **navigation log**, a nuts-and-bolts description of how, given the structuring conditions of our genealogy and the possibilities nurtured in our ecology, we came to build this particular book. Finally: a **guided invitation**, a brief set of suggestions for how you might engage in certain necessary, and necessarily experimental, acts of suspension.

Genealogy

Genealogies are messy. Origin stories are multiple.

Here is one version: In 2006, the dean of the College of Liberal Arts at Penn State convened a working group of faculty members, charging them (us) to lay the groundwork for the foundation of an East Asian studies program. Up to that point, Asian studies on campus had been disparate. The Department of Comparative Literature, as part of its mission to offer instruction in less-commonly-taught languages and literatures, had created a robust environment of Chinese, Japanese, Korean, Arabic, and (sometimes)

Hindi or Farsi while also cultivating a range of courses in the literatures and visual cultures of East, South, and West Asia. The History Department, which had built strengths in early modern globalization and which had taken on a roster of religious studies scholars when that department was dissolved, was home to a number of faculty specializing in maritime East Asia, trans-colonial South Asia, early China, and Confucian and neo-Confucian thought. Other scholars with connections to Asia dotted the campus, often singly or with at most one or two other colleagues, in Linguistics, Political Science, Business, Art History, Economics, Geography, and so forth.

The challenge was to build a community. Administratively, it was clear that a department of (East?) Asian studies was coming, that the language offerings (and associated instructors, and student credit hours and majors) would move from Comparative Literature to that new department, that multiple faculty members would see their lines split across departments (for example, with 75 percent of their job in History and the other 25 percent in Asian Studies), that new majors and minors would need to be created, and so forth. There was some distrust, born both of a pragmatic concern around competition for campus resources and of an intellectual and political wariness regarding the cold war origins of area studies in the United States. Under the leadership of Eric Hayot, who became the first head of the Asian Studies program, this faculty group took three years (2006–2009) to have conversations with one another, to get to know one another, to consider what our undergraduate and graduate students wanted to learn, to gauge the administrative demands and explore the structural possibilities, and to let people decide (for themselves, whenever possible) whether they wanted to be involved. July 2009 saw the inauguration of the Department of Asian Studies at Penn State as a multidisciplinary unit with strengths in literature, history, classical philosophy, and modern Northeast Asian languages and cultures. Three years of conversations between humanists and social scientists had also generated a department that was curious about the different ways that "Asia" was defined, or simply assumed as self-evident, in our various fields and disciplines. This is an origin story that follows, mostly, a familiar narrative of institutional consolidation.

Here is another story: In 2008, the Penn State English Department hired its first (and only) Asian Americanist. In the spirit of supporting the new program, the dean invited Tina Chen to put 25 percent of her line in Asian

Studies. This invitation was simultaneously unwelcome and appreciated given the ways it emblematized both the problems and the possibilities of institutional consolidation. As most of our readers will already know, area studies and ethnic studies are distinct interdisciplines and their contradistinctive approaches to the study of culture and cultural differences had historically positioned them in antagonistic relation. However, even as the institutional motives for including an Asian American studies scholar in an Asian studies program primarily involved efficiency, limited resources, and maximizing impact, the intellectual possibilities of such engagement presented a significant opportunity for bringing these historically oppositional knowledge forms into nonaligned relation. In other words, by differentiating institutional consolidation from intellectual cooperation, the conversations we were having shifted and we recognized not just the opportunity but the importance of conceptualizing Global Asias as a multidisciplinary, trans-field approach to the study of Asia and its multiple diasporas.

We realized that the academic knowledge silos we were inhabiting actually made it harder than it should be to think about Asia and the world on a more global, transhistorical scale, and to think about Asia in relation to its multiple and proliferating diasporas. Even as Asian studies and Asian American studies had historically focused more on the distinctions between the fields than the similarities, renewed attention to issues of diaspora, Transpacific displacements and affiliations, and comparative work suggested the increasing importance of acknowledging the synergies possible between them. Our conceptual realizations concerning Global Asias as a response to these developments were accompanied by a practical understanding: that bringing area studies and ethnic studies into nonaligned relation would require the building of infrastructure. The gaps between Asian studies and Asian American studies stemmed from more than the different assumptions, priorities, and critical genealogies informing these distinct interdisciplines; they were also reinforced by the lack of institutional spaces and scholarly structures designed to cross-pollinate conversation across disciplinary and field boundaries.

Which brings us to a third narrative of origins: An interesting littoral space began to develop among the ever-changing wrack lines and swash zones of institutional consolidation and intellectual collaboration—a space

where, as a faculty, we tried to allow ourselves to stay suspended in unfamiliar currents while remaining responsible to one another. Did we have (did we want?) a shared notion of "Asia"? What we read, and where we published, made a difference: we found that our intellectual zones of habitation were often segregated by geography, history, or disciplinary focus, and we grew more interested in finding spaces, building places, where we could conceivably think together and be in conversation. Some models suggested themselves. Transnational studies, for one, but "transnational" assumes "nations," which are problematic for premodernists and which have been problematized in much Asian American scholarship. "Transpacific" provided another framing, but we were also interested in Indian Ocean zones, in the resonances and discords between Pacific and Atlantic spaces, and in Central Asian gyres of cultural circulation. So we thought about collectively building a journal, *Verge: Studies in Global Asias,* which could operate as a platform for making these conversations and other kinds of collaboration possible. When we published our first issue in spring 2015, we did not so much have a theory of "Global Asias" as we did a belief that building the journal as a space for collaborative engagement, and creating new genres of academic writing that would work to make conversations across field and disciplinary boundaries possible, would enable us to collectively generate multiple theories of and for Global Asias. As we have said before, working on the journal over the last decade has produced a concept of Global Asias that is still (and always) in process.

Each of these origin stories is true, if summative. And each is also partial, only a fragment of an evolving narrative. What they share, or what became shared between them, was an ethos of trying to take what could have been a top-down, bureaucratic mandate to build an institutional structure (something like an area studies department in which we would labor) and to build it into an infrastructure (something like an ecology in which we, and others, could potentially thrive).

Over the course of our multiyear process, four hallmarks emerged. If we were going (to have) to build something, we wanted to build it *collaboratively:* there would be to-and-fro, listening and deciding and then undeciding, trying various options to see what allowed us to meet structural demands with as little pain and as much freedom as possible. If we

were going to build something, we wanted it to be *multidisciplinary:* we would make courses, speakers' series, departmental events, and conferences that put humanists and social scientists into active conversation again and again. If we were going to build something, we wanted it to *encourage unconsolidation.* Though we would build structures to keep us in dialogue across and between disciplines, time periods, methodologies, and approaches, we were not interested in terms of allegiance, praxes of flattening, or forms of gatekeeping. Finally, if we were going to build something, we wanted it to be formally and generically *innovative.* Here, an attentive evaluation of area studies, both its possibilities and its complex histories, became a moment of promise: could we strip out some of the "know your (potential) enemy" mechanics of twentieth-century hot and cold war area studies, rewiring or hotwiring Asian studies into a way to hold space for Asian American studies on campus, to make space for conversations across ethnic studies and Indigenous studies, and to think seriously about diaspora? We tried many things at Penn State (some of which, inevitably, failed or faded), but we also tried many things beyond Penn State: in addition to *Verge,* we created the Global Asias Initiative, a research enterprise that sponsors a biennial Global Asias conference series, a Global Asias Summer Institute (which mentors early-career scholars), a Global Asias Cyber Chats program, and most recently the Global Asias: Method, Architecture, Praxis (Global Asias MAP) book series with the University of Hawai'i Press, of which this is the inaugural volume. We built *Global Asias: Tactics & Theories* to exemplify the four hallmarks of our approach: collaboration, multidisciplinarity, unconsolidation, and innovation.

As the brief genealogy offered here should demonstrate, it is important for us to approach Global Asias as both a theory and a tactic, as an interwoven praxis. On the one hand, we acknowledge that the academy in its current form tends to read theory and tactic as distinct: "theory" is research and "tactic" is pedagogy. In institutional parlance, some of us have "tactic" jobs (language instructors and teaching faculty, for instance) while others have "theory" jobs (paradigmatically, tenure-line faculty at research-intensive universities). Educational institutions erect any number of barriers between the two categories of labor, barriers that include pay grade, ability to access research or travel funding, course load, class size, and so on. As you will see in this volume, however, we think that theory and tactic

are deeply intertwined. Yes, you will find a "theory" part to each convergence—here we have referred to them as "research forums"—and you will find a "praxis" part to each convergence, consisting of pedagogical notes, outlines, sources, syllabi, and exercises. And, yes, we have placed the research forums first in each instance, followed by the pedagogical materials. But this is not a hierarchy. Rather, it is a record of collaboration, multidisciplinarity, unconsolidation, and innovation. Take a group of three or four scholars, have them discuss a keyword for a year, ask them to reflect on how those discussions have been shaped by and have shaped their research, encourage them to listen to disagreement and stay in productive tension, bring them together in person for a week, and ask them to imagine how they and others might teach the process of this keyword. Different theoretical discussions both require and engender different pedagogical tactics. Experimental pedagogical experiences (such as this multiyear collaboration) yield altered theoretical approaches and different formats for written presentation. Tactics and theories comprise, together, a praxis.

Ecology

Andrew Leong, navigating by way of Gloria Anzaldúa (1990), draws attention to an apt metaphor for describing the ecology of Global Asias: the sandbar as a matter (the aggregated matter) of "elective and temporary affinities" (Leong 2021, 1020). What you are reading now both is—and is not—an edited collection. Yes, it is a volume with a scholarly introduction, five collaboratively authored chapters, five sets of pedagogical resources, and an index. Perhaps more accurately, though, what you are engaging with here is the product of many sedimented layers of conversation showing numerous tugs of interest and currents of inquiry. It is a temporary, coalitional sandbar. This volume is part of a long-term overlapping ecology of intellectual inquiry, mentorship, and collaborative engagement among scholars at all ranks of the profession. We hope that this ecology has laid some (inherently shifting) groundwork for sustainable and sustaining intellectual exchange across disciplinary, institutional, and field boundaries. We also hope that this edited volume and the ecology from which it arises will serve as one example of how the collaborative ethos of Global Asias scholarship can create innovative models of academic knowledge production,

as well as a catalyst for generating new approaches to Global Asias scholarship and pedagogy.

The volume's format offers a multipronged approach to the composition of content. Such an approach derives from a commitment to enacting the central tenets of Global Asias—a distinctive embrace of multidisciplinarity, collaborative knowledge production that is not consensus-driven, and self-reflexivity—to create an opportunity for different kinds of scholars and different kinds of scholarship to be in dialogue without collapsing them into a unified set of perspectives and approaches. Each of the keyword teams took up the invitation to innovate differently. You will see that evidenced in the formatting and the genres of this volume. Indeed, the diversity of materials and approaches included in the volume reflects a broad understanding of scholarly work and promotes an intellectual approach that resists mastery by building and investing in structures of conceptual engagement and experimentation that embrace disagreement and differences. Suresh Canagarajah (2006, 587) has written on the necessity of "pluralizing composition from the specific angle of emergent World Englishes." In a similar move, we aim here to open a space for other kinds of knowledge makers and other styles of academic writing to find an audience.

What you have, then, are not five chapters but rather five *convergences*. (As Junyong Verónica Kim described the works in progress in the course of the 2022 summer institute: "These pieces may sit side by side, but no one came to their piece alone.") A convergence, as theorized by and instantiated through the journal *Verge: Studies in Global Asias,* is a form of relational nonalignment, a clamor of scholars coming into a shared space for a time, arriving via different vectors and departing with different trajectories and at different speeds, practicing the art not of synthesis or consensus but of *suspension*.

Navigation Log

We hope that Global Asias will be an open infrastructure upon which we might accrete (for instance: a community of scholars coming together in temporary coalition, as with a sandbar) or upon which we might fasten (for example: an edited volume such as this one, more like a barnacle, sticking and building). And yet, we are aware that this project is very much

rooted in the United States' intellectual academy, both in the forms it recognizes (thus, you will see gestures to strategic disciplinarity) and in the forces of its desires (therefore, you will find us both insisting on more than minimal inclusion and also holding a space for opacity and protective coverings). What does it mean to do this work, to work like this?

In short, we work by convergence and collaboration—but also through divergence and disarticulation. One way of saying this: what you are seeing here (holding in your hands as a book, reading as a PDF, viewing on a screen) is part of a multiyear, trans-institutional collaboration on the methods, problems, tactics, and possibilities of Global Asias as a conceptual risk and an intellectual endeavor. Another way of saying this: what you are seeing here (holding in your hands as a book, reading as a PDF, viewing on a screen) is a product that has been created with care and by caring about process. While the product has a shape, a heft, and an undeniable materiality, the processes through which it has been made—asking (and sometimes leaving unanswered) questions, holding regular conversations and debates, engaging ethically with precarity and the limits of expertise, experimenting with form—are equally valuable and equally worthy of attention.

Underneath these sentences lies a great deal of subterranean labor. Figure I.1 provides a glimpse of some of that buried work. The graphic is an example of the sort of experimental writing that both animates and is animated by a project like this one. We hope you will take some time with it, noticing the various time stamps: GMT is Greenwich Mean Time, while seasonal references (SU and FA) are keyed to the Northern Hemisphere. Scanning left to right, you move from June 2021, when Tina and Charlotte began conceptualizing the project, to November 2022, when the full team submitted the complete draft manuscript to the University of Hawai'i Press. Then (not shown in the visual) came a period of external review and readers' reports (January–May 2023) followed by revision and resubmission (June–September 2023). The prolonged arc of collective labor involved in creating this volume emblematizes a praxis of suspension. Our intentional staging of multiple, repeated, repetitive, and accumulative opportunities for engagement, dispute, and co-creation encouraged us to stay with moments of unsettling, desettling, friction, and dissonance. Indeed, to stay *in the moments* of being uncomfortable, out of water, unmoored.

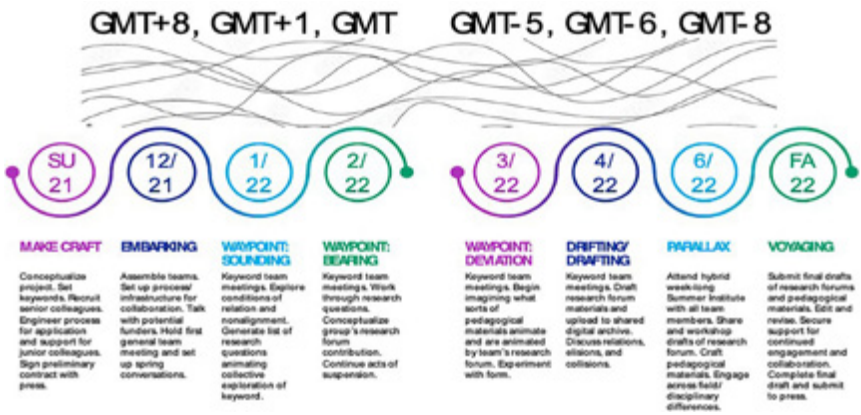


Figure I.1. Charlotte Eubanks, *Waymarks for a Collaborative Journey,* 2023. Microsoft PowerPoint and Photoshop.

Guided Invitation

So, how does one read, not a chapter in an edited volume, but the convergence of a yearlong conversation? What is a *readerly* act of suspension?

Dear reader, here is where we ask certain work of you. As you engage with this volume and its various substrates, we encourage you to be open to formal experimentation and attentive to discomfort around not having (not being offered) clarity. This is not a volume of answers, but a record given to you by fellow questioners. The capacious nature of Global Asias means that traditional models of expertise and mastery are inadequate. Indeed, acts of purported mastery often entail violent impositions. We choose, rather, the noisy turbulence of the sandbar, and we see experiment with form as a mode of generosity.

The volume's architecture thus emblematizes infrastructures that are both conceptual and material. Instead of chapters or essays, we present to you a series of convergences that capture the movement of knowledge as it is produced, debated, co-constituted, challenged, and transformed. Each convergence opens with an interleaf designed to evoke in some way part of the less visible engagements that always undergird the making of scholarship. The interleaf is followed by a research forum and a pedagogy forum. The formal arrangement of what each convergence contains thus facilitates the movements that make collaboration possible as well as

suggests that there should be greater movement between the putatively distinct scholarly labors labeled as "research" and "pedagogy."

In pushing against the false divide of research/pedagogy and in honoring multidisciplinary collaboration, the result is not a definitive statement of the field but, instead, a set of overlapping voices, disagreements, moments of surprise, and divergence. Not a singular arrival but a series of acts of suspension. Here are some examples of how you might begin to suspend yourself.

Look at the table of contents and find the keyword most interesting to you. Before you read any further, take a few minutes to ponder just that word. Let it unfold for you. You might ask yourself some questions and freewrite some preliminary responses. What, for instance, are some of the many things a "transit" might be? Or you might place the keyword next to "Global Asias" for a while and consider what comes up for you. Why, for example, might it be useful (interesting? necessary? surprising?) to insist that "Indigeneity" and "Global Asias" be in dialogue? Or, a different approach: Are there keywords you thought should have been represented but aren't? What are they and how might decentering those keywords (say, for an imaginary year) change how you think about Asias, global or otherwise?

Pick a convergence and think of it as a (perhaps unsolvable) puzzle that a small group of generous, curious strangers are trying to put together. Their ways of writing and thinking may be different from yours. Notice the questions they ask and the paths they pursue. Find the spaces of disagreement they hold between them.

Read a pedagogy forum first. Consider: What conceptual questions does it pose? What theoretical assertions does it make? What forms of research undergird it? Use it to ask questions of the associated research forum.

Assume that an author's writing style is part of the argument they are making, that authorial voices are crafted in response to multiple communities. Who does the writing open to? Who does it make space for?

Finally, we hope you will imagine joining these (or other) circles of interlocutors. How would you address them? How would you like to be welcomed? If your role is not to rebuke, rebuff, or provide a definitive answer, what is it? Will you join us in this praxis of suspension?

Interleaf—*Vortex: Global Asias, Where to Begin*

Global Asias *Tactics. Theories. Praxis*

Where to begin?

Orientation. Stellar alignments. Planetary transits. Vectors of departure and arrival.

Circulation. Movement. Oceanic voltas, riverine flows, littoral spaces. Fluid relation.

Suspension. Friction. Dissonance. Breaker, swell, surge. Turbulence.

Unsettling. Stuckness. Struckness. Stickiness. Shifting. Sandbar and holm.

Sedimentation. Buried knowledge. Subterranean labors. Antecedents. Bog and peat.

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Where to begin?

Charlotte Eubanks, *Vortex: Global Asias, Where to Begin,* 2023. Microsoft Word.

Editors' Introduction

Acts of Suspension

Tina Chen and Charlotte Eubanks

We begin by thinking about suspension.

Suspension

In a liquid mixture, agitation and movement keep soil, leaf, seaweed, sand, and other matter from settling. In music, prolonging a note of one chord into the next produces a moment of discord. In realms of legality and state control, a prohibition temporarily prevents enforcement. In navigating rough terrain, mechanical springs and shocks provide cushion. All variants of suspension.

In a collective intellectual endeavor, a praxis of suspension attends to and stays with moments of unsettling, desettling, friction, and dissonance. Disciplines, nations, languages, institutional structures, temporalities, and funding pressures do not just disappear in a praxis of suspension—indeed, as submerged reefs they are part of its ecology—but in a praxis of suspension, attention stays with the swells and surges, the matter that is washed aloft. The work of attending to power asymmetries produces its own turbulence.

Suspension is a noisy place. Think of the pool beneath a waterfall, the riffle of rapids in a stream, or the boom of combers on a beach: acoustic density. Suspension is necessarily polyvocal. As part of the creation of this volume, we gathered (in person and virtually, as we were able) for a week-long discussion: an institutional structure functioning, in this extended and decidedly mixed metaphor, like the pebbles on the streambed or the submerged sandbar, providing a point of friction resulting in sound and movement. Some of the turbulence, offered here as opening voices in suspension, would sound like cacophony. Might sound like a chorus. Could even be imagined as a suspension between these different articulatory possibilities.

What is included or centered when you say "Asia" in different places?
(Fiona Lee)

How do we challenge our own centers, in terms of where we depart from and where we arrive?
(Desirée Valaderes)

Thinking in fluid relation is a matter of survival.
(Junyoung Verónica Kim)

Staying with friction and dissonance as desirable, as a tactic.
(Carla Nappi)

We are still connected to North American academic forms and expectations. Whose desires are motivating this; who wants to know and why?
(Erin Suzuki)

Attending to power asymmetries and the necessary praxis of writing from "cannot."
(Naveen Minai)

Who pays the toll for legibility? Where are the edges of silence?
(Youngoh Jung)

The history and materiality of disciplines and ideas matter; the importance of thinking through antecedents: a geological stratigraphy of knowledge covering, recovering, uncovering.
(Andrew Leong)

We invite you into this noisy space and, in this introduction, we aim both to provide points of orientation (histories, inventories, a discussion of antecedents) and to show you the agitation and movement animating our exchanges; we commit fully to the ethos of Global Asias and a praxis of suspension.

As we conceptualized, collaboratively engineered, discussed, wrote, and revised the architecture of this volume, we envisioned certain *voltas* of circulation, potential points of flow. On the one hand, we hope that *Tactics & Theories* will find circulation among intellectuals, scholars, students, and administrators who are interested, but not yet involved, in Global Asias work. For such an audience, this edited collection should orient you to the keywords, major thinkers, conceptual currents, and developing directions of this dynamic method of engaging Asian, Asian American, and Asian diasporic studies in ways that bring those fields, their histories, principles, and practices, into conversation but not into alignment with one another. On the other hand, we dream that the volume will be borne along a current of intellectuals, scholars, students, and administrators already involved in conceptualizing and building Global Asias work. Whether you run a Global Asias institute, speaker series, center, or book series; direct an undergraduate program; or are a graduate student, researcher, or teacher invested in shaping this emerging scholarly field, we hope you will discover in the volume a collection of provocative conversations that redefine what it means to work in, at, for, and around Global Asias, not as a settled object of knowledge, but as a dynamic praxis of engagement.

Orientation

Over the last decade, Global Asias as a conceptual means of bridging discrete academic disciplines studying Asia and its diasporas has come into increasing visibility and prominence. While the contours of Global Asias

are still being explored and contested, this volume articulates a particular philosophy, set of principles, and collection of practices. We draw attention to the ways in which Global Asias scholarship and collaborative practice can encourage recognition without resolution by cultivating nonaligned relationality as both theoretical aim and collective enactment. Structurally dissonant as an epistemological project, Global Asias encourages scholars to acknowledge the institutional designs and disciplinary practices that currently organize and make legible work on Asia and its diasporas while simultaneously highlighting the limits of, and points of noncontact between, the broader infrastructures (including area studies, ethnic studies, diaspora studies, and the disciplines and interdisciplines) under which such work has traditionally been organized.

Previous work on Global Asia/s[1]—which has been conducted using rubrics such as "Inter-Asia," "Other Asias," "Global Asia," "InterAsia," "Transnational Asia," and "Global Asias"—has focused on the concept's fictionality and narrativization, its ability to encompass intra-Asian differences and to imagine alternatives to geopolitical realities, its subjection to overdetermination by historically constituted discursive structures that ironically create the conditions by which to undermine unified notions of what "Asia" might mean or represent, and its reimagination of Asia as an interlinked set of formations that stretch beyond national, territorial, or cultural boundaries.[2] It is important to note that some analytical work that might be understood now as exemplary of Global Asias scholarship was generated as part of earlier and ongoing critical engagements with globalization—manifested, for example, in the increasing attention over the last twenty-five years to "inter-Asian" connections in area studies, the "transnational turn" in American studies of the 1990s onward, and the surfacing of what Prasenjit Duara calls "circulatory histories" in interdisciplinary fields like Transpacific studies and Indian Ocean studies.[3] It is also worth noting that Global Asia/s approaches may overlap with emerging interdisciplinary studies that are focalized through the movement of populations (such as migration studies, diaspora studies, and critical refugee studies).[4]

In mapping the complex disposition of Global Asia/s, Tina Chen has compiled a provisional inventory of seven critical operations:

- as a heuristic for foregrounding the epistemological operations that structure our understanding of Asia as both geopolitical entity and cultural construct;
- as an injunction to look beyond Western intellectual frameworks in theorizing Asia and to establish intellectual networks that connect across Asia without being necessarily triangulated through "West-oriented singularity" (Chen and Chua 2007, 1);
- as a means of understanding transnational, transregional, and inter-Asian dynamics (sometimes as part of an explicit challenge to culture-language focus as the primary means of approaching the study of Asia, a legacy of cold war area studies models, but also at times as a vehicle for emerging modes of disciplinary and epistemic colonialism);
- as an expression of the neoliberal university's and global capitalism's drive to commodify the study of difference and otherness, reflective of ongoing efforts to absorb the resistant potential of emergent knowledge formations into existing curricula and practice;
- as an instrument for challenging the fallacy that area studies produces "local" content but does not generate more broadly applicable theories and concepts;
- as a critical space of interdisciplinary and trans-field collaboration, one that emphasizes the central roles of migration, movement, and interconnection fundamental to a globally oriented world;
- as a multidisciplinary collective practice that leverages the disjunctions, disagreements, and differences structurally embedded in how academic knowledge production about Asia and its peoples is compartmentalized into area studies, ethnic studies, and diaspora studies approaches to both destabilize existing institutional practices and generate new cooperative models for scholarship and intellectual engagement.

Global Asia/s is conceptually capacious enough to include all these usages, and there is analytical potential in actively keeping these disparate ideas in tensile relation. Admitting the ways in which this inventory disarticulates concepts and approaches that are, in practice, often overlapping

and entangled, this section of the introduction pays particular attention to the last two approaches and how they reflect the theories and tactics espoused by the journal *Verge: Studies in Global Asias* and the related Global Asias Initiative projects with which it is engaged.

Some of what we might now consider Global Asias scholarship was previously promoted and developed under different paradigms and concepts. While an in-depth exploration of all the relevant work generated out of the "transnational turn" in American studies or the "inter-Asian" connections of area studies would be generative and lengthy, briefly attending to the overlaps and distinctions between the field of Transpacific studies and Global Asias should be illustrative and enable a preliminary assessment of the ways in which Global Asias might generate alternative approaches that complement, contest, or extend "transnational" or "Transpacific" scholarship.

As Viet Thanh Nguyen and Janet Hoskins note in their 2014 attempt to define the field of Transpacific studies, the Pacific has been both a space of "exploration, exploitation, and expansion" and "a contact zone [whose] history [is] defined not only by conquest, colonialism, and conflict but also alternate narratives of translocalism, oppositional localism, and oppositional regionalism" (3). The Transpacific's expansiveness has been critically theorized in manifold ways: it has variously (and often synchronically) served as a void to be traversed (Huang 2008), a space of imperial projection and fantasy (Wilson 2000), a zone of economic development and capital flows (Dirlik 1998), a site of Indigenous world making and praxis (Hau'ofa 2008), a semiotic space for the development of counter-poetic artistic practices (Huang 2008), a dynamic site from which to consider the overlaps and disjunctions between Indigenous Pacific and Asian American epistemologies (Suzuki 2021), a militarized space (Shigematsu and Camacho 2010), an "oceanic archive" of decolonial possibility (Shu, Heim, and Johnson 2019), and a mediated network whose "thick environment" makes conceptual and cultural engagement possible (So 2016). Crucially, Transpacific studies generates myriad critical engagements with the existing fields with which it is in conversation (including Asian studies, American studies, Asian American studies, and Native Pacific studies, among others) although the nature of its relationships to such existing contextual and interdisciplinary frameworks has not always been centered as an integral aspect of its approach.[5]

Rehearsing the contours of Transpacific studies, even in such condensed form, as part of the prehistory or para-history of Global Asias draws attention to the ways in which we should not understand these intellectual fields/formations/approaches in developmental relation. Indeed, there are significant overlaps between the aims and approaches of both intellectual projects. Both are anchored by spaces of what Edward Said (1979) calls "imaginative geography"; both oscillate between efforts to pluralize (i.e., Erin Suzuki's [2014] notion of "alternative transpacifics" and *Verge*'s insistence on the significance of Global *Asias*) and the critical consolidation that inevitably accompanies field formation and institutionalization; both leverage the vastness of oceanic and terrestrial spaces to work beyond national imaginaries and the nation-state as privileged sovereign form; both knowledge projects orient their transnational vision in ways that recognize but hopefully exceed US exceptionalism.

While these shared investments are significant and not to be discounted, it is also worth considering some of the critical distinctiveness of Global Asias as theory and tactic, which in this iteration includes how (1) its multidisciplinary (as opposed to interdisciplinary) genealogy enfolds without resolving the tensions between area studies and critical ethnic studies, thus making it especially sensitive to the possibilities and limits of what Donald K. Emmerson (2008), a political scientist of Southeast Asia, has identified as the "terms of enlistment" and "dilemmas of allegiance" that are encountered by those working at the intersection of field and discipline;[6] (2) its aforementioned critical awareness can be carefully cultivated to create an intellectual approach that resists mastery, that "holds a space without taking over existing spaces"[7] by building and investing in structures of intellectual engagement and experimentation that embrace disagreement and differences; and (3) it actively directs attention to its ageographical constitution to enact a self-reflexive critical practice.

On a practical level, Global Asias creates a structure for bringing scholars together across temporal and methodological boundaries that is explicitly welcoming of diverse approaches to scholarly inquiry. Its distinctive embrace of multidisciplinarity, collaborative knowledge production that is not consensus-driven, and self-reflexivity offers an opportunity for different kinds of scholars and different kinds of scholarship to be in dialogue without collapsing them into a unified set of perspectives and

approaches. In other words, Global Asias is not so much (or at least not simply) a repertoire of methods but an architecture that makes critical conversation across the silos of knowledge production that structure academia—discipline, field, area, period, methodology—possible without interpellating interlocutors and practitioners into singular, synonymous, or even especially allied subject positions. Understood in this way, Global Asias serves as a conceptual infrastructure enabling diverse scholars, methods, and practices to meet without declaring new fealties or renouncing cherished loyalties—although its successes may well generate increasing interpolative pressures, and mechanisms to combat such pressures should be part of Global Asias' architectural and critical evolution.

Thinking of Global Asias in infrastructural terms draws attention to an inversive approach that foregrounds the elided structures that condition knowledge production. Even as Jessamyn R. Abel and Leo Coleman remind us that "inversion in this distinctive sense is a figure-ground reversal, bringing into view the buried or hidden material relations and expert negotiations that govern the operation and appearance of technical novelties, corporate forms, and the visible structures of political life" (2020, xi), Global Asias encourages not just a shift in perspective, but also a shift toward a more methodology-based approach. In the introduction to a special issue of *Prism,* "Method as Method," Carlos Rojas characterizes such an approach as one that "attends simultaneously to both objects and theories—including both ways in which objects are constituted by specific sets of theoretical assumptions and the ways in which theoretical paradigms often rely on the objects and localities out of which they emerge" (2019, 216). In other words, inversion cautions against simply replacing one set of objects of analysis with others, but rather considers both relatively spectacular objects and relatively invisible contexts in grounded relation.

In this volume, we seek to reimagine scholarly approaches to the study of Asia and its multiple diasporas by making figure-ground reversal and the grounded relation between objects/contexts of study fundamental aspects of our conceptualization of Global Asias as an architecture that can be collectively built to generate conversation and debate across siloed sites of academic knowledge. Bringing into relation, but not into alignment, the

fields of Asian studies, Asian American studies, and Asian diaspora studies, we focus attention on how institutional fields of academic knowledge production operate historically and contextually to influence the scholarly understanding of the politics, cultures, societies, aesthetic practices, and peoples of Asia. As an operating principle, we advance Global Asias by drawing on the methods, vocabularies, and priorities of critical race and ethnic studies to unsettle the assumptions of Asian studies while, in parallel fashion, leveraging Asian studies' attentiveness to questions of place, regional awareness, and linguistic expertise to discomfit Asian American studies' tendency to reinforce the US centrism of concepts governing the Asian diaspora.

Fluid Relation

To complement the conceptual topography of Global Asias we have just outlined, this section proposes three praxis-oriented concepts—**relational nonalignment; structural dissonance;** and **imaginable ageography**—that enable Global Asias as a tactical and evolving approach to the study of Asia and its multiple diasporas, one that actively resists the drive toward "critical consolidation" (Chen 2017) that often results from academic paradigm work. While academic knowledge production often privileges the clarity of consolidation, we embrace the possibilities of fluid relation in our ongoing conceptualization and enactment of Global Asias.

The term itself signals both the promises and the dangers of its epistemic ambitions and challenges. For some, "Global Asias" may connote imperial imagination, a drive toward mastery, and the consumerist leanings of racial capitalism—and we would do well to keep these in mind as potential consequences of the concept's critical purchase, portability, and popular adoption. Nonetheless, its strategic deployment also operates on other levels to undermine these connotations. In such instantiation, "Global" encourages us to consider the multiple and relating parts of a situation, the dis/connections that make possible world-spanning dynamics, and suggests a modality of representation/anti-representation that can offer alternatives to nation-based frameworks.[8] And "Asias" is deliberately plural/pluralizing. A rhetorical marker that moves us away from

self-evident expressions of geographical identity (and their attendant cultural and linguistic associations) to relational dynamics, it shifts critical attention from the singularity of terrestrial denomination to the multiplicity of geographically demarcated but culturally inflected semiotic space.

The theories of Global Asias work we share here have organically evolved in relation to on-the-ground tactics developed through working on *Verge: Studies in Global Asias,* and through work published in the journal. To round out our discussion of the methodological and architectural aspects of Global Asias, we now connect theories and tactics by naming three particularly meaningful elements of our conceptualization of Global Asias. Specifically, we focus on a trio of praxis-oriented concepts that not only have been useful in establishing the structural underpinnings of Global Asias as an emerging and collectively generated knowledge formation but also have helped us to keep the fluid relationalities of Global Asias in continued flux.

Concept 1: Relational Nonalignment

In writing about "settler moves to innocence," Eve Tuck and K. Wayne Yang remind us of the importance of an "ethic of incommensurability" when treating decolonization in relation to human and civil rights–based social justice projects and argue that "opportunities for solidarity lie in what is incommensurable rather than what is common across these efforts" (2012, 28). Relational nonalignment serves as a principle to embrace the coalitional possibilities of incommensurability. In approaching this principle structurally, this project promotes a set of collaboratively authored features that create opportunities to dialogue across differences, and welcomes disciplinary and field dissensus as critical to troubling the critical consolidation of institutionalization and academic paradigm work. Emphasizing relational nonalignment as both principle and structure enables the paradox of our parallel efforts to construct Global Asias as an institutionally legible knowledge project while resisting the urge to concretize it as a new (and dominant) institutional form.

Under the auspices of the Global Asias Initiative and *Verge,* we have collaborated with colleagues to bring together work from a variety of

disciplinary vantage points and approaches and focus on the potential intersections and/or blockages that such a range produces. The journal has been a key driver in the development of Global Asias as a new epistemological paradigm through which to consider the interrelation—but not necessarily alignment—of academic work in Asian studies (as a cold war institutional formation), Asian American studies (as an ethnic studies formation), and Asian diaspora studies (as an emergent post-national formation). In addition to acknowledging the intellectual frictions between these interdisciplines, the journal recognizes ongoing tensions between disciplinary priorities and interdisciplinary commitments. The distinctions separating these interdisciplines are real and continue to be important even as increasing emphasis on globalization, transnationalism, and diaspora suggests that the fields also have more in common than traditionally understood.

Accordingly, the multiauthor Con*verge*nce features pioneered by the journal—intellectual forums that encourage conversation among scholars working in different fields, disciplines, methods, and approaches—were created as structures that could facilitate discussion and debate across academic silos. Sometimes relational nonalignment is fostered across disciplinary boundaries, such as through a Codex feature orchestrating a collaborative review of SanSan Kwan's *Kinesthetic City: Dance and Movement in Chinese Urban Spaces* by scholars working in Asian studies, Asian American studies, urban studies, dance studies, and performance studies.[9] Other times, relational nonalignment results in projects on topics as distinct as the relational displacements of Vietnamese refugees and the Indigenous Aetas of the Philippines (Espiritu and Ruanto-Ramirez 2020), the processing of disasters across Asia through the creation of a digital hub of scholarly engagement inspired by the 2011 Tōhoku earthquake and tsunami (Onaga and Teo 2019), rethinking the *Rāmāyana*'s cultural travels through the rhizomatic work of Japanese folklorist Minakata Kumagusu (Selinger 2021), or the ethical quandaries of collaborative digital humanities projects that make historical multimedia collections on the Himalayas available to global audiences (Turin 2018).

Verge's conceptualization of Global Asias does not attempt to resolve or downplay the disparities that divide historically contradistinctive fields of study; neither does it hope to blend them into a newly unified

interdisciplinary field of academic inquiry. In seeking to foster multigeneric and multidisciplinary conversations, we aim to showcase the possibilities (and limits) of how Global Asias can be approached as an object of study that can also actively unsettle its continued self-constitution. In this way, Global Asias pursues the goals outlined by Junyoung Verónica Kim (2017) in her exploration of Asia–Latin America as method wherein she resists pressure to create knowledge as "a definable object of study" but instead works "to articulate a precarious position that calls attention to the workings of knowledge that naturalizes itself and forgets the material conditions of its own making" (100).

Concept 2: Structural Dissonance

Earlier efforts to conceptualize this aspect of Global Asias emphasized how "structural incoherence" (Chen 2018) could helpfully reference several interlocking aspects of the knowledge production about and representational practices of Global Asias. Structural incoherence offers us a way to theorize "a) the multiple, overlapping, and embedded contradictions undergirding the cultural, social, political, and economic dynamics of a 'place' both real and imagined (which contains valences of the really imagined, the imagined as real, and the real as imaginary); b) the use of varied representational structures to produce nonunified ways of reading and critical thought; and c) the coexistence of a singular manifestation (of place or identity) and the multiplicities of which it is made" (Chen 2021b, 318). Indeed, the Global Asias work we advocate for in this volume is generated by the very incompatibilities—field v. discipline, Asian studies v. Asian American studies v. Asian diaspora studies, regional differences, disparate critical and theoretical prioritization—that challenge the stability of Global Asias as a field of knowledge production. Structural incoherence gives name to those incompatibilities and suggests that rather than working against such incoherences, scholars embrace them as the generative conditions for cultivating work on/of Global Asias.

With the benefit of time and experience in seeing some of the various epistemic, disciplinary, and artistic cross-pollination that the architecture of Global Asias encourages, it now strikes us that "structural incoherence" might be too focused on describing the systemic conditions

out of which Global Asias operates, and it would be useful to draw attention to the nature of the collaborative non-consensus work that is being generated. Even as Global Asias does not serve as a means or process of unification but rather as an architecture that encourages ongoing juxtaposition, proximity, and generic friction, the incongruities it encompasses do often operate in productive relation. To that end, we offer here an amended concept—structural dissonance—to remind us that these new and exciting knowledge forms and practices are not so much incoherent as they operate in anomalous interrelationship.

To that end, the journal's A&Q and Field Trip features—which inspired the research forums published in this volume—often bring together scholars working in the same discipline but on different geographical regions, periods, and/or topics, or on the same topic (Indigeneity, settler colonialism, or Asia–Latin America Transpacific studies) but using different methodologies, to discuss pressing questions about shared investments and potentially oppositional stances. The resulting conversations emphasize structural dissonance as a key characteristic of Global Asias epistemology by embracing dissensus and creating space for agreement and contention to be equally valued forms of collective engagement.[10] The diverse ways in which work encompassed by this aspect of Global Asias becomes the unstable conditions for simultaneously theorizing within and outside of the institutional structures organizing the academic study of Asia—area studies, diaspora studies, the disciplines and interdisciplines—embody both the challenge and the potential of what work on Global Asias can accomplish.

Concept 3: Imaginable Ageography

This concept is inspired by thinking about Global Asias in nonaligned relation to other geographically referential concepts like "the Orient" and "Asian America." Drawing attention to how their utility as interpretive paradigms derives from the ways in which they simultaneously reference and remain disarticulated from "real" geographies, we emphasize the critical possibilities of focusing on how such paradigms are *ageographic:* "built to reference the solidity of terrain but more grounded in the conceptual/imaginative realm than they are in specific terrestrial features or characteristics.

Even more precisely, while they encompass or bring into visibility specific geographic features and characteristics (and acknowledge geopolitical structures), the conceptual realities that they signal and enact are enabled by the ways in which they simultaneously reference, exceed, and remake such topographies imaginatively" (Chen 2021b, 313). By drawing attention to Global Asias as imaginable ageography, we foreground the ways in which the conceptual and political significances of Asia derive from, but cannot be equivalent to, the geographical certainties bolstering them.

As Naoki Sakai has argued, "the West is one term of the West and the non-West binary which serves to co-figure spatially the relation of one subjective position to another. Rather than designating a bounded territory, it expresses the orientation or gradient at a specific place" (2000, 83). This reminder that the West is not simply a geographical location but a spatial orientation that signals asymmetries of power clarifies the need, in thinking through the spatial relationships of modernity and globalization that necessarily undergird Global Asias, for paradigms and practices that bring into visibility the inextricably interconnected material and conceptual matters that make such formulations work and that acknowledge their reality-producing effects even as they operate to resist their own intellectual dominance. To that end, imaginable ageography recognizes and foregrounds the epistemic operations that draw on cartographic authority to naturalize knowledge production itself.

An illuminating example of the ageographic mapping of Global Asias can be seen in Thai artist Rirkrit Tiravanija's monumental series *Untitled 2008–2011 (the map of the land of feeling)* (figure I.2).[11] Born in Argentina, Tiravanija has built a global career that spans New York, Berlin, and Chiang Mai. The three scrolls that form the series map the artist's physical, emotional, and artistic movements over two decades. Stretching over eighty feet, they involve a broad range of printmaking techniques and were produced in collaboration with a community of forty assistants over three years. Tiravanija's passports are mingled with maps, journal entries, recipes, directional notations, art historical references, and personal symbols. Confounding the map's orienting function, Tiravanija instead uses his art to archive memory, feeling, and experience—and to encourage relationship building, social interaction, and embodied engagement. The sheer size of the scrolls requires collaborative effort to make and install them and forces



Figure I.2. Rirkrit Tiravanija, *Untitled 2008–2011 (the map of the land of feeling) I.* Thai, b. Argentina (b. 1961). Inkjet print, offset lithography, chine collé, color silkscreen, ed. 3/40, 36 × 344.5″ (91.4 × 849.6 cm). Collection of Jordan D. Schnitzer. © LeRoy Neiman Center for Print Studies and Rirkrit Tiravanija.

viewers to confront partial perspectives and question the authority of how they view the terrain being ostensibly mapped.

Acknowledging partial views and questioning the authority of perspectives that are always limited by the institutional structures through which knowledge about Asia and its diasporas is generated are key characteristics of Global Asias as a conceptual rubric. As already noted, the critical consolidation of Global Asias as an emergent field formation is heightened by the totalizing potential of "Global Asias" as a term. An integral aspect of an architectural understanding of Global Asias involves structural dissonance of a different order, generated not through the inter/disciplinary frictions discussed earlier but through the tactical staging of the paradigm's constructedness, evolution, and disintegration. Thus, even as Global Asias makes possible alternative kinds of critical attention to the power of geographical imagination, we propose that conceptualizing it as imaginable ageography serves the important function of encouraging us to work against the consolidating effects of Global Asias by squarely centering the simultaneous discordances and unifying mythologies inherent in its conceptualization. In other words, imaginable ageography invites the ongoing process of self-critique necessary to prevent concepts like Global Asias from cannibalizing, homogenizing, or critically consolidating the very complex subjects and experiences that they epistemologically reference and create.

These three concepts are obviously not meant to fully flesh out the nature of Global Asias work. However, they do provide some scaffolding points upon which we can collectively build Global Asias as a new institutional formation, one that recognizes the challenges inherent in conceptual totalization and remains open to the frictive energies powering intellectual encounters between and beyond the silos that separate the study of Asias from its multiple diasporas.

Unsettling

Global Asias is an unsettling project. Or perhaps it would be more accurate to say that Global Asias is a project of unsettling. Such unsettling manifests variously, sometimes as the "disrupting and unfixing [of] established arguments, methodologies, disciplinary fields, and institutional knowledge formations" and other times as the "paradoxical dual commitments both to establish and to discompose Global Asias as an intellectual object and practice" (Chen 2019, vi). In a praxis of suspension, unsettling generates discomfort and disturbance but also the possibility of working and thinking otherwise. In other words, Global Asias as an unsettling knowledge practice can lead to a willingness to keep things in suspense/suspended, and to embracing the experience of being unsettled.

While our discussion thus far has illuminated how Global Asias as a multidisciplinary and trans-field arena of scholarly knowledge production contravenes the inter/disciplinary norms as well as some of the agreed-upon epistemic assumptions of area studies, ethnic studies, and diaspora studies, we now focus particular attention on the ways in which Global Asias also unsettles expectations about *coverage, evenness,* and *locatedness,* qualities to which more conventional scholarly approaches might aspire. We use these terms to describe some of the assumptions about how scholarly expertise makes possible academic knowledge production: in other words, "coverage" to name the desire to map scholarly expertise onto geography and an aspiration to comprehensiveness; "evenness" to make visible the practice of producing scholarship that synthesizes and creates uniformity out of discrepant sites, conditions, and dynamics; and "locatedness" to describe both the importance of acknowledging the positions from which we produce knowledge and the representational challenges such

acknowledgment may generate. We also use these terms to suggest that Global Asias unsettles, in part, by simultaneously clarifying and resisting these existing scholarly assumptions.

Here we are indebted to our many interlocutors within the Global Asias scholarly community whose diverse approaches to and generous engagement with this project clarify some of the significant challenges (to conceptual understanding but also to academic practice) that this collaborative and experimental approach to creating Global Asias scholarship generates. Even as they celebrate the project's commitment to creating spaces for collective/collaborative work that traces unfolding and coalescing engagements that are not presented in absolute or concretized terms, they also draw attention to the limits and absences that something as capaciously imagined as Global Asias casts into relief. Their critical insights create an opportunity for us to articulate more explicitly how and why Global Asias resists expectations about coverage and evenness—and to engage the complicated politics of subjectivity and representation informing the very specific North American academic context from which this project emerges.

Global Asias as a formulation might encourage some to embrace "coverage." In this imagining, "global" indexes something wholistic or all-encompassing. So "Global Asias" should include anything (and everything) that could be conceptualized as part of Asia and its multiple diasporas. While this idea makes logical sense if one simply extends the expectations about coverage that developing areas of scholarly expertise encourages to more expansive topographies, we believe Global Asias actually cautions us against such extension. To clarify: we do not use "global" in wholistic or all-encompassing ways, partly because to do so repeats at an epistemological level the excesses of imperialism, the dangers of mastery, and the fallacies of conceptualizing knowledge production in totalizing ways. Instead, what we find useful about the global as a measure of scale is that its enormity exposes the very idea of coverage as a myth. Coverage is impossible. Or it leads to tokenism. Even as the logic of "coverage" can be productive—by encouraging us to be more inclusive, to think more carefully about the relationality between people and areas, and to be more committed to exploring spaces that aren't already familiar—the vastness and the amorphousness of Global Asias are meant to be uncoverable. We are motivated by the

idea of holding space and making space (rather than claiming to cover it). Accordingly, our approach in this volume has not been to produce coverage per se but to allow an open invitation to put new interlocutors, fields, and questions together in a provisional way that isn't meant to concretize into a new territory that then needs to be "covered."

Similarly, there is no way to produce Global Asias in an "even" manner because that is not true to the situations and structures in which we find ourselves. Instead, unevenness is a characteristic that something as impossible as "Global Asias" can help us to identify, live with, and attempt to restructure. While a desire to treat the diversity potentially encompassed by Global Asias can result in interesting and surprising assemblages, we understand these structures to be fugacious and inherently asymmetrical. What Tina Chen has argued in relation to the Transpacific is, we think, also true of the imaginable ageography of Global Asias: the asymmetry of "uneven contestation—with such unevenness undergirding the engagements between nations and regions and territories, land and sea, humans and nonhumans, among others— . . . might be usefully understood to be illustrative of [Global Asias'] capacious incoherence, its ability to encompass much without becoming subsumed into any one single formulation" (2020).

In other words, while there is abundance here, there is also a great deal that is not in this volume. Some of the questions that surfaced on our first day of discussion at the 2022 Global Asias Summer Institute included: Why doesn't the nation disappear? Whose global imaginary is this? How can we understand Global Asias in a littoral or oceanic framework? From places of blockage or damming? From temporary coalitions like sandbars? From places of sedimentation and stratigraphic layering? These are all questions that ask us to view the myriad places that may make up Global Asias and suggest that certain locations have not been treated equally with others. They are also ways of insisting on the timeliness of space, the shifting contours and fluid edges of spatial imaginaries, and the fundamental unevenness that is generated out of attempts to focalize or prioritize.

The timeliness of space here, in this edited collection, tends toward the nineteenth century and picks up speed as it approaches the present. And so with the impossibility of coverage and evenness in mind, it is instructive to think about the possibilities of Global Asias that do not anticipate

the nation-state's emergence as a dominant or stubborn terrain. In terms of language, we might have considered Sanskrit, Buddhist Modified Sinitic, or Arabic as linguistic currents that Global Asias have navigated and been borne by. A/geographical consideration may have been extended to Jambudvīpa and the imaginative geographies of heavens and Pure Lands, the desires of toponymic borrowing, or the tectonic forces of dharma as shaping sentient entanglements with the material sphere. We could have considered sonic epistemologies of resonance and the transits of cosmic sound whether in dhikr, whistle, or hum. And so forth. But what is missing should not be read as inadequacy or lack. Instead, these absences are futural possibilities, an expansive projection of what might be possible through Global Asias as conceptual and epistemological praxis. We imagine Global Asias work as, by definition, speculative and open-ended. Which is to say: there are other keywords that were, other keywords that are, other keywords that will be when we orient our work differently with respect to temporality or decrease our proximity to modern forms like the nation-state.

We see unevenness as important on formal as well as conceptual levels. Indeed, one of the criticisms that working with so many people and disciplines produces is that of unevenness: as you will see in this volume, the contributions are not uniform; they are juxtaposed or run up against one another in ways that don't get synthesized; there is a willingness to use a diversity of generic forms such that the insights proffered are not presented neatly but rather unfold surprisingly or remain unconsolidated. While we understand that such irregularity in traditional scholarly forms may be read as problematic, we believe that asymmetricality is a generative characteristic of Global Asias that is important to maintain, and we approached the crafting of the volume with this in mind. Accordingly, we encouraged our keyword teams to collaborate in ways that do not necessarily privilege cohesion, to allow the seams of their work together to show. The roughness of such an approach can be unsettling for those who have been trained to synthesize their research findings, but such disruption, we argue, is critical to the making of Global Asias as a collaborative knowledge formation that resists consolidation.

Which brings us (well, actually we have been here all along) to the myriad issues of position, perspective, structure, and representation that we

understand through the concept of "locatedness." For us, locatedness is a way to describe both the importance of acknowledging the positions from which we produce knowledge and the representational challenges such acknowledgment may generate. A simpler way of saying this might be: we start where we are, and our conceptualization of and approach to Global Asias is informed by, and responds to, the institutional and structural conditions in which we are currently situated. In our case, as we share in our reader's guide, we are at a research-intensive land-grant university that happens to be in central Pennsylvania; it is an institution that has not had a long history of supporting either Asian studies or Asian American studies. Our approach to Global Asias has been to bring into nonaligned relation these historically antagonistic interdisciplines and to insist on including the emerging field of Asian diaspora studies as part of this conversation. Our training, our institutional location, and the legibility of area studies and ethnic studies as fields of academic knowledge production all contribute to what we readily acknowledge: Global Asias is a critical conversation that has been largely shaped by and responsive to the structural conditions of the US academy.

There are many reasons for this, including the fact that the fields of area studies and ethnic studies are historically grounded in US contexts; that English is the language privileged for academic research; that colonial histories contribute to English dominance in academic publishing; and that there are unequal levels of institutional support between the Global North and Global South, research universities and teaching colleges, and tenure-track faculty and contingent faculty. Indeed, the difficulties of locatedness are legion and require acknowledging where and how structural conditions of uneven resource distribution, for instance, continue to produce in existing Global Asias projects a drift toward East Asia, a trait of US centrism, and a structural absence of Indigenous voices along with underrepresentation of South Asia and of land-based flows westward. Put differently, locatedness is not only about the positions from which we produce knowledge but also about the absences that signal who/what has not been invited to be part of the conversation. Crucially, these issues result from structural conditions *that we are trying to erode* through the multidisciplinary epistemic endeavor of Global Asias work. What we attempt here is to reckon with the structural factors that lead to certain outcomes

and highlight the ways that Global Asias provides mechanisms for disrupting standard operating procedures like field, discipline, gatekeeping, and training.

Because we wrestle with Global Asias in a processual way, what might be read as lack or absence is instead an invitation and provocation to do this again, holding spaces open to do different work and to work differently. To illustrate how these issues of coverage, unevenness, and locatedness not only operate intersectionally to make Global Asias work im/possible but also point us to possible future directions, we offer an example drawn from our efforts with/in this volume. Specifically, one of the keywords from this project, "Indigeneity," usefully serves as a focalizing lens to zero in on the issues of coverage, unevenness, and locatedness that we have been discussing. As astute readers will note (and as our astute manuscript reviewers did note), none of the team members working on this keyword identify as Indigenous scholars. This noticeable absence registers the complex ways in which the representational politics of Global Asias is intimately connected to the structural conditions of academic knowledge production and raises a complicated set of possible questions, responses, and approaches.

Crucially, our inclusion of "Indigeneity" as one of the five keywords for conceptualizing a Global Asias praxis in this volume is something we have been building toward for a decade. In 2013, we contacted the Interinstitutional Consortium for Indigenous Knowledge (ICIK) at Penn State. The University of Minnesota Press had just agreed to publish *Verge: Studies in Global Asias* and our first issue was not yet in production. We knew that Indigenous peoples, voices, and conceptual approaches would form crucial partners in the attempt to bring Asian American studies, Asian diaspora studies, and Asian area studies into relational nonalignment and we wanted to make sure that the structures we were building would actively invite Indigenous peoples and scholarship to these conversations. Through the consortium we reached out to a range of Indigenous scholars, ultimately inviting Pasang Yangjee Sherpa (Sharwa) to join the editorial board. Charlotte Eubanks and Pasang Yangjee Sherpa went on to codirect a Global Asias Summer Institute in 2017, for which we invited—and funded—eight junior scholars researching Indigeneity in intra-Asian contexts. The goals of the institute were several: to provide financial support and publishing mentorship for junior scholars, to bring scholars located in Asia and

scholars located in North America into extended conversation, and to kick-start a deep discussion of Indigeneity in Global Asias.

While concepts of Indigeneity that have largely been formulated in the Global North and West in the context of settler colonial histories do not "fit" Asian contexts precisely, it is important to note that, even as we questioned the term, we did so with self-identified Indigenous participants as part of the conversation: Pasang Yangjee Sherpa (Sharwa), Megumi Chibana (Uchinānchu), and Yu Luo (Buyi) were all important interlocutors. Carrying this work forward, Charlotte and Pasang Yangjee worked together for the next two years on a special issue of *Verge* that appeared in 2017 and for which we commissioned a piece by Alice Te Punga Somerville (Te Āti Awa, Taranaki). Through *Verge,* our Global Asias conference series, and sponsored panels and roundtables at venues like the Association for Asian Studies and the Association for Asian American Studies, we have continued to support work that examines the various interfaces that Indigeneity has with Asian, Asian American, and Asian diaspora peoples and materials.

Our keyword team for "Indigeneity" in this volume does not include an Indigenous scholar even though we made efforts to build on this history of including and encouraging Indigenous voices to be part of the Global Asias conversation. For instance, we issued targeted invitations to some senior scholars who we thought would be well positioned to provide meaningful mentorship. We also had an open call for early-career interlocutors, which we circulated widely, frequently, and through as varied a range of networks, LISTSERVs, and cold calls as possible. This dual process brought us no Indigenous scholars. Rather than then trying to identify and target an Indigenous scholar to be included in a tokenistic way, what we try to do here/now is reckon with the structural factors that led us to this and envision how this version of the Global Asias conversation can lay groundwork for the next conversation, which will include a different roster of contributors and draw attention to what are perhaps an entirely different set of concerns.

Even as concerns about coverage, evenness, and locatedness point us to addressing Indigeneity through the important lenses of identity, culture, and epistemology, the absence that this particular Global Asias approach/project encompasses is an opportunity to highlight that there may also be

other ways of thinking with Indigeneity. As Jenny Chio, Diego Javier Luis, Kyle Shernuk, and Erin Suzuki explain in their convergence on the topic, recognizing the importance of Indigenous perspectives can and should exist alongside "critically engaged reflection on some of the similarities and differences that emerge around different *articulations* of Indigeneity—as a marker of identity, as an epistemology, and as a methodology—as they move across different geopolitical areas and in different historical and colonial contexts." In other words, the conceptual stakes of thinking with and about Indigeneity in terms aside from those of (self-)identity not only unsettles some of the representational assumptions undergirding the terms of enlistment and participation structuring our critical conversation. They also make it possible to keep our scholarly praxis unsettled and open to continued variation.

Circulation

In thinking about **circulation**, we are attentive both to the ways in which the volume's architecture has been designed to facilitate the movement of knowledge (between collaborators, between fields and disciplines, and between the ostensibly different scholarly activities of "research" and "teaching") and to the myriad ways in which the knowledges generated by this project can be accessed and transmitted. To put this another way, circulation is about both movement and flow. While these terms are often used synonymously, they suggest different characteristics and dynamics. Even as both delineate motion, fluctuation, and transmission, flow might be characterized as movement with continuous deformation. Movement and flow in this volume thus manifest through structure (the volume's formal composition) and the flexibility of approach (in reading, in utility) such composition promotes.

As we've already noted, this volume is crafted to draw attention to the collaborative ethos of Global Asias praxis. Although we employed keywords to help give shape to knowledge production, astute readers will note that this is not a keyword volume in a traditional sense. Even as keywords invite focus and clarity, a standard approach to their use in academic writing entails rehearsing previous scholarly research related to the keyword in order to elucidate critical genealogies and how they affect usage

of the term in contemporary discourse. In *Tactics & Theories,* keywords operate in a different fashion. We chose the keywords for their potential to encourage cross-pollination across knowledge silos and to inspire collective engagement (indeed, some of our contributors expressed surprise that we did not pick more "obvious" keywords such as "nation," "globalization," or "area" for this volume). To compose each keyword team, we engineered for diversity—of field, discipline, geographical focus, rank, period—but kept in mind the impossibility (and problems) of approaching Global Asias by prioritizing coverage. While each team member had to identify and share their disciplinarily informed critical genealogy of the keyword in order to begin the multidisciplinary and trans-field conversations required to collaborate, the keywords themselves became opportunities to seed a new ecology of knowledge for Global Asias scholarship.

In transitioning from movement to flow in this meditation on circulation, we recognize the need to build structures to make movement possible but also the continuous deformation that movement can create. "Waymarks for a Collaborative Journey" (figure I.1) plots a wavering course, indicating the ways that the crew for this collaborative voyage tacked and traveled over the course of eighteen months. It may be helpful to specify: though each keyword group navigated a similar course, we were not one vessel. Six crafts gathered at the starting port: A/geography, Epistemology, History, Indigeneity, Language, and Transits. But before embarking, the crew from one vessel (History) scuttled, finding new cabins with Indigeneity and Epistemology. After leaving port and throughout our journey, Tina and Charlotte jumped from ship to ship: Tina met each month with A/geography, Epistemology, and Transits while Charlotte met each month with Indigeneity and Language, and the two of us stayed in regular communication about the currents of the conversations we were riding. Much of shipborne work is ropework, after all: braiding and knotting, tying and casting, rigging and mooring up.

It is difficult to put a windborne, winding, and wayward traverse into linear order, as one must in a paginated volume. While we offer here one such ordering, we invite you to imagine and take up others.

We start with **Transits**. The "Transits" convergence narrativizes the conceptual work of Global Asias by asking its readers to put themselves into relation and movement: in relation to the subjects we study, and in

movement between different institutional formations. The Transits research forum performs this movement at multiple levels. Each of the case studies charts spaces, for instance, in which flux encounters fixity, whether in the carceral sites of Second World War "confinement camps" in Desirée Valadares's piece or through an examination of "coerced movement" in the Indian Ocean sphere as examined by Neelima Jeychandran. The forum also performs movement at the level of its own internal ordering, asking readers to move fluidly from a consideration of transit as stuckness (Valadares) to transit as archipelagic arrangement (in Evyn Lê Espiritu Gandhi's piece), from transit as a "speculative history" of Africans in Kochi (Jeychandran) to the transits of jazz music between transwar Tokyo and the San Joaquin Valley (in Alexander Murphy's contribution). The "Transits" convergence concludes with several sets of pedagogical tools—counter-mapping exercises, guiding questions for curricular design, and so forth—addressed both to classroom settings (university level and K–12) and to museums, cultural institutions, and programming units. Collectively, the work of the "Transits" convergence illustrates that there is no simple, linear movement between origin and destination; rather, there are multiple departures, numerous arrivals, endless circulation. "Transits," this team notes, "is an intersectional theoretical and methodological paradigm" that considers mobility, migration, and diaspora while also exposing "frictions and stasis in connectivities, peripheral regimes of transitions, and processes of waithood as a tactic for a new Global Asias praxis."

We move next to **Indigeneity**. As the work of "Transits" should have cued us to notice, Indigeneity is not a static category but rather is a dynamic process of relation. Indigeneity, also, is a concept that transits into and through Global Asias work, not as an autochthonous term but as a conceptual apparatus that arrives from elsewhere (the United Nations Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples represents one method of arrival) and is already on a trajectory. That trajectory, however, can be slowed, re-inflected, trimmed, and tacked toward different directions. All of the scholars in this section demonstrate how engaging with the idea of Indigeneity transforms their own scholarship, whether drifting through the context of the Native Pacific and the settler colony of Hawai'i (Erin Suzuki) or moored in the language of "original inhabitants" (*yuanzhumin* 原住民) in Taiwan (Kyle Shernuk). Positionality is crucial to the work of Indigeneity

as a Global Asias praxis, and each of the contributors to this keyword convergence articulates the intellectual commitments of non-Indigenous scholars, located within settler colonial societies, and seeking to engage with Indigenous communities. Locatedness must exist alongside the movements of transits in this work. Attending to other terminologies and their genealogies reveals how concepts and language linger, forming another sort of "imperial debris" (Stoler 2013) that must be navigated, whether in considering the place of ethnic Kazakhs in the centuries-old land-based empire that has become the People's Republic of China with its "minor nationalities" (*shaoshu minzu* 少数民族) explored in Jenny Chio's piece, or in excavating the histories by which, as Diego Luis reminds us, "the first Spanish word for Indigenous peoples, 'indio' ('Indian'), applied indiscriminately to Nahuas of Central Mexico, for example, just as it did to Tagalogs of the Philippines." Frictions between Indigeneity and imperialism ignite around relations to land. The pedagogical materials generated by the Indigeneity team include a set of guiding questions, followed by annotated bibliographies for further reading on keywords in the study of intersections and impasses between Indigeneities and Global Asias. Thus, the work of the "Indigeneity" convergence helps to map out a Global Asias conceptual cartography that responds to, but is not equivalent to or delimited by, a geopolitical mapping of Asia and of Asian diasporas. The idea that "Asia" names something discrete, or that "Indigenous" names something obvious, is a mistake. Both Global Asias writ large, as we understand it, and the work on Indigeneity in this convergence put pressure on these terms, which do not, in fact, deliver epistemological clarity. Rather, they are always being mobilized in order to create conceptual spaces to challenge such clear demarcations, whether of national borders, racialized categories, or conceptual domains. As Kyle Shernuk asks, "Who are we, and why are we here?" Or, in Erin Suzuki's formulation, "What is the relationship between responsibility and reciprocity?" There are benefits to identifying Indigeneity and Global Asias, each as a way to help think through the other; but there are costs as well, of which we must be mindful. Do we name to categorize, to dismiss, to diminish? Or do we name to bring into relation, leaving room for nonalignment, finding space for temporary coalition? The Global Asias work we endorse in this volume commits itself to the latter.

Which brings us to **Epistemology**. As with Indigeneity, a critical consideration of epistemology as a Global Asias tactic asks us to wrestle with the limitations of inherited concepts and the damage that received conceptual formations can do. If engaging with Indigeneity points out that knowledge is neither neutral nor transparent, that it transits between locales freighted with unequal benefit, grappling with epistemology pushes us to think about where we go from here. What do we think now? What do we think next? Working with epistemology not as a transparent and therefore unremarkable capacity (transcendent knowledge) but as an opaque and marked container requires taking up the question of embodiment. What does it mean to inhabit one's relation to knowledge, in contrast to pretending that objective or disembodied rationality is desirable, or even possible? As Junyoung Verónica Kim and Naveen Minai write in the research forum introduction for "Epistemology," "Just as one's passport or visa status determines how one arrives at the borders of a nation-state, the process of being a good citizen in academic institutions abides by the same logic." They continue this thought around the "bordering" of area studies and ethnic studies as putatively separate disciplines and "call for disobedience and rebellion against these forms of institutionalization." What does epistemological disobedience look like, then, as a Global Asias tactic? It may mean refusing to commit a family member's voice to the archive, as we see in Youngoh Jung's powerful meditation on the grandson–grandmother–tape recorder triad, or refusing the structural pressures that seek to constrain how "a scholar from an area that is studied" should organize their research, as Naveen Minai explores. It may "call attention to the affective economies that underpin the desire for area and ethnicity" (Verónica Junyoung Kim), or perhaps a rebellious Global Asias praxis would allow area studies formations to "burn" or "rot" altogether, as Carla Nappi suggests. Each of these approaches draws out the role of the institution—in the context of a discipline (history, for instance), a scholastic site (research-intensive university, say), or a recognized knowledge formation (such as area studies and ethnic studies)—in relation to a global pandemic stretching its tendrils into our living rooms by way of video technology and screen share. The pedagogy portion of the "Epistemology" convergence responds to the disciplining of knowledge with an invitation to engage in "pedagogies of rebellion," methods for thinking otherwise by evoking, for instance,

critical listening, intimacy, and translation. The research and pedagogy forums collectively show a willingness to push against institutional expectations and generic constraints by experimenting with form, by being in conversation across historical and disciplinary boundaries, and by working against institutional logics that might push us away from conversation with one another. In short, these materials reflect a relational practice in which institutional constraints on what one can or cannot do become a starting point, not an end or a stop.

At this point, should we talk about **Language**? We are writing in English; you are reading in English; English was and is the medium through which contributors to this volume connected to one another at every stage of our eighteenth-month journey. The joke goes, "Ask a fish what water is, and it'll say, 'What?'" What is the watery "what" of English? How can we think with, of, and through English not simply as a constraint but as a point of beginning? The "Language" convergence centers the question of Anglophone dominance, both as a structural condition and as a provocation that asks to be rethought. All of the interlocutors in the "Language" convergence are located within English departments, from which position they seek to "work with the tension of English's capacious institutional reach . . . and the discipline's inadequacy in coming to grips with the density of the . . . multilingual environments" in which their research is sited. The authors of this section make the "water" of English visible by funneling their research forum through the vortex of a tightly structured, initially Arabic, form of poetry: the ghazal. The ghazal, literally "a conversation with the beloved," meditates on love and loss, the bittersweet pleasures of separation, the frustrations of longing. It is not an easy form of poetry to pull off in English, posing particular conceptual and linguistic constraints (including a demanding rhyme scheme) that work in tension with the disciplinary bounds of Anglophone academic writing. Jerry Won Lee turns the provocations of the ghazal toward imagining "a space out of English" (defined singularly) and into a milieu of World Englishes. Circulation is key here. English circulates as a language of academic discourse, which entails both opportunities and costs. Fiona Lee's meditation on the potential of "(a) race out of English" shows us that this circulation is not unidirectional and, in the process of movement, the meaning of language itself changes. Finally, Andrew Way Leong identifies a "place out of

English" by returning us to a crucial point in the formation of North American Asian studies and Asian American studies, a point at which distinctions between those fields had not yet congealed and a "buried past" in which community languages (Cantonese spoken at home, for instance) may have been differently valued. Leong's thinking here resonates with what Ana María Ochoa Gautier (2014, 58) has identified as an embodied form of linguistic "competence," a way "of understanding the conscious and historical usage of multiple knowledges in the mobilization or practices of self-definition." English dominates—or, we have allowed English to dominate—our scholarly conversations. But whose English? The "Language" convergence concludes by offering three pedagogical case studies, examples of how one might "language" Global Asias, whether through the use of language stories, via a reworking of graduate-level syllabi, or in the context of community translation workshops. As English circulates, questions of belonging and ownership change, and a Global Asias praxis attends to those transformations.

And this takes us to **A/Geography**. A/Geography is a critical neologism. As Tina Chen (2021b, 313) has argued, "the Orient," "Asian America," and "Global Asias" are all terms that have "been employed to generate critical work about Asia and its diasporas" and yet "their utility as interpretive paradigms has derived, in no small part, from the ways in which they simultaneously reference and remain disarticulated from 'real' geographies. As such, they are not so much geographic as they are ageographic: built to reference the solidity of terrain but more grounded in the conceptual/imaginative realm than they are in specific terrestrial features or characteristics." Had we placed the "A/Geography" convergence first, perhaps you would have encountered it as merely an unfamiliar word posing a conceptual challenge. By placing A/Geography last in this linear lineup, we hope that readers will have some sense both of why the term is necessary and what a Global Asias praxis might need from, might need to do with, imaginable a/geography. A/Geography invites the innovations of countermapping and other decolonial approaches of knowledge production in which maps might recognize, for instance, not current national boundaries (India/Kashmir/China) or regional groupings (East/South/Central Asia) but, rather, zones of ecological contingency or routes of Afro-Asian solidarity. Taking up the provocations of imaginable a/geography draws

attention to movement as a form of protest, as in the Kashmir Freerunning and Parkour Family, cabbage walking, and Kashmir Bicycle Movement practices outlined by Omer Aijazi. Alternatively, an a/geographical approach might employ a narrative mapping of the "new Asian city" to show the ways in which "stories of growth—urban, industrial, economic—look very different from the level of psychic, gendered, migrant, and classed social narratives," as Jini Kim Watson shows. A/geographies also enable us to see how Jim Crow practices separating Black and White populations in the American South encouraged specific placements of Chinese grocery stores, a pattern that, as Shaolu Yu puts it, reveals how "racialization of space and spatialization of race perceptualize each other and maintain the plantation system and racial hierarchy in the American South." In their pedagogy forum, the members of A/Geography propose a "syllabus of possibilities." Constellated around units on the city, borderlands, and mapping, the collective effort here is "to unmoor Asia from current frames of legibility in favor of more expansive, experimental, and speculative a/geographies."

And so, with "unmooring," we come full circle, back to Transits. The logic of movement and the praxis of suspension continue. Pursuing this line of thinking gives us one route through Global Asias conceptual work, moving us through conversations outlining the importance and significance of positionality—with respect to racialized formations, imperial and colonial histories, institutional and disciplinary inheritances, and contestations of linguistics ownership and belonging—toward and through a neologism that asks us to conceive of a geography differently, imaginatively, as something not given, but co-construed and always in flux.

That said, we certainly could have ordered this volume in different ways. Indeed, one earlier arrangement evoked the playful, polyvocal electricity of the Japanese word game *shiritori* (尻取り lit. "tail-grabbing") in which players have to say a word that begins with the last syllable of the previous word: Kashmir. Miracle. Culvert. Vertiginous. Nuzzle? In this alternate throughline, Language may come first, ending with Fiona Lee's consideration of the chief minister of Sarawak's position that "non-Malay Indigenous constituents of his state would be best served with English-medium schools," and thereby keying the "Indigeneity" convergence. That convergence might end with Diego Luis's observations concerning the prolific spread of the Spanish

category *indio* across multiple imaginable ageographies, including the "New" World and the "Philippines," a moniker that purports to claim those islands for the Spanish king Philip II. The A/Geography forum could conclude with Omer Aijazi's meditations on Kashmir as a speculation of free movement, "unencumbered by military checkpoints, barbed wire, and borderlines." Taking us to Transits, where we might pick up with Evyn Lê Espiritu Gandhi's mediations on the archipelago as a "useful spatial imaginary for mapping" transborder relational geographies and end with Neelima Jeychandran's examination of persistent silences around the Indian Ocean slave trade, querying how we might come to know that which has been silenced, thus cuing the importance of location with respect to epistemology. The "Epistemology" convergence could wrap up this alternate linear arrangement by opening with Junyong Verónica Kim's consideration of "offshoring," in which, thinking alongside Lisa Yun (2008), she considers the "Afro-Asian intimacies [of] Chinese indentured laborers working side-by-side with African slaves in Cuban sugarcane plantations." The implications of this possible ordering would have been somewhat different, drawing more attention to the conceptual topography of disciplinarity and various ways of trimming that ship's sails to other winds (multidisciplinarity, undisciplining, strategic disciplinarity, anti-disciplinarity). Still other arrangements would have drawn attention to materiality and embodiment; to rhythms of sediment, antecedent, and genealogy; or to ethics and accountability in our practices of listening and knowing, querying and knowledge making.

There is also the option of reading this volume in a host of nonlinear ways, such as might be suggested by Julio Cortázar's 1963 novel *Rayuela* (published in English translation in 1966 as *Hopscotch*). In his instructions to readers at the outset of the volume, Cortázar notes that the book "consists of many books" (1966, i). One book, read linearly, would start at chapter 1 and end at chapter 56, suggesting that the reader may ignore "with a clean conscience" the multiple chapters that follow (1966, i). Reading hopscotch-wise, beginning with chapter 73, then jumping to the chapter number listed at the end of each, produces a second book. There are looping and crossing ways of reading the book according to yet more disorderly orders.

If you are so inclined, we encourage you to hopscotch throughout this volume at will. For instance, if you are teaching a course on the global city, you might wish to read the "A/Geography" and "Transit" research

forums, adding to these some of the materials from the Epistemology team's pedagogy module on "Asia–Latin America as Method." You might then, with a Cortázaran "clean conscience," decide not to read the rest of the volume (at least, not until later).

Then again, maybe you are working on a research project that has to do with infrastructure. Perhaps you want to start by reading all the research essays in the "Language" convergence, each of which thinks through English as a language infrastructure. You could follow this up with Naveen Minai's contribution in "Epistemology," "Disorientations: (Un)Knowing from an Area Studied," and then work through the citational mapping exercise proposed by the Transits team as a way of identifying the infrastructures of empire and capitalism that may be curtailing or disrupting certain intellectual movements. "Are there areas of particular [citational] transit density? Are there certain transits that are less visible and harder to trace" in your citational map?

Or perhaps you want to center questions of race and ethnicity in your thinking. Here, you might begin with a close reading of the "Indigeneity" and "A/Geography" convergences, using the materials from the research forums to ground a deep exploration of the collated pedagogy materials the Indigeneity group has provided on the keywords "Race and Ethnicity." You could then turn to Fiona Lee's meditation on "Malaysian Literature in English, Global Anglophone Literature? Imagining (a) Race out of English" in the "Language" convergence.

Or maybe something else entirely is on your mind. We invite you use this volume in whatever way fits your needs. Disorderly reading is welcome and the flow of knowledges produced by this project embraces the process of continuous deformation that makes collaborative scholarly praxis possible.

Suspension (Again)

And this brings us to one of our core assertions, from which we begin and with which we conclude: Global Asias is a *collective* epistemic project that makes visible the role that institutionalization plays in creating knowledge about Asia and its multiple diasporas. Through engineered modes of engagement that enable cross-disciplinary dialogue and trans-field cooperation and debate, the methods and architecture of Global Asias

challenge existing institutional practices that separate scholars working on "Asian" topics from those working on "diasporic" topics in order to create new conditions of possibility that embrace the fundamentally transnational and global nature of Asia-focused worlds and epistemologies. Such engagement is enacted multiplicitously through a series of critical shifts in perspective and collective practice, shifts enabled by building spaces (both literal and conceptual) for scholars working with disciplinarily specific approaches to meet; by encouraging cross-pollination across knowledge silos through interdisciplinary or trans-field approaches; and by asking those trained to promote academic expertise (often defined in prescriptively narrow ways) to inhabit zones of discomfort and give up individual authority in favor of collaboratively generated modes of inquiry.

Such critical shifting signals a process of reorientation, one that centers the significance of Asia and its peoples even as it resists the logics of singularity and critical consolidation. By literally placing Asia, Asian diasporas, and Asians at the heart of our epistemological enterprises, we acknowledge the significance of movement, borders, and boundary crossing as a dynamic aspect of studying worlds that are focused on, influenced by, and birthed out of Global Asias, and reorient the space/time coordinates by which we imagine Asian worlds such that alternative cultural concepts and geopolitical contexts come into focus. This reorientation helps us remap Asia outside of an East-West binary to focus on different axes of relation (i.e., Asia–Latin America, inter-Asia, Sino-Africa), attunes us to alternative forms of territoriality (such as non-sovereign entities like Taiwan, Hong Kong, Tibet, or Oceania, or concepts like Brian Russell Roberts's [2021] "borderwaters"), and enables critical attention to migratory formations that complicate center/periphery models of movement (such as the "double diaspora" [Wacks 2015] of Indians from Tanzania who then scatter throughout the Anglophone nations of the developed world or *zainichi* Korean Americans, who now reside in the Americas rather than "residing in Japan," which is the literal meaning of *zainichi*). Global Asias recognizes the importance of migration (for the subjects we study, but also for us as scholarly subjects), consequently enabling us to consider ongoing forms of exodus and resettling, new and old forms of displacement along with an awareness that displacement can occur even when populations stay in place, and emerging forms of connectivity generated by technology and

the increasing prominence of the digital in mediating across distance and division. As a vibrant, multidisciplinary field of academic knowledge production, Global Asias thus reimagines the conditions of possibility animating scholarly research on Asia and its multiple diasporas and lays the groundwork for sustainable and sustaining intellectual exchange across disciplinary, institutional, and field boundaries.

In closing this introduction, and in opening to the convergences that follow, allow us one final observation. As should be clear by now, this volume makes its arguments through exemplification, and it is worth noting that its compositional layers, both the particular genres and forms of which it is made as well as its general arrangement as a scholarly enterprise, exemplify an argument about the academic profession as well as about Global Asias as a field of academic study. To return to the praxis of suspension with which we began: this project—its contours and challenges, its conceptual possibilities and limits, its forms and modes of engagement, its durational structure and ethical commitments—could only take its current shape after we suspended the usual practices that determine the nature, priorities, and expected outcomes of academic knowledge production. For many of us, the demands of the profession can feel unrelenting. They constrain to the point of suffocation, valuing only certain forms of labor and certain genres of scholarship. In tackling this project by refusing to conduct "business as usual," we dare to imagine new forms of scholarly engagement, new models for intellectual collaboration, new outlets for creative energy, and new methods for doing work that matters. Global Asias as a speculative endeavor makes imaginable alternative conceptual topographies and alternative circuits of relation, not just for the study of Asia but for ourselves as thinkers, writers, teachers, and collaborators. We are *in suspense* imagining how this volume and its arguments might encourage readers (yes, you) to join us in this worlds-making endeavor.

Notes

Portions of this introduction were initially formulated by Tina Chen and published in "Global Asias: Method, Architecture, Praxis" (2021a).

1. We use "Global Asia/s" in this section to refer to a diverse set of transnationally oriented approaches to the study of Asia, and "Global Asias" throughout

the rest of the introduction when discussing the specific iteration of such an approach promulgated by *Verge: Studies in Global Asias* and this volume.

2. Such work is being accomplished through publication as well as institutional restructuring. Previously published criticism on the topic includes Chen and Chua (2007), Spivak (2007), Chen and Hayot (2015), and the Global Asias forum and Christine Yano's presidential address published by the *Journal of Asian Studies* (2021). Also, it is worth noting that both Oxford University Press and Amsterdam University Press have Global Asia/s book series and that this volume inaugurates the Global Asias: Method, Architecture, Praxis book series published by the University of Hawai'i Press. Institutional restructuring is increasingly reshaping programs and departments (i.e., Global Asia programs at Simon Fraser University, Utrecht University, Haverford College, and the University of Toronto, among others; the Department of Transnational Asian Studies at Rice University; various Global Asia/s initiatives at Duke University, Rutgers University, New York University, and Penn State) and encouraging trans-institutional partnerships (i.e., the InterAsia Program sponsored by the Social Science Research Council or the New York Southeast Asia Network).
3. For an overview of the transnational turn in American studies, see Duran (2020); for an overview of Asian area studies and the emergence of critical attention to inter-Asian connections, see Duara (2018); for a discussion of circulatory history, see Duara (2021) and the Field Trip on "New World Orders and the Geopolitics of the Transpacific" in *Verge* 7, no. 1 (2021).
4. See *Verge* 6, no. 1 (2020), the special issue "Displaced Subjects," for an example of how critical refugee studies and Global Asias can operate in tandem.
5. For an overview on the asymmetries and interconnections generated out of Transpacific studies' engagements with these four interdisciplinary fields, see Chen (2020).
6. See the A&Q feature on "Political Science and the Study of Global Asias" (Lee et al. 2017) for a discussion on navigating the challenges of disciplinary priorities and interdisciplinary field commitments.
7. Charlotte Eubanks formulated this articulation, which they shared during the April 23, 2021, Global Asias Cyber Chat, "Challenging Disciplinary Silos."
8. Thank you to Andrea Mendoza for inspiring this observation through her comments at the April 23, 2021, Global Asias Cyber Chat, "Challenging Disciplinary Silos."

9. See "An Interdisciplinary Review of *Kinesthetic City: Dance and Movement in Chinese Urban Spaces* by SanSan Kwan" in *Verge* 2, no. 1 (Bacalzo et al. 2016).
10. See, for example, the two A&Q features "Political Science and the Study of Global Asias" (Lee et al. 2017) and "Contemporary History/Contended History" (Lanza et al. 2019) and the three Field Trip features "Indigeneity at Sea" (Herman et al. 2018), "Settler Colonial Studies, Asian Diasporic Questions" (Day et al. 2019), and "Approaches between Asia and Latin America: A Critical *Renga*" (Bachner et al. 2017).
11. This work was featured in *Global Asias: Contemporary Asian and Asian American Art from the Collections of Jordan D. Schnitzer and His Family Foundation,* an exhibition curated by Chang Tan and organized by the Palmer Museum of Art at Pennsylvania State University, August 28–December 12, 2021.

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Interleaf—Oceanic Transits



John Nelson and Desirée Valadares, *Oceanic Transits.* The Spilhaus World Ocean Map is based on the Spilhaus projection, developed in 1942 by Dr. Athelstan Spilhaus, which brings together the world oceans to form a singular, contiguous, and connected body of water. Illustrated by John Nelson at ArcGIS Living Atlas team at Esri and annotated by Desirée Valadares. Courtesy of ArcGIS. 2023.

CONVERGENCE 1

Transits

Theorizing Transits Im/Mobility, Im/Materiality, Im/Permanence

Desirée Valadares, Evyn Lê Espiritu Gandhi, Alexander Murphy, and Neelima Jeychandran

Research Forum

"Transits" draws attention to the nonlinear and fitful movement of subjects, objects, texts, cultures, languages, and elements across multiple geographies alluded to by "Global Asias": the Transpacific, Transatlantic, and Indian Ocean; Asia, Oceania, and the Americas; East Asia, Southeast Asia, South Asia, and West Asia. "Transits" also invokes the flux of infrastructures and governmental regimes that both facilitate and curtail such movement: trade routes, safe harbors, and flight terminals; immigration or customs checkpoints, state borders, and refugee camps; passports and the lack thereof. The term "transits" is used in the plural throughout the convergence to illustrate not only multiple movements but also blockades and stopovers to open up new understandings of space and time. Transits thus allows us to move away from the bounded nation-state as the primary unit of cross-border analysis to tend toward other spatial metaphors, such as oceans and archipelagos, and anchor in multiple temporalities, contemporaneous conditions, contested memories, and emergent futures.

Though less explored as a theoretical concept, transits is a familiar term and a relatable reference frame to bring together innovative methods and polyvocal perspectives on the state of people, practices, and places in flux in discrete Asian worlds (i.e., regional, national, diasporic, and expat spaces). In many ways, transits is an intersectional, theoretical, and methodological paradigm that on the one hand considers mobility, migration, and diasporic studies and on the other hand diverges from these previous frameworks that stress connectivities and cross-border movements, to expose frictions and stasis in peripheral regimes of transitions and processes of waithood as a tactic for a new Global Asias praxis. In contrast to mobility studies, which tends to romanticize mobile subjects and cosmopolitan convergence, transits addresses the violent histories and ongoing afterlives of colonialism, empire, and racialization that structure movement, producing both forced displacement and carceral containment. In contrast to diaspora studies, which limits its analysis to human subjects and may reify the point of departure or arrival, transits points to the material and immaterial movement of objects, soundscapes, and cultures. In contrast to global studies, which highlights circulation and connectivity, transits also grapples with the missed connections, impermanent relations, and failed solidarities of people and

things on the move. In sum, transits is best defined by the duality and complexity embedded in the slash: im/mobility, im/materiality, im/permanence.

Transits is an inherently relational and collaborative praxis that calls for a transdisciplinary approach: one that transits across disciplines, from area studies to ethnic studies, material culture to cultural history, literature to music, geography to ecology, anthropology to architecture. Transits encourages flexible methodologies that attend to flows and stoppages, convergences and divergences, tracing how different concepts and practices change in relation to specific sociohistorical contexts. It draws on a rich comparative ethnic studies framework, invoking Black geographies in the wake of slavery, Indigenous critiques of colonialism, and Asian migrations due to empire, global capitalism, and war (Sharpe 2016; Byrd 2011; Lowe 2015b).

As writers and researchers, we each approach transits from different disciplinary trainings, familial backgrounds, and areas of expertise. Yet what brings us together is a commitment to exploring how transits can disrupt academic silos, encouraging radically transdisciplinary convergence and collaboration without flattening historical, contextual, and political contentions of the topics we study. We conceive of transits as a collective process guided by three clusters of research questions:

- Who or what transits? Who or what has the mobility / privilege / cultural capital to choose to transit, and who or what is forced to transit? Who or what aspires to transit but is prevented from doing so?
- What geographies are informed by transits? How do transits challenge and push our spatial imaginaries? How do transits unsettle spaces and stable cartographies? What is the "trans" in "transit"? How do we map transits?
- In what ways are transits a reflection of existing dynamics of colonialism, empire, and global capitalism—and in what ways might this keyword offer alternatives to those structures of circulation? What are the political implications of studying transits?

What follows is a collection of short essays that theorize transits from our respective research projects, sites of departure, and positionalities. Desirée Valadares offers "transborder relational geography" as a method

for examining how Pacific Islander, Alaska Native, and Japanese North American communities in the Indigenous Pacific negotiate their memories of forced relocation and the preservation of former Second World War incarceration camps and wider oceanic and carceral circuits. As an example of relational geography, Evyn Lê Espiritu Gandhi offers the concept of "archipelagos of transit" to think through refugee-Indigenous transits across Vietnam, Israel-Palestine, and Guam as well as discursive southern transits across South Vietnam, South Korea, and the US South. Neelima Jeychandran turns our attention to the Indian Ocean rim, theorizing oceans alongside archipelagos in order to think through movements of people, things, and practices through transit ports and the transactions shaped by histories of European, African, and South Asian cultural contacts. Alexander Murphy builds on this method of tracing cultural exchanges by attending to the im/materiality of Transpacific and Transatlantic soundscapes; his research traces an Afro-Asian genealogy of jazz in Japan routed through sites of migration and displacement in California's Central Valley. In between our short essays are a series of interludes: pauses that disrupt the flow of academic writing even as they also serve as bridges between our different sites and modes of analysis. Collectively, we offer these reflections as a model for how transits can be taken up by multiple disciplines and areas of study, even as we encourage readers to note resonances and points of connection across the different contributions.

Our collective pursuit here is to approach transits through different spheres of exchange (material, affective, performative, and multi-scalar) and to look at relational geographies, unsettled sites, archipelagic landscapes, and sensorial cartographies. We thus examine the vitality of transits as a threshold concept and how it opens up different tracks for us to cross over with one another's fields, topics, and timelines of inquiry. Embodying a Global Asias praxis, our process was productively collaborative: during the many animated conversations that we had in writing this piece, as evidenced by our meeting notes (figure 1.1), we acknowledged the bearings of our individual training and the ways in which it defined our calibration of the transits concept. However, the inherent figurative potential of the term "transits" and the dynamism it signifies enabled us to chart trajectories of convergence while still embarking from our disciplinary-inflected vantage points on how to de-compartmentalize and



Figure 1.1. Neelima Jeychandran, "Team TRANSITS Meeting Notes," 2023. Reproduction of an example of Team Transits' preliminary meeting notes. Designed by Neelima Jeychandran.

displace space and categories (i.e., Asian American, Asian, Pacific Islander, South Asian).

The objective of this research forum is to candidly reveal our positionalities and our consensus, coherences, and overlaps, but also the contentions and the ways in which we navigate transits to illuminate complex, nonlinear, and im/material transnational networks and relational sites to offer future potentialities in comparative knowledges. In doing so, we would like to corral the discussions on Global Asias and see how transits can open new possibilities to not only move away from area studies and disciplinary conversations but also reimagine discourses on the Global South, South-South relationalities, theories from the South, and Asian Indigeneity.

After this research forum, we reflect upon how the research questions outlined previously also guide what we conceive of as a transits-oriented pedagogy. We then share some ways to design a course around the analytic of transits and offer specific examples of transits-informed exercises that instructors can adopt for their own syllabi. In so doing, we hope to offer transits as a pedagogical model that can serve to augment the spatial and historical horizons that structure our respective disciplines and methods of study, with an ear to how their mutual interconnection might yield more generative paths of inquiry in and beyond the classroom. We also consider transits as a political praxis and a pedagogic practice to illuminate existing structures of power as well as to map conditions of aesthetic and political possibility to inform our imaginations of a more just future.

Transborder Relational Geographies

Desirée Valadares

Let us consider the matter of passages and arrivals. Jodi Byrd's *The Transit of Empire* (2011) begins with a simple provocation: "What does it mean to be in transit?" What follows is a brief rumination on movement, mobility, and travel and the fluidity, noise, and instability that accompany motion through space. Reflecting on a simple object, a certificate of transit, Byrd concludes that to be in transit is "to be in motion, to exist liminally in the ungrievable spaces of suspicion and unintelligibility. To be in transit is to be made to move" (xvi). Transit thus implies a spatial shift across a given

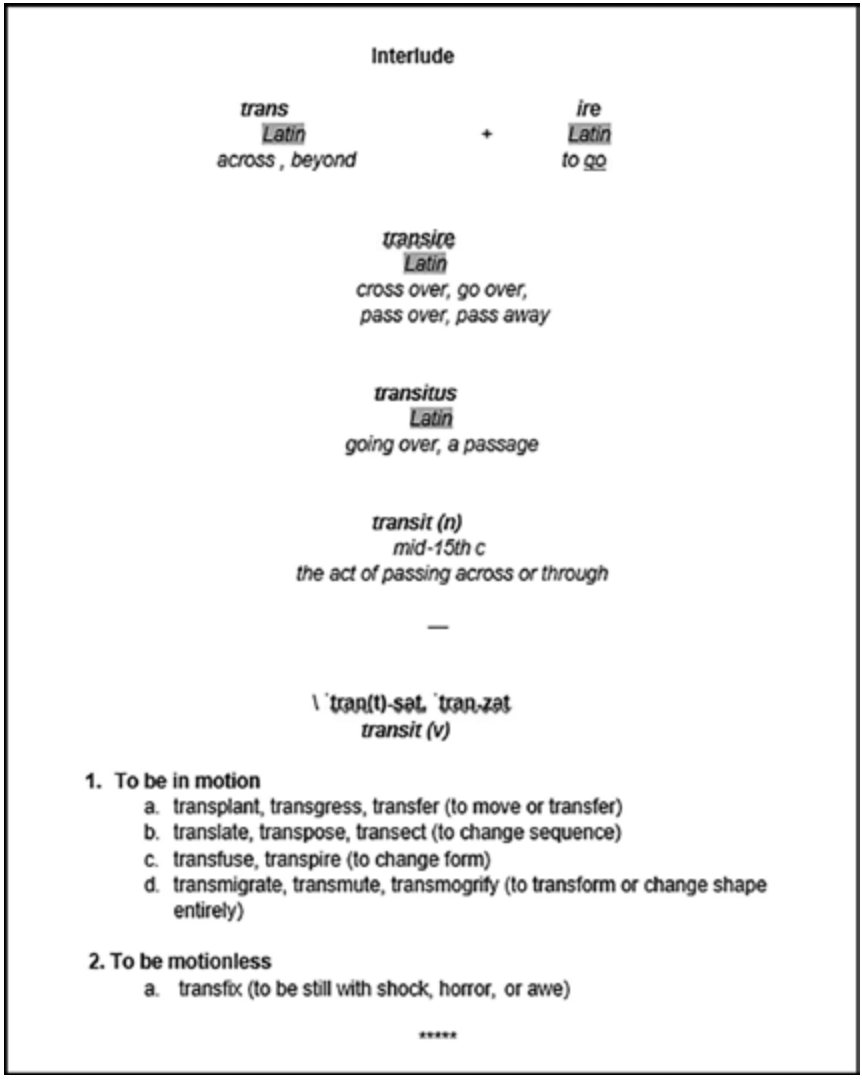


Figure 1.2. Desirée Valadares, *Etymology of Transit,* 2023. This graphic is based on Team Transits' initial research into the origin and historical development of this keyword's meaning. Created by Desirée Valadares in collaboration with Evyn Lê Espiritu Gandhi, Neelima Jeychandran, and Alexander Murphy.

geographic and temporal frame. Byrd elaborates: "To be in transit is to be an active presence in a world of relational movements and countermovements. To be in transit is to exist relationally, multiply. . . . Transit as a concept suggests the multiple subjectivities and subjugations put into motion" (xvi).

In this piece, I consider the key term "transits" to situate my own research and training as an architectural historian. In spatial design disciplines such as architecture and urban planning, "transits" evokes modes in transportation planning, infrastructural connectivity, and flow (such as "a transit corridor"). In these fields, transits can also denote spaces of passage and infrastructures of containment, which are liminal, temporary, and transitory sites that limit or hinder mobility. In both instances, transits function as sites of capitalist extraction to facilitate empire across vast and discontinuous landscapes.

My understanding of "transits," and the politics of im/mobility, is also informed by my family's immigration from Mumbai to Toronto. I write as an "Asian Canadian," more specifically a South Asian Canadian or Indo-Canadian, the latter of which bears a problematic hyphenated ethnic tag that is a product of early eighties policies of Canadian multiculturalism that centers citizenship as a defining marker. I also write from the positionality of a person who has lived in the United States for the last seven years as an international student under the legal classification of a "nonresident alien," but a "resident alien for tax purposes." Living across varied geographies and nation-states, I am acutely aware of my ever-shifting subjectivity. The word "transits" not only is apt to describe my geographic position but also encompasses the "diasporic, mobile, transmigratory nature" of the Asian North American experience (Lim et al. 2006, 8). This word captures the multiplicity of migrant subjects in place-bound locations as well as non-places—the metaphorical and legal spaces of in-betweenness, non-belonging, and non-existence as described by immigration law and citizenship scholar Leti Volpp (2012).

The following sections of this piece explore how transits informs my study of, firstly, the "space" of Asian Canadian studies; secondly, Transpacific im/mobilities of wider carceral circuits or the "carceral archipelago" during the Second World War; and, finally, the value of critical juxtaposition or transborder relational geographies. Each of the three sections underscores how transits is a useful analytic tool to unsettle temporal and spatial scales beyond contiguous landmasses and national borders, allowing for an oceanic or hemispheric perspective that transcends the limits of the nation-state.

Asian Canadian Studies "in Transit"

The field of Asian Canadian studies has largely unfolded within nation-based and often nationalist frameworks even though it has sought to critically expose the racist foundations of the Canadian nation-state (Day 2008; Day et al. 2008; Lee 2007). In 1999, literary critic Glenn Deer, in his introduction to the special issue of the journal *Canadian Literature* devoted to Asian Canadian writing, writes that Asian Canadian studies is quite literally "in transit" (Deer 1999). This guest-edited special issue emerged in a moment of crisis: the arrival of Fujianese migrants on the shores of British Columbia in 1999, which led to racialized backlash in public discourse. Deer juxtaposes the arrival of these migrants with the story of his father, who came to Canada in 1921, and that of Adrienne Clarkson, whose family came to Canada as refugees and who eventually rose to the office of governor-general. Questioning the discourses that make "Chinese" migrants legible in Canadian society, Deer draws parallels with the United States in order "to move beyond the constraints of racial categories and into the ongoing assertions of identity in borrowed or invented voices that we might call our own" (15). Asian American and Asian Canadian experiences and scholarship are positioned alongside each other, acting alternately as models and points of comparison in a continental conversation about identity, self-representation, migration, and inclusion. Just as Byrd (2011) explores how Indigeneity functions as a transit in *The Transit of Empire,* how do we (as Asian Canadians) understand our locations and ourselves in the colonial present?

While he does not explicitly define the term "transit," Deer argues for the importance of "mov[ing] beyond the constraints of racial categories and into the ongoing assertions of identity in borrowed or invented voices that we might call our own" (Deer 1999, 15). He draws attention to the importance of self-identification, building coalitions between diverse groups, and providing exposure for a wide range of authors and artists. Deer argues that this mode of critique is vital in a country where federal multiculturalism policies of the 1980s have encouraged a Canadian "reticence" in discussing matters of race at the policy level. As Lisa Lowe argues in *Immigrant Acts* in a statement that is meant to apply to the United States but serves especially well for the Canadian situation, "The presence of Asia and Asian

peoples that currently impinges on the national consciousness sustains the figuration of the Asian immigrant as a transgressive and corrupting 'foreignness' and continues to make 'Asians' an object of the law, the political sphere, as well as national culture" (Lowe 2012, 19). At the time of Deer's writing and publication in 1999, Asian Canadians continued to be cast as other by a historical narrative that included acts of exclusion, incarceration, disenfranchisement, and discriminatory taxation.

Methodological Transits and the Carceral Archipelago

How do we understand Asian, Indigenous Asian, and Indigenous subjectivities and mobilities in the noncontiguous United States and outlying US former territories during wartime and in its aftermath? In my current book project, tentatively titled *Carceral Conversions: Stewarding Second World War Confinement Landscapes,* I study how distinct wartime legal conditions of martial law in Hawai'i, imperial Japanese occupation in Alaska, and the enactment of the War Measures Act in Canada produced fundamentally new architectural typologies of the camp. I find the figure of the *carceral archipelago* to be a useful spatial imaginary for mapping, remapping, and unmapping the im/mobilities or uneven mobilities of differently racialized peoples during wartime. In particular, I focus on the blurred categories of Japanese North American and Alaska Native people who were unjustly and forcibly confined during wartime in repurposed camps in the under lands (the plantation gulch) in Hawai'i, along linear routes (the unbuilt highway) in British Columbia, and in salvaged sites (defunct canneries) in southeast Alaska.

Transits as an analytic allows for a deeper understanding of these camps, which form a larger carceral circuit or archipelago in the Indigenous Pacific. These uncontained and discontinuous sites were repurposed landscapes that differed from the purpose-built sites on the US mainland. These camps tested cultural boundaries and advanced programs of forced labor. Given their recovery in the public consciousness, my project traces the ways in which intergenerational post-redress movements in the noncontiguous United States and Western Canada negotiate claims to space and war memory, in the absence of treaties and in the wake of long-standing calls for demilitarization and restitution of lands and waters.

In *Nature Behind Barbed Wire* (2018), environmental historian Connie Chiang argues that wartime incarceration was "fundamentally an environmental story" (Chiang 2018, abstract). Her environmental history of the incarceration period offers new insights into four US mainland camps, namely, Manzanar, Topaz, Gila River, and Minidoka, which were "deeply embedded in the lands and waters along the coast and the camps further inland" (5). She argues that these site-specific environments have become "an unexamined backdrop rather than an integral part of this wartime program" (4). However, few scholarly studies contend with the afterlives of these landscapes and the heritage politics of their preservation. The archival and architectural lens by which I study ongoing preservation processes at these sites raises questions about Pacific War remembrance and commemoration on occupied, contested, and unceded lands in the Indigenous Pacific. I ask: how can the preservation of war atrocities be better oriented toward a politics of restitution in settler colonial contexts? These lines of inquiry require the application of cross-disciplinary methodologies in art and architectural history, environmental history, geography, and critical heritage studies as well engagement with American, Asian North American, and Indigenous studies. My research draws from legal, cartographic, and visual archives and embodied forms of knowledge to understand multivocal and unarchived histories of each landscape. I combine this with on-site fieldwork using land-based methods such as landscape archaeology, community gardening, and architectural documentation to forefront ground conditions of repurposed Pacific War camps nestled in ditches, islands, river valleys, and mountains.

Ultimately, this research requires a methodological transit to reimagine a de-carceral future in which former camps are recognized and remembered as sites of conscience but also are attuned to distinct but inextricably connected histories of colonization, Western imperialism, and militarism in Asia-Pacific and the Arctic that shape migrant and Indigenous subjectivities and relationships to land (Trask 2008). This research imagines a heritage politics attuned to competing and overlapping settler war memories of unjust incarceration amid unresolved Indigenous (Kānaka Maoli, Alaska Native, and Coast Salish) land claims while also broadening the geographical parameters of the aftermath of forced wartime incarceration across a

transoceanic circuit in the noncontiguous Pacific. The project's transborder framework exposes critical legal distinctions in US and Canadian wartime histories and in subsequent movements (as Lisa Yoneyama terms "transborder redress culture") for redress and symbolic reparations such as memorials, heritage sites, and markers that shape the built and natural environment (Yoneyama 2016, 12).

Transiting De-carceral Geographies

My research uses "relational geography" as a mode to understand how disparate post-redress movements, across a north-south oceanic axis, coalesce to demand formal recognition and preservation of former wartime confinement landscapes. Relational geography, or a "geography of relational politics," advanced by geographers such as Doreen Massey (2005) and taken up by Katherine McKittrick (2016) aims to resist traditional geography formations and traditions by engaging in transregional and transborder formations that can identify, expand, and/or create new lines of inquiry and struggle. Relational geography is akin to the concept of transits (or Lisa Lowe's "intimacies") and aims to "read across archives" to trouble the geography of disciplinary knowledge production determined by conventional mappings of the colonial world (Lowe 2015a, 2015b). In critical ethnic studies, a shift from comparative approaches to relational analysis builds on the thought of Black feminist theorists such as Hortense Spillers and Sylvia Wynter. The turn toward relationality has had an impact on how critical ethnic studies scholars approach their object of analysis. Relationality offers a complex shift in analysis with scholars such as Iyko Day, for example, who has argued that comparisons conceal the workings of racial capitalism that fail to contend with Asian racialization in North America in the context of war and settler colonialism (Day 2016; Day et al. 2019). Similarly, Manu Vimalassery, Juliana Hu Peagues, and Aloysha Goldstein (2016) discuss "colonial unknowing" as an epistemological orientation that works to preempt relational modes of analysis. In addition, Naomi Paik (2016) connects histories of prison camps with broader histories of incarceration in the United States and draws parallels between subsequent processes of redress and pardon. This scholarly work opens further avenues of inquiry by situating the space of the camp within the US prison-industrial complex and the racial politics it entails.

Transits is thus a useful analytic to consider how camp networks extend and prefigure the military-industrial complex and how wartime internment operations fundamentally unsettled and uprooted multiple populations in Hawai'i, British Columbia, and Alaska. To understand these landscapes' transformations in the contemporary moment, I consider how reparative logics embedded in circuits of redress operate through shared tactics. I look to geographers in the subfield of carceral geography who challenge spatiotemporal understandings of the camp along a "carceral continuum." These scholars focus on the distribution of carceral systems through multi-sited and multi-scalar studies. The "carceral" is seen not only as spatial, but as emplaced, mobile, embodied, and affective. For example, Ruth Wilson Gilmore's *Golden Gulag: Prisons, Surplus, Crisis, and Opposition in Globalizing California* (2007) on the prison-industrial complex in Central California and issues of rural-urban forced migration addresses issues of gender, mobility, labor, security, economics, and state power. Geographer Laurel Mei-Singh similarly extends the carceral to explore military-carceral convergences through a study of fences as security infrastructure on the island of O'ahu at Ka'ena Point. Her reading of the fence as environmental conservation infrastructure reveals how military occupation on the islands has transformed Kānaka Maoli lifeways through displacement and the disruption of subsistence practices (Mei-Singh 2016, 2021; Mei-Singh and Mullins-Ibrahim 2019). She terms this phenomenon "carceral conservationism," which imposes an environmental protection paradigm to "enforce state imperatives for legitimacy and control" while simultaneously stifling Pacific Islander claims to land, water, and resources (cited in Perez 2015, 621). My project similarly contends with issues of access, stewardship, and kinship relations. It speculates how experimental or unauthorized forms of preservation might take place within, outside, and beyond the state through other models of collective ownership and authorship that provide space for communities to narrate and manage their histories in culturally appropriate ways.

Interlude

From the incarceration camp to the refugee camp
From the carceral archipelago to the archipelago of resettlement
War curtails and compels transit

Subjects flee and resist displacement
Across lands and waters, islands and oceans
Migrants transit across borders
The relational emerging in their wake

* * * * *

Archipelagos of Transit

Evyn Lê Espiritu Gandhi

The camp exceeds the temporality of war. As war seems to draw to a conclusion, militarized spaces of both war-making and civilian incarceration are quickly remade into sites of humanitarian aid for displaced refugees. Guåhan (Guam) is a prime example of what Yến Lê Espiritu (2014) calls "militarized refuge(es)." Andersen Air Force Base and Naval Base Guam, built over the remnants of CHamoru villages, served as key institutions of US military intervention during the Vietnam War; when Saigon fell, these same bases hosted the first camps for Vietnamese refugees that were erected on US soil. From April to November 1975, more than 112,000 Vietnamese refugees were processed in Guam during what became known as Operation New Life. Crossing oceans and islands, they were offered refuge on CHamoru lands and waters in the wake of war.

What does it mean to think of the refugee camp as a space of transit? In what ways are refugee transits entangled with Indigenous transits, embodying complex articulations of im/mobility, im/permanence, and im/materiality? How does the figure of the archipelago enable us to view transits in relation, as transborder relational geographies? These are some of the questions that I explore in this short essay, which reflects on how a Global Asias–inflected analytic of transits has informed my research projects. I come to these projects as a second-generation Vietnamese Filipina American, marked by familial histories of refugee and immigrant transit and currently situated on Tovaangar: the traditional, ancestral, and unceded territory of the Gabrielino/Tongva peoples.

The refugee camp, like the incarceration camp, is a space of transit. As an analytic, transits marks im/mobilities: the forced mobility of refugee

displacement as well the immobility of confinement behind the barbed-wire fences of the camp. In his memoir, *Ship of Fate* (2017), Trần Đình Trụ, one of the 1,652 repatriates who decided to return to Vietnam from Guam on October 17, 1975, writes that although the refugee camp in Guam had "plenty of activities, and all our basic needs were met," it was still "surrounded by barbed wire and had a gate. On the one hand, the base could be seen as an apartment complex, but on the other hand, it could also be seen as a detention camp. It was all the same" (90–91). "Transits" also marks a kind of im/permanence: the temporary nature of the refugee camp mapped onto the more permanent structure of the military base. In Guam, "settler militarism," the confluence of settler colonialism and military empire, is characterized by a *permanent-transient temporality:* the relative transience of militarized bodies (US soldiers as well as Vietnamese refugees) obfuscates the as yet permanence of the US military as an institution that occupies native CHamoru land (Nebolon 2017; Gandhi 2022b, 133–156). In this situation, it is the Vietnamese refugees who stayed in Guam, rather than those who transited elsewhere (to the continental United States, Canada, or France, for example), who are best positioned to remain accountable to ongoing CHamoru struggles for decolonization. Ears attuned to island politics, they are a part of what Vietnamese CHamoru blogger Bianca Nguyen calls a "decolonization conversation" (Nguyen, October 25, 2008–December 19, 2020).

In Guam, the refugee camp invokes not only refugee transits but also Indigenous transits: the displacement of CHamoru families from their ancestral villages to make room for the increasing military occupation of the island. By Indigenous transits, I mean the forced displacement of Indigenous subjects from their native lands and waters due to settler colonial occupation, exclusion, and genocide. "Transits" also invokes Chickasaw scholar Jodi Byrd's concept of "transit of empire": how the United States "makes Indian" those peoples and landscapes it seeks to conquer and incorporate in an insatiable drive to expand into new markets for capitalist production and consumption (Byrd 2011, xx). The imagined geography of "Global Asias" is deeply shaped by these transits of empire: how the United States colonized Indigenous islands and archipelagos across Oceania in order to reach into and across East, Southeast, South, and West Asia, as well as how the rise of Japan during the early twentieth century offered an

inter-Asian alternative to US empire that was nonetheless predicated on violent hierarchies and occupations in Manchuria, the Philippines, South Korea, and Guam, to name but a few.

Refugee and Indigenous transits mark the militarized geography of Guam (Ghanayem 2023). In summer 2022, I visited Orote Point on Naval Base Guam with my mother: a return of sorts. In April 1975, my mother and grandmother had left Saigon by military plane with very little except the clothes on their backs; they were interned at Tent City at Orote Point (so-called for the rows of tents that at its peak housed over 39,331 refugees) for ten days before transiting to Southern California, where I grew up in the shadow of Camp Pendleton, another military base (on Juaneño, Luiseño, and Kumeyaay lands) that had sent marines to fight in Vietnam during the war and that had housed Vietnamese refugees after the war. Orote Point is a palimpsest of multiple militarized histories. It was originally a military airstrip constructed during World War II by CHamoru and Korean laborers at the command of Japanese soldiers who occupied Guam from 1941 to 1944. In June 1944, US military forces returned to Guam to challenge the Japanese. On July 21, 1944, a day alternatively remembered as Liberation Day or Re-occupation Day, the United States regained control of Guam and a rapid postwar military buildup ensued. Land was taken and borders were drawn; entire CHamoru villages were uprooted as the US military constructed ever-larger bases. Then, in the wake of the Vietnam War, tents were hastily erected on the overgrown World War II airstrip at Orote Point to house the incoming Vietnamese refugees.

On the day of our visit to Orote Point, the military tour guide pointed out local CHamorus who were visiting their ancestors at a nearby cemetery on base—all that was left of the CHamoru village of Sumay. For the guide, it was a point of pride: how gracious the military was to allow CHamoru civilians to access the base once a year to pay their respects. For us, it was further evidence of military violence and the im/mobility of transits: the forced relocation of CHamoru villagers to make way for the US security apparatus as well as the restriction of their ability to visit their loved ones buried at Sumay save for one day out of the year.

The refugee camps in Guam are echoed in other postwar refugee camps across Southeast Asia, such as in Malaysia, Hong Kong, and the

Philippines. They also invoke spaces of Vietnamese refugee resettlement, such as the continental United States, France, Canada, Australia, and Israel-Palestine. Israel-Palestine is another site in which Vietnamese refugee transit is entangled with Indigenous transit: the forced displacement of Palestinians uprooted from their homelands by the Zionist state. How do we think about these different refugee camps and sites of refugee resettlement in relation?

I find the figure of the *archipelago* to be a useful spatial imaginary for mapping these transborder relational geographies of refugee and Indigenous transits. First, the figure of archipelago invokes both land and water, noting a duality or non-opposition between the two. "Land" can invoke both the homeland that refugees are forced to flee and the native lands that Indigenous subjects cultivate. "Water" can invoke the oceans and seas that refugees and Indigenous subjects are compelled to navigate due to forced displacement. One may assume that land references stability and immobility while water alludes to fluidity and transit; but the archipelago disrupts these assumptions, noting how lands are moved, shaped, and connected by waters, and how waterways intersect across lands to carve out connections between fluid bodies. In sum, the figure of the archipelago marks multiple forms and relations of transit: those who transit, those who wish to transit, those who fight not to be transited, and the lands and waters through and across which one transits.

Tracing Vietnamese refugee transit to Guam and Israel-Palestine, for example, reveals two interconnected forms of critical geography: first, archipelagos of empire, or how the Vietnam War is linked to the US military buildup in Guam and unwavering support of Israel. Vietnamese refugee transit, in other words, renders visible otherwise occluded connections between seemingly disconnected sites of US imperial power. Indeed, empire itself is a form of transit—of imperial sovereignty, control, and overreach—that disavows its own power, seeking to obfuscate and disaggregate in order to divide and conquer. But imperial power is never totalizing; it is always met with resistance. The second form of critical geography that tracing Vietnamese refugee transit to Guam and Israel-Palestine reveals is an archipelago of trans-Indigenous resistance: how CHamoru decolonization efforts and the Palestinian liberation struggle are linked in a global struggle against settler colonial violence in its many forms

(Gandhi 2022b). Even as Indigenous movements agitate and organize to resist forced transit, they understand the importance of a different kind of transit: that of "trans-Indigenous" solidarity across multiple place-based struggles (Allen 2012). Similarly, transits is a useful analytic for thinking about refugee-Indigenous solidarities, which transit across the structural antagonisms formed by what I have elsewhere theorized as the "refugee settler condition": the vexed positionality of refugee subjects whose resettlement in a settler colonial state is predicated on the forced transit of Indigenous subjects (Gandhi 2022b, 2).

What does it mean to think about transits in regard to im/materiality—that is, to consider forced and voluntary transits of not only material subjects and bodies but immaterial rhetorics and discourses? My current work investigates southern transits: how different concepts, connotations, and ideas that cohere around an understanding of "the South" change as they transit from one southern locale to another. Focusing on South Vietnam, South Korea, and the US South, for example, invites us to consider articulations and invocations of "the South" that do not easily conform to the presumed political homogeneity of the "Global South"—typically associated with anti-colonial, revolutionary, socialist politics. Both South Vietnam and South Korea were spaces of US intervention that aligned with the United States in the cold war order and were therefore seemingly outside the Third World Liberation movement. What if we interrogate their southern politics: what does "the South" mean in a Global Asias cold war context?

Furthermore, what happens when South Vietnamese and South Korean refugees and migrants transit to the United States and encounter a different North-South political geography? What happens when they are interpellated by the racial politics of a US nation-state shaped by slavery, anti-Blackness, the US Civil War, and Lost Cause rhetoric manifested as White supremacy? How do South Korean and South Vietnamese discourses and understandings of southern history and affect change in transit to the US South? Consider, for example, the Capitol insurrection of January 6, 2021 (figure 1.3), which witnessed the stark juxtaposition of Confederate flags with South Vietnamese and South Korean flags. South Vietnamese and South Korean anti-communist politics, shaped by Asian



Figure 1.3. Evelyn Hockstein, *Storm the Capitol,* 2021. Confederate flags juxtaposed with South Vietnamese flags at the January 6 insurrection. Evelyn Hockstein for the *Washington Post.* Digital photograph.

cold war histories of civil war division, are unevenly translated into the geopolitical logics of the US South. According to Viet Thanh Nguyen (2021), "In America, white nationalists and Vietnamese nationalists share a common condition: a radicalized nostalgia for a lost country and a lost cause." In a more celebratory valence, Monique Truong (2010) has described herself as a "Southern girl, twice over: South Vietnam and the American South."

Susan Choi's novel *The Foreign Student* (2004), meanwhile, offers a literary example of these vexed southern transits. When the protagonist Chang Ahn, Korean War refugee and recent foreign exchange student, finds himself faced with the challenge of explaining the Korean War to a congregation of white southern Americans at St. Paul's Episcopal Church in 1955 Jackson, Tennessee, he resorts to an uneven linguistic transit, translating the seeming inscrutability of the Korean War into the terminology of the US Civil War, the foreignness of South Korea into the intimate geography of the US South:

> "Korea is a shape just like Florida. Yes? The top half is a Communist state, and the bottom half are fighting for democracy!" He would groundlessly compare the Mason-Dixon line, and see every head nod excitedly. "In June 1950, the Communist army comes over the parallel and invades the South. They come by surprise, and get almost all of the sea." . . . "The Communists go fast, until the UN force is crowded into a very little space at the bottom of Korea, around the city of Pusan." He pronounced it for them loudly: *Poos-ahn*. "This is like, if the war is all over Florida, and our side are trapped in Miami." (Choi 2004, 51–52; emphasis in original)

Via Chang's translation, Korea becomes Florida; the 38th parallel, the Mason-Dixon Line; Pusan, Miami. In this passage, the referent for "the South"—a political entity fighting for democratic sovereignty against the invasion of the North—remains slippery: South Korea in June 1950, but also the Southern Confederacy almost a century earlier, given the prior sentence's invocation of the Mason-Dixon Line. In this transit and translation between two civil wars, two southern geographies, Chang also translates his foreign body into the sociality of the US South: "This is like, if the war is all over Florida, and *our* side are trapped in Miami" (Choi 2004, 52; emphasis added). With the use of this first-person plural, Chang performs a two-way translation: he asserts a shared camaraderie with his southern American audience, shaped by the legacy of the US Civil War, and he invites them to identify with the civil war of his own homeland, the decolonizing nation of Korea.

But what if South Korean and South Vietnamese subjects rejected the Southern politics of the Confederacy and Lost Cause rhetoric, and instead embraced a different southern legacy routed through Black survival and resistance to the afterlives of slavery (Gandhi 2022a, 2022c)? We can find a glimpse of such alternative southern transits in Hương Ngô's installation, *And we are still here . . . but we are still here* (2021) (figure 1.4). Born in a Vietnamese refugee camp in Hong Kong and having grown up in the US South (North Carolina), Ngô created this installation for the Contemporary Arts Center, New Orleans, as part of Prospect 5, the city's triennial art event. Consisting of hectograph-print as well as block-letter-cut posters hanging from the ceiling, the installation features the phrases "We are still here" and "But, we are still here" in English, Vietnamese, and



Figure 1.4. Hương Ngô, *And we are still here… but we are still here,* 2021. Hectographs. Installation view: Prospect.5: *Yesterday we said tomorrow,* 2021–2022. Contemporary Arts Center, New Orleans. Photo: Alex Marks.

Louisiana Creole (Kouri-Vini), marking the ongoing presence of Black, Native, Creole, and diasporic Vietnamese communities on the lands and waters of Bulbancha, the Choctaw name for New Orleans. As the project description reveals, these "low-tech, highly accessible prints created using a water solution reference the Communist anti-colonial movement that employed this medium to swiftly disseminate sensitive information," but they also, in the New Orleans context, allude to the history of the Transatlantic slave trade: "water [is] a force that has brought commerce and life to the port city while harboring potential violence" (Ngô 2021–2022). Overall, the installation bears witness to multiple forms of southern transit, marked by im/mobility, im/materiality, im/permanence. Tracing how forcibly displaced African, Vietnamese, and Indigenous communities (and the intersections between them) come to coexist in the space of New Orleans necessitates an archipelagic method, a mapping of archipelagos of transit. "Archipe-logics," to borrow a term from Lanny Thompson (2017, 70), attend to how war, empire, racial capitalism, and settler colonialism shape transits of forced and voluntary migration—but they also decenter hegemonic power,

instead focusing on how southern actors, refugees, migrants, and Indigenous subjects make sense of their lived experiences of transit via storytelling, writing, art making, and world-building.

Interlude

What does it mean to inhabit a transient place?
What does it mean to be moved or journey under duress?
How do we then illustrate histories of spaces of indeterminate confinement,
and stories of those who are being held through an archipelagic lens?
One that tells the story of isolation, marginalization, and
cultural transactions under contingency.

* * * *

Transient Oceanic Spaces and African Spectral Histories

Neelima Jeychandran

Kochi, the South Indian harbor town, is a popular tourist destination for national and international travelers and has been the focus of my research inquiries on the Indian Ocean and African-Asian studies.[1] It is also home, as my parents live in Kochi. To explore the different connotations of the word "transits" and its spatial, lexical, and conceptual references, I take a situated approach and look at Kochi—a colonial and international transit port in the Indian Ocean—a place that has witnessed the shifting claims of empires and one that has absorbed histories of mobile communities and cultures. In many ways, this essay stems from my personal and intellectual engagement with Kochi and my intellectual tryst with oceanic epistemologies. By taking the case of Kochi, I unravel how oceanic landscapes nurture ecologies of transits, and in so doing, I also factor in and expand on the three questions posed at the beginning of this convergence: Whose mobilities are invisibilized? How do different kinds of mobilities get situated in particular localities? And how does transits, as a concept, unsettle earlier understandings of nodes of exchanges? I probe these questions by positioning myself in the Oceanic South to call for a rethinking of our

conceptual and methodological approaches to mobility, connective spaces, and sites of transcultural interactions.

Suppose one has to narrate a concise history of Kochi; it can be said that Kochi (Cochin) in the early sixteenth century became a strategic entrepôt for the Portuguese, who wanted to secure their maritime spice routes. Initially for the Portuguese and later for the Dutch and the English East India Companies, the harbor of Cochin became vital in moving their goods and safeguarding their maritime empire. While the fortified area referred to as Fort Cochin housed the Europeans, in contrast, Mattancherry, its adjacent town, burgeoned as the cosmopolitan universe that accommodated Indian Ocean migrant communities like the Arabs, Hadhramis, Jews, Gujaratis, Kutchi Muslims, Tamils, and Konkanis. Today, the old parts of Fort Cochin/Kochi visibly reflect European architectural influences. At the same time, Mattancherry's heritage streets and religious landscapes (i.e., synagogues, mosques, churches, and Hindu and Jain temples) exhibit centuries of transcultural exchanges. However, many invisibilized histories of colonial occupation and regional retentions of the troubled pasts manifest in inconspicuous spaces at Fort Kochi and Mattancherry. It is to unravel these unnoticed, unsettling, and unwritten histories of the Indian Ocean entrepôts and transit geographies that I mobilize transits as a concept.

Indian Ocean Transit Geography

In the Asiatic worlds, maritime and overland pathways have played a vital role for centuries in funneling the movement of people, practices, and a range of commodities, from essential to luxury goods. Asian, African, and Arab seafarers and their heterogeneous maritime networks functioned as "bridges" and "doors" (Simmel 1994) that not only linked the western Indian Ocean with Southeast Asia but also created a thalassological world through the circulation of ideas, texts, technical knowledge, and craftsmanship, among other exchanges. Religious spaces, markets, and docks in the littoral geographies were not merely zones of contact but also sites of rest, refuge, and reintegration for people and things in transit. At stopover ports, traders, religious scholars, missionaries, and artisans would stay for months and years before continuing their journey, and a few got permanently anchored in the transit geography. Though by definition, anchorage and transit connote diametrically opposite meanings, historically, in the Indian

Ocean, entrepôts and archipelagos defied such categorizations as they emerged as sites shaped by im/mobilities. Scholars studying the Indian Ocean have argued that many littoral cultures and spaces are archipelagic in nature, as people moored and unmoored at these geographies, shaping relational social and spatial connections (Kabir 2022). For instance, in the Indian Ocean, religious establishments were archipelagic sites, as they offered temporary shelter and were vital community spaces that affectively and spiritually connected distant geographies. For the South Asian diaspora, sacred spaces have long been anchorage sites that link them to other community members and back to the homeland during transoceanic migrations. Studying the Sikh communities in Fiji and other Indian Ocean sites, Nicole Ranganath (2020) notes that gurdwaras served as an oasis for people stranded in the Indian Ocean during migration journeys, and they offered them spaces to live and work under the hostile sociopolitical and climatic conditions of Fiji.

How do we then review mobilities and stuckness borne out of forced and coerced movements in the Oceanic South that often do not fall within the scope of transnational studies? Transits as a dynamic yet ambiguous concept can enable us to transcend the disciplinary and spatiotemporal limits of a land-based approach for reimagining trans-Asian migrations. Jodi Byrd's (2011) foundational work on Indigeneity and transits/transitions indeed offered a new epistemological entry point to review mobilities and the impact posed on movements by structures of empire and racial capitalism. In employing the analytical framework of transits, I hope to move beyond migration studies to study how rhizomatic crossings and forced movements of people between Africa and Asia continue to thrive as lived histories in Indian Ocean ports and archipelagic geographies.

Histories of migration in the Indian Ocean show that, on the one hand, migrants followed nonlinear and multidirectional routes, with some becoming serial migrants. On the other hand, mobile beings like pilgrims charted customary pathways to their destinations and created an oceanic circuit that linked distant geographies in the Indian Ocean. For instance, Muslim pilgrims from the Strait of Malacca who were headed to Mecca via the Arabian Sea transited through different Indian Ocean ports that hosted the hajj pilgrimage infrastructures and its ritual economies, such as systems of payment, travel bonds, and insurance (Tagliacozzo 2014). Such

travelers not only linked the Islamic Indian Ocean through the religious economy and the circulation of texts, portable objects, and sacred materialities but also connected the Afro-Arab and South Asian worlds through systems of bondage as they either marginally or fully participated in the forced mobilities of Africans. Religious travelers returning from Mecca often brought enslaved Africans purchased in the Arab markets.

The circulation of religious travelers and religiosities in the Indian Ocean thus intersects with the forced and indentured movements of people, and it has marked the region's social, economic, and cultural fabric. In the history of the Indian Ocean slave trade, the Arab trade network was instrumental in Africans' indentured and involuntary migrations toward the Indian subcontinent. We see a forced migration of Africans beginning in the eighth and ninth centuries that expanded later to the extent that it surpassed the Transatlantic slave trade in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries. The history of the Indian Ocean slave trade is multidirectional, as there was an inverse forced movement of Asians to work as indentured laborers in the European-controlled territories in Africa and the Indian Ocean islands, such as Mauritius, the Mascarenes, and Madagascar (Alpers 2003; Campbell 2008). The violent histories of involuntary migrations of Asians and Africans are fabulated through sacred geographies from Cape Town to Cambay to Cochin/Kochi. Take the case of the *kramat* shrines in Cape Town dedicated to South and Southeast Asian Sufi saints who were political prisoners exiled to Cape Town by the Dutch during the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries. These saints questioned religious orthodoxy, opposed colonial oppression and slavery, and challenged systems of privilege and racial discrimination. The tombs of these revered saints later became a space for spiritual and cultural anchorage for Indian, Malay, Tamil, and Javanese enslaved and freed people as these sacred geographies registered archaeologies of violent migrations, deaths, memories, and circulations of spirituality (Jappie 2018; Machado 2020). Today, Muslim and non-Muslim devotees from South Africa and Southeast Asia undertake a pilgrimage to these grave shrines to alleviate their afflictions and benefit from these saints' intercessory powers, thus creating new pathways and avenues of oceanic transactions.

To circle back to the transit port of Cochin—a place directly linked to the Indian Ocean religious networks—it is vital to ask how the arrivals

of religiosities (i.e., Islam, Judaism, Christianity) shaped Cochin's cultural geography through creative, ritualistic, and affective place-making practices of diverse actors. At Cochin, while European missionaries and colonial enterprises established churches and seminaries, merchant diasporas created spiritual spaces close to marketplaces that promoted interactions among the African, Arab, and Asian communities. In the premodern and colonial periods, Cochin and its neighboring ports (i.e., in the Muziris region) represented the oceanic cosmopolitanism with Arabs, Armenians, Jews, Europeans, and Indian communities like the Gujaratis living and trading in close proximity and practicing their (religious and ethnic) cultures (Joseph 2006; Varghese 2017). These histories of transcultural exchanges—at times uneasy and strained—are still manifested through sacred architecture, arts, socioreligious traditions, and cuisines. Though a place like Cochin served as a contact zone, as Mary Louise Pratt (1992) has argued—as a site where cultures interact, where people come into contact with their other practices—not all cultures were in proximal contact. Some communities lived on the periphery of the cosmopolitan town and remained segregated. In other instances, transactions between local cultures and cultures from elsewhere occurred at the very margins of the contact zone of Cochin, and such interethnic cultural expressions became doubly marginalized. That may have been the case with Africans in Kochi; though they were present, they were a community living on the margins. To write about the histories of enslaved Africans and the intimacies they shared with other subaltern and disenfranchised communities during their temporary or permanent stopovers in colonial Cochin, we need to not only explore alternative archives but also mobilize alternative analytical frameworks like transits.

African Spectral Pasts and Transit Spaces

In a port like Cochin (Kochi), Africans were part of the colonial day-to-day operations. They worked as guards, agricultural laborers, dockhands, and domestic slaves and were also part of the Portuguese and Dutch auxiliary military forces. However, historical discourses on Africans in Cochin are sparse, and, in the present, shrines dedicated to African spirits serve as a counter-historical living archive through which African memories are regenerated (Jeychandran 2016). The histories recorded in archives thus omit Black migrant histories. I use an uppercase "B" for Black histories to

refer to a sociocultural group representing Africans, Afro-Arabs, and interracial communities. Michel-Rolph Trouillot (1995) has pointed out that there are silences that morph histories and silences that evade when the pasts are told. One of the silences surrounding the past of a transit space like Kochi is the history that links Africa and India through the Indian Ocean slave trade.

I thus turn to novel shrines dedicated to Kappiri (African) spirits to discuss how these spirited sites reveal archaeologies of hidden African pasts. I heard different narratives about Africans in coastal Kochi during my ethnographic research. While most locals noted that Africans were brought to the Malabar Coast as enslaved people by the Portuguese and were murdered by them after the Dutch captured Cochin in 1662, others recounted tales of Arab traders bringing Africans. The story of the murder of Africans in Portuguese Cochin is a living myth with a historical recourse—one that redeems the history of the oppressed through ritual practices directed toward African spirits (Jeychandran 2016). Kappiri spirits are benevolent African spirits who inhabit the coastal landscapes and are often considered as a singular spirit that semantically and symbolically represent the souls of unknown deceased Africans and Black people. (The expression "Kappiri" is a racialized blanket term used to refer to Africans, which may have been borrowed from the Portuguese. The spirits of the deceased Africans are often treated as a pantheon of spirits.)

Indeed, the processual landscape of Kochi is embedded with memories of Black people, and some of these memories over time got occluded, while others got repurposed through modest shrines, only to be remembered by a few and forgotten by most. Cultural geographers such as Hägerstrand (1992) have proposed the concept of "processual landscape"—that is, an all-seeing landscape that consists of everything that is present, which entails the remains of the past and all things on the way somewhere in time. Exegeses concerning African spirits show that fraught histories of African migration resurface through sacred geographies in Kochi, a palimpsestic cultural geography that conceals and reveals multiple histories of mobilities. Such forms of historical retention remind us that we need to move beyond existing theorizations of mobilities (Urry 2007) and connectivities or "routes" (Clifford 1997) to understand historical echoes and Indigenous/subaltern voices on migrations. Transits-focused examination

of African or Black itinerant belongings and "repertoires" (Taylor 2003) of memory in the Indian Ocean can unpack how invisibilized pasts get mediated and reanimated in the archipelagic landscapes, in turn suggesting how African-Indian affinities are born out of historical contingencies.

Envoi

Transits as a conceptual paradigm can offer methods to make sense of the messy and obscure histories of Afro-Asian cultures, memories, terrains, and knowledge ecologies and lend a different understanding to histories of involuntary mobilities in the Indian Ocean. Transits-oriented inquiry reminds us to look at different forms of social and cultural moorings at port cities, layover or crossover landscapes, and spaces of unsettlement. A place like Kochi also shows that Black histories of transits survive through memoryscapes and spirited geographies, and to write such histories, we need to approach migration and migrant landscapes differently in the study of Global Asias. Here, I have used an oceanic framework (Menon 2018; Menon et al. 2022) for centering various transits to reimagine relations between coasts (i.e., African and Indian) and other physical, sacred, and speculative geographies. I have taken the example of Kochi to foreground African mobilities that are sporadic and contested and to show that on an epistemic level, a transits-focused approach can enhance discussions on Black oceanic geographies.

Interlude

Given that Afro-Asian geographies are
vibrant, multiple, spirited geographies
And given that they are often
invisible, inapparent, im/material
Composed of transits
unwritten, eclipsed, occluded
One may be led to wonder:
How do their transits sound?
And how, for that matter,
do their sounds transit?

* * *

Tokyo by Way of Tulare County: Jazz Performance in the Transwar Pacific

Alexander Murphy

Tulare County, California, lies roughly two hundred miles inland from the Port of Los Angeles—its southern county line drawn just north of Bakersfield and its eastern border tracing the crest of the Sierra Nevada ridgeline. If these coordinates yield a superficial impression of the area, it is one likely removed from the maritime and littoral geographies so far traversed; formerly home to the largest freshwater lake west of the Mississippi, Tulare County has been, since the turn of the twentieth century, a site of frequent water shortages and droughts. Where the local tule rush was once metonymic of the marshlands surrounding Tulare Lake, the near-complete draining of the lake basin by the 1890s meant that to be "out in the tules" thereafter was to be stranded at the edge of desolation—to be miles from the nearest port, station, or point of transit.

With this in mind, Tulare County may seem a curious point of embarkation in any effort to further chart the aqueous modes of transit that have thus far concerned this suite of essays. Moreover, the very lack of visual reference on most maps to the former existence of Tulare Lake points to the sheer scope of ecological and human history that tends to elude cartography's conventional lines of sight. Yet where visual mapping seems to reach its limit, one finds in this inland region a compelling array of sonic traces: sounds that reveal an archipelagic network of transwar musical performance extending from Tulare County to Tokyo, Japan, and which conjoin a diverse cohort of Black and Japanese American musicians—in transit between tenant plots, incarceration camps, and dance halls—within a shared musical genealogy navigable at oceanic scale. What one finds here, in short, is an occasion to offer an account of California's Central Valley that is simultaneously a history of jazz in Japan.

In concert with the theme of this convergence, then, I want to embark from Tulare County to offer a brief historical example of Afro-Asian transits across a Transpacific sphere of music and sound, and to consider the questions that such an example might raise for the study of Global Asias. Namely, what might it mean for a Global Asias praxis to route a history

of jazz in Japan through the Central Valley—a largely rural, landlocked area seemingly removed from the urban centers and port cities that tend to populate jazz historiography? What latent formations—sonic, social, political, or otherwise—might be heard by connecting sites of drought, incarceration, and displacement to those of creative and coalitional potential? And how might such an attunement challenge the boundaries, containments, and carceral impulses that extend from social life into our disciplines of study?

From One Country/side to Another

In approaching these questions, it is worth turning to the town of Allensworth, a small rural settlement at the edge of the former Tulare Lake basin founded in 1908 as the first self-sufficient Black agricultural community in California. Having thrived in its early years, the town fell into crisis in the 1920s due to severe drought and the Pacific Farming Company's diversion of irrigation services to neighboring White landowners. Those who remained in Allensworth faced dwindling resources, while the majority of residents relocated elsewhere. Among the latter, a young mother named Virginia Williams left Allensworth with her family and settled 250 miles away, in Berkeley. Several years later, in 1934, Williams's four teenage children—John, Charles, Robert, and Midge—would travel roughly 5,000 miles from Berkeley to Tokyo to perform as a song-and-dance quartet at the Florida Ballroom, the most famous of Japan's prewar dance halls. In so doing, Midge Williams would become one of the first Black female jazz singers to perform in Japan (Arnold 2005).

For the critic Segawa Masahisa, Midge Williams's talent was "immediately apparent." Her singing, "full of ad libs and uninhibited vibrato," was apparently impressive enough that the Florida manager charged an "unheard-of" admission price of thirty sen per ticket and still managed to sell out every night of the weeklong run (Segawa 2005, 118). On the heels of her residency, Williams entered Japan's Columbia Records studio to record bilingual versions of her repertoire—first verse in Japanese, second in English—with the prominent jazz critic Nogawa Kōbun translating the lyrics to "Bye Bye Blues" and "Dinah." The buoyant arrangement of "Dinah," in particular, with Williams adding intrepid back-phrasing and flat fifths to those verses in her nonnative tongue, caused a stir in Japan's nascent

music industry. Over the course of the year, a number of aspiring Japanese jazz singers—some of whom had sought out Williams for pointers on their phrasing—took to covering the song in similar fashion, setting off what Edgar Pope (2011, 162) has described as Japan's "Dinah boom."

Yet while many Japanese commentators noted the apparent novelty of Williams's nonnative vocality—"possessed," for the performer Hayashi Tokio, "of a particular flavor that we Japanese could scarcely imitate"—Williams was only the latest among a growing cohort of Black singers to tour the region (Segawa 2005, 118). Over the preceding decade, groups like the Louisiana Trio, Wilbur's Blackbirds, and Jack Carter's Music Makers passed through Tokyo and Osaka on their way to and from venues in Shanghai and Manila, joining musicians like Teddy Weatherford, Valaida Snow, Nora Holt, and Buck Clayton in building a vibrant interwar network of Black jazz performance in Asia that extended from India to Indonesia. By the time Williams arrived in Japan, the jazz age in Asia was nearing its apogee, with venues like the Florida racing to rival those in Shanghai, Paris, and New York. Perhaps for this reason, Japanese promoters were keen to advertise Williams's "Harlem-style" appeal, drawing associations with the Cotton Club and other urban sites of Black performance while largely ignoring her rural upbringing in California's Central Valley. Ironically, however, it was precisely this inland region that would deliver not only Williams but two more singers to the Japanese jazz world: Betty Inada from Sacramento, and Helen Sumida from Fresno.

Betty Inada, a jazz singer possessed of a powerful voice and a deep repertoire honed over several years of performing on California's vaudeville circuit, arrived in Tokyo in 1933 and swiftly established herself as a marquee act at the Florida, where she shared billings with Midge Williams during the latter's residency. Helen Sumida, meanwhile, earned leading status in Japan through a series of duets with the crooner Fujiyama Ichirō and an appearance in the 1935 film *Hyaku mannin no gassho* (A chorus of a million voices) (Tomioka 1935). Together, Inada and Sumida became leading exponents among a larger group of Nisei (second-generation Japanese American) performers who traveled to Japan in the mid-1930s to pursue careers in show business that had been foreclosed by increasingly virulent anti-Japanese racism on the West Coast. For these performers, many of whom had yet to perform beyond the amateur showcases of

their Nikkei (ethnic Japanese) enclaves, Tokyo offered the chance to advance their talents on a scale that would be scarcely imaginable in the United States.

Like Midge Williams, however, this cohort of Nisei expats found their musical and gestural fluencies attributed not to their own everyday experiences but rather to an imagined acculturation in urbane American pop culture. Japanese reviews cited their "Hollywood" appearances and "Broadway-style" routines, while almost none mentioned their provincial extractions—born to Issei (first-generation) migrants, many from nonurban areas in southwestern Japan, who had found work in markets, fisheries, and tenant farms in the United States. In short, what reviews failed to mention (and what many accounts have neglected since) is that this pivotal moment in the Transpacific formation of modern Japanese popular music was less a product of importation than of remittance—one shaped not merely by elite urban consumption but more crucially by the reciprocal transits of agricultural labor migration from one country/side to another.

In this sense, the affinities between Midge Williams and her Nisei counterparts in Tokyo stemmed from more just than a shared sense of bilingual fluency in the era's pop-cultural vernacular. Indeed, the fate of Allensworth bore resonant parallels with that of Fresno and Tulare County's rural Nikkei community, which had grown large enough by the 1920s that the local Ku Klux Klan in the town of Orosi sought to intimidate Nikkei farmers into abandoning their properties (Bringhurst 2000). Tulare's Nikkei population dwindled accordingly over the course of the 1930s but jumped to more than five thousand after the Pearl Harbor attack, when the War Relocation Authority opened the Tulare Assembly Center: a detention facility built to quarantine Nikkei "evacuees" en route to more permanent concentration camps in Gila River and Tule Lake. As with the refugee and incarceration camps so far discussed in this forum, the Tulare Assembly Center represented a paradoxical space of coercive im/mobility—at once a site of confinement and transit—as well as a transient monument to the vexed logistics of mass displacement; most of those incarcerated at the site came not from Tulare but from Los Angeles, while many Nikkei residents of Tulare County were detained with residents of neighboring Fresno County at the Fresno Assembly Center. Among the latter group of detainees was Helen Sumida.

Sumida had returned to California in 1937, finding herself less disposed than Inada to life in Japan. Yet unlike Midge Williams, who went on to pursue a career in New York and a stint in Louis Armstrong's touring band, Sumida effectively retired from entertainment after returning to Fresno; several articles mention her participation in a handful of local dance recitals over the next few years, but her activities remain largely obscure until June 1942, where she is listed in a "Flag Day Program" in the *Fresno Grapevine,* the weekly newsletter of the Fresno Assembly Center.

After being detained in Fresno, Sumida was transferred to Gila River along with the majority of those detained in Tulare. At Gila River, a number of Nisei musicians had formed jazz bands, performing songs likely in Sumida's repertoire at talent shows, dances, and special events. Among them was a group called the Music Makers, which featured a young alto saxophonist named James "Jimmie" Araki. Known for his proficiency across a range of instruments, Araki went on to pursue his talents in jazz beyond the confines of Gila River; after internment, he worked as an interpreter at the Allied occupation's general headquarters in Tokyo, where he used his spare time to sit in with local jazz combos. In 1947, Araki contributed several of his own arrangements for a recording session with Nanri Fumio, the veteran trumpet player who had played on Midge Williams's 1935 recording of "Dinah," and who would later be reportedly nicknamed "the Satchmo of Japan" by Louis Armstrong himself. The session itself meanwhile yielded the first bebop recordings in Tokyo, presaging an oft-cited "golden age" of Japanese jazz in the years to follow (Atkins 2001, 180).

Paths of Resonance

What I have so far recounted, however briefly, is a history composed of and through transits—a series of Transpacific routes of sojourn and settlement linking the trajectories of jazz and popular music in East Asia to currents of racialization, displacement, and agricultural migration unfolding in and beyond North America. It is also a history that has long been inconvenient to tell; after World War II, the stories of Nisei singers who had carved out careers in the imperial culture industry of America's wartime enemy may indeed have seemed less conducive to the task of Nikkei assimilation and civil recognition than those of the 442nd Infantry Regiment (the highly decorated World War II unit composed almost entirely of

Japanese American soldiers), for instance. Meanwhile, in a postimperial Japan now cast as America's cold war ally, the image of postwar "jazz diplomacy" lent credence to an alluring narrative of Japan's democratic rebirth under American tutelage. What complex Afro-Asian transits and migrations had actually laid the foundation for such a rebirth went largely unremarked.

Such has been the general pattern since. Even now, the story of jazz in Japan continues to find description primarily as an occupation-era development—a brief yet efflorescent period of tutelary encounter between mostly White American servicemen and the young Japanese musicians who frequented their bases (Nguyen 2022). In only select cases has this story been scrutinized, and even in instances where the prewar history of jazz in Japan finds fuller discussion, one still encounters a prevailing narrative of importation and territorialization between bounded national entities, mediated likewise by an urban coterie of critics (Atkins 2001, 96–106). Less considered is a more complex rural-urban network of sonorous, embodied transits—one with deeply resonant implications for the very sounds of jazz and popular music to come.

Here, then, to invoke resonance (or dissonance) is not to speak in strictly metaphorical terms. Rather, it is to apprehend the foregoing encounters within a more capacious vibrant field, wherein the very vibration of matter can direct our attention to how voices and bodies, related through musical sound, do not encounter one another as pre-given entities, but rather "emerge anew through the vibrational event in question" (Fast, Leppänen, and Tiainen 2018). For if to be "in transit" is, as Jodi Byrd suggests, "to exist relationally, multiply," then it is also to exist musically—to unfold in an ever-changing state of harmonic tension and release (Byrd 2011, xx). Moreover, the frictious transits of sound through different elemental media—over land, water, and air—alert us to the material properties and affordances of music's cultural and political circulation, lending shape to the often invisible infrastructures of race and empire that set these paths in motion. Yet if one attends to the subtler sonic transformations of vocal inflection—the odd bending of vowels, the syncopation of errant syllables—one can also observe the emergence of new sonic and social bodies in transit: ones that not only call from the material and micropolitical surfaces of recorded sound but also inscribe their "migrant curvature" upon

these objects in ways that resonate beyond the routes of imperial capital that they have hitherto traced (Moten 2018, 70).

For Daphne Brooks, it is this fugitive potential of sound, and "Black sound technology" in particular, that has allowed minoritized performers and listeners to score a "long countermelody" to the more domineering overtures of empire, and to reroute the pathways of imperial capital toward new modes of inventive and coalitional possibility (2021, 79). Similarly, for the voices of Midge Williams, Helen Sumida, and Betty Inada—ones formed in transit and shaped mutually through translation, improvisation, and backstage tutorials—such fugitive countermelodies offer a corrective, in their very sonic materiality, to the discourses that have either trapped them within narratives of national and imperial interest or else subdued them entirely. For indeed, if the figure of "voice" is all too often invoked as a shorthand for idealized forms of subjective agency (premised upon no less fictive transparencies of wholeness, access, and discretely bounded interiority), then it is in fact the very *sound* of the voice that presents a challenge to the former notion. That is, if we tense our ears to the relational and circulatory basis of subjective articulation, it becomes possible to hear such voices not as evidence of pre-constituted essences but as audible traces of intersubjective formation—sonorities forged through the tactile relations of sounding bodies and the vibrant fields they traverse.

To listen after these transits, then, is to resurface a genealogy of jazz in Japan that extends past mere refractions of American popular culture, beyond tropes of exoticism traded between cities and strangers across the Pacific, and ultimately beyond the propagandistic service to cultural diplomacy in which jazz has been historically enlisted. Rather, by broadening the audible spectrum to encompass the diasporic peripheries and nonurban settings of jazz's Transpacific formation, what emerges is a field of aleatory yet agentive crossings—ones reverberating from the dance halls of Tokyo and Gila River to the agricultural plots of Allensworth and Orosi—that join the paths of Midge Williams and Helen Sumida, born in neighboring counties, in an oceanic history inscribed in the im/material transits of migration, displacement, and sound.

But if there is value to be found in such a history, it must derive from more than its apparent novelty—a curious addendum underscoring the extent to which the national, linguistic, and disciplinary boundaries that

separate the foregoing experiences have calcified into common sense. Rather, what I hope these transits offer is an opportunity to theorize Global Asias in a register that is both speculative and deeply rooted in material connections, such that the resurfacing of these already interwoven yet unresolved histories becomes a form of theoretical praxis in itself. In short, to follow these circulatory paths of resonance is to consider how the uneven pluralities of Japanese, Nikkei, and Afro-diasporic cultural experience cross one another in transit, and to listen after the frictions, intimacies, and possible futures they set in motion.

Conclusion

In this research forum, we have used transits as a dialectic to map our distinct approaches to the study of Global Asias. Collectively, we uphold transits as a pedagogic provocation to revise and extend existing paradigms of transculturalism and transnationalism to arrive at new avenues for theorizing decolonial subjectivities. In doing so, we have also reflected on our particular methodological arrivals to transmigration, transnational histories, and transcultural practices and probed what the "trans" in "transits" represents. That is to say, we have asked how this plural focus on "transits" might at once sublimate the term "trans" into a shared vocabulary, while simultaneously inviting multiple lexical interpretations as it merges with other productive terms. And we have shown what transits as a concept can do to intervene in generating contemporaneous understanding of the very category "trans" and its different sociopolitical lexical renderings (namely, transfigurations and transmigrations).

The four pieces that make up this research forum are spatially, thematically, and temporally disparate and disciplinarily diverse, spanning architecture, anthropology, media studies, history, Asian American studies, and Indian Ocean studies. Yet, we have defined a meta-approach for interrogating this term and its assumptions (literary, theoretical, methodological). In doing so, we make no assertions that transits as a concept binds all our epistemic inquiries and ambitions. Rather, what it does on a conceptual level is provide a comparative and relational language for understanding the diverse projects that we pursue under the umbrella of Global Asias. And rather than fusing and disentangling spaces and categories to focus

on clear movements and countermovements, we use transits to illuminate precisely those intermittent points of contact and convergence among similar histories of migration and displacement.

With these contributions, our research forum stresses the importance of archives in flux, latticed histories of spaces, and networks of transmission through practices. Our collaborative thinking process hopes to bridge the gap between theories developed in academe and modes of classroom-based knowledge production by translating such theoretical impulses through various methods, activities, and exercises.

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Pedagogy Forum

While the research forum lays out different ways of approaching transits as a theoretical paradigm, this section explores the translatability of these concepts into teaching. Our transits-oriented approach to Global Asias pedagogy is informed by the same questions that animated our research forum, tracing issues of mobility and containment, diaspora and Indigeneity, and trans-imperial encounter in ways that reach beyond unilinear or terrestrially bounded conceptions thereof. In order to craft effective learning methods, we use the following set of questions on transits to bring into relational consideration various topics that encompass the study of Global Asias, while recognizing the complexities of transdisciplinary approaches:

- Who or what transits? Who or what has the mobility / privilege / cultural capital to choose to transit, and who or what is forced to transit? Who or what aspires to transit but is prevented from doing so?
- What geographies are informed by transits? How do transits challenge and push our spatial imaginaries? How do transits unsettle spaces and stable cartographies? What is the "trans" in "transit"? How do we map transits?
- In what ways are transits a reflection of existing dynamics of empire and capitalism—and in what ways might this keyword offer alternatives to those structures of circulation? What are the political implications of studying transits?

While we come to these questions from different trans/disciplinary trainings and teaching experiences, what connects us is a belief that these questions provide a step-by-step framework for critically analyzing transits and the power dynamics that structure them, both historically and in the contemporary moment. What follows are potential exercises, course models, and tips for building programs that aim to demonstrate how the archipelagic and oceanic transits of actors, objects, and affect unfold across a range of disparate yet resonant cultural and spatial terrains, and how an attunement to dynamics of feedback, circulation, and resonance might enliven students to new paths of practical insight. Rather than offer a

specific set of readings or sites of analysis, which may inadvertently reify a canon instead of opening up fruitful experimentations and juxtapositions, we propose tips and suggestions at three different levels, or scales—exercises, course syllabi, and program building—that can be easily adapted to the Global Asias topic of the instructor's choice.

Exercises

Here, we outline a variety of mapping exercises—both visual and conceptual—that can challenge students to conceive the multiple ways that the texts or media objects of a given course relate to or resonate with one another, what forms or formats of transit can occur between them, and how they might be reshaped as a result. Likewise, we ask how these newly conceived geographies—cultural, relational, and affective—might be metabolized in the very form and philosophy of course design.

Practice Exercise 1. Consider the readings assigned for the week and create a conceptual map of how the different readings relate to one another. What themes or concepts transit between these different readings? How do these readings thematically and geographically change in relation to one another? What transits of knowledge are made possible by juxtaposing these different readings? How do the readings for this week relate to other readings you've encountered, perhaps in other classes? This exercise can also be scaled up to think about the readings for an entire quarter/semester.

Practice Exercise 2. Draw a concept map or a visual map based on the readings for this week. Trace different forms of transits on the map. Who or what is transiting? In what direction(s)? How can you illustrate this transit without using words (but instead symbols, lines, figures, images, etc.)? Once your map is completed, ask yourself: Why did you construct the map in this way? How is the map oriented? Does the map presume a particular vantage point? Did you include nation-state borders on the map? Why or why not? Next, consider what transits are made visible on the map. Are there areas of particular transit density? Explain why, in historical and geopolitical terms, these areas are particularly dense nodes of transit. Are there certain transits that are less visible and harder to trace? Reflect on

why that would be the case. Were certain transits curtailed or disrupted? If yes, why and by what? What larger structures or power dynamics are revealed via the juxtaposition of different spatial trajectories of transit? This exercise can also be scaled up to think about the readings for an entire quarter/semester.

Practice Exercise 3. Using two or three readings from the course, identify a specific theme (this could be expressed in a keyword or phrase) with which to trace a unique "transit" between discrete works. In so doing, don't hesitate to draw transits or linkages that may seem at first counterintuitive or unexpected. If two works at first appear divergent or unrelated to each other, consider how these very divergences or dissonances might nonetheless be framed in a dialogic manner, such that the works might speak to each other, even agonistically. Or in the case of three works, consider a thematic transit that might usefully triangulate their respective contexts or concerns.

Syllabus

Building on the mapping exercises, a possible method to reconceive the syllabus beyond its prevailing function as a linear "road map" is to reflect upon the "archipe-logics" of cultural and geopolitical transit in their organization and presentation of assigned texts and media objects. Rather than reinscribe unidirectional movements to and from fixed geopolitical, thematic, or theoretical points, that is, we ask how different organizational forms might aid in conceiving nonlinear circuits of exchange and knowledge production. In particular, we propose framing syllabi in visual terms as network diagrams or as integrative spatial maps, and in organizing texts and course materials in ways that foreground juxtaposition, counterintuitive connection, and short-circuited paths of resonance. We hope such spatial and geographic reorientations might help students to uncover the unseen, uneven, and multi-distributed ways that different humans, nonhuman beings, and materials cross one another in transit, and the infrastructures of empire and capitalism that underpin such connective movements.

We also discuss what kinds of transits between different disciplines, modes of learning, and interpretations of knowledge are made possible by

the advent of digital technology, and how we might translate such possibilities into generative models of transmedial pedagogy and coalitional learning. Such translations in a course syllabus might take the form of digital exhibitions, podcasts, projects in multisensory ethnography, or visual analysis of queer ecologies in architecture and media that extend beyond the traditional classroom setting. We consider the implications of these teaching tools for a Global Asias pedagogy that extends to the creation of course clusters, transdisciplinary programs of study, and, ultimately, a coalitional and solidarity-building praxis that transcends the space of the university. Following are a few exploratory ideas for a course/syllabus.

Exploratory Syllabus Idea 1: Translation Zones. Emily Apter posits the "translation zone" as a site of linguistic encounter that exists "in-translation," or a space "belonging to no single, discrete language or single medium of communication" (Apter 2006, 6). As with Mary Louise Pratt's (1992) "contact zones," such sites (be they geographic locations, texts, or media objects) are social spaces not only of cultural and linguistic exchange but also of contestation and struggle. For a course that employs a large number of texts in translation, then, consider framing the translated texts as sites or "zones" of semantic and linguistic transit. In so doing, ask what frictions, intimacies, and asymmetries can be gleaned from both formal analysis and historical contextualization, and how these dimensions shape the meaning of a given set of texts. With these inquiries in mind, consider how approaching texts in-translation as contested and unstable "zones" of transit and transference might help students to rethink notions of origination, fidelity, and semantic authority, and how such texts might yield different geographic imaginations, alternate routes of knowledge, or horizons of meaning.

Exploratory Syllabus Idea 2: Out of Area. In lieu of a specific historical or geographical focus, a syllabus can be just as productively organized around a particular theme or set of themes. In teaching a course on oceanic geographies, for instance, one might focus on themes like materialities, mobilities, and diaspora rather than discrete regions or eras; instead of reinscribing boundaries and spaces of containment, such a focus might serve to foreground intimacies and relationalities that arise in and through the transits of people, ideas, and things. Alternatively, one can address issues of carceral

space and im/mobility in transits by way of attention to themes of resistance, agency, liberation, and post-carceral geographies. In turn, take care to discuss with students how each week's readings relate to or build upon the former; in other words, try to draw attention to how a given theme "transits" between weeks, what issues arise in these movements, and what new questions can be asked. By inviting students to articulate the transits between topics in this way, a thematic approach can offer not only a unique sense of internal continuity but also the potential for novel pathways of connection and cross-comparative analysis to emerge.

Exploratory Syllabus Idea 3: Counter-Mapping. In presenting a course's schedule of topics and materials from one week to the next, a syllabus is often likened to a road map: a linear guide to a course's progression from start to finish. In this sense, the syllabus can often function to reinscribe certain historical narratives of developmental progress and assimilation, as well as a sense of unidirectional movement to or from fixed centers of knowledge. Without sacrificing the practical utility of the course schedule, then, consider how a syllabus might serve to challenge rather than reinforce certain spatial geographies of global power and the narratives of progress that underpin them. In addition to a weekly schedule, for instance, one might present a map or diagram that incorporates each text or topic as its own coordinate. Such a rendering might appear as an integrative map that corresponds to a uniquely drawn geographic area, or for more thematically oriented courses, a network diagram.

Exploratory Syllabus Idea 4: Sensory Ethnographies. Consider what happens when people bring ideas, things, and memories of their homelands to other territories. We often see profound transformations influencing the cultural landscapes of both places at once and also the intermediary sites of global transits. In building a course that tracks cultures, heritage, and thoughts in transits, examine how experimental ethnographic mapping (through video, sound recording, drawing), modes of collaboration (with different communities or disciplinary approaches), and presentation (through images, maps, digital media) might help to make otherwise imperceptible processes and neglected histories of movement visible in new ways. Sensory ethnographic methods can be an effective tool to study how

various media, mediums, and narratives represent and record transits of people and cultures.[2]

Transits as Methodology for Academic Dialogues and Programming

The growing economic development in Asia and South-South partnerships have resulted in the recent establishment of research centers, clusters, and initiatives focused on Global Asias such as the Global Asias Initiative at Pennsylvania State University, Centers for the Study of Global Asia at New York University, Asia Research Institute at the National University of Singapore, Indian Ocean World Centre at McGill University, Centre for Indian Studies in Africa at the University of Witwatersrand, Emerging Worlds at the University of Copenhagen, and the International Institute for Asian Studies at Leiden University. Considering the academic surge of interest in studying Asian globality and trans-Asian connections and negotiations, transits as a framework will be useful in focusing on contemporary relationalities within the region but will also be critical in enlarging the terms of previous scholarship and building the field of study. Transits as a method can bring together diverse participants working on Global Asias, such as scholars, writers, artists, curators, educators, students, architects, and popular content creators committed to the reclaiming of multivocal histories of trans-Asian connectivities through academic, creative, and experimental endeavors. To address the blind spots in existing disciplinary frameworks, it is necessary to decenter our knowledge and the thinking of Asia through conventional lenses and methods—or what counts as historically established viewpoints and practices of humanities inquiries.

Transits-based cross collaboration as a method informed by the exercises and syllabus ideas suggested in this convergence will be useful for individual researchers and research initiatives to partner ethically and responsibly with local people, researchers, and Indigenous communities. To this end, the exploratory syllabus idea "Translation Zones" is a useful template to translate transnational and postcolonial histories narrated in vernacular languages that need not necessarily prescribe English-centric knowledge production. Research scholars and faculty affiliated with Global Asias–focused centers and programs in North America and Europe can build on the principles of our transits-based exercises and syllabi to ensure

equitable collaboration with scholars from the Asiatic worlds to stress the importance of transactions through comparative learning and reflexive research practice.

K–12 Education. As anti-Asian attacks surge across North America in the wake of the COVID-19 pandemic, some states and provinces are mandating that Asian North American and Indigenous history be taught at the elementary, middle, and high school levels. In the United States, the history of Asian American and Pacific Islanders is often left out of classrooms and public discourse. Stewart Kwoh, an activist and lawyer, and his wife, Patricia, are at the helm of advancing Asian American studies. Their nonprofit, the Asian American Education Studies Project, founded in 2021, has a series of learning resources created in partnership with the UCLA Asian American Studies Center, Stanford University SPICE, and PBS LearningMedia (Kwoh and Kwoh 2021). Professional development workshops are offered, free of charge, to teachers, and a repository of free lesson plans and teaching tool kits on Asian American history are available. These efforts to bolster K–12 curricula also coincide with the ongoing national backlash to the teaching of race in public schools. Since 2020, a total of thirty-five states have signed into law or proposed legislation banning or restricting the teaching of critical race theory, which seeks to understand how racism shaped US laws.

While this concerted effort to teach about Asian American history in the United States is commendable, there is an urgent need for a Global Asias framework to reiterate the pan-ethnicity of Asia through a transits-oriented framework to emphasize the heterogeneity of Asian diasporas in the Americas. In addition, there is a need to interrogate the "AAPI" label, as it has been mobilized in the North American context, through the lens of global and/or trans-Indigeneity through fostering an understanding of Indigenous peoples across Oceania and Asia.

Museums and Cultural Institutions. In 2019, the Smithsonian Asian Pacific American Center in Washington, DC, launched a $25 million fundraising drive for permanent gallery space on the National Mall. In May 2021, Representative Grace Meng introduced a bill in the US House of

Representatives to establish a commission to study the feasibility of a new National Museum of Asian Pacific American History and Culture as well as a suitable location (Commission to Study the Potential Creation of a National Museum of Asian Pacific American History and Culture Act 2021). This bill passed in the US House of Representatives and then was unanimously approved by the Senate, subsequently becoming Public Law 117-140 on June 13, 2022, when it was signed by President Joe Biden. In the interim, existing museum and cultural institutions with a mandate to educate the public about Asian heritage and Asian American and Pacific Islander contributions to the arts must receive adequate funding to develop multiaccess programming to reach intergenerational audiences. For example, the Chinese Canadian Museum in Vancouver expanded its services through virtual programming for the entirety of 2020 and 2021, during COVID-19, drawing links between the Chinese Canadian and American experience as well as the larger diaspora. In 2022, in observance of National Day for Truth and Reconciliation, the Chinese Canadian Museum cohosted a community screening and premiere of *British Columbia: An Untold History* (Eastwood 2021) to highlight Coast Salish struggles, convergences with the Asian North American experience, and resistance.

Transits-oriented museum programming will bring an emphasis on accessibility (i.e., a traveling exhibition, multipart exhibition, or virtual exhibition component to provide access to in-person audiences as well as other publics). It will also allow exhibitions to be more interdisciplinary by privileging translatability, transportability, relationality, and porosity (i.e., it challenges traditional notions of jurisdiction, historical timelines, and art historical or museological language, etc.). For instance, multilingual translations would feature voice / oral histories / music or mixed-media compositions—featuring a blending of genres and audio and visual content. Furthermore, programming influenced by the principles of transits will allow generative inclusion of Indigeneity as a core concept when discussing Asia and its diasporas.

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Notes to Convergence 1

1. The name Cochin is the Anglicized version of Kochi and is also the name under which the town was known during the European occupation.
2. A course centering these exploratory methods has been taught by Samuel Mark Anderson and Neelima Jeychandran as part of the January-term session at New York University, Abu Dhabi.

Interleaf–"Naturales tagalos"



Naturales tagalos (Tagalog natives) in the "Sino-Spanish Codex" (aka "Boxer Codex"), ca. 1590. Courtesy of the Lilly Library.

CONVERGENCE 2

Indigeneity

Articulating Indigeneity in Global Asias: Identity, Epistemology, and Methodology

Jenny Chio, Diego Javier Luis,
Kyle Shernuk, and Erin Suzuki

Research Forum

> *Concerned that indigenous peoples have suffered from historic injustices as a result of, inter alia, their colonization and dispossession of their lands, territories and resources, thus preventing them from exercising, in particular, their right to development in accordance with their own needs and interests . . .*
>
> —United Nations (2007)

> *Indigenous peoples have in common a historical continuity with a given region prior to colonization and a strong link to their lands. They maintain, at least in part, distinct social, economic and political systems. They have distinct languages, cultures, beliefs and knowledge systems. They are determined to maintain and develop their identity and distinct institutions and they form a non-dominant sector of society.*
>
> —United Nations (2012)

> *According to the UN the most fruitful approach is to identify, rather than define indigenous peoples. This is based on the fundamental criterion of self-identification as underlined in a number of human rights documents.*
>
> —United Nations Permanent Forum on Indigenous Issues (2004)

Trying to discuss, describe, and define "Indigenous," as these three excerpts from various UN documents and declarations suggest, is complicated in perhaps the most unsurprising of ways. How can one term be used to encompass and identify the diversity of people and communities living in extraordinarily different historical, political, cultural, and ecological conditions around the world? And yet, as Indigenous studies scholars and

Indigenous activists have effectively asserted throughout the term's contemporary usage from the mid-twentieth century onward, it is precisely the *global* and *shared/collective* experience of being Indigenous that makes self-/identification as such so powerful and potent in the world today.

On this subject of self-identification, we acknowledge from the outset that none of the authors in this convergence identify as Indigenous, even as we engage questions of Indigeneity in our respective disciplines—literary and cultural studies, history, and anthropology—and areas of study: China / Taiwan / the Sinosphere (Chio and Shernuk), the Philippines (Luis), and the Pacific/Oceania (Suzuki). Trying to unravel "Indigeneity"—the *fact* or *quality* of being Indigenous—in this context thus raises many questions as well as potential insights and emergent synergies. A fundamental question we confront in our research and writing, to slightly rework what Shernuk poses in his contribution, is: who are we, and why are we here? Given that the very existence of an Indigenous identity is rooted, historically, in an asymmetrical colonial power relationship, as Luis powerfully states, what can this discussion of Indigeneity in Global Asias, by non-Indigenous scholars, contribute to both Asian studies and Indigenous studies?

While it is not our place to speak for or from the perspective of Indigeneity under differing national regimes, what we offer in this keyword research forum is a self-consciously, critically engaged reflection on some of the similarities and differences that emerge around different articulations of Indigeneity—as a marker of identity, as an epistemology, and as a methodology—as they move across different geopolitical areas and in different historical and colonial contexts. With our contributions, we aim to model how to engage the work of Indigenous researchers, writers, and activists to highlight continuities and contrasts across a range of Indigenous histories, politics, and epistemologies in the expansive context of Global Asias. We believe this form of engagement is not only necessary but unavoidable, as Indigenous peoples have created the foundations upon which the concept of Asia/s is built, and it should be all scholars' responsibility to understand and engage with Indigenous pasts and presents.

This research forum begins with brief and relatively informal reflections on the UN definition of the term "Indigenous." These reflections model the conversations that we had when we got together, as we discussed the sometimes very different ways we had been thinking about Indigeneity

from our respective disciplinary perspectives, scholarly commitments, and regions of study. Starting with the UN's official definition of the term "Indigenous," which by its nature was designed to apply to Indigenous peoples across the globe, we each think through how this definition did or did not apply to our own understandings of Indigeneity in the context of our own disciplinary perspectives.

Our individual essays then elaborate on our approaches to Indigeneity as a scholarly concept. Erin Suzuki begins by giving an overview of how Indigeneity can operate not only as an identity category but also as an epistemological framework offering situated critiques of colonial and postcolonial articulations of sovereignty and solidarity. Kyle Shernuk demonstrates how Indigenous epistemologies have the potential to become Indigenous methodologies in the writing of Tao Indigenous Taiwan writer Syaman Rapongan. He contends that the Tao worldview's inherent connectivity serves as a model for how to resist and deconstruct the capital-driven perspectives and cultural practices of the Han majority in Taiwan. Diego Javier Luis turns to the racializing terminological origins of Indigeneity, a concept first deployed during the Spanish colonial period as a way of marking a distinction between European and non-European individuals. He argues that contemporary Indigenous identities in the Philippines cannot be neatly disentangled from the colonial conditions that have been responsible for defining and describing them. Finally, Jenny Chio addresses the different ways that Indigeneity has been mobilized in the context of the People's Republic of China (PRC), comparing the ways that discourses of Indigenous identity have and have not been deployed by the Chinese state, in *shaoshu minzu* (少数民族 ethnic minorities or minority nationalities) communities, and by dissident political parties like Buntou Manzyu Cinsin (本土民主前線 Hong Kong Indigenous). Taken together, our essays explore articulations of Indigeneity, its conceptualization, and its theorization within a Global Asias framework. Given the history of the term "Indigenous" as one intended to operate globally and supranationally, we aspire for our contributions, while each rooted in specific cultural, regional, and historical contexts, to demonstrate the ways in which the complex and multi-sited discourses of Indigeneity illuminate the study of Global Asias, and vice versa.

Throughout this forum, we capitalize the terms "Indigenous" and "Indigeneity" when referencing identity. This follows accepted practices at the time of writing to capitalize terms that refer to racial, ethnic, and cultural identities as a means of acknowledging collective histories and experiences that have been and continue to be overlooked and/or oppressed—politically, socially, culturally, and economically—and of offering a gesture of respect and recognition for the formative role of these histories and experiences in the lives and values of these communities.[1] However, when quoting directly from texts, we follow the capitalization conventions used by the source authors.

"Indigenous": Reflections on a Term

Diego Javier Luis: I find that definitions of "Indigeneity" often relegate the term to a set of essential and non-reducible characteristics. Classification for the purpose of sublimating to distinct legal procedures—whatever the positive, neutral, or negative effects of those procedures—is itself a colonial invention. The nature of "Indigeneity" as a formal and definable category has been debated in Europe ever since Christopher Columbus first returned to the Iberian Peninsula in 1493 with kidnapped Taínos. Were these Indigenous people to be enslaved, or were they vassal subjects of the Crown? Were they docile or warlike? Were they capable of receiving Catholic doctrine? Did they have souls? The spirit of those early, fraught debates has persisted over time. One of the clearest examples of this drive toward essentialism comes from the 1720 correspondence of an Augustinian missionary, Gaspar de San Agustín, about the nature of "indios" (the term used to refer to the Indigenous subjects of the Hispanic world) from the Philippines: "It is the truth that the difficulty of knowing these indios is not in the individuals, but in the group because, if one is known, then all are known without distinction—so much that the Greek name monopantos fits them, and which another critic [Francisco de Quevedo] gave to another type of people [Jews] for being among themselves all homogenous and consistent" (San Agustín 1720; my translation). This method of knowing all "without distinction" from meeting one individual was a model of antisemitism developed in Quevedo's work, which San Agustín applied to Philippine Natives. This relational mode of thinking undergirded the

imposition of colonial laws designed to collectively categorize and control populations deemed "rebellious" or "unruly" (Pérez 2005, 208). The "monopantos"—from "mono" (single) and "pantos" (entirely)—is precisely the work of racialization that continues to pervade political and academic thinking about Indigeneity today.

Herein lies one central difficulty of writing about Indigeneity as a subject. It is critically important to maintain a close attention to individual groups and locales while simultaneously acknowledging that an Indigenous subject position often indicates a particular kind of experience—an asymmetrical power relationship with a colonial hegemon, state structure, and/or national identity. And yet, overprivileging this element of power is to miss the complexity of postcolonial states like the Philippines, where the overwhelming majority of denizens are considered Indigenous, even though Philippine "Indigeneity" gets evaluated and assigned variably based on ethnicity, religion, and language. Furthermore, Indigenous identities are often unfixed, change over time, and mean different things to different communities. This is all to say that invoking the term in the context of the Americas, the Pacific, or Asia requires what Gaspar de San Agustín lacked: caution and intention, care and precision.

Jenny Chio: Defining "Indigenous" often appears to function more like describing who is Indigenous, as Diego suggests, from the emic ideal proposed by the UN for self-identification to an etic classification based on a predetermined set of variables. To take another example, the growth of Indigenous film festivals around the world—film festivals committed to the exhibition, distribution, and production of film and media by and about Indigenous experiences—might serve as a case par excellence of how Indigeneity constitutes not only highly specific local contexts and histories but also a shared, collective sense of similarity and solidarity. But what really links all the films in an Indigenous film festival together, other than the fact that they are all classified as Indigenous by virtue of being in said festival? It can feel impossible, and indeed sometimes undesirable, to define what should be obvious: the "you know it when you see it" quandary, as it were. Would we, as viewers or festival attendees, know that these films are Indigenous if they were not curated as such? Why does it matter, and how does it matter, to classify something, or even some*one,* as Indigenous?

I raise the example of film festivals in order to offer a parallel case of "higher-level" Indigenous definition. The UN, in its various institutional efforts to support and protect the rights of Indigenous peoples around the globe, promotes this top-level definition of Indigenous, rooted in the principle of self-identification, out of pragmatic and political necessity. I do not fault the UN for doing so, even if I maintain a (long) list of critical concerns and questions about the consequences of this rhetorical move. The greatest concern, for me, is the potential for states and powerful institutions to co-opt or otherwise take advantage of the good intentions behind the UN's commitment to self-identification. *Who* should be able to self-identify as Indigenous? What if, as I discuss in my contribution here, a government declares its entire citizenry Indigenous? What then?

Kyle Shernuk: I cannot imagine a definition of "Indigeneity" that would satisfy all interested and relevant parties. The UN definitions shown at the beginning of this research forum, as Jenny suggests, meet the political needs of the moment by avoiding the prescription of explicit criteria but also, as Diego suggests, still impute a somewhat essentialized image onto those who adopt it as their own identity. To this latter point, it raises a concerning question: if one assimilates, to some degree, into hegemonic colonial culture—even if it is a matter of survival—does it somehow diminish or erase one's claim to being Indigenous? I am thinking here of Gerald Vizenor's theorization of Native American survivance, which serves as a framework for thinking through a contemporary Indigenous existence that is built on but not beholden to the traumas of Native Americans' colonized pasts (Vizenor 1994). For me, the need for such a term belies the potential stasis imposed on such individuals by broader legal frameworks, such as Indigeneity and nativeness, and makes clear the need for developing alternative discourses that capture a more complete picture of modern life.

To think of Indigeneity in terms of Global Asias, then, I start from a concern about Indigenous essentialism. The reasons for this concern become clear when we consider something like Taiwan's Formosan Aboriginal Culture Village. Founded by Indigenous peoples from different tribes in Taiwan, it is an amusement park featuring thrill rides and re-creations of famous sites from around the world, as well as a museum to aboriginal culture, re-creations of different aboriginal villages, and tribal scenic areas

(Formosan Aboriginal Cultural Village 2022). In many ways, the village appears to be the manifestation of essentialized Indigenous identities in Taiwan, and the pairing of Indigenous education opportunities with an amusement park only further underscores the capitalist impulses that lead to Indigenous homogenization and consumption. And yet, if Taiwan's Indigenous communities feel this is their best means for survival—of survivance—then perhaps their supporting such venues is better understood as an act of strategic essentialism that achieves a kind of political expediency even if it may not perfectly align with one's identity politics.

Definitions of "Indigeneity" and "Indigenous experience" therefore might be said to come at a cost: they create recognizable molds for individuals to inhabit that are then capable of occupying public space, but they also preclude those same individuals from expressing themselves freely for fear of breaking the mold and becoming unrecognized/unrecognizable. Put differently, Indigeneity is an expedient means as much as a lived experience. One's personal experience could, of course, fit perfectly into the Indigenous mold, but the odds are just as likely (if not more likely, in practice, I would hazard) that this will not be the case. Moreover, although Indigeneity is a recognized discursive category on the international stage, the term's colonial conception still risks enacting a kind of epistemological violence against the very people it is intended to promote by prescribing the terms of their existence. On the whole, I am cautiously optimistic about the confluence of Indigeneity with Global Asias. On the one hand, it has great potential precisely because of the vast network of people it suggests across such a wide geographic span; on the other hand, I am aware of the great risk that promoting the term's use might have in localized contexts, like the one raised in this discussion. My approach to the study of Indigeneity in Global Asias, then, is to be hyper-attentive to the localized knowledge structures, stories, and life experiences of people who both adopt and reject Indigenous identities, in the hope of counteracting the term's colonial prescriptions, elevating alternative modes of self-expression, and generating Asias from the ground up.

Erin Suzuki: What strikes me most about "official" definitions of "Indigeneity" is how very difficult it is for legal language to account for communities that do not fit easily into preexisting racial or national cate-

gories. As Diego, Jenny, and Kyle point out, "Indigenous" continues to operate as a catachrestic term weighted down with some problematic baggage, whether because of its historical emergence in the context of colonial race making (Diego), its continuing deployment as a racialized identity category (Kyle), or its appropriation of local culture into a broader narrative of national exceptionalism (Jenny). To me, the unwieldiness of the term "Indigenous" in global discourse points to some of the limitations of the concept of self-determination within a system based around the policing of borders, bodies, and property in ways that do not necessarily align with the lifeways, histories, and habits of the peoples subjected to it. These limitations have been highlighted through acts of deliberate refusal of certain forms of recognition by the settler state (Simpson 2007; Coulthard 2007) or refusing the category of "Indigenous" altogether (Yeh 2007b; Teaiwa 2010).

This is not to argue that official definitions and recognitions of Indigeneity do not serve a purpose, only that it is a first step or tactical move rather than an end goal. (For example, the very fact that we are writing this entry on Indigeneity as a key term for Global Asias speaks to some of the shifts within academia that have emerged since the UN declaration was adopted in 2007—although the fact that none of us identify as Indigenous similarly shows the limitations of these changes.) As I will discuss further in my contribution (the next section), I am interested in how reflecting on Indigenous methodologies with and alongside Indigenous identities can put critical pressure on questions of sovereignty, self-determination, and the nation-state as a form. Such questions might be of central importance not only to Indigenous-identified people attempting to assert or defend their cultural integrity within a settler state, but also to other peoples who may or may not identify as Indigenous yet continue to navigate material and cultural legacies of colonization.

Indigeneity and/as Method

Erin Suzuki

When I learned that I would be writing on the keyword "Indigeneity" for this volume, my first thought was: "Who, *me?* I'm not the person you want

to be writing this." But as I reflected a little more, I began to realize that what I have to contribute to this book of methods, theories, and tactics is not a summary of the field of Indigeneity *for* Global Asias but rather a reflection on the work of thinking *with* Indigeneity as a non-Indigenous scholar navigating different methodologies, audiences, and disciplinary expectations in my own research. Following Maile Arvin (2015), I understand "Indigeneity" as a term that—much like the terms "race" and "nation"—operates as both a category of identity and an analytic methodology.[2] As the other essays collected in this convergence point out, Indigeneity as an *identity* category has been deployed by a diverse range of communities, states, and multistate organizations to very different political ends. My contribution considers the idea of a global notion of Indigeneity in terms of the ways that different articulations of Indigeneity have opened up a range of methodological frameworks, and how these frameworks have been taken up (or not taken up) in Global Asias scholarship. I continue by thinking through various sites of coalition and contestation between methods for Global Asias and Indigenous studies. How might the study of Indigenous methodologies complement or complicate the idea of "Asia as method" and vice versa? How might scholarship in the field of Global Asias engage with Indigeneity as an analytic that both poses and problematizes the question of what, exactly, it means to be *self-determining?* And what might methodologies emerging from Global Asias have to offer to the field of Indigenous studies in return?

Before I dive into these questions, let me first return to my initial moment of hesitation to say that I come to the term "Indigeneity" with a keen awareness of the mismatch between the kinds of knowledges and experiences this term invokes and my own personal and academic background. I am a fourth-generation Japanese American raised in Hawai'i, where my early life and education were shaped by the class- and race-inflected intimacies and distances between Hawai'i's deeply entangled settler ("local") and Native (Kānaka Maoli) communities. My research, which explores intersections and incommensurabilities between Transpacific Asian American and Native Pacific studies through comparative literary analysis, emerges out of my personal investments in unpacking my own relationships and responsibilities to both communities. Yet while my engagements with Indigeneity come from a genuine desire to critically examine

affects of settler affinity and think through an ethics of settler accountability, my relationship to Indigenous thought necessarily remains mediated by the way I enter into the discourse—both as a settler scholar and as someone whose disciplinary "home" and training lie in Asian American literary studies.

I share my background, along with some of the privileges and limitations that have conditioned my worldview, not out of modesty or defensiveness but rather as an invitation to be open and forthright about the particular conditions that frame the ways that we as scholars think about the relationship between Indigeneity and the emergent field of Global Asias. Scholarship in both Indigenous and Global Asias studies—including work elsewhere in this volume—has addressed how colonial and racial legacies embedded in disciplinary formations and methodologies can encourage us to invisibilize or downplay the complexities of our relationships to our subjects of study in the name of professionalism.[3] Against these tendencies, the work of making visible and remaining accountable to these relationships can operate as a decolonial praxis that helps us to remain attentive to the potential of our scholarship to flatten, erase, or extract knowledge, even in our attempts to work across and forge solidarities between our different fields and commitments.

The incorporation of positionality and self-reflection into a theoretical framework is something that I see clearly modeled in the writing practices of scholars who reflect on Indigeneity as both identity and category of analysis. To give one example, a number of Native Pacific[4] scholars have discussed how localized understandings of genealogy[5] and relationality[6] inform their articulations of identity *and* their critical methodologies/worldview, since these concepts serve as important frameworks that connect individual perspectives while acknowledging the complex ways they remain differently entangled within specific histories, cultures, institutions, and environments. In this context, the position from which one engages in dialogue, approaches a text, or develops a research agenda will have an important bearing on the outcome: the knowledge produced is necessarily entangled with the conditions of its production. Such analytics do not exclude or negate the conceptual distancing and abstraction of academic critique, but they can avoid assuming this style of objective detachment as the only, or the most authoritative, mode of knowledge production.[7]

This shift in emphasis from an abstract yet singular and universalizing "Western" perspective to a more plural, relational approach to environments and communities might be usefully placed in dialogue with relational frameworks emerging out of US critical race studies, inter-Asia studies, and an emergent Global Asias critique. Each of these fields, in their different ways, has sought to call attention to the racial and colonial dynamics of knowledge production, in the process reframing our understandings not only of *who* produces theory, but what "theory" or theorizing looks like. In the context of inter-Asia and Global Asias studies, Kuan-Hsing Chen's theorization of "Asia as method" shifted the focus of Asian studies from knowledge produced *about* Asia in the Western academy to knowledge produced *by* other Asian societies, scholars, and artists, to "provide alternative horizons and practices" for Asian scholarship beyond the disciplinary limitations of area studies. Like Hau'ofa's (1994) and Albert Wendt's (1976) calls to the field of Pacific studies to recontextualize Pacific peoples, histories, and dynamics into the more expansively inclusive and theoretically dynamic frame of "Oceania," Chen notes that his reclamation of "Asia" is not intended to reify a singular or monolithic understanding of who or what that term might define, but instead to index a "pervasive structure of sentiment" that is rooted both in long histories of exchange and interconnection and in contemporary political and economic conditions that have encouraged thinking beyond the frameworks of individual nation-states (Chen 2010, 214).

Indeed, much of the spirit, if not the continental / East Asian focus, of Chen's critique has extended into the fields of Transpacific studies and Global Asias, which have sought to further pluralize and diversify the scope of what a critical "Asian" studies might look like. While Global Asias and global Indigenous studies face similar theoretical and methodological challenges in terms of balancing deep attention to particular localities, histories, and politics alongside needs and desires to assert more broadly global forms of solidarity and interconnectivity, for the most part scholars in Asian and Asian American studies have only recently begun to engage Indigenous studies and vice versa.[8] On the one hand, the long-historical sense of "nonencounter"—to borrow a term from Andrea Mendoza—between these two fields highlights how even scholarship that pushes at the edges of their disciplines continues to be entangled within "disciplinary practices

that rely on naturalized separations [and] perpetual cultural empiricisms [to] obscure the intimate, entangled histories that can animate dialogues between unexpected archives."[9] On the other, scholars must necessarily be cautious about engaging in comparative work across incommensurable fields: as many have noted, comparative frameworks deployed by transnational and global studies can easily fall into the trap of assuming a certain degree of sameness or equivalence between groups with very different levels of access to power. Yet marking these incommensurabilities in power between and within Indigenous studies and Global Asias does not mean that one should not attempt to think these fields together: as Aimee Bahng and I have argued in the context of Transpacific studies (Suzuki and Bahng 2020), and as Danika Medak-Salzman (2015) has argued for Japanese studies, ignoring or refusing to engage extant Native and Indigenous scholarship extends colonial erasures that invisibilize the ongoing agency of these communities. Instead, we can strive to remain accountable to the incommensurabilities of our positionings, even as we may be working to sound out sites of affinity and solidarity.

One of these sites where Global Asias *and* global Indigenous studies might be usefully thought about together emerges around the question of self-determination. While scholarship in Global Asias studies frequently considers the concept of self-determination in terms of the postcolonial nation-state, Indigenous theorists have pointedly questioned what it means to be "self-determining" in spaces where being recognized as a separate state is not necessarily the goal (Corntassel and Primeau 1995). Speaking to conditions of Indigeneity in North America, Glen Coulthard argues that the language of "self-determination"—the right enshrined in the United Nations' 2007 Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples—has in practice led to a problematic politics of recognition that seeks to "'reconcile' Indigenous assertions of nationhood with settler state sovereignty via the accommodation of Indigenous identity claims in some form of renewed legal and political relationship with the Canadian state" (Coulthard 2014, 3). In this reading, processes of recognition and reconciliation do not operate as concessions to Indigeneity so much as they operate as a means through which the state justifies its ongoing exploitation of the land. Pushing back on the way that these discourses of recognition have been used to define and subsume Indigeneity, Audra Simpson (2007) invokes the idea

of "refusal" to mark the limits of the state's ability to set the terms of Indigenous self-determination. This refusal is not the same thing as giving up or ceding land and territorial claim to the settler or colonial state. It is, rather, to demand from the state not only a partial recognition of Indigenous sovereignty but a fully reciprocal relationship whereby the state agrees to abide by the practices of what Coulthard has called "grounded normativity," an ethical framework that, as he and LeAnne Betasamosake Simpson elaborate, "teaches us how to live our lives in relation to other people and nonhuman life forms in a profoundly nonauthoritarian, nondominating, nonexploitative manner. Grounded normativity teaches us to be respectful in diplomatic relationships with other Indigenous and non-Indigenous nations with whom we might share territorial responsibilities or common political or economic interests. Our relationship to the land itself generates the processes, practices, and knowledges that inform our political systems, and through which we *practice solidarity*" (Coulthard and Simpson 2016, 254; italics in original). In other words, an effective form of self-determination emerges not simply from being "recognized" as a sovereign body by one's own or other nation-states, but out of a materially grounded and reciprocal—that is, nonexploitative and nonextractive—relationship with the land on which one lives.

Ironically, in some Asian contexts "Indigeneity" is not considered a relevant term precisely because it has been so closely tied, in a global context, to the politics of recognition that Coulthard, Simpson, and others critique.[10] Across many Asian (and, relatedly, across many Pacific Island) states, post–World War II decolonization has meant that peoples who might have much in common with Indigenous populations in Western settler states do not explicitly identify as Indigenous because of the different ways that the term has been defined or deployed to exclude them. In certain Asian states, for example, Indigenous populations are not politically or demographically minoritized groups, whereas in others, generational histories of movement and diaspora long predating colonization by the West mean that navigating questions of Indigeneity and place can be extremely complex.[11] Such cases bring up the question of how we might approach ideas of Indigeneity as they pertain to, for example, Indigenous peoples in an Indigenous-majority state who remain subordinate to an elite class; Indigenous peoples considered a "minority nationality" or ethnic

subset of a dominant population that considers itself equally "indigenous" or autochthonous; or the cases of historically marginalized, diasporic peoples who have lived for generations in a non-settler colonial context. These are sites where a Global Asias studies, with attention and attunement to frameworks emerging from Indigenous studies, might usefully explore sites and methods for articulating comparative or even what Chadwick Allen (2012) has termed "trans-Indigenous" connections between groups that may hesitate to define themselves as "Indigenous" precisely because of the way that the term has entered into local political and cultural contexts.

In my outline of these varying commitments and orientations to the idea of Indigeneity in Global Asias Studies, I parenthetically mentioned how the complex dynamics around Indigeneity and postcoloniality that circulate across different sites in Asia likewise emerge in the field of Pacific studies. In conclusion, I would like to return to some of the scholarship that has been done in that field as one way to model how to think *with* Indigenous studies in a postcolonial context. Like studies in Global Asias, contemporary Pacific studies emerges from and pushes back against an "area studies" model and has been interested in critically reexamining the methods and assumptions that have shaped knowledge production in the field (Wesley-Smith and Goss 2010). Pacific studies—again like Global Asias studies—does not always find itself in conversation with Indigenous studies, despite sharing many similarities and solidarities (Diaz and Kauanui 2001; Te Punga Somerville 2012, 2018; Mar 2015; Teaiwa 2010, 2014). However, unlike Global Asias studies, Pacific studies often runs the additional risk of becoming absorbed by or naturalized as part of the broader field of Indigenous studies, particularly from the perspective of US-based academia (Hall 2015). Work by Teresia Teaiwa (2010, 2014), Tracy Banivanua Mar (2015), Alice Te Punga Somerville (2012, 2018), and Vicente Diaz and J. Kehaulani Kauanui (2001), among many others, has offered both complementary and critical perspectives on Indigeneity precisely by highlighting important sites of kinship/affinity and practices of solidarity while also using local examples to note some of the limitations of definitions of Indigeneity based on assumptions of settler colonial or minoritarian conditions. I would argue that scholarship in Global Asias has equally important perspectives to offer to global Indigenous studies by outlining the different ways that Asian Indigenous identities

get articulated, appropriated, or refused under the range of diasporic, postcolonial, sub-imperial, and late socialist contexts that shape contemporary Asia and its diasporas.

Indigenous Methods for Global Asias

Kyle Shernuk

As Erin Suzuki highlights in her essay, the question of positionality is central to discussions of both Indigeneity and Global Asias: who are you and what brings you here? As a queer White male scholar of Chinese literature from Kansas, there is much to be accounted for. I grew up on Indigenous land forcibly occupied by White settlers, and my K–12 public education was characterized by the revision if not erasure of Native histories; it was only as an adult that I came to learn more fully about Indigenous concerns and began the long process of trying to redress this shortcoming in my education. Regarding the study of Chinese literature and culture, the importance of positionality returns in analogous if distinct forms. As a cultural outsider interested in issues of nonnormative identity politics, my position must always first account for difference even as it attempts to bring new and comparative insights to Chinese studies. It was, in fact, my study of intersectional queerness in Chinese contexts that first brought me to the study of Indigeneity as an academic discipline. While experiences of queerness and Indigeneity are necessarily products of unique historical contingencies, I find that they possess both practiced and intellectual affinities—histories of oppression, violence, disenfranchisement, and erasure, as well as resistance, revival, and growth—that resonate with one another and provide rich grounds for forging solidarities. It is in this fashion that I also understand the intersection of Indigeneity with Global Asias and view it as an opportunity to discover moments of mutual illumination in the world through comparative, relational, and resonant analyses of both terms.

In this essay, I want to further explore the possibilities and limits for developing Indigenous methodologies that respect Indigenous knowledge and are commensurate with the idea of Global Asias. This proposition is one fraught with potential pitfalls. First among them is the motivation to build a methodology and conduct "research" at all, which are ideas that have

long been identified by Indigenous scholars as "inextricably linked to European imperialism and colonialism" (Smith 1999, 1). We must, therefore, actively decenter colonial knowledge forms before centering Indigenous knowledge if we are to succeed. If we are optimistic about this possibility, then we must also ask how Indigenous methodologies might, in turn, shape how we think about Global Asias. Proposed as "a tactical and evolving approach to the study of Asia and its multiple diasporas" that "actively resists the drive towards 'critical consolidation' [Chen 2017, cited in Chen 2021, 999] that often results from academic paradigm work" (Chen 2021, 999), Global Asias has emerged from the colonial legacies of institutional and disciplinary frameworks even as it attempts to imagine something new. It is the intersection of Global Asias' desire to resist the consolidation sought by diverse disciplinary demesnes combined with the potential of Indigenous methodologies to reshape our approach to knowing the world that I find to be most promising.

My point of entry for thinking through these questions is the island of Taiwan, located just over one hundred miles off the southeastern coast of the People's Republic of China (PRC). The island's complex history provides a rich case study for considering both the possible meanings of Indigeneity and their intersection with Global Asias. Taiwan has been inhabited for as long as eight thousand years by people of Austronesian heritage whose migratory footprint can today be seen as far as Madagascar in the west, Easter Island in the east, New Zealand in the south, and Taiwan in the north. In the 1620s, Taiwan was colonized by the Dutch and Spanish, who were quickly followed by the colonial presence of the Han-ethnic Ming and Manchu-ethnic Qing dynasties from the mid-seventeenth to nineteenth centuries. After losing the First Sino-Japanese War, the Qing dynasty ceded Taiwan to Japan in 1895. Japan administered the island until the end of World War II (also known as the Second Sino-Japanese War) in 1945, when control of Taiwan was returned to the inheritors of the Qing empire, known now as the Republic of China (ROC) and ruled by the Chinese Nationalist Party (KMT). When the KMT was defeated in a civil war with the Communist Party of China (CPC) in 1949, they fled to the island of Taiwan. Taking nearly 2 million of their followers with them, the KMT maintained an authoritarian regime in the name of the ROC until 1987, when the island transitioned to a multiparty democracy; meanwhile, the

CPC founded the PRC and claimed Taiwan as part of its sovereign territory. The issue of Taiwan's international status—either as a province of the PRC or as an independent country still known as the ROC or, more recently, just as Taiwan—continues to be a key flashpoint in global affairs.

The politics of Indigeneity have been differentially reflected across Taiwan's tumultuous history. Serially colonized, arguably postcolonial (for certain populations), and the recipient of multiple waves of migration, Taiwan has seen Indigeneity produced along multiple vectors. The earliest records of Taiwan's first-known inhabitants, the Austronesians, come from sources compiled by other peoples with whom they interacted—the Dutch, the Spanish, the Ming and Qing dynasties, and the Japanese—in which they were described as "uncivilized barbarians," among other titles rife with colonial pretensions (Teng 2004, 1). In more recent history, when control of Taiwan was given to the ROC from Japan in 1945, the ruling KMT party largely inherited earlier colonial attitudes toward the island's Austronesian inhabitants even as the Han-ethnic population celebrated their newfound postcolonial status. Referred to as "mountainous compatriots" (*shandi tongbao* 山地同胞) by the ROC government, Taiwan's Austronesian peoples were relegated to second-class citizenship for the next several decades. It was not until the 1980s that the various Austronesian communities joined together and formed the Alliance of Taiwan Aborigines—notably achieved, in part, through their shared participation in Christian organizations that are themselves part of the island's colonial legacy—and began using the term *yuanzhumin* 原住民 to collectively describe themselves; the term literally means "original inhabitants" and is commonly translated as "aborigines" but is now also frequently rendered as "Indigenous" (Hsieh 1992). While the alliance and other organizations won many victories, the struggle for Indigenous rights in Taiwan remains an ongoing process.

One of the most consequential changes in government treatment of Taiwan's Indigenous peoples occurred on August 1, 2016, when the president of the ROC, Tsai Ing-wen, issued an apology to the ROC's Indigenous inhabitants and acknowledged their serial colonization over the past four hundred years (Office of the President, Republic of China 2016). The apology (figure 2.1) highlighted earlier government achievements, particularly the 1994 revision of the constitution to formally refer to the island's



Figure 2.1. Taiwan Presidential Office, *Apology Ceremony.* Indigenous Peoples' Day (Taipei, Taiwan), August 1, 2016. Digital photograph.

Austronesian inhabitants as "Indigenous people," a change that Tsai reiterated as marking Taiwan's Indigenous inhabitants as the "original owners" of the land. At the same time Tsai also announced the creation of a new Indigenous Historical Justice and Transitional Justice Committee, which was meant to demonstrate the government's commitment to respecting Indigenous rights going forward. The apology came, however, amid ongoing protests over the state's prosecution of Tama Talum, a member of Taiwan's Bunun Indigenous community, for hunting endangered species on government-managed land with an unapproved firearm. The central point of the case, for which a lower court had already sentenced Talum to three and a half years in prison, rested on conflicting ideas about Indigenous sovereignty and the state's right to manage claimed natural resources and Indigenous cultural practices. At that point in time, the court's opinion privileged government ownership of forest lands as natural resources, overriding Indigenous claims of historic land use in the process.[12]

The contrast between these two events highlights a stark divide between espoused political respect for Indigenous populations and practiced respect in legal (and other) terms in Taiwan. Taiwan's Indigenous inhabitants may have been recognized as the "original owners" of the land, but they are not, judging by the court's decision, its "current owners." It is in this change of ostensible ownership that we also discover contemporary Indigeneity's foundational relationship to the island's history of colonial occupation. As the word "original" suggests, Taiwan's Indigenous population was produced as such once they had been dispossessed of the lands and seas previously understood as belonging to them. It is also in this way that capitalist fantasies of colonial "ownership" of the environment and language about "natural resources" become distinctly associated with the colonizer and not necessarily with the Indigenous populations that are the result of such colonial logics. How these now Indigenous groups think about themselves and imagine their relationships to the environment is consequently stifled but certainly not erased.

How we discuss the relationship between humans, nonhuman animals, and the environment becomes one of many opportunities for centering Indigenous knowledge and decentering colonial managerial regimes. The case of Taiwan offers many opportunities to investigate this relationship, with one notable example being the Austronesian Indigenous Tao people. The ancestral homeland of the Tao is Pongso no Tao, which means "Island of People" and is otherwise known as Orchid Island (Lanyu 蘭嶼) in Mandarin Chinese. The island, only seventeen square miles in size, is located approximately fifty miles off the southeast coast of the island of Taiwan and governed by the ROC. The Tao are traditionally a seafaring nation, and many of their cultural practices and linguistic expressions reflect this fact. For instance, the Indigenous calendar has separate names for each night of the lunar month that indicate distinct tidal behaviors, and a man's coming-of-age ritual involves carving one's own boat, known as a *tatala,* and taking it out on the sea alone. The ocean is an active agent in Tao culture, with many gods who live among it or manage it from the skies, and the Tao's relationship with the ocean is one of actively preserved, mutual respect. It is this relationship, between humans, nonhuman animals, and the environment, that offers a way of decentering hegemonic and colonial Han-Taiwanese worldviews.

The Tao writer Syaman Rapongan and his works serve as an instructive example of how this relationship might become an Indigenous methodology that intersects with the idea of Global Asias.[13] Syaman Rapongan chose to be educated in the schools of his Han colonizers as a youth but returned to Orchid Island as a young adult after participating in the Aboriginal rights movement in the 1980s. Having originally refused to learn the traditions of the Tao growing up, he dedicated himself to relearning his culture upon his return to Orchid Island. This moment of return also corresponded with the beginning his writing career, and the result is that his writings serve a wide range of purposes: a space for self-reflection; an ethnographic record of Tao traditions and customs; and a venue to interact with his largely Han-ethnic and colonial readership.

Syaman Rapongan's writings actively center Indigenous knowledge and challenge hegemonic Han cultural practices. The opening paragraphs of his novel *Eyes of the Sky,* for instance, insist on decentering colonial Han information systems. Addressing the reader directly, the narrator remarks that

> the ocean is like a starry sky; a starry sky is like the ocean. And so it has been since the primal chaos of ancient times, when the myriad peoples began to move about the earth and the origins of their myths and legends were lost to time. The ancestors of my people evolved in the watery world for several thousand years, but our evolution isn't something that marine biologists are interested in, which I believe is a good thing. After all, once one's entire existence has been "deciphered" it loses its mystery.
>
> When I was young, my great-grandfather told me a story that had been passed down about the ancestors of the ancestors of the Tao people. A civilized person like you shouldn't bother exhausting your intellect or using scientific reasoning to make sense of the fact that I, the teller of this tale, am a "fish." You also can't spend your life glued to your computer and TV screens, then presume to know everything about the world and calling my story absurd . . . I have heard. (Syaman Rapongan 2012, 2; my translation)

Issuing a challenge to his "civilized" (read: Han-ethnic) readers, the ichthyic narrator proceeds to then deconstruct and critique normative

Han-Taiwanese social practices (such as capitalist-driven overfishing, the environmentally damaging practice of trawling, and the process of making fish floss) using Indigenous knowledge that finds such behaviors unthinkable. In the end, readers cannot but reflect on hegemonic cultural practices and begin imagining the world in an alternative epistemic mode. The scope of this alternative mode even extends to the literary form of the text itself, which repurposes the genre of the novel to include aspects of the Tao oral tradition and reimagines what a "modern" story can look like.

Syaman Rapongan's writings also connect the Tao, Taiwan, and even the Asia Pacific with circuits of global circulation. *Eyes in the Sky* achieves this in several ways. For instance, the Kuroshio Current, which runs north from the Philippines to Taiwan and then on to Japan and the Korean peninsula, is a constant consideration. For the fish-narrator, readers discover that it journeys across the Pacific and back on the Kuroshio and other currents, visiting as far as the Hawaiian and Society Islands archipelagoes before making its way back to Taiwan. For the Tao people in the story, the currents affect boating and fishing practices and explain the Tao's linguistic and cultural connections with people from the Bataan Islands in the northern Philippines. Oblique references to political entanglements with China also demonstrate connections of a different sort between the Tao, Taiwan, and continental Asia, and, at the end of the novel, a Chinese relative by marriage even comes to visit the Tao protagonist from the United Kingdom, where readers learn she has been studying "non-Western religions" at the University of Edinburgh; the dreaded (Han) "researcher" appears again in Indigenous lands. The point to be made here is that Asia has never not been global, and Syaman Rapongan demonstrates this through the various environmental, nonhuman animal, and human trajectories he traces in his work.

Returning to the question of Indigenous methods for Global Asias, I understand Syaman Rapongan's work as one instance of a broader category of Indigenous cultural production, with both the example and type possessing distinct methodological potential. At the level of the individual text, Syaman Rapongan offers new ways of imagining community in Asia; the extent of Asia's globality; and the nature of relationships between humans, nonhuman animals, and the natural world. He does this by insisting on

centering Tao-Indigenous knowledge and its relational vision of existence, which has the potential to transform not only individual behavior but also scholarly inquiry by directing our understandings of both toward points of mutuality and connection rather than distinction and difference. Thinking about Syaman Rapongan's writing as a type of Indigenous cultural production more broadly, each individual's engagement with such objects—literature, film, art, music, and so on—also has the potential to further decenter settler colonial epistemologies. An individual's collective reading of Indigenous cultural products can become its own kind of method, one that insists on the centrality of Indigenous perspectives and activates the latent potential for intellectual and political solidarities inherent to the study of Global Asias (and beyond). I suggest, too, that this purposeful centering of Indigenous knowledge has the potential to generate the kind of dialectical tension necessary to dislodge established categories of knowledge and help us arrive at an understanding of Global Asias that we are perhaps yet to imagine.

Locating Indigeneity in the Graveyard of Empires

Diego Javier Luis

For historians of the early modern Hispanic world, the notion that Asians, Pacific Islanders, and Native peoples of the Americas can all be "Indigenous" is uncontroversial; it is a matter of historical record and unravels another thread to Shernuk's statement that "Asia has never not been global." The first Spanish word for Indigenous peoples, "indio" (Indian), applied equally to Nahuas of Central Mexico and to Tagalogs of the Philippines (van Deusen 2015, 10–12; Horodowich and Nagel 2023). They and other Indigenous peoples occupied the same legal subject position within colonial hierarchies despite the considerable and obvious differences between them as distinct ethnolinguistic groups. Thus, the global nature of Indigeneity is itself a product of the global reach of early modern empires, and as such, the concept of Indigeneity remains rooted in the history and legacy of the peoples Europeans once called "indios." Even today, Indigeneity prominently signifies a relationship to a colonial category (its

continuity or absence), even as new nation-states have struggled to distinguish themselves from the colonial systems from which they emerged.

The word "indio" (and its derivatives) was a racial and legal invention that differentiated a land's autochthonous inhabitants from its European counterparts. Thus, the racial formation that enabled colonial violence against "indios" in the Americas directly impacted Asians and Pacific Islanders when foreign sails appeared on their horizons. The word's fraught colonial origins reveal that what Indigeneity means, to whom it applies, and how it has changed over time is often taken for granted, as Chio elegantly demonstrates in her contribution to this forum. Given the pernicious nature of the "indio" category, it is worth questioning if its analogous terms today are at all recoverable from their tainted genealogies within the colonial lexicon.

As distant as early modern Spanish terminology may initially seem to the project of Global Asias, these distortions, in fact, continue to impact identity and culture in postcolonial states like the Philippines. There, the task of creating a national identity in discourse and in law has often relied upon disentangling what is Indigenous from a post-contact, Hispanic, or US imposition. The central problem with confirming what is "authentically" of the Philippines, though, is that the archival records attesting to the languages, spiritual beliefs, and customs of pre-Hispanic populations are themselves documents of the colonial regime. They filter and distort content according to the biases of witnesses, the hearsay of outsiders, the ideologies of the writer(s), and the formalism of colonial textual genres. As Vicente Rafael notes, the twin discourses of Christianization and Hispanicization structured early writings on precontact histories and cultures. He continues:

> One cannot write about Tagalog local history without taking into account the presence of alien colonizers who recorded and so lent documentary density to the reality of "Tagalog" as a distinct ethnolinguistic group among numerous others in the archipelago. People who spoke Tagalog certainly existed before the Spaniards took note of them; yet our ability to speak of them as a group qualitatively distinct from other groups is directly dependent on their having been previously objectified—through the translation of their language, the descriptions of their customs and

> politics, and the recording of their responses to colonial authority—in Spanish accounts. (Rafael 1988, 16)

This fundamental problem of translating language and defining ethnicity has produced many misunderstandings about what is considered Indigenous or foreign to the Philippines. Even the act of searching for an Indigenous legacy often presupposes that there is a pure, unalienable Indigenous culture that can somehow be recovered unaltered from the archival rot of the overseas Spanish textual record. In truth, the contested nature of colonialism shaped what Indigeneity became.

There is, perhaps, no greater example of this issue than the barangay, a colonial construct that was and remains the smallest unit of socio-familial organization in the archipelago. It is a fixture of local identification and neighborhood pride. During the colonial period, the barangay was a collection of several dozen families with a chieftain (called the *cabeza de barangay*) who, beyond being the designated go-between with Spanish authorities, was responsible for tribute collection and corvée labor mustering (Scott 1994, 5; Phelan 1959, 122–123). In 1973, the Ferdinand Marcos regime established the postcolonial barangay as "the smallest political subdivision or unit of the government" based on the assumption—clarified in a presidential decree from the following year—that the barangay "was the basic political unit existing in the Philippines before the arrival of the Spaniards" (Woods 2017, 118).

This understanding of the barangay, however, originates not from a precontact source but from the ethnographic writing of one Franciscan missionary named Juan de Plasencia in 1589. Plasencia's observations were enormously influential and became a foundation of colonial law and custom in the Philippines. Plasencia wrote that the barangay was an ancient reference to the family clusters of Malay origin that had migrated together to the archipelago and that continued to live as communities in close proximity after landfall. Other Spanish ethnographers from the period, though, both disagreed and agreed with Plasencia's interpretation in equal measure. Crucially, Indigenous writing inscribed in baybayin script does not support the claim that the barangay was a ubiquitous, pre-Hispanic form of social or political organization. In the words of Damon Woods,

"the barangay is a myth," a convenient invention that facilitated the reduction of local communities to Hispanic settlements, taxation, labor exploitation, surveillance, and conversion (Woods 2017, 119).

This conundrum reveals that in searching for what is "authentically" Indigenous, Indigeneity itself becomes a temporal category—estranged from the modern world—that must be assimilated and grafted onto the postcolonial state to ground its national imaginary as distinct from and older than its colonial legacy (Herman 2018, 16). However, as Florina Capistrano-Baker writes, "the primary concern should no longer be the quest for that elusive 'essence' of what is 'authentically Filipino' but, rather, dissecting the dynamics of global entanglements that gave birth to the Philippine present—dynamics that, I suspect, reverberate across geographies to other diasporic, transnational cultures" (Capistrano-Baker 2015, 255). Thus, deromanticizing Indigeneity begins to deconstruct the old temporal models of "precontact," "colonial," and "modern" that have historically determined what Indigeneity can look like, sound like, feel like.

Should the barangay be discarded because of Plasencia's mediation and possible inaccuracy, even though it holds enormous importance for Filipinos today? The question is not mine to answer, but its posing signals that the study of Indigeneity in a Global Asias context must remain attentive to how the colonial archive continues to shape the reception and interpretation of Indigeneity in the present. It must commit to the seemingly paradoxical task of resisting essentializing imaginaries of Indigenous cultures and peoples, while acknowledging the enduring influence of those same imaginaries to numerous ethnolinguistic and national communities today.

As much as Indigeneity can reorient analysis away from hegemonic centers and toward under-studied issues and communities, the term can also exclude, again as a function of its colonial genealogy. We have a clear example in the Aeta and Ati Austronesian peoples of the Philippines, whom Europeans associated more closely with Blackness than with Indigeneity. The Jesuit Francisco Colín wrote in 1663 that "they are called Negrillos in Spanish because many of them are as [Black] . . . and their hair as curly as Negros [Blacks]." Even though Colín suggested that "these Negros were the original inhabitants of these islands," he hypothesized from their appearance that they were descended from Ethiopians (Colín 1663, 18). Thus, despite their status as "original inhabitants," they could

not be Indigenous in the same way that Tagalog, Visayan, and Kapampangan peoples were because of their dark skin. A priest named Pedro Cubero Sebastián would later confirm this distinction in 1682 when he wrote that the pejoratively termed "Negrillos" "are Gentiles, and they wander about the mountains, the forests, capturing and killing the natives" (Cubero Sebastián 1682, 313). Therefore, Blackness combined with non-Catholic religious belief and violent acts could separate "Negrillos" from "natives," despite the fact that the Aeta/Ati had lived in the Philippines with other Indigenous groups for centuries prior to Spanish arrival.[14] Today, numerous Aeta/Ati groups remain largely isolated from the national economy, services, and imaginaries. They are instantly recognized as different from Tagalogs, Kapampangans, Visayans, and other groups because of their skin color, hair, languages, clothing, and customs. Therefore, an inclusive approach to Indigeneity must still acknowledge that Indigenous groups themselves occupy dissimilar hierarchies of power relative to the state based on historical legacies, access to resources, and contemporary discrimination.

Invoking Indigeneity in this Global Asias context therefore invites reflection on the concept's constructed and, at times, limiting nature so as to not enshrine its inscribed coloniality in contemporary scholarship. For its widespread political, social, and cultural importance, Indigeneity in Asia and the Pacific cannot be ignored, nor should it be. Though the vestiges of colonial essentialisms frequently pervade modern usage, the case of the Philippines encourages us to constantly clarify the term's contemporary significance, the historical contingencies of its deployment, and how it participates in or unravels the racialization of non-European peoples.

The colonial baggage embedded in early Spanish conceptions of Indigeneity, as a mode of differentiating groups politically, racially, and culturally, remains a lingering shadow, from the soul-searching of postcolonial states to the self-fashioning of its peoples. It may be easy to simply condemn colonial legacies wherever they appear, but doing so would be to cling to a romanticized idea of colonialism and Indigeneity as diametrically opposed and not, in fact, deeply entangled and constitutive of the postcolonial realities of Global Asias.

Indigenous, Everyone?

Jenny Chio

> *Beijing's official stance is that all ethnic groups in China, including the majority Han, are indigenous; hence, the term does not apply.*
>
> —Michael Hathaway (2010, 302)

What is global about Indigeneity? And how does Indigeneity help us to think about Global Asias? These two final questions are intended to connect and broaden the previous discussions of Indigeneity across Asian and Pacific contexts. They emerge from the confluence of my scholarly commitments as a cultural anthropologist who investigates ethnic politics and minority conditions in the People's Republic of China as well as my personal experiences living as a privileged minority, socially and economically, in the United States (Taiwanese-Chinese-Asian, in ascending order to global reference) and working in/with ethnic Miao, Zhuang, Baiku Yao, and Tibetan minority communities in China as a member of privileged, sociopolitically and economically, majority communities (Han-Taiwanese-American, in ascending order). I am often asked if the minority communities I work in and with are "Indigenous" (and, frequently, if I am a member of said community), a question to which I have given only long, complicated, and unsatisfactory answers. Thus, my contribution to this research forum is generated in the spirit of not necessarily trying to untangle the knot that is Indigeneity in China but rather to acknowledge the complex patterns it presents and the possible new ways of connecting, binding, and holding together that this knot might engender.

The first question is, perhaps, the easier one to answer because the terms themselves—"global," "Indigeneity"—are historically as well as conceptually linked, as the essays preceding this one clearly demonstrate. Moreover, the emergence of an international "Indigenous" category or Indigenous internationalism, as Francesca Merlan detailed, emerged from the post–World War I internationalist movement through which "some of today's 'indigenous peoples' became visible as disadvantaged minorities in

various problem frameworks" (Merlan 2009, 307). In many ways, therefore, the 2007 UN Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples was an effort to concretize such long-standing "problem frameworks" by "hypostatizing" Indigenous peoples and Indigeneity as "a freestanding characteristic of a certain 'kind' of people," Merlan argued (2009, 319). To turn the question around by asking what is global about Indigeneity rather than how Indigeneity is global admittedly runs the risk of treating Indigeneity as a static or essential characteristic, as a *classification*. But it is also, as I discuss here, an invitation to take seriously the various, diverging, and often contradictory ways in which "Indigeneity" and "Indigenous" are invoked in global politics and globally significant political problems.

The second question—how Indigeneity can help us think about Global Asias—extends from the somewhat illogical supposition suggested in the epigraph from Michael Hathaway's 2010 article on the emergence of Indigenous discourse in China in the early years of the twenty-first century. By embracing Indigenous identity as applicable to all people within the political nation, the Chinese state effectively nullifies any potential "problem frameworks" articulated by Indigenous internationalism, at least in the context of the People's Republic of China. What can we make of this simultaneous embrace of the term "Indigenous" and its dismissal of the concept's relevance for the contemporary PRC? If all ethnic groups are considered Indigenous irrespective of minoritarian or majoritarian status, then the term itself and, by extension, the problems and forms of political recognition raised by Indigenous internationalism are rendered void. What makes this position from China possible? How can the concept of Indigeneity be used in such radically opposing ways: to demarcate different kinds of presumably recognizable characteristics as well as to describe everyone in a particular country? What can we learn about globality and Indigeneity from the PRC's position on it?

A twist emerges: despite Beijing's demurral of the applicability of Indigeneity within China, the Chinese state has nonetheless leveraged the concept of indigenous as a valuable and worthy characteristic and, perhaps coincidentally, they started doing so at around the same time they signed onto the 2007 UN Declaration.[15] In 2006, China announced a national strategy for "indigenous innovation" (which is the official English translation; in Chinese, it is *zizhu chuangxin* 自主创新), which was laid out in the

2006–2020 Medium- and Long-Term National Science and Technology Development Plan. As described in a policy brief, "China's new indigenous innovation strategy [introduced in 2006] . . . is attempting to use indigenous innovation to balance the domestic-market demand against the export-market demand; the development of domestic innovation capability is now being prioritized over the acquisition of foreign technology" (Liu and Cheng 2011, 18). On the surface, "indigenous innovation" has little, in fact nothing, to do with Indigeneity except in the most basic and fundamental meaning of the word as a "first-order connection between a group and a locality" (Merlan 2009, 304). But it is precisely this apparent lack of relevance between indigenous innovation and Indigenous peoples that I wish to draw attention to. China's promotion of indigenous innovation underscores a contemporary global moment when the idea of Indigeneity, or better put the quality of being Indigenous, is hyper-salient. Moreover, it is arguably most potent within domestic contexts because of its internationalist aura. Therefore, the invocation of "indigenous" to describe innovation and what is ultimately a political strategy to promote Chinese technologies prompts an examination of how discourses of Indigeneity are reinterpreted in order to rationalize, legitimize, and make globally legible particular sets of ideological positions that assert very specific local political claims.

In what remains, I raise a few examples of Indigeneity at work, or not, in China, with particular attention to the term's invocation in Hong Kong (a special administrative region of the PRC). These iterations of Indigeneity further illuminate how the concept has been utilized, rejected, sidelined, and, following Hathaway, "smuggled" (Hathaway 2016); what these instances tell us about minority and ethnic politics within China and its administrative regions; and what they might tell us about the global significance of Indigeneity. The term's more conventional usage, as Hathaway's work on environmentalism (itself a network of global movements) in Southwest China has detailed, was largely the result of non-Chinese actors who were working for transnational environmental groups and development agencies and who applied, sometimes deliberately but sometimes without much critical reflection, the term to communities that the Chinese state officially recognizes as "ethnic minorities" (*shaoshu minzu* 少数民族, also translated as "minority nationalities"; Bulag 2019). The blanket application of Indigenous to ethnic minorities in China has not been uniformly

welcome; as regards Tibetans, Hathaway writes, "One of the ironies of Tibetans is that, while they are the most likely candidate in all of China for inclusion within the global community of indigenous peoples, they have by and large eschewed this aspiration. . . . Tibetan activists [in the diaspora] suggest that they are striving for more than what indigeneity would achieve" (Hathaway 2016, 12–13; see also Yeh 2007b).

More recently, many scholars writing about the catastrophic cultural oppression and incarceration of Uyghurs, Kazakhs, and other Turkic Muslims in the Xinjiang Uyghur Autonomous Region increasingly refer to various ethnic minority groups in Xinjiang as Indigenous. In so doing, these researchers not only assert the global Indigenous rights and claims of communities deemed "minority" by the Chinese state (Salimjan 2020, 2021) but also pointedly situate the Chinese state and Han Chinese communities in Xinjiang within the analytical frameworks of settler colonialism and capitalist dispossession, thereby aligning the current situation in Xinjiang with other literatures on Indigenous political disenfranchisement and cultural survival (Byler 2021). In writing on the loss of livelihood and land by Kazakh pastoralists in northwest Xinjiang, Kazakh scholar Guldana Salimjan argues that "the Belt and Road initiative as a 'zoning technology' (Ong 2006) connecting Xinjiang and Central Asia also constitutes a spatial and epistemic violence that normalizes the eradication of Indigenous existence on that land" (Salimjan 2020, 138). Salimjan's use of the term "Indigenous" without hesitation and without need to justify it in spite of Beijing's official stance, which dismisses the necessity of the term, is a political act of defiance and an insistence that we, the readers, see and think beyond the rhetoric of the state.

The invocation of Indigenous is thus always tied, in some way, to international considerations, whether because it does not do quite enough, such as for diasporic Tibetan activists who may wish for *more than* recognition as Indigenous, or because it can do quite a lot, such as in terms of reorienting the analysis of Xinjiang away from a Beijing-centric perspective on the region and its peoples. Both of these acts are directed, to some (large) degree, toward an imagined global community for whom the terms "Indigenous" and "Indigeneity" signify certain "problem frameworks" that warrant international attention. The qualities of these concepts—the immediacy, the presumed relevance, and the potential to quickly enable global

solidarity—are also, I believe, at the heart of the next, and final, examples of Indigeneity at work in perhaps one of the most global places in Asia: Hong Kong.

Two instances from Hong Kong serve as productive, if troubling, interruptions to commonplace assumptions about Indigenous identity and, by extension, Indigenous politics. Selina Ching Chan, in her article on Indigenous identity in Hong Kong, lays out the history of "indigenous inhabitants" in Hong Kong and its complicated subjective implications, especially for present-day Hong Kong residents (Chan 1998). As Chan writes, "The term 'indigenous inhabitants' does not denote an objective category. First, the indigenous inhabitants are descendants of villagers who were living in the New Territories before 1898 [when the New Territories were leased by China to Britain for ninety-nine years]. This year is in fact a political construct for the identification of the 'earlier settlers' (the indigenous inhabitants) as distinct from British and later immigrants" (Chan 1998, 41). In this instance, "Indigenous" is still used to describe a "first order connection" between locality and a group, although it is deployed to distinguish a community who happened to find themselves on land leased by one government (the Qing) to another (the British Empire) from British colonial settlers and then, later, from the waves of Chinese immigrants who settled in Hong Kong from other regions of China. In many ways, being Indigenous in the Hong Kong case therefore echoes many of the presumed characteristics of Indigeneity elsewhere: a tie to land and resources and physical presence over time. But, as Chan explains, during the British colonial regime in Hong Kong until the "handover" in 1997, Indigenous identity shifted from being defined primarily in terms of ethnic difference from colonial culture to becoming a term to describe communities in Hong Kong who aligned themselves culturally and politically with mainland PRC in the years leading up to 1997 (Chan 1998, 39–40).

In this context, it is ironic that one of the most radical pro-democracy "nativist" political parties to be formed in the aftermath of the 2014 Umbrella Movement protests in Hong Kong, during which major streets in the financial and political center of the territory were occupied by protesters demanding greater autonomy from Beijing, named itself Hong Kong Indigenous in English (in Cantonese, it is *buntou manzyu cinsin* 本土民主前線).[16] The first term in the name, 本土, is commonly translated

into English as "native" and carries a strong sense of place and locality, as in one's "native place," more so than an ethno-cultural identity; in this regard, the choice to write the party name in English as Hong Kong Indigenous is illuminating. In an essay about Edward Leung, one of the most prominent pro-democracy activists in Hong Kong in the 2010s and member of Hong Kong Indigenous, a journalist describes how the party was formed out of a disillusionment with the Umbrella Movement and its apparent lack of effects or real transformation. "When the protests ended, [activist Ray Wong] founded Hong Kong Indigenous, a party championing 'self-defense, more radical means of protest, and . . . our unique identity as Hong Kongers,' he [Leung] told me [the journalist]. . . . The beliefs of some of these [localist] groups have at times veered into the xenophobic, with members demeaning mainland visitors as locusts invading Hong Kong" (McLaughlin 2019). From marking ethnic Chinese inhabitants in contrast to British colonial residents, to indicating a Chinese-ness in Hong Kong more aligned with PRC, mainland Chinese identity, to becoming a name for a radicalized pro-democracy and anti-Beijing political party, what is, and is not, "Indigenous" in Hong Kong thus elides a simple or straightforward set of common characteristics, let alone shared political priorities or problems.

How, then, does Indigeneity, across these usages in the PRC political sphere, help us understand Global Asias? First, the contrasts and contradictions in rhetoric and discourse reaffirm the uncontroversial point that we cannot assume that "Indigenous" and "Indigeneity" necessarily refer to the same (or even merely similar) sets of political ideologies and principles everywhere. It is critical to examine both the assumed politics of Indigeneity (which are often employed to promote or build global solidarities) and the politicization of "Indigenous," or the way in which the term is deployed in specific circumstances for often diverging political ends. And second, the examination and exploration of when, where, how, and why "Indigeneity" and "Indigenous" are evoked in the PRC and its territories can illuminate the contests between local struggles and global orders. These are the moments not only when "Asia" is globalized, but also when global conditions are forced to adapt and respond to diverse Asian contexts.

Conclusion

As this research forum elucidates, not only is Indigeneity a global category, but it also takes on distinct characteristics in Asian geographies. From its social constructedness in the colonial Spanish and Hong Kong contexts to its recalibrations of land and community for LeAnne Betasamosake Simpson and Syaman Rapongan, studying Indigeneity through a Global Asias framework opens up a new field of inquiry. As Shernuk writes in his reflection, doing so starts "from a concern about Indigenous essentialism," which immediately sets the Global Asias commitment apart from the UN language that began this convergence. While our four provocations elaborate different approaches to this issue, by necessity they are but a metonym for a broader field. They also reveal the current fissures and gaps in scholarship for future research that might probe the connections across Asian contexts—from the Pacific to the Indian Ocean, or from Northeast Asia to the South Asian subcontinent. In the pedagogical forum that follows, we invite you to make your own determinations about Indigeneity in Global Asias and to explore the sources that have grounded and informed our writing on the subject.

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Pedagogy Forum

As the research forum demonstrates, there are multiple points of entry and perspectives on what can and does constitute Indigeneity, and Indigenous identity, within and beyond a Global Asias context. This pedagogical intervention begins with four open-ended questions to guide the exploration of Indigeneity in the context of Global Asias, followed by a series of keywords that serve as sites where different experiences of Indigeneity might be productively juxtaposed or placed into relation. Each keyword entry contains an annotated selection of primary source materials (texts, speeches, films, poems, visual collections, etc.) that provide opportunities for close reading, case study analysis, and/or comparative investigations. This list should by no means be taken as definitive or exhaustive; rather, the texts included have been chosen from our respective fields of study to emphasize the cross-cultural and cross-disciplinary resonances and relationships between these different approaches to Indigeneity. When relevant, we also point to contributions in this volume by scholars working in South Asian contexts. Our hope is that, considered together, this collection of keywords and primary sources will motivate future investigations into when, where, and how Indigeneity has shaped lived experiences and cultural productions in Global Asias.

We have loosely organized the primary sources according to their salient themes, including colonialism, nation and empire, race and ethnicity, methodologies, environmental stewardship, and mobilities. Broadly speaking, the first three terms engage with the historical and intellectual foundations of Indigeneity by exploring how the idea was imagined, produced, enforced, and differentiated in a wide range of contexts across Asia. The latter three terms, by contrast, relate more closely to expressions of Indigeneity by individuals from those communities and showcase some of the core concerns occupying debates about Indigenous identity and expression. The suggested divisions are meant to serve as a guiding framework for navigating your first encounter with a source but should not be taken as rigidly prescribing an entry's potential. In many cases, questions about one theme may lead you to questions about another, and we encourage you to explore how all the entries may expand our thinking about each thematic grouping.

Throughout these questions, keywords, and annotations, we adhere to the consensus conventions in scholarly and journalistic writing to capitalize "Indigenous" and "Indigeneity" to indicate specific political and cultural identities and lived experiences and as a sign of respect for and recognition of these individuals and communities.[17]

Guiding Questions for Indigeneity and Global Asias

- How do you situate yourself and your research vis-à-vis Indigeneity?
- Beyond the UN's definitions of Indigenous peoples as those who have "suffered from historic injustices," most notably including dispossession of their lands, what are some other, perhaps more tangible, ways of articulating Indigenous identity? When do definitions of identity generated from *within* communities overlap with those generated by the state, and when do they differ?
- What are some of the political, cultural, historical, and theoretical connections across Indigenous groups in Asia and encountered in Asian diasporas?
- Is it useful to reorient and/or center the concept of Indigeneity in Asian conditions that are, in certain aspects, similar to experiences of Indigeneity as it has been theorized in Anglo-American settler colonial contexts? What might be gained, and what remains overlooked, by doing so?

Keyword: Colonialism

Histories and experiences of colonialism, both direct and indirect, political and cultural, shaped the emergence and social construction of Indigeneity over time. As such, the histories of Indigenous peoples remain deeply tied to both colonial and postcolonial lived realities, environments, and politics. Studying colonial initiatives and Indigenous responses and adaptations is thus among the most fruitful approaches for acquiring a foundational understanding of Indigeneity in a historical context that roots it as a category that long predates its modern incarnations. It also reveals the encounters and conflicts that placed Indigenous groups in competition and drew others into closer collaboration.

Berry, Michael, ed. 2022. ***The Musha Incident: A Reader on the Indigenous Uprising in Colonial Taiwan*****. New York: Columbia University Press.** The Musha Incident of 1930 is one of the most famous "Indigenous uprisings" in Taiwan, if not East Asian, history. In addition to being perhaps the most studied of such incidents, it is also among the most controversial given the wide range of diverging explanations that have risen around it. During a field day being held by Taiwan's Japanese colonizers, six Indigenous tribes banded together and attacked and killed 134 Japanese. Nearly a century later, the event is interpreted to be many things: a sign of Indigenous "barbarity" to the Japanese at the time; an anti-colonial act of Indigenous solidarity with the Han Chinese in Taiwan; and even a kind of "authentic" Taiwan culture that makes the island distinct from the People's Republic of China. The reader offers translations of primary sources and critical introductions to this complicated topic that make it accessible without oversimplifying this complex event.

Blair, Emma Helen, and James Alexander Robertson, eds. and trans. 1903–1909. ***The Philippine Islands, 1493–1803,*** **vols. 1–55. Cleveland, OH: Arthur H. Clark.** This monumental fifty-five-volume translated series of primary sources covers the entire period of Spanish contact and rule in the Philippines. The project emerged from a renewed US interest in the islands after their purchase and acquisition from Spain in 1898. Upon publication, it offered unprecedented access to what have become the canonical sources of colonial history and cemented the history of the Philippines as a viable field of study across the Anglophone world.

Deal, David, and Laura Hostetler, trans. 2006. ***The Art of Ethnography: A Chinese "Miao" Album*****. Seattle: University of Washington Press.** "Miao albums" originated during the eighteenth century in China and featured prose, poetry, and illustrations of minority ethnic groups living in the frontier regions of the Chinese empire. This fully illustrated translation of a Miao album depicts groups from present-day Guizhou Province; in this context, "Miao" was used to refer both to groups who referred to themselves as such as well as other minority peoples in China's southwest. The albums, with their hand-drawn illustrations and handwritten texts, are now considered valuable art objects and significant documents of proto-ethnographic

encounters between imperial Chinese representatives and the vast diversity of communities who lived in the mountainous frontier regions of the empire.

Gardiner-Garden, John. 2003. "Defining Aboriginality in Australia." Current Issues Brief No. 10 2002–03. Information and Research Services: Department of the Parliamentary Library. Canberra, Australia. Accessed September 12, 2023. https://parlinfo.aph.gov.au/parlInfo/download/library/prspub/EBG86/upload_binary/ebg865.pdf;fileType=application/pdf. This policy brief provides an example of a concerted attempt by a settler colonial state to define, within its borders, the terms of Indigenous identity for the nation. In addition to discussing the specific histories of Aboriginal identity and classification in Australia, the brief can serve as a useful example of the importance of political definitions but also the contentious nature of attempting to formally define and delimit Indigeneity.

Lee, Christina, and Ricardo Padrón, eds. 2020. *The Spanish Pacific, 1521–1815: A Reader of Primary Sources*. Amsterdam: Amsterdam University Press. This new volume of translated primary sources has already revolutionized the teaching of the "Spanish Pacific," an early modern contact zone between Spanish colonies in the Philippines and in Mexico. As part of a continuing series, the volume and its subsequent iterations include introductory essays and never-before-seen documents that problematize many of the prevailing meta-narratives about early Transpacific histories and the nature of early modern empire.

Wei, Te-sheng, dir. 2012. *Warriors of the Rainbow: Seediq Bale*. Taipei, Taiwan: Vie Vision Pictures. DVD. *Warriors of the Rainbow* presents a cinematic reimagining of the Musha Incident that reflects contemporary social and political ideas about Indigenous people in Taiwan. Released first in two parts and running a total of just over four and a half hours, then released internationally in a consolidated two-and-a-half-hour edition, the film sparked heated debates in Taiwan and elsewhere. Noted for its intense depictions of violence, the centrality of Indigenous and particularly Seediq culture, and nationalist interpretations of history, it raises important ques-

tions about the relationship(s) between Indigenous and settler colonial culture both historically and today.

Keywords: Nation and Empire

Perhaps the single most important "characteristic" shared by all Indigenous groups around the world is a history of colonialism and/or domination by an outside authority, whether an empire or a nation-state. In consequence, the question of the nation looms large over all Indigenous communities and the states in which they now find themselves. How and should Indigenous communities be considered a part of a nation-state? Are they included or excluded in discourses of nationalism and national identity? What implications does this have on Indigenous sovereignty, authority, and cultural survival? How colonial, settler colonial, and postcolonial states have addressed and managed Indigenous issues within their political territories, including issuing "apologies" to Indigenous peoples, remains a central topic for research and analysis in understanding Indigeneity in Global Asias contexts. The texts that follow outline various ways that national and international documents have sought to accommodate and/or incorporate Indigeneity in the nation-state.

Chinese Historical Ethnographic Film Series. 1957–1966. Göttingen, Germany. Digital video/DVD (English versions produced by Institut für Wissen und Medien Göttingen in 1998). As part of the People's Republic of China's ethnic classification project, which began in the 1950s and concluded officially in the early 1980s, teams of documentary filmmakers were sent to record and produce documentary films about the diverse ethnic minority groups living within the nation's political borders. The films were written and edited to reinforce dominant Marxist ideologies about stages of economic production and the inevitability of socialism, thus justifying the Chinese Communist Party's authority and rule in the recently established nation-state. Each film focuses on a single ethnic group, such as Oroqen, Kucong, and Uyghurs. In the 1990s, eleven films were translated into English from the original Chinese voice-over and made available internationally. Libraries that hold copies of these films include the

University of California, Berkeley, Columbia University, Cornell University, Whitman College, Chinese University of Hong Kong, the German National Library of Science and Technology (Hanover), and Médiathèque du Musée du Quai Branly (Paris).

Elliott, Mark. 2015. "The Case of the Missing Indigene: Debate over a 'Second Generation' Ethnic Policy." ***China Journal*** **73:186–213.** Ethnic and Indigenous politics in the People's Republic of China (PRC) is an important and sensitive topic, to which Elliott's article provides an excellent introduction. Originally modeled on Soviet ideas of "nation," the PRC recognized (and sometimes invented) a total of fifty-six distinct ethnic groups within its borders. With a majority Han population, the remaining fifty-five groups were marked as "ethnic minorities" and accorded special rights and representations. This policy of accommodation, however, did not last, and a new policy of assimilation was later proposed. This new proposal serves as the foundation for much of the decision-making surrounding ethnic issues today in the PRC. Where ideas of Indigeneity fit into these discussions (or not) is Elliott's point of intervention, and he describes how and why this discourse is yet to be adopted in the PRC, as well as how it might be useful.

Moseley, George, ed. 1966. ***The Party and the National Question in China.*** **Cambridge, MA: MIT Press.** This is an English-language translation of an early political document from the People's Republic of China titled "A Discussion of the National Question in the Chinese Revolution and of the Actual Nationalities Policy (Draft)," written by Chang Chih-I, then a deputy director of the United Front Work Department of the Chinese Communist Party (CCP). It discusses the ideological relationship between the CCP's Marxist-Leninist thought and the empirical realities of the social, cultural, and religious diversity of peoples living within the territories claimed by the PRC. The book lays out some of the fundamental arguments behind China's approach to "national minority affairs" in the early years of the country, as the CCP attempted to both justify and reinforce its authority, while promoting a new Chinese national identity based on principles of communism.

National Apologies and Formal "Redress." The four sources in the list that follows are examples of apology statements issued by the governments of

the United States, Aotearoa / New Zealand, Australia, and Taiwan to Indigenous populations within their respective political territories. They are grouped together here in order to provide both a semi-comprehensive and a comparative perspective on the rhetorical and affective implications of "apologies" as a political tool for addressing histories of violence against, subjugation of, and oppression of Indigenous communities.

- US Congress. 1993. 100th Anniversary of the Overthrow of the Hawaiian Kingdom. Public Law 103-150. 103d Cong., 1st sess., 107 Stat 1510. S.J. Res. 19, November 23.
- "The Crown's Apology [to the Ngāi Tahu]." November 29, 1998. Te Rūnanga o Ngai Tāhu. Accessed September 11, 2023. https://ngaitahu.iwi.nz/ngai-tahu/the-settlement/settlement-offer/the-crowns-apology/.
- "Apology to Australia's Indigenous Peoples." February 13, 2008. Accessed September 12, 2023. https://www.indigenous.gov.au/reconciliation/apology-australias-indigenous-peoples.
- Office of the President of the Republic of China (Taiwan). August 1, 2016. "President Tsai Apologizes to Indigenous Peoples on Behalf of Government." Accessed September 12, 2023. https://english.president.gov.tw/NEWS/4950.

Rizal, José. 1887. *Noli me tángere*. Berlin: Berliner Buchdruckrei-Action-Gesselschaft. Widely regarded as the single most important Philippine text, José Rizal's classic novel, published in 1887, offers a Filipino rebuke of Spanish colonial practice and has become foundational to the formation of a Philippine national identity. Although Rizal was not an explicit advocate for independence, his work had a fundamental role in inspiring revolutionary movements against colonial rule. Rizal's call for reform ultimately led to his capture and execution in 1896.

Treaty of Waitangi/Te Tiriti o Waitangi. February 6, 1840. "Read the Treaty." Ministry for Culture and Heritage. Updated June 12, 2023. https://nzhistory.govt.nz/politics/treaty/read-the-treaty/english-text. Considered the founding document of modern Aotearoa / New Zealand, the treaty was originally intended to allot to the British the power of "governance"

(*kawanatanga*) while preserving for Māori signatories the rights to "chieftainship" (*rangatiratanga*). While the English text of the treaty interpreted "governance" as "sovereignty," the translation's blurring of the meaning between the British concept of "sovereignty" and Māori concepts of *rangatiratanga* continues in ongoing debates and litigation around questions of sovereignty, landownership, and land occupation.

UN Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples. September 13, 2007. "61/295 United Nations Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples." Accessed September 13, 2023. https://www.un.org/development/desa/Indigenouspeoples/wp-content/uploads/sites/19/2018/11/UNDRIP_E_web.pdf. Adopted by the UN General Assembly in 2007, this declaration details various rights that the signatories acknowledge should be accorded to Indigenous communities in line with recommendations from the UN Human Rights Council. It lays out many of the key issues relevant to Indigenous communities around the world, such as colonialism, although it does not define what constitutes Indigenous identity. Instead, the UN declaration aligns with the principle of self-identification in terms of recognizing who is, or is not, Indigenous.

Keywords: Race and Ethnicity

Almost any attempt to understand Indigeneity, let alone define it, will run into questions about race and ethnicity: Is Indigeneity an outgrowth of racial or ethnic thinking? Does Indigeneity function independently of race and ethnicity? Or are the three terms, perhaps, so intricately related that they cannot be separated even if they are used in different contexts? From ethnographic practices rooted in colonial expansion to legal frameworks reducing Indigeneity to one's blood quantum, and from multicultural projects of inclusion through a respect for difference to the commodification of ethnicized and racialized Indigenous identities through tourist practices, the resources in this section help us think through the relationship between race, ethnicity, and Indigeneity in specific historical and social contexts. They also bring to the fore the power differentials that belie the use of these terms, which is a circumstance that connects them all and generates a meaningful space for dialogue across time, place, and term.

"Sino-Spanish Codex" (aka "Boxer Codex)." Ca. 1590. Lilly Library, Indiana University, Bloomington, IN. The ethnographic manuscript known as the "Boxer Codex" was commissioned in Spanish Manila circa 1590 and consists of 314 foliated pages of text and 163 colored illustrations distributed across an additional 97 foliated pages. Of Spanish authorship and Chinese artistry, the manuscript catalogs the diverse range of peoples inhabiting the vast oceanic and terrestrial regions neighboring Manila. It is an exceptional document that combines ethnographic, costume book, cabinet of curiosity, and Chinese literary genres and forms an early node of Indigenous textual visibility in coastal Asia and the Pacific.

Gordon, Tamar, dir. 2005. *Global Villages*. Video, 58:58. https://vimeo.com/308809004. Featuring interviews and observational footage from ethno-cultural theme parks in China (including China Folk Culture Village and Window of the World in Shenzhen) and Japan (Huis Ten Bosch Dutch Village and Parque España), this ethnographic film illuminates how these simulated environments create experiences of ethnic difference and re/produce ideas of heritage, identity, and nationhood. Interviews with park managers and performers reveal how discourses of cultural difference are both specific to the Chinese and Japanese sociohistorical contexts and also shared by and drawn from globally circulating ideologies of "racial" characteristics and hierarchies.

US Congress. 1921. House. Hawaiian Homes Commission Act, as amended. Act of July 9, 1921, c 42, 42 Stat 108. 67th Cong. This act, originally designed to give Kānaka Maoli access to specially designated homesteading land, formalized a definition that individuals must possess 50 percent or more Kānaka Maoli ancestry in order to be recognized as Native Hawaiian under US law. While originally intended to give aid to displaced Kānaka Maoli, critics argue that its focus on blood quantum over genealogy has problematically bound Indigenous identity to colonial racial discourses, excluding many in need of assistance and undermining more expansive sovereignty claims.

Ibau, Dadelavan. 2021. "Muakai." In *A Queer Taiwanese Fiction Reader,* edited by Howard Chiang, 139–169. Amherst, NY: Cambria Press and the

National Taiwan Museum of Literature. Ibau is a member of Taiwan's Paiwan Indigenous community. In one of few works in Mandarin Chinese (let alone translated into English) that focus on Indigenous experiences of queerness, the story's female protagonist navigates between Indigenous and settler colonial social expectations. In doing so, she forges a distinctly modern Paiwan identity that is rooted in tradition even as it accommodates certain aspects of colonial culture. The narrative style reflects the multiple cultural influences on the protagonist and is consequently linear at times, broken at others, and intensely lyrical.

Tseden, Pema, dir. 2015. *Tharlo*. New York: Icarus Films. Film. Author and filmmaker Pema Tseden (1969–2023) was the most well-known contemporary Tibetan director in China; he was the first Tibetan student to attend Beijing Film Academy and began making films in the early 2000s. *Tharlo* is adapted from a short story he wrote and tells the story of the titular character, a naïve shepherd, who is called into the city to obtain an ID card as required by the government. Underlying Tharlo's subsequent misadventures in the city are the questions of Tibetan identity, changing pastoralist livelihoods, and Chinese urbanization that informed much of Pema Tseden's oeuvre. The film premiered at the Venice International Film Festival in 2015.

Keyword: Methodologies

The need to move beyond colonial or other externally imposed definitions of Indigeneity has often meant returning to Indigenous methodologies and epistemologies that have been subordinated to more restrictive or legalistic definitions of Indigeneity set down by the state. The texts collected in this section are examples of ways that Indigenous scholars and artists have articulated Indigeneity not only as an identity but as distinctive worldviews, praxes, and analytics. Engagement with these Indigenous methodologies has many important ramifications for politics, research, art, and science. See also Omer Aijazi's contributions to this volume on geographical imaginations, mapping, and free movement in Kashmir (convergence 5, "A/Geography").

Telegut, Alisi. 2023. Alisi Telegut personal website. Accessed September 13, 2023. http://alisitelengut.com/. Alisi Telegut is a Mongolian Canadian artist whose works often draw from traditional Mongolian stories as well as themes of diaspora, cultural memory, and kinship. Her hand-painted animated films have shown widely in festivals around the world and offer an evocative, reflexive avenue for thinking through and representing an experience of an Asian diaspora through creative artistic practice.

Smith, Linda Tuhiwai. 1999. ***Decolonizing Methodologies: Research and Indigenous Peoples.*** **London: Zed Books.** In this monograph, Māori scholar Linda Tuhiwai Smith shows how academic research methodologies emerge out of colonial and imperial projects of exploration and exploitation. Smith argues that a truly decolonial methodology cannot depend on accepted disciplinary norms but must identify, challenge, and remake academic "regimes of truth" that naturalize Indigenous erasure or belittlement and promote a colonial dynamic of discovering and claiming knowledge. Research on Indigenous communities must ultimately be guided by, and be useful or in service to, the community being researched.

Wuwu, Aku, Jjivo Zopqu, and Mark Bender. 2019. ***The Nuosu Book of Origins: A Creation Epic from Southwest China.*** **Seattle: University of Washington Press.** The Nuosu-Yi people of Liangshan live in the southwest of Sichuan Province in the People's Republic of China. A collaborative translation by leading members of the Nuosu community and a specialist of Chinese folklore from the United States, the story takes readers through several cycles of births and rebirths of the world and explains the migration of the Yi people as well as the development of their various branches (the Nuosu being only one subset within the Yi ethnicity). It also offers a new understanding of what it means to be "human," suggesting that we exist not only for ourselves but as part of an interconnected web spanning the cosmic, spiritual, and ecological realms.

Yunkaporta, Tyson. 2020. ***Sand Talk: How Indigenous Thinking Can Save the World.*** **New York: Harper.** Aboriginal Australian author Tyson Yunkaporta centers Indigenous perspectives and analytic frameworks—such as

"yarning," or the practice of learning through sharing and exchanging stories—in order to think through complex questions around globalization, gender, community, and technology. Through these yarns, Yunkaporta emphasizes the way that Indigenous epistemologies depend on an ethic of balance and reciprocity that promote systems and structures based on sustainability.

Keyword: Environmental Stewardship

Indigenous peoples have been stewards of their lands for many generations. While this stewardship has sometimes resulted in problematic colonial understandings of Indigenous communities as being affixed or limited to a specific landscape, in other contexts Indigenous methods of relating to and working with the land and sea have provided a powerful critique of and corrective to the practices of colonial and imperial land exploitation. While Indigenous communities contribute a minimal amount—in terms of emissions and waste—to global warming, many bear a disproportionate burden of the damages caused by climate change on the environment. The works in this section show how the cause of environmental justice is profoundly entangled with Indigenous rights and decolonial politics and vice versa.

Lhaze, dir. 2011. From Our Eyes + Yak Dung. 云南乡村之眼图文化研究中心 (Yunnan From Our Eyes Rural Documentary and Culture Research Center). Organization website (www.xczy.org). Accessed September 13, 2023. Film.

Lhaze/Lance, dir. 2010. Yak Dung. Digital video, color, 49:09. Accessed September 13, 2023. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ZfpTHOhExGI.

Yunnan From Our Eyes Rural Documentary and Culture Research Centre is a Chinese NGO based in Kunming, Yunnan Province. Its founders have organized community media workshops in ethnic minority communities in Southwest and Western China since the early 2000s. From Our Eyes often works closely with local environmental and cultural heritage groups in China, and one of its longest-running collaborations has been with the Nyanpo Yuzee Environmental Protection Association in Golok prefecture, Qinghai Province. *Yak Dung* was shot and directed by

Lhaze, a Tibetan pastoralist; of the hundreds of documentary films produced by participants in From Our Eyes workshops, this film depicting the centrality of yak dung to pastoralist livelihoods has garnered the most attention domestically in China and internationally for its direct and often humorous perspective on the interdependence of humans and their animals. In so doing, it also gestures to environmental and ecological changes brought about by state-led development and urbanization policies that have transformed Tibetan pastoralist communities across the region.

Jetñil-Kijiner, Kathy, and Aka Niviâna. November 21, 2018. ***Rise: From One Island to Another.*** **Posted by Climate Vulnerable Forum. Spoken word, 6:36. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=QtT-hJBZlUY.** This video poem is a collaborative project by two Indigenous authors, Kathy Jetñil-Kijiner (Majel / Marshall Islands) and Aka Niviâna (Kalaallit Nunaat / Greenland), who write about the interrelated impacts that climate change has had on their respective homelands: glacier melt in Greenland and sea level rise in the Marshall Islands. Sharing stories of their homes and the warnings that their respective cultures have passed down about the effects of man's greed on their surroundings, the poem articulates both trans-Indigenous solidarity and the immediacy of our climate crisis.

Perez, Craig Santos. 2020. ***Habitat Threshold.*** **Oakland, CA: Omnidawn.** Using as a starting conceit the concept of a "habitat threshold" or minimum required area of habitat needed for a species to survive, this collection of poems by CHamoru poet Craig Santos Perez draws connections between environmental degradation, climate change, and ongoing forms of colonialism, capitalism, and militarism that have displaced and disproportionately endangered Indigenous and racialized communities around the globe.

Keyword: Mobilities

More than either "diaspora" or "migration," "mobility" encompasses all forms of movement, both the permanent and transient, single-site and multi-site, voluntary and forced, isolated and assimilationist. The intersections between Indigeneity and mobility raise questions that merit further

attention. For example, what happens to Indigenous identities when they are uprooted from particular locales? Is it possible to be considered Indigenous in one space and not in another? Most importantly, mobility perhaps best indicates the global expanse of Indigeneity and the concept's enduring relevance to the project of Global Asias. See also Neelima Jeychandran's contribution in this volume on the Indian Ocean slave trade and African speculative histories (convergence 1, "Transits").

Hau'ofa, Epeli. 1994. "Our Sea of Islands." ***Contemporary Pacific*** **6, no. 1:148–161.** Tongan author Epeli Hau'ofa argues that rather than adopting the dominant view of the Pacific Islands as small, isolated "islands in a far sea," Pacific scholars and communities might more usefully think of themselves as a "sea of islands," an expansive network emerging from historical trade and kinship networks that spanned vast ocean spaces. This essay also advocates for the use of the term "Oceania" (over "Pacific Islands") as a term that more adequately communicates this dynamic history of interaction and migration.

Hearn, Lafcadio. 1883. "Saint Malo. A Lacustrine Village in Louisiana." ***Harper's Weekly: A Journal of Civilization*** **27:196–199.** Before Lafcadio Hearn became a Japanese citizen and published numerous books on Japanese society and culture, he penned the first ethnography of a group of Indigenous Filipino fishermen living in an isolated village in Louisiana. This community had existed, he claimed, fifty years prior to the date of publication, largely outside of the jurisdictional oversight of the US government. Hearn's dating places this group of Indigenous Filipinos as among the first and longest-lasting Asian communities in the United States.

Lee, Erika. 2003. At America's Gates: ***Chinese Immigration during the Exclusion Era,*** **1882–1943. Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press.** Erika Lee charts the steady militarization of the US borders through the hostile implementation of the Chinese Exclusion Act of 1882. The analysis tracks common strategies that Chinese migrants would use to enter the United States during this era, one of which was the attempt to pass as Indigenous people of the US/Mexico borderlands. This act signals a shared space of racialization and contact that made such attempts to pass both

plausible and punishable. The aftermath left the border fortified to an unprecedented degree in US history, which has subsequently impacted the lives of Indigenous peoples from the Americas attempting to migrate north.

Matsuda, Matt K. 2008. *Pacific Worlds: A History of Seas, Peoples, and Cultures*. New York: Cambridge University Press. Matsuda's landmark "trans-local" history of the Pacific uses episodic narration to define the region's history through a series of long-distance movements, contacts, and conflicts among Indigenous peoples, Europeans, and Asian polities. Matsuda recalibrates the *longue durée* of the Pacific with an attention to multi-imperial colonial incursions and the limits of European power projection.

Mijit, Mukaddas, dir. 2022. *A Poem about Exile*. Digital video, color, 5:38. Accessed September 13, 2023. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=oa6fQtbEzcU. In this work of video art, the titular poem by Yazi provides the soundtrack for an experimental dance performance by a single woman inside and outside an urban apartment in France. The juxtaposition of the woman's shaky, brutal physicality in the public street alongside the anger and fear of life in unintentional exile captures an experience of longing, distance, and instability for Uyghurs who have left China, a country that was (and for some remains) both the place where they were once at home and a nation that has compelled their departure, most recently due to the repression and mass detention of Uyghurs and Turkic Muslims as part of the Chinese state's "People's War on Terror." The video was directed by Mukaddas Mijit, a Uyghur scholar-dancer-filmmaker based in France, whose works on Uyghur cultural practices and identity extend across experimental dance, curatorial work, documentary, and narrative filmmaking.

Wang, Bing, dir. 2016. *Ta'ang*. New York: Icarus Films. Film. Wang Bing, an independent Chinese documentary filmmaker, is known for his unyielding, often lengthy, films focusing on overlooked or forgotten communities in China's rapid socioeconomic development since the late twentieth century. In this observational documentary, Wang follows members of the Ta'ang minority in Myanmar (classified as De'ang in China) as they flee to China to escape an ongoing civil war in Myanmar, settling in refugee camps or pressing onward to seek work in fields or in Chinese cities. The

film depicts the conflicting senses of uncertainty and inevitability facing Ta'ang refugees in China as they cross and recross borders and frontiers that are often geographically unclear but politically, and economically, the determining factor for survival.

Notes to Convergence 2

1. See "Capitalization" (2017); Scire (2020); also "Capitalization and Formatting of Indigenous Terms" (2023).
2. Arvin explains that "viewing indigeneity as an analytic rather than only an identity allows us to deeply engage the various power relations that continue to write indigenous peoples as always vanishing. . . . Beyond the writing of indigenous peoples into stories about humanity's journey out of Africa or the final inclusion of indigenous peoples as bearers of human rights, indigeneity can be used to better recognize what Scott Lyons has called, in the context of Native America, our 'actually existing diversity,' inside and outside of the many given taxons our indigenous lives are formed in." See Arvin (2015, 126).
3. See, for example, Smith (1999) and, in this volume, convergence 3, "Epistemology."
4. As I will discuss later in this convergence, this term ("Native Pacific") is a heuristic that gestures to commonalities linking peoples and places in the Pacific Islands while also glossing some important distinctions to be made between Indigenous and Pacific studies. For more on this distinction, see Teaiwa (2010, 114–116).
5. On the use of genealogy as critical theory in Native Pacific studies, see Trask (1993); Teaiwa (2014, 43–55); Na'puti (2019, 495–501); Wilson-Hokowhitu (2019); and Makereti (2020); among others.
6. On relationality as a critical framework in Native Pacific studies, see, for example, Hau'ofa (1994, 148–161); Thaman (2008, 173–187); Salesa (2014, 31–52); Warren et al. (2021, 7–16).
7. See Wendt (1976, 49–60); Marsh (1999, 337–356); Teaiwa (2014).
8. The past decade has seen a number of published monographs engaging Indigenous and Asian North American studies; there is also an increasing number of scholars working comparatively in Asian and Indigenous studies. See, for example, Medak-Saltzman (2015, 11–32); Yao (2021, 471–504); and special issues of *Asian Ethnicity* 17, no. 4 (2016) and *Verge: Studies in Global Asias* 4, no. 2 (2018). However, for the most part, scholars engaging Indigeneity in

Asian contexts make little or no explicit reference to Indigenous scholarship or theory emerging from settler colonial states and vice versa.

9. I draw from Andrea Mendoza's theorization of the "nonencounter" as a critique of area studies' reluctance to engage with questions of race and racialization by transfiguring them into "constructed disparity." See Mendoza (2021, 3).
10. To give one example, Emily Yeh notes that Tibetans have tended to avoid the label "Indigenous" precisely because accepting it would mean that they could be recognized as a minority nationality under Chinese rule (Yeh 2007a, 648–667); however, more recently Dawa Lokyitsang has argued that Tibetans living in diaspora have been increasingly engaging Indigenous scholarship and methodologies for refusal, embracing Indigeneity not so much as a given identity but as a "decolonial praxis" (Lokyitsang 2017).
11. For a broad overview of these dynamics, see Baird (2016); Eubanks and Sherpa (2018).
12. The case was later found by Taiwan's Supreme Court to be partially unconstitutional, and President Tsai later pardoned Talum in 2021, one of only seven pardons in Taiwan's history. For more, see "Erase Conviction of Bunun Hunter, Control Yuan Says" (2022).
13. Several of Syaman Rapongan's short stories are available in English translation in Tu and Backus (2005).
14. Scott (1994, 253, 256); Manickam (2009, 70).
15. Here I do not capitalize "indigenous" as it is not used as a category of political identity but rather as an adjective more akin to "local" or "domestic" in opposition to global and foreign.
16. Many thanks to Dr. Ka Lee Wong for the Cantonese transliteration.
17. For a specific example, see "Capitalization and Formatting of Indigenous Terms" (2023).

Interleaf—Reorientations

Murmurs as Political Thought (or, A Political Theory of Murmurs): In Search of Ways to See the Sorrow and Things Hidden

Lee Chonghwa

Bē/Boat

Things that we don't know. Things that we cannot know. Things that you have to take in rather than consume.
From the outside, we can interpret it however we like. But, from the moment we enter the frame.
We cannot refuse an interpretation.
Because the frame is where we live.

To talk about those things, we need to find words that cannot be consumed, words that are tied to the choices we make in our way of life …
So that we don't forget the question of whether we can live after talking and after listening …

But by not making them, how can we preserve the testimonies, histories, and symbolisms born out of memory?

These are the many "Tales of Bē/the Boat."

The Korean word "bē" simultaneously means a person's stomach and the Japanese word "boat" …

In fact, my body, which refuses all things that can be named, gives itself up to that "bē," to that boat. Through these stories, I hope that my life can overlap with yours …

Nation-state • Ethnos/Race • Man • Woman

つぶやきの政治思想

李静和

（ベー・舟）（噓）

分からないこと．わかってはならないこと．消費するのではなく受容し
なければならないこと．それは語る私に、聞く我々に、居心地悪さを残す．
外部からはどう解釈してもいい．だが、いったん枠に入った瞬間は．
解釈することを拒否しなくてはならな．
それが生きる場だから．

それを語るには、消費されない言葉、生き方における選択につながる言
葉を見つけなくてはならない …
語ったあと、聞いたあと、とう生きるかという問いを忘れないために…

それをつくられないことで、記憶から生まれた証言や歴史性やシンボル性を、
いかに保ちうるか。

これはいくつかの「ベー舟物語」であ。

韓国語の「ベー」は人のお腹を意味すると同時に日本語の「舟」でも
ある …

実はもう名付けられる（なづけられる）あらゆるものを拒否している私の体は、その
＜ベー＞に、その舟に身をゆだねている。これらの物語が、私の、そしてあ
なたの生に重なることを願いつつ …

国家・民族・男・女

The Passport

Mahmoud Darwish

They don't recognize me in the shadows
That suck my color in this passport.
To them my wound is a showroom
For a tourist who passionately collects pictures.
They don't recognize me. Don't leave
The palm of my hand without a sun
Because the trees
Know me …
The spinning mills of rain know me.
Don't leave me mummified like the moon!

The birds follow
The palm of my hand to the distance airport
And all the wheat fields,
All the prisons,
All the pale sepulchers,
All the barbed boundaries,
All the waving handkerchiefs,
All the dark eyes
All the eyes
Are with me, but the masters,
Drop them from this passport!

جواز سفر

لم يعرفوني في الظلال الظلال التي تمتص لوني في جواز السفر
و كان جرحي عندهم معرضاً لسائح يهش جمع الصور
لم يعرفوني، آه.. لا تتركي كفي بلا شمس، لأن الشجر يعرفني..
تعرفني كل أغاني المطر
لا تتركيني شاحباً كالقمر! آه آه كالقمر

***

كل العصافير التي لاحقت كفي على باب المطر البعيد
كل حقول القمح، كل السجون..
كل القبور البيض كل الحدود..
كل المناديل التي لوحت كل العيون
كانت معي، لكنهم قد أسقطوها من جواز السفر!

Mirror Words

Don Mee Choi

Mirror words come out of my thoughts about translation. Translation is a mode=Translation is an anti-neocolonial mode. I obsess about "order words that are given in our society." In 1945, it took less than thirty minutes for order words to be carried out, to divide the country I was born in, along the 38th parallel north. Order words compel division, war, and obedience around the world. But other words are possible. Translation is an anti-neocolonial mode can create other words. I call mine mirror words. Mirror words are meant to compel disobedience, resistance. Mirror words defy neocolonial borders, blockades. Mirror words flutter along borders and are often in flight across oceans, even galaxies. Mirror words are homesick. Mirror words are halo. Mirror words are orphaned words. Now look at your words in a mirror. Translate, translate! Did you? Do it again, do it!

Junyoung Verónica Kim, *Reorientations,* 2022. Poems by Lee Chonghwa (1998), Mahmoud Darwish (1974), and Don Mee Choi (2020).

CONVERGENCE 3

Epistemology

Knowing from the Flesh: Disobedience, Epistemologies, and Disciplines

Junyoung Verónica Kim, Naveen Minai,
Youngoh Jung, and Carla Nappi

Research Forum

How can we use method and methodology to engender a radical scholarly praxis that seeks out liberation within our present system of knowledge—with-across-outside-against—within normative disciplines? That is, how can we construe methodology as an act of disobedience and rebellion that resists integration, refuses appropriation, and disrupts implications of union and reconciliation that uphold the governmentality of neoliberal multicultural imperial nationalism?

Introduction

Junyoung Verónica Kim and Naveen Minai

Defined as the study of knowledge, epistemology as a Western historical construct always already categorizes what is knowledge—as opposed to superstitions, fantasies, and feelings—and determines the ways in which we know and study. The definition of knowledge governs how we work as students, as teachers, and as scholars. In short, epistemology underpins and scaffolds the historical development of academia as infrastructure, institution, and set of practices. The assemblage of cisheterosexism, imperialism, settler colonialism, and racial capitalism, which co-constitute and often overlap, creates complex networks of infrastructures and technologies that are not limited to geopolitical and economic spheres but create the conditions under which knowledge is produced in academia. What counts as knowledge and by what mechanisms are other forms of making sense of the world discounted? Who/where takes on the position of the knowing subject and who/what/where is only valued as an object of knowledge? What are the infrastructures and technologies through which certain forms of knowing are legitimized, canonized, and perpetuated as episteme and logos? Questioning the logics, desires, and assumptions that subtend the definition of knowledge, Global Asias brings to light the material conditions of knowledge production that are most often disavowed.

As the works of Lee Chonghwa (1998), Mahmoud Darwish (1973, 2010), and Don Mee Choi (2020) in the Interleaf show, the question of knowledge is intimately intertwined with the question of positionality in

terms of both the geopolitical (nation, border, state) and the biopolitical (race, gender, sexuality). Who is valued as human? Who and how does one belong (or not belong) to a nation/state? Indeed, what counts as knowledge is often about who counts as human. Only those who count can have histories, languages, archives, and maps. Invoking questions of belonging (to nations/languages/institutions/disciplines) and centering the body and the flesh as *where* we know *from,* our research forum and pedagogical modules take up the provocations crafted by these poets.

These epistemological challenges are precisely the catalyst of Global Asias as an intellectual project. Global Asias interrogates the historical construction of disciplinary boundaries thereby suspecting hegemonic binaries of object/subject, local/global, home/diaspora, citizen/alien. Multiplying frames of "Asia," Global Asias challenges the definition of "Asia" and "Asian," calling into question discrete identity formations that subtend the study of Asia/s and Asian diasporas. Indeed, one of the greatest contributions of Global Asias is the problematization of the bordering of area studies and ethnic studies as separate putative disciplines. It brings into contact geopolitics and biopolitics, connecting questions of economy and sociopolitics to race, gender, and migration. The troubling of disciplinary boundaries goes hand in hand with the adoption and adaptation of transdisciplinary methodologies that pay attention to ways of knowing the world that are not always counted in academic frameworks. In our meditation on epistemology, we mobilize Global Asias to trace the ways in which certain histories, stories, feelings, myths, *cosmovisiones,* are obfuscated, silenced, incarcerated, extracted, and/or commodified.

As students and scholars who continuously grapple with the violences of disciplinary borders, Global Asias has provided us with space, tools, and a community to cultivate queer futures. Each of us arrives at the question of epistemology conditioned by multi-scalar violences—colonialism, racial capitalism, war, partition, cisheterosexism, racism manifested in the institutional as well as the intimate and the everyday. Our un/belonging to disciplines and fields resembles our positionality in nation-states. Just as one's passport or visa status determines how one arrives at the borders of a nation-state, the process of being a good citizen in academic institutions abides by the same logic.

Academia—as institutions and infrastructures of knowledge—is grounded in a Eurocentric epistemology that pivots on a model of the individual, which has historically rewarded White men for the knowledge they have extracted and commodified. Academia functions on and promotes competitiveness, exceptionalism, and ownership of archives, histories, and knowledge making. Indeed, the neoliberal imperial university functions precisely by deploying the logic of individual exceptionalism in their model of "diversity and inclusion," which is most often engineered as tokenism. This logic means that there can only ever be *one:* one racialized/gendered body is made to stand in for diversity to demonstrate the university's supposed benevolence and the semblance of meritocracy. In turn, the university demands that the *one* be obedient, grateful, and silent and assimilate violent logics and practices of positioning other racialized/gendered scholars as competition and threat.

Building community and collectivity, therefore, is antithetical to academic ecologies and economies. While the logic of individual ownership of knowledge is promoted by academia—from student assignments to research to tenure—we know that we survive, thrive, and flourish as scholars, teachers, and students through cultivating community. It is only through mutual generosity, care, love, and accountability that we navigate, manage, and live through systematic oppression. By depending on one another, our histories, lived experiences, and knowledges—despite being continuously erased, silenced, and obfuscated—continue to surface and sustain us. Community, therefore, is one of the most effective forms of rebellion against the colonizing project of the university (García-Peña 2022).

Global Asias builds community by demanding a different way of doing things: instead of stepping on and over one another to get to the finish line first, we have one another's backs and build together a practice of trust. We have helped one another survive and thrive. Numerous emails and phone calls make sure that we are okay as an explicit acknowledgment of the conditions under which each of us is laboring, often characterized by precarity and crisis. By creating safe spaces where we can be vulnerable and take time to pause and breathe, we built a community that has sustained and nourished us. Over the past two years, we have thought together about

the question of epistemology, engaging one another and reading and reflecting on one another's work, the process of which is made material in the following essays. We take up this project and further call for disobedience and rebellion against these forms of institutionalization that are integral to geopolitical and biopolitical violences.

Offshoring Disciplinarity: Asia–Latin America as Method

Junyoung Verónica Kim

Although I was not conscious of it at the time, my research and teaching that takes "Asia–Latin America as method" (Kim 2017) emerged as I tried to make sense of the questions I received on a daily basis, which treated me as an object of surprise and demanded an explanation for my existence, for my name, and for my genealogy: "Where are you from? What is your ethnicity? What is your nationality? Why do you look Asian (*china*) and speak Spanish? How can your name be Junyoung Verónica? Which is your *real* name? Where are your parents from? When and why did Koreans come/go to Argentina? Are there Asians in Latin America?" When I returned to South Korea and came to the United States as an international student, I realized that although the affective charge of the questions might differ depending on the geopolitical, sociopolitical, and material context, I would receive these questions no matter *where*—perhaps for me this is what the global signifies, the global normative ideas subtended by categorizations of geographies/nations/races/ethnicities/genders/sexualities (Ferreira da Silva 2007).

Trying to make sense of these questions and grappling with my feelings of frustration, I started to ask my own questions and wonder at the surprise I evoked. Why is "Asia–Latin America" and why are Asian Latin Americans always a surprise? Why is the juxtaposition of "Asia" and "Latin America" always in need of an explanation unlike that of Asia and the other Americas, North America? How come an Asian-looking face/body that speaks fluent English does not surprise, but a recognizably Asian person speaking fluent ("native") Spanish is a cause for astonishment? That is, why is the *American* in the term *Asian American* not called into question when most of the time *American,* in this case, signifies a putative notion of the United

States? As Katherine McKittrick (2006) explains in the context of Black Canada, when peoples and places are not supposed to be part of a nation and/or region, and contradict the putative notion of *area,* they are seen as surprises. In the case of Latin America, a region that defines itself largely as Euro-dominant in which Indigenous and Black peoples are only symbolically incorporated as the region's past or as footnotes on particular cultural traits or practices (e.g., food, dance, music), the economy of surprise places Asia–Latin America in tension with the region's obfuscation and erasure of Asian Latin Americans: "[Asianness] is surprising because it should not be here, was not here before, was always here, is only momentarily here, was always over there [in Asia]" (McKittrick 2006, 93). Asian peoples in Latin America are always presumed surprises because they exist in a space that is defined by non-Asianness (or anti-Asianness) and yet, as I will later explore, they create a thick livingness that does not conform to reified ideas of either Asia or Latin America.

The epistemological inscrutability of Asia–Latin America / Asian–Latin American set the trajectory for my arrival to both area studies and ethnic studies—Latin American studies, Asian studies, Asian American studies, and Latinx studies. I arrived at these disciplines not through "Asia," "Latin America," or "Asian American," but through Asia–Latin America, precisely because there was no space in which to study, analyze, ponder, and make sense of Asian Latin American histories, experiences, and epistemologies. Even the cumbersome term I deploy, "Asia–Latin America," speaks to the limits of our present grammar, which restrict, reify, and mercilessly compartmentalize places, peoples, and temporalities into discrete categories. Part and parcel of this grammar are the epistemic infrastructures of academic disciplines. As I tried to navigate my way through these institutional spaces by somehow trying to open or at least move the borders of disciplines, I encountered thick brick walls and electric fences prohibiting my movement. Sara Ahmed (2017) reminds us that the difficulty of speaking about institutional walls is that they are visible and palpable only to those who attempt to change the normative order of things; that is, for many, not only do these walls not exist, but the continuing operation of academic disciplines and institutions necessitates the refusal to see these walls. As I banged my body against these immobile walls, my disenchantment and anger became a force to reckon with (Lorde 2007; Wynter

1987)—rebellion must start here at this border wall, at this electric fence. Indeed, it is these moments of "undoings and scholarly breakdowns," as Carla Nappi (a contributor to this volume, personal correspondence with the author, 2022) incites us to think, that "generates new forms of knowledge" and makes possible creative acts of disobedience. For how do we (many of us scholars of color, women of color academics) work through the thorny racial/gender/class privileges and biases that animate the fields in which we situate ourselves? Or as Andrea Mendoza (Kim and Mendoza 2022) eloquently asks, "In thinking about the capitalist, extractive, and exploitative practices of the formation of Area Studies, what debts can we pay to the work of critical race theory (especially the work of Black and Indigenous epistemologies) when we contend with the question of [Global Asias] as a critique of the pitfalls of Area Studies?"

It is one thing to speak about colonialism, imperialism, and neoliberalism as objects of study, but another to sit down and think through how racism and other forms of oppression subtend the political economy of academic disciplinary thinking that converts data/facts/archives/bodies into capital (Jung, this volume). As many Black, Indigenous, and Asian diasporic feminists and queer scholars of color have noted, the investment in disciplinary thought is thick and wide-ranging, which is precisely why the supposed "end" of area studies signals merely afterlives of the discipline and not necessarily queer futurist methods of thinking. In her study of Black and anticolonial methodologies, Katherine McKittrick (2021, 35) explains, "Discipline is the act of relentless categorization. Academic disciplines make knowledge into categories and subcategories The weight of discipline is evidenced by the density of disciplinarity and the method of making disciplined categorization happen: around every corner, at every turn, disciplinary practitioners provide disciplined narratives that confirm the solidity of disciplinary knowledge and its categorical difference from other ways of knowing." The canon, the key thinkers, the core courses, the anthologies, the comprehensive exams, and the textbooks are all clear examples of this.

We need only think about citation: not only are citational practices gendered and racialized, as Sara Ahmed brilliantly observes, but they also obey disciplinary categorization. Who must you cite if you work in Latin American studies as opposed to Asian American studies? How do the

authors you decide to include in your bibliography determine your legitimacy and belonging (or illegitimacy and non-belonging) to disciplinary fields? For instance, what does it mean to think through decoloniality not through Anibal Quijano and Walter Mignolo, but through Linda Tuhiwai Smith and Sylvia Wynter? Or in exploring the relations between race, sexuality, history, and power to go through Denise Ferreira da Silva and Anne Cheng, instead of Michel Foucault and Giorgio Agamben? Women of color scholars are seen as tied to a particular area, ethnicity, and/or field of study, while White male European/Euro-American thinkers are posited as the bearers of universal knowledge. Instead of reading women of color thinking as particularized by locality or area—which already forecloses its reach as a closed and limited discourse that cannot account for the human or the universal/global—how can we think of beingness that is not captured by the grammar of humanism, that is, by the logics of disciplinarity? Citation as a method of discipline congeals the borders of knowledge as disciplinarity creates fictive distance between us, between "Asia" and "Latin America," between area studies and ethnic studies. In this knowledge system, the commensurable differences between humans swell—Asian, Black, Indigenous (McKittrick 2021).

The bifurcation and differentiation of modes of knowing is in part, as Edward Said reminds us, the work of empire. That is, discipline is part and parcel of the operation of heteropatriarchal settler colonial racial capitalism. This is exemplified when we notice that "studying Asian people" and "studying Black people" is, to use McKittrick's words, "an intricate Malthusian project of bifurcating each racial history according to different identity markers and genealogies" (2021, 38), thereby a priori obfuscating Afro-Asian intimacies, unseeing the fact of peoples such as Black Asians, and refusing to acknowledge the multi-scalar dynamic of power and the complex racial entanglements that underpin the operation of capitalism.

It is in this context that I can make sense of a comment from a colleague working on Asian Latin American relations. In response to a question on the Asian heritage of the renowned Afro-Cuban artist Wifredo Lam and the Asianness of his work, my colleague said, "There is nothing Asian about Wifredo Lam's artwork. I have looked at every single piece looking for Asian influences and found none. What some people mistake as bamboo are actually sugar cane—the most Cuban thing of all!" And of

course, what he missed was that sugarcane is also precisely the commodity of Afro-Asian intimacies: Chinese indentured laborers working side by side with African slaves in Cuban sugarcane plantations (Yun 2008). By always already defining "Asian" as that which is separate from "Black," "Afro-Caribbean," and "Cuban," this grammar of knowledge is unable to see and listen to the complex Asian diasporic experiences, histories, languages, and affects that disobey disciplinary ecologies of thought. However, instead of dwelling in this oversight, I want to call attention to the affective economies that underpin the desire for area and ethnicity. What is the investment in searching for Asianness in Wifredo Lam or, in turn, denying Asianness? As Naveen Minai (this volume) poignantly questions, what are the desires that drive scholars to know, to capture something or someone, and to render it transparent? Whose desires go unquestioned as part and parcel of objective knowledge production, and whose desires are dismissed as inappropriate and "too much"? Whose desires stick and whose slide away? That is, what are the desires that are foundational to the construction and continuation of area studies and its afterlives? Can we speak about a "racial politics and geopolitics of desire" for *area* (Minai, a contributor to this volume, personal correspondence with the author, 2022)? Indeed, these questions point to the racial unconscious of area studies in which the fetishization of area hinges on a disavowal of its own investment in race.

If this is the case in area studies, how does ethnic studies talk or not talk about race? Arising from the civil rights and liberation movements of the 1960s and 1970s, ethnic studies contests the hegemonic narrative of the United States by focusing on migration and systematic racism as large structuring forces of both national state politics and subjectivities. Despite its careful attention to difference and multiplicity in relation to US histories of racialization and systematic racism of peoples who have been interpellated as "Asian," Asian American studies largely examines migration as a movement from one Asian country to the United States, thereby privileging the United States as the destination for immigration. The dominant geohistorical view of migration that privileges the Asia-US channel inevitably obscures the dynamic currents of global migration that include the migration of Asian peoples to Latin America and the Caribbean, as well as the circuits of return migrations to Asia from the Americas.

Indeed, how does ethnic studies both hyper-visibilize and elide its locus of enunciation, that is, its spatial (the United States), temporal (the dismissal of early colonial connections between Asia and the Americas, such as the Manila galleon trade), and linguistic (Anglophone) configuration (Kim 2017; Lee 2022; Seijas 2014)? To situate Naveen Minai's questions in the understudied and undermined site of Asia–Latin America, I ask: how does ethnic studies even in its critique of *American* (America = United States, America ≠ América) settler colonialism, imperialism, and racial formation normalize and universalize *America?* By equating Asian American as pertaining to the supposed continental borders of the United States (what Daniel Immerwahr calls "the logo map" in his book *How to Hide an Empire* [2019]), how does it construct a grammar that frames Asian diasporas outside of the "logo map" as anything other than copy/extension/margin/footnote? What are we Asian diasporics, Asian Latin Americans, doing for Asian *America?* Whom or what purpose does Asian American studies serve? That is to say, the dominant US-centered ethnic studies framework only differentially includes the studies of other Asian diasporas solely to appropriate them and strengthen even more the hegemony of US-focused epistemologies. Indeed, the category of "Asian American" obscures as much as it reveals. Instead of co-opting or including Asia–Latin America into "Asia/n America/n," which ineluctably bolsters US exceptionalism, I ask that we pull critical ethnic studies away from the US *offshore* to Asia and Latin America and grapple with systems, thoughts, methods, languages, histories, affects, and sensations that cannot be seen, heard, and/or understood in our present grammar.

My proposal of Asia–Latin America as method does not finance a fix or provide the missing part—Asian Latin Americans—to a larger Asian diasporic identity in the hemispheric Americas. Instead, it is a proposal to take seriously the thoughts, affects, and practices that could arise from the silences, murmurs, cracks, and fissures that constitute our queer diasporic histories of war, displacement, and migration (Jung, this volume; Nappi, this volume). Moreover, I am not arguing for similitude or even solidarity between, let's say, Asia and Latin America or Asian racial indenture and Black enslavement. Rather, I am asking that we pay attention to cacophonous and promiscuous intimacies and multi-scalar entanglements; that is, not to limit our thinking to the confines of commensurable difference or

sameness, of death or resistance, but rather to center the complex livingness that defies categorization. This livingness cannot be merely extracted as a mode of critique or as a reified representation of the subaltern, but pulsates and thickens in the ruptures of archives, in the intertextuality of everyday living, in the breakdown of reason. It harkens to the ways in which we navigate forms of being in the world and making sense of it that cannot be captured by taxonomies of nation/border, race/ethnicity, human/animal, or even language.

This to me is precisely what Global Asias as praxis can do: by bringing to the fore the scattering of peoples / nonhuman animals / objects / chemicals across space and thereby undoing maps, geographies, languages, and lineal histories, Global Asias instead of signaling reterritorialization—the redoing of maps/nations/archives—involves celebrating spaces that normally are skirted over; it is the practice of celebrating diasporic livingness that does not fall into death or resistance, which is the way in which racialized beings and communities accumulate value in academic disciplines. It is important to note that inclusion (into the nation, the discipline, the canon, respectively) may just as easily take part in a representational politics that does not necessarily address the structural inequities that underpin inclusion. To go beyond the US politics of race in ethnic studies and the disavowal of race in area studies, we need to not only debunk hegemonic epistemic circuits and ecologies of thought but also engage in an ethical reading/viewing/listening praxis that holds us critically accountable for our own desires for knowledge, transparency, and visibility. Only then can we forge untamed directions that creatively undo disciplines and discontinue the heterosexist, racist, and capitalist underpinnings of knowledge production.

Disorientations: Un/ Knowing from an Area Studied

Naveen Minai

I cannot think about epistemology without thinking about the conditions that produce how we know what we think we know. I come to this question of epistemology from the Global South, which means centering the routes we take to academic institutions. Epistemology is not abstract; rather,

epistemology is a matter of the material conditions through which we ask questions about our worlds.

In *Queer Phenomenology* (2006), Sara Ahmed tells us that it is important to think about how we arrive—to a nation-state, to a department, to a conclusion, in a discipline, in an academy, at a set of questions. Attending to how we arrive is about attending to the conditions that shape our arrival (indeed, if some of us arrive at all) and the terms that determine the shape of how (if) we stay. I name some of the conditions that have shaped my arrival to academic institutions of the Global North: *Pakistan,* the Fulbright Scholarship, economic and cultural capital including an *American* accent, a British undergraduate degree (I can still do a posh English accent), and class-based access to transnational mobility coupled with the right kind of respectable legibility, at the embassy, at immigration at Dubai International Airport, at the international students' office, at the department office.

These conditions of arrival were (still are) also the terms upon which I was/am supposed to remain in the American academy; that is, these conditions signaled, as Ahmed notes, the directions I was/am supposed to follow (2006). I was supposed to study *Pakistan, Islam, woman.* I was supposed to ask whether Pakistani feminism is secular or Muslim. I was supposed to look for queers in Pakistan. I was supposed to understand *Pakistan* as a frontline state in the War on Terror. I was supposed to think of Karachi as resilient. I was supposed to focus on *poverty, violence, democracy, terrorism,* and/or *fundamentalism.* I was supposed to agonize about *English* and *Urdu* in postcolonial (world) literature.

I did not quite turn (Ahmed 2006) that way.

In "On Being Area Studied: A Litany of Complaint" (2016), Keguro Macharia begins by stating the conditions of his departure from the American academy and his return to Nairobi. He pulls apart this map (185) to trace how these conditions are the infrastructures and histories of area studies and queer studies, how these conditions as infrastructures and histories form the frames through which "well-meaning European and US researchers descend on Africa with notebooks and digital recorders to capture the belated entry of Africans into queer modernity" (185).

In "Asia–Latin America as Method: The Global South Project and the Dislocation of the West" (2017), Junyoung Verónica Kim maps

Asia–Latin America as the epistemological articulation of a "precarious position" (100) that attends to multi-scalar, cacophonous, intimate frictions in and across the spaces between us. Kim dislocates the frame of center and peripheries for both the question of *area*—this is not about somewhere called Asia and somewhere called Latin America as new/er points for trendy comparisons—and *ethnic*—we need to think about the geopolitical borders of *Asian America,* that is, the bordering of *Asian America* within the United States, and how ethnic studies rarely delves "into the differing forms of racialization that do not neatly fall into the U.S. historical construction of race and cultural difference" (101).

I think together with Ahmed, Macharia, and Kim (and others) about geopolitics as a matter of epistemology, and geopolitics as the (raw) material of epistemology.

I am a scholar from an area that is studied. To be from an area studied is to be from a geopolitical location that is only ever (supposed to be) *data* and *evidence* and *raw material* and *fieldwork*. To be from an area studied is to never be able to know—*the Global South* becomes legible, in some ways, through the fact that it is somewhere (someone) who can be the *object* and/or *site* of *data* and *fieldwork,* rather than a (knowing) subject, a space *from which* to ask questions and *from which* to theorize.

To theorize from an area studied is not a matter of going over there, as it were, partly because the infrastructural capacity to conceptualize a somewhere as *over there* and go somewhere called *over there* is integral to the material conditions that underpin both *area studies* and *ethnic studies* (alongside other disciplines and fields such as anthropology, english, comparative literature, political science, and philosophy) in the American academy (Ahmed 2006; Hong 2020; Chow 2006; Kim 2017). Macharia writes a caution about the maps of the world re/traced through international quests for queerness, effects of the same logics that bind area studies and ethnic studies: "earnest US-based scholars who promise not to replicate imperial strategies as they travel around the world to discover, if they dare, that they hold US passports, and this means something they cannot escape" (Macharia 2016, 188).

This is one reason why I conceptualize passports as a matter of epistemology and methodology. I do this not just because passports determine which archives which scholars can go to in order to complete scholarship

that will count as historically situated and thorough. I do this not just because passports determine how much time and energy which scholars can spend on applying for visas, instead of on reading, writing, teaching, and service work. I do this not just because passports determine who can travel where at what cost to attend conferences. I do this not just because passports determine who is eligible for which positions in academic institutions—and who can afford to be present in spaces (ostensibly) for transnational scholarly dialogues. I do this also because passports are a powerful symbol of how the material conditions under which knowledge is produced are obscured—including where/what/who counts only as *area.* I do this also because passports make material the situatedness of our inquiries as a matter of epistemology even as some of us move and some of us do not (cannot). Passports signal the geopolitical as the epistemic situation and orientation of our inquiries (Ahmed 2006; Macharia 2016; Kim 2017). Passports as the materiality of citizenship also provoke questions of *race, ethnicity, diaspora, area*—and highlight where we might ask these questions from.

Kim and Macharia invite me to imagine what might happen if we dis/un-locate ourselves from the epistemic space of the American academy. I do not mean here a disavowal based on antagonism or (phobic or philic) orientalism (Abbas 2010). I mean, instead, to think seriously about what disorienting ourselves from the epistemic frames that underpin area studies and ethnic studies might mean—and how we might think *from* the Global South through such disorientations (Ahmed 2006). For example: What does the word *Islam* mean from Pakistan? How do we map the geopolitics of Sunni supremacy of state and public cultures and spaces? Given the genocidal violence against Shia and Ahmedi communities in Pakistan, underpinned by transnational flows of capital and arms, how do we take apart different forms and genealogies of *Islam* in and from Pakistan?

To theorize *from* somewhere named as the Global South requires what Sara Ahmed calls disorientation and reorientation (2006, 6). In epistemic terms, this means for us to not begin where we (usually) might begin, to turn away from the directions and lines—of inquiry, of thought, of discipline, of borders—that we are supposed to follow (Ahmed 2006, 17).

Why do we turn to *English* and *Urdu* as languages through which Pakistan is imagined as a postcolony? Why do we not map the histories and

processes by which a particular form of Urdu becomes the national language of Pakistan, in relation to other languages? To disorient dominant frames through which the question of language is imagined in and from Pakistan, we might map the histories of languages as histories of ethnicities and borders and regions, tracing their routes and roots across the borders of Pakistan, a state and nation younger than any of those languages. This is a matter of epistemology precisely because of the ways in which languages are integral to how nations and states are mapped, and how we understand terms such as *community, globality, affinity,* and *home (land)* (Kim 2017).

Disorientation requires that we attend precisely to how and why we begin where we begin. How have we become oriented, toward and within our disciplines and fields in the first place, to the material conditions that shape how each of us arrives at our fields and disciplines, how we take up space in those spaces—and the pressures to remain in place, to follow particular lines of inquiry—including turning *to* the Global South as an *area* (Ahmed 2006, 112–113). While Ahmed takes apart "the cartographic imperative" (113) that produces "geographic space as phenomenal" (112), I take up Ahmed's analysis to think of the geopolitics of phenomenal space, of epistemic space (Ahmed 2006).

A note on mapping epistemic space: an attentive reader might notice that I have used *Pakistan* rather than *South Asia* in my writing. In the stickiness (Ahmed 2004) between *area* and *ethnic* (studies) in the American academy, this specificity matters. While I sometimes practice an attachment to *South Asian* (for love of Shahrukh Khan if for no other reason), I remain wary of how my desire (and my "self"), named as *South Asian,* obscures and dismisses differences within and across Pakistan, India, Bangladesh, Nepal, Sri Lanka, Bhutan, and Afghanistan with dangerous consequences, including epistemic ones. *Area* (studies) dislocates *Pakistan* and *Afghanistan* as *South Asian* (Af-Pak), re/routes *Islam* toward and from the Arabian Peninsula, disconnects *south* from *central* Asia, and disappears Iran into the *near east. Asia* remains fragmented into colonial, postcolonial, and neocolonial fantasies with real consequences—as do the diasporas that constitute, I would argue, *Asian.* A reader might notice that I use the lowercase for naming regions here—precisely to challenge the ways in which area studies function, and how *area* is alchemized into *racial difference* at a/the border. *South*

Asia in both *area* and *ethnic* (studies) terms might restrict us from necessary epistemic reorientations (Ahmed 2006). For example: from *Pakistan,* I turn toward Kashmir, Korea, and Palestine, and I think: *partition* as colonial and postcolonial technology across Asia as continent.

My work is not *on* Pakistan. My work is not *about* Pakistan (Chuh 2014; Macharia 2016; Kim 2017). When I write *from* Pakistan, I try to engage with the challenge Junyoung Verónica Kim (2017) has posed: "What notion of the global can we propose that does not recenter the West as a mode of organizing the world?" To theorize from Pakistan is to ask different questions.

From Pakistan, the question becomes: how do we understand the Cold War as a rubric for a world order, in palimpsestic relation with the war on drugs and War on Terror? As a living, transnational, continuous, uneven, and open process across the Global South, a dense knot of wars whose legacies and effects we must still deal with (Kim 2017)? To ask after the Cold War from Pakistan is to reimagine the Cold War as a frame of infrastructures of violence, governance, and capital, produced by multiple empires (American and Russian) between scholars in Africa and Asia and Latin America, re/oriented toward one another, rather than toward the United States (or Russia) as epistemic pivot, around which we come into view of each other (Ahmed 2006). From Pakistan, the question of empires becomes: not just American and British but also Russian, Ottoman, Mughal, Maratha, Safavid, Portuguese, Dutch, and French. From Pakistan, the point, as Chow (2006) and Kim (2017) stress, is not comparison that requires one geopolitical point of reference; rather, it is to "confront conflicts, contradictions, and unequal power relations" alongside exploring "histories of (inter)connection and spheres of solidarity" (Kim 2017).

From Pakistan, the question is not whether something called Pakistani feminism is secular or religious, which perpetuates both phobic and philic orientalist notions of feminisms from postcolonial states imagined through *Islam* as a category. From Pakistan, the question becomes: how is heteropatriarchal violence in Pakistan accumulative of, and dense with, the material, affective, and cultural legacies of the partition of 1947, the War of Bangladesh (1971), the Cold War, the War on Terror, and numerous wars and military dictatorships? From Pakistan, the question becomes: What might the history of ethnicity tell us about the history of sexuality? What

might the history of sexuality in South Asia have to do with what Manu Karuka called railroad colonialism; that is, what might the history of the railroad tell us about the history of sexuality, state, and space in South Asia (Karuka 2019)? What might the history of the slave trade along what we might call the silk trade routes (from, roughly, the eleventh to eighteenth centuries) tell us about histories of global anti-Blackness, race, ethnicity, and sexuality? What might we learn about sexuality as a matter of the oceanic if we trace cultural, economic, and legal histories and forms of sex across port cities along the Arabian Sea?

From Pakistan, partition becomes not just an event but a concept, a haunting, a technology of the invention of new/er relations among peoples, languages, and spaces as much as the destruction of old/er ones (Faiz 1989). From Pakistan, the question of *diaspora* compels us to think of different roots and routes and becomes: What is the story of partition told from Quetta instead of Karachi and Lahore? What happens to our understanding of *Pakistani diaspora* if, from Pakistan, we ask after Karachi's Jewish, Christian, and Hindu peoples who fled before, during, and after the partition of 1947?

From Pakistan, the question becomes: How do we understand the question of Brand Islam across Asia and Africa (Shirazi 2016)? What happens if we trace flows of capital, labor, and arms across the Persian Gulf, Central and South Asias, and the Near East from the 1960s onward? From Pakistan, the question becomes: how is Chinese capital remaking regimes of security and development across Africa and Asia?

If Junyoung Verónica Kim challenges us to think of methodology as an act of disobedience (Kim and Mendoza 2022), then I wonder about what disobedience can mean and what the material conditions are that produce both obedience and disobedience. Maybe a conversation about epistemology (and methodology) needs to be (and already is) a conversation about material conditions (Nappi, this volume; Jung, this volume; Kim, this volume). Perhaps what is difficult about these processes is that we might be forced to think about relation: is the only problem between area studies and ethnic studies in the American academy about *race* and *geohistory*—or is one more problem about where all these problems are being discussed and is one more problem about who is setting the pace and tone and terms of this discussion?

Maybe what Global Asias as a frame pushes us to do is to ask after the uglinesses in our disciplines and fields (Jung, this volume; Kim, this volume). Maybe what Global Asias as praxis offers us is to ask questions about who is called upon to explain what and whom and where and when, on what terms. Who is never able to theorize because they are constantly expected to explain and translate? Who wants where/what/when explained, on what terms, and why and by whom (Kim, this volume)? How does desire as an epistemological technology drive the questions that ethnic studies and area studies ask—and what about (Chuh 2014) all the other questions? Whose desires are considered default so as never to be questioned and whose desires are dismissed as too much, not enough, too far, not relevant (Ngai 2005; Hong 2020; Kim, this volume)? What desires are central to, and dominant in, area studies? What are the racial politics and geopolitics of these desires (Ahmed 2006; Macharia 2016)? What are the infrastructural histories of these desires?

Listening to Murmurs and Silences in Living, Breathing Archives

Youngoh Jung

It was the summer of 2013 when I was on a field research trip to Seoul, frantically locating and searching the archives to complete my master's thesis on the history of conscription and conscientious objection in South Korea. For a two-week period that summer, my whole family, who were all residing in Seoul at the time, were overseas for work and other family-related reasons. It had been a very long time since I was at home with just my maternal grandmother, who had raised me. One day after having lunch, she began to tell me her life story, opening out of the blue. She spoke for nearly three hours, and recalling every single word would be difficult, as her narration was filled with gaps and faded memories. But I do remember the surges of emotions—of joy and sadness and of surprise and fear. I remember how those three hours also triggered memories and emotions of my own, as they reminded me of the world of stories that my grandmother opened for me before I fell asleep as a child. Stories that were interrupted by my impatience to know "what happened next?" or questions

seeking clarifications that my adolescent mind couldn't fully understand. That summer in 2013, thinking as a historian of modern Korea, I was curious about what her life was like during the tumultuous period of Japanese colonization and the Korean War. And much like in the story times of the past, I blurted out interruptions of "what happened here?" during certain events in Korean history. And every time I asked a question, with much excitement, she promptly shared her memories.

"Independence Day?" I asked.

Korean flags covering the street.
Her marveling at how so many were made and distributed so quickly.

"Marriage?"

At age sixteen, how my much older grandfather persuaded my grandmother's father to marry her off to him.
So that she won't be taken away by the Japanese military.
The earlier years of her marriage were very difficult for her.
I can sense her emotionally engaging with her memories through silent gaps and quiet murmuring.

"War?"

The cavern below the tall mountain close to her house that her family used as a bomb shelter.

I think: the route to flee may have been cut off as Seoul fell only two days after the KPA (Korean People's Army) crossed the 38th parallel. Seoul was farther south from Gimpo, where my grandmother's family resided, which also fell to the KPA during the first couple of days of the war.

The fear she felt when a large group of KPA troops passed by her house, alleviated by a nice North Korean soldier boy who jogged up to her pleasantly to ask for directions, and seeing the KPA troops march northward.
The bomb that landed in her front yard shortly after, the silence and the ringing in her ears, the shrapnel that missed her head by inches and blew apart the rooftops.

The South Korean marines who treated her neighbors horribly, forcing them to bring food to them like they were their house servants.
Her neighbors who were taken away after the KPA retreated, never to be seen again, most likely accused as communists and suspected collaborators.
I see: the fear, silence, and hesitation as she tries hard to remember their names and faces.

When she started to talk about the war, I reached for my phone and turned on the sound-recording app, but before clicking "record," I turned off the home screen and put the phone away. My refusal to produce and claim ownership of my grandmother's memories echoes my objection to the conditions of knowledge production that silently dictate and normalize our singular identity as knowledge producers, which Naveen Minai will delve into later in this forum. Not recording my grandmother that day went against all the rules and methods I had just begun learning as a new graduate student in modern Korean history, a field that valued new, non-Western sources as currency. I was taught to begin building my archive by accumulating sources and records as if it was a bank account, and this banking of knowledge was what it took to engage in the "best" practices of historiographical writing. Such practices represent the rigorous disciplinary norms of history where in-depth archival research is paired with Western theoretical frameworks. These approaches are affixed to prominent European names that I am most definitely sick of repeating, or they are historical practices and pedagogies of the first- and second-generation dominantly White male North American historians who established the field of modern Korean history.

When it comes to intimate histories, empirical data and sources will always be insufficient in comparison to the practice of nonacademic community-based knowledge formation, which is too often dismissed as ahistorical, compromised, and unreliable. The history discipline traditionally does not accept concurrent histories of complex personhoods filled with stories of contradicting memories and emotions, of conflict and solidarities, of community building and strife, which are nonlinear and nonconforming (Baik 2019; Hartman 2007, 2019; Gordon 1997; Lowe 2015). And if they are to be deemed acceptable, the rules of the discipline require them to be supplemented by empirical data or recognized as archival

sources. The discipline of history produces knowledge by transforming memories and emotions into static artifacts that are appropriated to validate an argument or a discovered source. In the North American Korean history field, this process also reveals the racialized power dynamic where historians of Korea utilize the methodology and traditions standardized by Western scholars to claim and appropriate the voices and memories of Koreans. All the while, voices deemed nonempirical are dismissed as foreign and subjective, sidelined as non-scholarly hearsay unworthy of their placement in official archives, where objectively "real" sources can be excavated and utilized.

Nonetheless, academia continues to be invested in and keen on the extraction and exploitation of these memories and stories. I became more hesitant and uncertain about my decision especially after speaking to my thesis advisor (also a White male North American historian of modern Korea), who expressed his disappointment that I did not record my grandmother's memories. I never regretted my actions. However, choosing to listen, rather than to record, was also not a deliberate act of refusal against the academic industrial complex or the North American Korean history field's (and Asian studies in general) gendered and racialized power dynamics that policed what Korean history is (Ryang 2021). It was a spontaneous decision kindled by an emotionally instinctive rejection: something deep inside just said "no."

My impromptu action to turn off my phone led me to further grapple with my positionality as a historian and my responsibility as a grandson. I had just begun to indoctrinate myself, without much scrutiny, into the professionalized knowledge production of both history and Asian studies. The books and courses on Korean history—largely written, influenced, and taught by White male historians of Korea—demarcated my own understanding of what *is* and *is not* Korea and its history. My training automatically kicked in to measure my grandmother's story with the rubric set by the academic traditions of North American Korean history. A part of me presumed that my conversation with my grandmother would be incompatible to "utilize" as a "source" due to its personal and emotional nature. While my refusal to document her memories was the main reason I turned the recorder off, I still remained within the disciplinary parameters that considered such stories unofficial. I reassured myself that not preserving

her stories as a historical source in my growing archive was acceptable by presuming that there was no space for them. A part of me had already surrendered to the knowledge formation of what is considered "official Korean history" in the academy that made it plausible to set aside her memories. But as Crystal Baik states, "the perceived limitations placed on knowledge production or the disappointments we might feel when we are unable to access information we desire say quite a bit about scholarly presumptions that bind 'rigorous' research to the accumulation of official data" (2019, 89). At the time, I struggled to find the meaning behind what happened during those three hours, and searching for an alternative to forms of historiography beyond disciplinary traditions felt inconceivable.

These presumptions I had, concerning knowledge retrieval and the multiple conflicting tensions, were only met with more and more questions. In the process of trying to understand the depth of my experience with my grandmother, I repeatedly asked myself: in the end, who and what is this for? Referencing the work of Audra Simpson, Baik elaborates, "these presumptions, however, are also 'expansive in what they do not tell us'—and if we listen carefully enough, 'they tell us when to stop;'" she continues: "these felt tensions and refusals are not necessarily full 'stops' or 'impediments to knowing'" (2019, 89). For Baik, understanding historical knowledge formation as self-reflective and engaging in an "intentional process of 'stepping back'" in which we begin to comprehend the politics of our lack of knowledge are central components of a decolonizing praxis of ethical oral history (Baik 2019, 89; Lowe 2015). Here, "oral history" is perceived not as a verbal practice of knowledge retrieval and archival preservation but as a process of listening based on relationship and community building that decenters the colonizing praxis of excavation and ownership normalized in the history discipline.

In an ethical oral history praxis, trust, relationships, and community built between the listener and the narrator are of the utmost importance. And, how the setting and environment in which the narrator is speaking, and who they are speaking to, shape their narration. Likewise, it should shape how we approach the archives with care and recognize that the memories and stories that lie within hold so much more than simply knowledge waiting to be excavated and claimed. It asks the historian to fathom the question "What would you do when your archives talk back?"

especially when the very source of knowledge we rely on to produce work contradicts the programming of extraction and exploitation all too common in academic practices. For example, Sunny Xiang discusses Vinh Nguyen's encounter with a photograph of his mother in the government archives in which his mother's response was disbelief, as "her memory does not hold that moment" (Xiang 2019). When the historical gaps are constantly filled with what is solely legible in academia, the spaces for silent memories and murmurs are further extinguished.

Oral history practices are not without problematic research methodologies of their own. Due to their non-written form, issues surrounding emotional vulnerability, methods of preservation, and debate over agency occur frequently. Oral history is also not a "single" method but an umbrella term that encompasses a plurality of approaches and practices beyond its use as a qualitative tool that "captures" stories. It does not function as a solution to the inherently violent methodologies and research practices of the North American Korean history field, or any other academic discipline for that matter. An ethical oral history praxis is, however, highlighted by its expansiveness and flexibility, which prioritize critical listening over amassing of records. Echoing the praxis of Global Asias, it also does not necessarily align with a specific discipline, nor does it interweave any of the particular methods academic disciplines practice. It is rather a call for a reflective process of historical engagement with who or what we consider our archives to be, a praxis that turns on its head the notion that our "sources" are simply repositories of knowledge and evidence to which academics and institutions can lay claim.

Engaging in such practices opens up possibilities to reimagine the archives and other various forms of historical archives as living and breathing repositories of memories. And even when the archive no longer carries breath or life, it lives on through scholars' willingness to hold it in such regard where memories are preserved and dignified. It presents history as a multifaceted process filled with complicated and sometimes ungraspable stories as well as unexplainable encounters. It is an affirmation of histories that both contextualize the messiness of the present as well as imagine possibilities and hopes of alternative futures (Manalansan 2014). It upholds the critiques of the archives from feminist, queer, and communal perspectives, critiques that open space to ask questions like "If these are your

records, where are your memories?" (Arondekar 2009; Cvetkovich 2003; Hartman 2008; Marshall, Murphy, and Tortorici 2014, 2015). The work of queering, racializing, and gendering the archives refuses to separate the record from memories or privilege the singular "record" above the multiple memories. The praxis of ethical oral history is thus a history-making process that holds space for the memories, histories, and narratives that have been invalidated or entirely refused in the archive and the realm of professional historical discipline.

The deeply affective experience of kinship with my grandmother was an unexpected reencounter, one that I once believed was unattainable due to my physical and emotional distance from her, which was an inherent component of my diasporic identity (Baik 2019). In the moment, my body and mind instinctively reacted, refusing to render my grandmother's memories as a collectible item in the relentless pursuit of and desire for "new" knowledge. I also feared I would misinterpret or unknowingly exploit her memories, as my academic training devalued in-depth exploration of silences (as they are and not as gaps to be filled by excavated sources) and the entanglement of contradicting emotions. My grandmother's murmurs, whispers, and gaps of silences in between her stories. Her sudden reactions as if someone might be watching, and looking behind her before sharing a certain memory. Her voice reduced to whimpers, dampened by surges of emotions. How these responses were accompanied by quick smiles and laughter in recalling certain memories. Her excitement in trying to quickly answer her grandson's abrupt questions. These emotional cues said so much about her silences and what could and could not be spoken, as it was embedded in both the gendered sociocultural norms and the political power of knowledge formation throughout Korean history. For instance, when I had my late father read a short blog I had written for an online publication about my conversation with my grandmother, his only comment was, "She shouldn't have called the North Korean soldiers nice" (Jung 2015). I began to piece together how comfortable she was in sharing her stories with me when my father, as the *gajang* (master of the house), wasn't present. I connected this with her still fearful reactions of staring blankly into space and repetitively questioning "What were their names?" "What did they look like?" as she tried to remember the names and faces of her neighbors who were taken away. The norms of patriarchal and hegemonic

masculinity embedded in South Korean society along with the ideological vilification of North Korea worked hand in hand to silence her memories.

My grandmother went back to her room after our conversation, and I decided then and there to hold on to her memories. I return to them here to bring to light the importance of the tensions and contradictions I have grappled with while remembering her stories. The difficult process of recounting her words, emotions, silences, has guided me to constantly struggle with the epistemological limitations and the disciplinary norms of the academy as well as to slow down and attend to the humanity of history as stories, experience, and memories. The tensions still remain and have been exacerbated throughout the writing process, especially the contradiction of my refusal not to record yet to recall and write in depth about my grandmother's experiences. But I write with the hope that alternative spaces and communities exist and can be fostered within and beyond academia as trustworthy repositories to safeguard her stories and that value memories and dignity over the accumulation of sources. It is a space that I hope can be cultivated through the expansiveness of the Global Asias Initiative, a space committed to critical listening and alternative history-making processes and a space that engages in a praxis of care and collective reflection.

Decomposing Global Asias

Carla Nappi

For me, the question of praxis and methodology is a pandemic question. As I come to consider it, I'm conscious of coming to it from the location of a very specific moment that has been shaped by my experience of the past two years. The pandemic was a reckoning for some of us. It certainly was for me: it became impossible to assume that which I had assumed, to count on that which I had counted on. Because everything changed, now everything could change. It refocused my attention on the material conditions that made it possible for me to inhabit the spaces that cradled most of my life for what became years at a time: the bathroom, the kitchen, the bed, the dining table. Early modernity. East Asia.

There was no yeast, there was no flour; I no longer trusted that there would be toilet paper. Life was dehydrated, the cushion of habit that had protected my mental health was stripped bare; my understanding of dependence and independence was remade. This is all to say: the pandemic changed things for me. I had to relearn, from the ground up, what to do—my praxis—and how to do it—my methods, my methodologies—in order to figure out how to live by myself in my house for months that became years. And living in my house was how I lived in the texts and periods that I studied. And living by myself was how I lived in community with others: personal community or professional, disciplinary or intellectual.

But here we are. Praxis, method, methodology. And so, I locate myself in the question by locating myself here, now, and considering not only how to live with these notions but also how to work with them.

I slow things down now. I take things apart. I try to find a corner to dwell within the space of a question. I compose by decomposing. A decompositional praxis. A method of composting. A methodology driven by artful rotting.

(It may not seem self-evident that methodological approach to the global would rely on taking apart rather than bringing together, but for many of us who work in relation to something like world or global history—at the scale of the planetary or the personal—living in an era of ruins and floods, fires and mobile morgues, has brought us to a methodological concern with coming apart as a way to be together [Adelman 2017; Brand 2002; Tsing 2015]. "Many of us." Let's start with that "us.")

And so we start with "us." The pandemic changed things for me. But it also changed us: the field, the discipline, the business of academia. Specifically, it has changed—and is still changing—the kinds of "we" that might be thinkable.

Invoking a "we" is a way of making a claim: I am claiming membership in a larger collective; I am speaking on its behalf. This is one element of any scholarly methodology and it needs to be accounted for before we get to anything further. At the scale of my own person, this process has changed radically since early 2020. (Even now, I tend to stay in my own house most days. Even as the masks come off, the center of gravity of my life has not changed: I orbit my kitchen, my bathtub; I leave in order to be

able to return. And those orbits have changed my sense of a "we" on whose behalf I can make claims.) Even as I am still relearning how to feel that I can claim membership in "we's" of various sorts, that uneasiness itself feels like justification for invoking at least some sort of a shared experience of dislocation and estrangement. I bring a set of questions to the scale of scholarly work that are informed by this personal scale: Who is a "we" that I can claim access to? Is there something shared, in terms of method and methodology, that I can recommend? Dare I presume?

(Such a presumption is often the basis of the craft of the historian: speaking for, or on behalf of, the other. Even as this is critiqued as a methodological orientation, it is often still implicit in the work. It is possible to be a historian who refuses that presumption, though in doing so you may find yourself fracturing your voice into a constellation of others from which your own selves emerge, becoming many-voiced, staking out parentheses in the soil of a page so that you might dwell between them. And so, a decompositional praxis is a parenthetical praxis, and a refusal to presume that we might speak for another can seed methodology that refuses to grow into a plant, and instead asks the reader to attend to the patterns made by the seeds in the soil.)

This is a pandemic essay. I have seen inside some of your houses, seen your bedrooms and kitchens, seen your seminude partners flashing across the screen during conference panels. You have seen my cat's ass, the plant beanstalking its way toward the ceiling of my office. You have seen my belly; I have seen your desk lamp. Let's assume we've developed a kind of intimacy, you and me, over this period of shared mediation and hardship. And so I dare, and I presume. I have been in bed via the Zoom screen with some of you; you have been sipping wine via Zoom on my couch with me. Let's talk about us.

I'm trained as a historian of China with a focus on early modern natural history and medicine. I work a lot with Manchu-language texts, documents in the official language of the non-Han rulers of the Qing empire, which are sometimes welcomed into the scholarly spaces of Chinese studies and sometimes kept on the margins due to their questionable Chineseness. Sometimes Manchu studies is treated as its own thing, and sometimes Manchu studies is treated as an arm of the body of Chinese studies as an imperial or colonial history. Sometimes both. In terms of Asian

studies, this is where I'm coming from, and this is part of what I'm thinking about when I think of myself as part of a "we."

I'm not at all interested in identifying primarily with a geographical or temporal area, in my work: I used to identify as a China studies scholar, as an early modernist. This is my space, that is my time, join me here, join me there. That was early in my career. Then I began to be interested in ideas like "China" and "early modern" as actions or practices rather than nouns or adjectives: as orientations that allow us to ask particular kinds of questions in particular ways, rather than descriptors of specific space-times. (Not: Is this "early modern"? but: If we "early modern" this, what possibilities or perspectives does that open up?) Geographic and temporal areas were only interesting to me as some of many kinds of spaces in which to entertain and explore questions together. And then the pandemic changed things. Chinese and early modern texts became dislocated along with everything else, and rather than treating them as bricks in a contextual wall that helped build up a story about change over time, they were broken down into raw materials to think with, to put some hybrid of art and scholarship into the world that might help others think and make as well. (Perhaps this is what they had always been. Perhaps this is all they really can be.) I'm not concerned with the geographic or temporal focus of the work of those others. In the space of a given conversation, I may very well have more in common with a contemporary poet than with another Chinese historian.

And so when I move from an "I" to the possibility of a "we," and specifically in terms of area studies, this is where I'm coming from. The paste that held together an imagined or assumed "we" based on shared engagement with Asia, with China, has rotted away—the mortar between the bricks has eroded, the seedlings have failed to sprout—and what it has left is a handful of objects, ideas, and methods that can be seeded in the ground and grown in different ways, and which constitute different sorts of offerings depending on the person plucking the fruit. If I had to make a broader claim (which apparently I do) about this as a particular kind of methodological orientation that might be helpful to those who are also thinking about and with area studies and Asian studies in particular, it might be that, perhaps, this is a more general path forward in thinking about how we might come together in community.

While Asian studies (and its subdisciplines) can offer useful tools to think with, it has long been dominated by power dynamics at several scales that control access to the field, that limit the kind of work that can be done and supported there, and that reproduce the White supremacist capitalist structures that many of us critique in our work. (See Youngoh's brilliant piece in this volume on this phenomenon.) (This is not news. And it's certainly not limited to Asian studies, even as it manifests in a particular way in that field thanks to the cold war context in which it emerged.) Perhaps it's time for Asian studies to let itself decompose as a set of prescriptions, in order to allow recompositions (and further decompositions, and on and on) that could facilitate a kind of liberatory methodology, and that didn't depend on the kind of agonistic work that can be such a burden (in very many ways, a corrosive burden) on those of us who otherwise are pushed into orientations toward the field that are celebrated as resistance, as refusal, as disruptions: those all sound so productive and I want to celebrate them as well, but the reality of having worked in those positions for many years, for me, is that the celebration of those who resist, refuse, disrupt, tends to ignore the real toll that kind of energetic expenditure takes. We should not have to be your resister, your refuser, your disrupter. It should not fall on individuals to sacrifice their well-being to poke holes in the membrane of a dominant structure. That does not seem, to me, to be the path forward that I can support. The costs are too high. The most vulnerable are often sacrificed. I want to be able to say that I celebrate the celebration of a methodology of resistance. Having spent the first two decades of my career in Chinese history in a position of resistance, I'm not able to say that. The sacrifice of a resistance force is not the basis for a methodology. And if we didn't hold up the sanctity of scholarly field and discipline as if it would save us from the acid of the world, from what it is (and has to be) in order to be human, then we wouldn't need a methodology of resistance.

When it depends on a methodology of disobedience and rebellion in order for people to live, for them to be able to attempt to bring their full selves to the work that asks such a huge portion of their waking lives, when we accept and celebrate that as part of an institution, we're often asking the most vulnerable members of a system to offer themselves up for a kind of energetic slaughter. I can't support that. And so.

Let it rot.

Let it burn.

Indeed, disciplinary area studies is coming apart without our help. The pandemic has perhaps accelerated this, as part of a broader decomposition of our senses of space and time. Rather than expending energy trying to put it back together, what if we dwelt with the soil and the ashes?

Part of what we have been learning in the pandemic is how to attend to the detritus, how to release the illusion of control on many scales. We are learning to invite wildness in, to trust and hope that we can probably move forward from the failures, and to understand that we might not. (I'm talking about sourdough starter, but I'm not only talking about sourdough starter.) (I never made a sourdough starter, incidentally.)

The pre-pandemic scholarly methodologies of Asian studies were largely rooted in a prevailing ableism. We expected that colleagues would fly all over the world to talk at each other for fifteen minutes at a time and would go into debt in order to do so. We expected and demanded that colleagues physically relocate themselves in different countries and time zones for months or years at a time in order to prove their worthiness as experts of their area, even at the expense of their mental, physical, or communal health. (The fact that scholars of Asia are physically so widely dispersed is still, incidentally, a problem for the forging of Zoom-era community: Asian studies has not solved the time-zone problem.)

Pre-pandemic Asian studies was also rooted in a logic of scarcity. (This is shared across academia, I expect.) Work was based on a sense of not-enoughness: of time, of sources, of evidence, and so the ways in which we do what we do—the ways in which we attempt to create knowledge or access to it; this is the epistemology group, after all—are shaped by an ethos of scarcity.

This doesn't work, now. (It never did, but the cracks are now visible.) We are all working under conditions of massively heavy workloads. We are—I am—exhausted. (Ah, here is a "we.") Our bodies and souls are being crushed under a burden that includes pedagogical caregiving responsibilities that acknowledge that our students are suffering as well. There is simultaneously a too-muchness and a not-enough-ness. What kind of knowledge can emerge from these kinds of conditions? What kind of methodology does it shape? (How does it shape attempts to work with other methodologies?)

What I'm calling for, then, is a methodology that is shaped by the pandemic experience: a methodology of decomposition, of enoughness, of witnessing what one is in a position to witness. This is a methodology that depends on being self-conscious about your own positionality relative to what you're studying, and understanding that you can only move from, and within, that place. And saying what you have to say. And trusting that it's enough. And if it's not enough, accepting that and moving on. Witnessing, and sharing what you've witnessed, and entering into relation with those who are generously attending to that work. Rather than always growing something, it is a methodology of the fallow field, of patience in attending to the seeds that fail to grow, of the wild ferment that homes a fetid mold that you didn't invite into the jar. That's all we can do, and it's an exceptionally modest goal, and it's everything.

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Pedagogy Forum

Inspired by thinkers such as Paulo Freire and M. Jacqui Alexander, our pedagogy forum offers an invitation to rethink the ethical and epistemic frameworks that underpin our pedagogical practices, including bibliography, syllabus, and classroom climate and ethos. We provide modules based on keywords as conceptual tools that open spaces for Global Asias as praxis for teaching and learning.

Pedagogies of Rebellion

Junyoung Verónica Kim and Naveen Minai

We align with scholar-activists who envision pedagogy as an anti-racist and anti-colonial praxis in which teaching and learning enable movements against and beyond boundaries of nation/region, gender/sexuality, race/ethnicity, class, and ableism. We believe that the classroom—in whichever form—remains the most promising space of possibility in the academy. Urging us to suspect and unlearn the parameters of what constitutes "knowledge," we pose "epistemology" not as a given set of indicators or accepted content, but as a question that moves us to seek liberation from our present infrastructures of knowledge. As such, our pedagogical contribution to "epistemology" will take the form of a syllabus, which pivots on Global Asias as an epistemic anchor. We use this anchor to explore multiple intersecting thematics in our modules. We have identified method and methodology as our focal points. What does it mean to know? How do we know? Where do we know (from)? What does it mean to theorize from the flesh (Moraga and Anzaldúa 1981)? We take up knowledge as the politics of desire, the question of language and biopolitics.

The modules will thus mobilize the following terms as methodology. We use these keywords as provocations of method that foreground the material conditions under which knowledge is produced, acknowledged, and legitimated. Our modules are:

- Diaspora as method
- Infrastructures as method

- Queer/ing as method
- Intimacies as method
- Critical listening as method
- Asia–Latin America as method
- Translation as method

By critically juxtaposing unlikely terms, we speculate on the undisciplined possibilities of taking up Global Asias as praxis. Each module is composed of framing questions, audiovisual texts, and readings. The framing questions guide the reader on how to approach each of these concepts as methodological tools (how to know), rather than objects of study (what to know). We deliberately include audiovisual texts to problematize the normalization and legitimization of knowledge formation. First, the question of genre and media provokes an interrogation of the hierarchies that shape what constitutes epistemology by highlighting the relationship between form and knowledge making. Second, cultural texts cannot be contained within disciplinary logics and transgress fixed frames of interpretation, which include the affective and the sensuous that exceed grammars of knowledge. Audiovisual texts allow us to access different ways of knowing that are often delegitimized, such as feeling, touch, sensation, and memory. As is the case with the readings, the selected audiovisual texts offer a partial and incomplete invitation to expand each module as a framework.

We have deliberately organized the readings to interrogate and challenge normative classifications and institutional standardizations. First, we do not divide the readings into primary and secondary texts. This division inescapably hierarchizes knowledge, relegating certain forms of experience and articulation as supplementary and ornamental. Second, we resist the division between theory and literature in pedagogical practice. This division perpetuates geocultural sedimentations of knowledge: most often Western theory is posited as universal, while theory from marginalized communities (e.g., Global South, women of color, queer and trans people of color, Indigenous peoples) is dismissed as particular. Within the study of literature, the binary logic of universal/particular manifests as the practice of canonization, which continues to dominate through the vectors of area (regions, countries, languages) and race/gender. Third, to undo geocultural sedimentations of knowledge, we have tried not to prioritize

certain locations and regions over others by juxtaposing readings from/about/on South Asia, West Asia, Southeast Asia, East Asia, Central Asia, and multiple routes of Asian diasporas. Global Asias as pedagogical praxis compels us to question and rethink definitions of location and region, as well as the boundaries of Asia/n. Fourth, continuing our challenge to institutionalized epistemologies, we combine different forms of writing that are often categorized and hierarchized: poetry, prose, oral testimonies, novels, newspaper articles, academic monographs, and anthologies. Lastly, our pedagogical materials adopt a transdisciplinary vision that puts into contact different knowledge formations: history, literature, ethnic studies, anthropology, cinema studies, sociology, gender and sexuality studies, queer of color critique, area studies, and so on.

We urge the reader to read these texts together, side by side, in relation.

The following is a gathering of provocations about knowledge, disciplinarity, and institutions of learning.

Suggestions for Further Reading

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Module 1: Diaspora as Method

Naveen Minai

This module focuses on "diaspora" as a keyword that expands our understanding of the global processes of migration and im/mobility as forms of border making and state making. Diaspora as analytic lens provides ways to think about home, land, route, and belonging in capacious and complex ways.

Framing Questions

- How and what do you understand by the term "diaspora"? How do we mobilize diaspora as an analytic rather than as a fixed identity?
- How is diaspora deployed to critique and challenge the boundedness of the nation-state, while at the same time reifying and reaffirming the nation?
- Which destinations and routes are most often counted in imaginings of (Asian) diaspora(s) and which ones are not? (For example, the Afghan diaspora in Pakistan or the Korean diaspora in Latin America are very rarely acknowledged, while Asian North American diasporas are understood as paradigmatic of Asian diaspora.)
- What are the global processes of war, empire, labor, and capital that produce and anchor different Asian diasporas?
- How do we mobilize ocean, island, and archipelago as analytics for thinking about Asian diaspora?

- How do the politics of transit and arrival shape our understanding of Asian diasporas and the ways in which we categorize certain groups (e.g., Chinese diaspora, Indian diaspora, etc.)?
- How do we think about indigeneity and diaspora as relational and co-constitutive rather than as oppositional?
- How do the material conditions of forced displacement and dispossession, as well as slow violence (including climate change and debility)—subtended by racial capitalism and neocolonialism—shape the relations and processes of forced/voluntary mobility and immobility?
- How do notions of patriarchal heteronormative reproduction, as imagined in ideas of kinship, lineage, and belonging, function in dominant conceptualizations of diaspora studies?
- What are the ways in which sexuality is integral to notions and processes of citizenship, nation, state, land, diaspora, home?
- What are the economies of feeling (e.g., nostalgia, loss, gratitude, attachment) that structure our understanding of diaspora(s)?
- How does diaspora question the territorialization of languages by suspecting the linguistic borders of nations?

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Module 2: Infrastructures as Method

Junyoung Verónica Kim

This module focuses on "infrastructures" as a keyword that expands our understanding of the relations between technology, space, and networks, especially those that are transregional and transoceanic. Infrastructures as analytic lens offers ways to rethink histories of empire, racial capitalism, and the nation-state.

Framing Questions

- How do we understand infrastructure as an assemblage of technology, space, form, and networks?
- How do we understand infrastructure as not bound to national borders and jurisdictions but, rather, as transnational, transoceanic, and trans-local?
- How is infrastructure anchored in histories, materialities, and regimes of empire and global capitalism?
- What are the relationalities between infrastructures and lived experiences of migration, labor, displacement, and dispossession?
- How are spatiality and temporality (the experiences of space and time) produced and regulated by infrastructures?
- How are infrastructures and their effects in everyday lives normalized and invisibilized by a capitalist grammar that highlights the benevolence of development, progress, and value?
- How are discourses and practices of infrastructure related to slow violence, extractivism, and ecological destruction?

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Module 3: Queer/ing as Method

Naveen Minai

This module focuses on "queer/ing" as a keyword that expands our understanding of sexual politics as that which underpins processes of state building, nationalism, and geopolitical and capitalist infrastructures. Queer/ing as analytic lens offers ways to reimagine community, diaspora, and kinship.

Framing Questions

- How do we mobilize queer as an epistemological analytic and methodology rather than as an ontological category?
- How does queering as method challenge how/when/where we imagine queerness?
- How is queer a matter of racial capital, settler colonialism, and empire?
- How do queer of color critique and queer diaspora studies challenge dominant significations of body (race, gender, disability), space (nation, family), and time (history, lineage)?
- How does queering attend to the dynamic, complex, and structuring dimensions of desire in which desire functions not only as an individual feeling but as a geopolitical force that legitimates empire (e.g., the White man's burden, White man saving brown women from brown men, White savior, homonationalism)?
- How does queering as methodology call our attention to the sexual politics that underpin the formation and dissemination of area studies and its afterlives?

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Module 4: Intimacies as Method

Junyoung Verónica Kim

This module focuses on "intimacies" as a keyword that allows us to grapple with the multi-scalar dimensions of structures of power (e.g., imperialism, settler colonialism, racial capitalism) in the everyday. Intimacy as analytic lens provides a transdisciplinary inquiry into the connections between the body and the nation, the quotidian and the historical, the biopolitical and the geopolitical.

Framing Questions

- How do we mobilize intimacy as an analytic?
- How is intimacy produced as the property of White bourgeois heteronormative private domain by geopolitical currents of racial capitalism, settler colonialism, and imperialism?
- How are certain intimacies hyper-visibilized (e.g., heteronormative romance, White bourgeoisie family), while others are hyper-disciplined and/or obfuscated (e.g., queer cruising, sex work, interracial relationships)?
- What does it mean to conceptualize intimacy as the connections between what are posited as separate historical processes that are denied coevalness, such as settler colonialism, Transatlantic slavery, Transpacific indenture, and empire?
- What are the relations between intimacy as a register of the personal and everyday and intimacy as a register of the epistemic, the archival, and the geopolitical?
- What are the implications of acknowledging the multi-scalar dimensions of intimacy?
- How is intimacy an assemblage of race-sexuality-gender-class?

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Module 5: Critical Listening as Method

Youngoh Jung

In the following module, we provide materials for engaging in ethical oral history and empathetic listening practices within a classroom setting. These include framing questions to stimulate discussions about issues about ethics, legitimacy, and agency in approaching traditional and nontraditional sources.

Framing Questions

- How does conventional historiography determine and normalize whom to listen to and what to listen for when we approach alternative historical practices and non-written, aural methods?
- How can we listen and account for the silences and gaps that exist between continents, oceans, histories, cultures, that denote what is Asia from both the global and local context?
- How do entrenched norms of race and gender impact what is / is not "history" and which method is / is not "professional" from an academic context?
- What happens when memory becomes commodified as legible history through academic processes of knowledge production retained in institutional repositories?
- How do we understand archival silences not as a form of absence, but as presences that challenge and unsettle institutional knowledge formation?

- How do silences, whispers, and murmurs disturb dominant definitions of evidence across different disciplines and fields?
- What are the politics and ethics of listening as a research methodology? What does critical listening demand of us as scholars, teachers, and students?

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Module 6: Asia–Latin America as Method

Junyoung Verónica Kim

This module focuses on Asia–Latin America as an analytic that expands our understanding of Global Asias by bringing to light the complex relationalities between Asia/n and Latin America/n. Asia–Latin America as method challenges the politics of knowledge and disciplinary boundaries and opens space for rethinking epistemic routes and sites.

Framing Questions

- How does the study of "Asia" or "Latin America" relate to the study of the "Asian" migrant in Latin America or the Latin American of "Asian" descent?

- What are the connections between the creation of racialized humanity and the construction of *area* (as a target of military intervention, capitalist extractivism, humanitarian initiatives, and academic study)?
- What are the ways in which racial formation as a global system interconnect with operations of capitalism, as evidenced by theories of not only racial capitalism but also extractivism, neoliberalism, and ecological exploitation?
- How can Transpacific perspectives accountable to Asian / Latin American contexts unsettle the bifurcation between area and ethnic studies as disciplines that have struggled to move away from focusing on US contexts to inform mis/understandings about racism?
- How can decentering English as the language of knowledge, discipline, and communication undo (or redo) hegemonic currencies / infrastructures / circuits / ecologies of knowledge?
- What kind of collegialities and collaborative practices can we build through Asian Latin American perspectives?

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Module 7: Translation as Method

Carla Nappi

In the following section, we provide materials for engaging translation as method and practice into course syllabi. These include some orienting

questions and materials that are intended to help open up discussion and activities in class, with an eye to treating the category of "translation" creatively and capaciously.

Framing Questions

- What does it mean to claim that something is untranslatable? What possibilities does that offer or foreclose? What are the consequences?
- How might we think of translation as a machine for producing equivalence or the illusion thereof, what are the consequences of asserting that words, concepts, or objects are the "same" across languages, and what silences or power inequities does that produce?
- When one kind of language practice is translated or disciplined into the grammatical structure of another, what kind of knowledge is made equivalent, and what resists such disciplining? (How is that process of the production of sameness ultimately an imperial process?) How does learning to speak in a language, and thus learning to perform as a particular kind of social being, help produce a kind of sameness of bodies in their utterances and movements?
- Consider how a history of translation is also a history of selfhood and its metamorphoses: how are naming and the translation of names important epistemological gestures?
- What relationships to (the idea of) an/the "original" does translation work assume or produce? What are the consequences of that gesture toward "original" or "origin" for how historical or genealogical knowledge is produced, understood, or silenced?
- What kinds of relationships does translation produce, what is our language for understanding those relationships, and what might grow out of that understanding?
- How is translation a form of disciplining of knowledge? You might find it helpful to consider, here, the relationships of translation to the notion of a "standard" linguistic practice, or to a "correct" way of speaking.
- How does learning a language entail learning how to be a different kind of social being? What kinds of institutions and technologies—

textbooks, examinations and other pedagogical tools, dictionaries, and so forth—shape/determine that process? How might we read those instruments against the grain as an archive of the production and circulation of power, empire, family, and more?

- In what ways can we think of a language as an object that makes a particular kind of knowledge making possible: a map of space and time, a structure in which to dwell, an instrument of imperial power, an extension of one's body and flesh?

Audiovisual Texts

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Sample Attention Exercises

- Sit with a text from a language that is illegible to you. Translate it into a language in which you most comfortably dwell.
- Sit with one sentence from a text in a language you're comfortable working with. Imagine a possible audience for a translation of that sentence, and then translate it into another language that you're comfortable working with. Then put that translation to the side, reorient, imagine a very different audience, and translate the same sentence once again for that new audience. Do this until you have at least three translations of the same sentence into the same language, for at least three different audiences. What kinds of work does each translation do? What do you understand about the source text in comparing these multiple translations that you might not have understood otherwise?

Conclusion

Junyoung Verónica Kim, Naveen Minai, and Youngoh Jung

Global Asias as project, as praxis, as space, and as community problematizes the underlying rules that govern the definition of knowledge. Indeed, Global Asias centers the question of epistemology and epistemic violence. By defying disciplinary silos, putting into dialogue area studies and ethnic studies, and gathering scholars and students from multiple institutions, locations, and fields, Global Asias troubles the normative constructions of knowledge.

Moreover, the work of Global Asias calls for an intimate and collective labor: the quotidian practices of emailing, scheduling, rescheduling, thinking out loud, exchanging feedback, reading together, writing together, and being present together. Our contribution is made possible by this labor of collaboration.

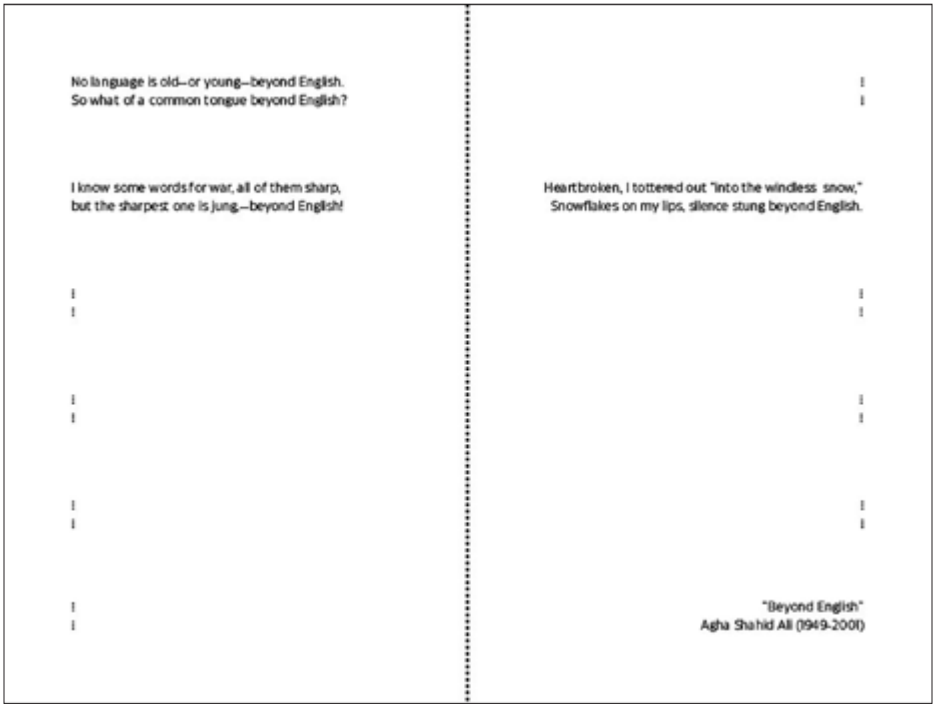
Relationship, trust, community, love. These are not the words we usually think about when we ponder academic spaces and labor. Yet it is precisely the relationships we have built with one another through Global Asias that have allowed us to imagine differently. We have used our essays to ask questions that we hope will act as open invitations, rather than to provide prescriptions based on sedimented economies of knowledge. Indeed, our pieces are more exercises in speculation than a blueprint for institutional revitalization. Our pedagogical modules urge teachers and students to think of the classroom (whether online or offline) as a space to expand, experiment, imagine, and create other forms, pathways, and methods of knowing. By not being restricted by discipline, field, and form, our transdisciplinary syllabi call for a pedagogy of crossing (Alexander 2005).

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Interleaf—"Beyond English"



No language is old—or young—beyond English.
So what of a common tongue beyond English?

I know some words for war, all of them sharp,
but the sharpest one is Jung.—beyond English!

Heartbroken, I tottered out "into the windless snow,"
Snowflakes on my lips, silence stung beyond English.

"Beyond English"
Agha Shahid Ali (1949-2001)

Jerry Won Lee, "Beyond English." Copyright © 2003 by Agha Shahid Ali Literary Trust, from *The Veiled Suite: The Collected Poems* by Agha Shahid Ali.

CONVERGENCE 4

Language

Out of English

Fiona Lee, Jerry Won Lee, and
Andrew Way Leong

Research Forum

In a reading of Agha Shahid Ali's (2002) ghazal "Beyond English," Aamir Mufti (2016) writes, "There are entire worlds to be discovered 'beyond English,' not in some geographically distinct and distant place but right next to you, wherever you happen to be, and even in your own (English) speech itself. Thus, if the attempt to look, think, or feel 'beyond English' involves a sort of warfare, that is, an effort that implies a certain arrangement of force, it is also, by the same token, already a matter of *love,* that is, *a suspension of force* in the very midst of a force field" (199; emphasis in original). We believe that looking, thinking, and feeling "beyond English" can serve as a "suspension of force," and as such is one of the "variants of suspension" that Tina Chen and Charlotte Eubanks identify in the introduction.

A ghazal is a poetic form with origins in seventh-century Arabic poetry that has since been taken up in other languages and literary traditions. The ghazal relies on couplets that end with an identical word or phrase (the *radif*) preceded by the couplet's rhyming word (the *qafia*). In the interleaved poem, the *radif* is "beyond English" and the *qafia* is "young/tongue," as in "No language is old—or young—beyond English" and "So what of a common tongue beyond English?"

Thinking "beyond English" is imperative because Global Asias comprises a multitude of languages. Yet, as this volume illustrates, in practice, the academic dialogues that Global Asias facilitates among Asian American studies, Asian diaspora studies, and Asian studies tend to occur overwhelmingly in English. The reliance on English reflects the fact that this volume is produced within US institutions by scholars either trained in or working in the US academy, or both, though it is worth noting that English is also a medium of scholarly knowledge production and intellectual exchange in Asia about Asia. Given that English is not a transparent or neutral information carrier, the essays in this convergence explore the materiality and power of the language's intermediary function in shaping knowledge infrastructures. It does so by imagining a Global Asias not only "beyond English" but, as each of the ghazal-inspired titles of our individual contributions below suggest, "out of English."

We use the phrase "out of English" in place of Agha Shahid Ali's "beyond English" to emphasize the struggle of speaking and writing *out*

of one's place while *in* one's place—a place that, for all three of us, happens to include being professionally employed by departments of English. In the militarized jargon of multinational corporations, the three of us might all be described as being "based in English." In general terms, the English departments we work in, and our pathways to working there, are all broadly similar. We all work in large public research universities—two of us in the University of California system (Jerry Lee and Andrew Way Leong) and one of us at the University of Malaya (Fiona Lee). We also received our graduate training through large public research universities: in English at the University of Arizona (Jerry) and the City University of New York Graduate Center (Fiona), and in comparative literature at the University of California, Berkeley (Andrew).

Despite these general similarities, these specific institutional histories and locations, as well as our own paths toward, within, and beyond them, are quite diverse. These differences inform our distinct approaches in this research forum and the following pedagogy forum. Jerry Lee works at the University of California, Irvine, a campus established in 1965, which, as of 2020, counts "Asian" students, at 37 percent of the student body, as its largest racial/ethnic demographic group. Lee's research forum essay and pedagogical materials emerge from his work as a founding codirector of the UC Irvine Global Asias multidisciplinary research cluster and his continued engagement with the discipline of sociolinguistics. Fiona Lee works at the University of Malaya, an institution formed through a merger of two British colonial colleges in 1949 and chartered as a national university in 1962. Her research forum essay considers, in part, the key roles that members of the University of Malaya English department played in the history of Malaysian literature in English at a moment when Malay ethnolinguistic nationalists were agitating for curbing the influence of the former imperial language in national institutions. Andrew Way Leong works at the University of California, Berkeley, an institution established in 1868 as the state's first land-grant university. The vexed history of the formation of the Asian (American) Studies program at Berkeley during the late 1960s and 1970s, and the professional academic field's subsequent drift toward the superficial generalizations of (English-language) social theory in lieu of deeper engagement with specific community languages, forms the backdrop for both of Leong's contributions.

Our home departments are English departments, but all three of us are multilingual Global Asias scholars who spend a significant amount of our time "out of English," working in and with other languages, disciplines, and communities. English departments are usually situated outside of Asian studies, even as there can be considerable overlaps. For example, comparative literature scholars working in Asian languages usually locate their work within Asian studies, but scholars working in Asian American, Asian diasporic, and postcolonial literatures tend to be housed in English. While an all-English team can hardly do justice to addressing the linguistic diversity of Global Asias, we highlight these disciplinary configurations, expectations, and occlusions to reflect on how English shapes the politics of knowledge production. Put differently, "out of English" captures a generative tension of what it means to work toward going "beyond English" while working "in English."

The duality inherent to the ghazal as a poetic form is an appropriate point of entry to understand the contradictory positionalities that each of us must negotiate, navigate, and (eventually) reconcile as three scholars committed to projects "out of English" but simultaneously positioned, institutionally, within English departments. After all, Ali's phrasing of "beyond English" captures the Anglocentrism that Global Asias might aspire to overcome even if it is simultaneously circumscribed by it. We do not mean to re-rehearse a call for the "abolition" of the English department proposed by Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o alongside Taban Lo Liyong and Henry Owuor-Anyumba (1973). Rather, we work with the tension between English's capacious institutional reach in encompassing different fields, such as sociolinguistics (Jerry Lee), Malaysian literature (Fiona Lee), and Asian American literature in Asian languages (Andrew Way Leong), and the discipline's inadequacy in coming to grips with the density of these fields' multilingual environments.

We collectively believe that a *space out of English* might be achieved, as Jerry Won Lee suggests, if we reconsider "language" as such in Global Asias inquiry. Further, as Fiona Lee urges, we need to attend more rigorously to processes of racialization and deracination that occur in relation to English so that we might disrupt the race for English and pursue a *race out of English.* Finally, Andrew Way Leong challenges us to imagine a *place out of English,* pointing to the buried promise of community languages as a

possible path forward. Our collective contributions, which are at times experimental inquiries that leave more questions than answers, present—we hope—a "suspension of force": a *love* that recognizes the struggles within English, but also shows us what might "come out" of English.

Language as Such in Global Asias Inquiry
Searching for a Space out of English

Jerry Won Lee

It is hopefully not controversial to say that translation, and particularly translation into English, is the lifeblood of Global Asias inquiry. I do not say this to incite provocation. Consider, though, for a moment that the same cannot be said of Asian studies, as there is a large body of scholarship being produced by scholars in Asia in Asian languages. The same also cannot be said of Asian American studies, in which there is an abundance of inquiry into artifacts of literary and cultural production that are exclusively in English. This is, of course, not to suggest that scholars have not attempted to multilingualize Asian American studies research. Yong Chen (2002) has argued, using the case of pre–World War II Chinese American history, for the importance of accounting for non-English sources. Chen writes, "To put it bluntly, there are aspects of the Chinese American experience that white Americans were unable or unwilling to see; and Chinese and whites did not see and document in the same light the material environments they shared physically" (244). However, what is also undeniable is that given that dominant ideology in the United States has constructed the Asian as chronically foreign for reasons up to and including language, it is not surprising to see a pattern of aspirations to "native" or "native-like" proficiency in English by Asian Americans, almost inevitably in tandem with the neglect if not outright rejection of their respective heritage languages. Finally, returning to the dependency of Global Asias on English, it needs to be noted that, unlike analogous Asia-oriented intellectual movements such as Inter-Asia cultural studies, Global Asias is still comparatively a US-oriented and thus, by default, an English-dominant intellectual paradigm. Is, however, the centrality of English an inevitability in Global Asias? This contribution attempts to search for a space out of English for

Global Asias inquiry. To do so, it explores the implications of the metalinguistic label of "English," along with the very notion of what constitutes "language" to begin with, particularly in relation to the complexities of "English" and "language" vis-à-vis Asia across global space.

The possibility of Global Asias inquiry being pursued via the vantage point of language is figured prominently in Naoki Sakai's (1997) *Translation and Subjectivity*. Translation is generally conceived of as the practice of representing a text from one language into another. From this perspective, languages and their respective cultural vantage points are presumed to be fixed. Using the case of Japan, both as a language and as an ethnic national culture, Sakai argues that the category is rather an entailment of translation. He shows, for instance, how Japanese intellectuals have imagined the idea of "Japanese thought" from the outset as a "comparative investigation, in relation to that of China, India, and the so-called 'West'" (50). The heuristic of language is foundational to Rey Chow's (2014) *Not Like a Native Speaker,* which is a sustained critique of the normative trope of the so-called native speaker. In the Hong Kong context, where much of Chow's inquiry is focused, the question of language and derivative considerations of who qualifies as a native speaker cannot be understood without attending to an inherently multilingual ecology shaped by its histories of British colonial occupation and its relation to mainland China, whose state ideology promotes the use of a simplified script and spoken Mandarin that is not mutually intelligible to Cantonese. Chow recalls listening to plays broadcast on Hong Kong radio during her childhood featuring the "lingual problems of Chinese populations in the diaspora" who "struggl[ed] with the Hong Kong Cantonese language in all earnestness, these characters often provok[ing] laughter with the hilarious misunderstandings they caused" (109).

Finally, it would be difficult to ignore the impact of COVID-19 on language and communication in general. It is fair to assume that not many people knew what a "KN-95" referred to pre-2020, that likely nobody knew what "social distancing" meant, and now we all forever have to specify whether the meeting is "in person" or "over Zoom." But one must also acknowledge the direct impact on language and communication in relation to Global Asias in particular. COVID-19, for better or worse, put Wuhan on the proverbial map, and the city will forever have a "global"

reputation. Particularly in the early months of the pandemic, in late 2019 and early 2020, laypersons, pundits, and even political leaders referred to the coronavirus as the "Wuhan virus," the "China virus," and the "kung flu." Anti-Asian sentiment and violence became a global phenomenon, a direct result, no doubt, of the anti-Asian language around COVID-19, serving as an important reminder of the necessity of centering questions of language in not only COVID-19 intellectual inquiry but Global Asias inquiry more generally.

Consider, for instance, the trope of the inscrutable Oriental, which serves as a useful reminder for how language has always figured heavily in the imagination of the global Asian subject across time and space. The figure of the inscrutable Oriental, as described by Homi K. Bhabha (1994), is not merely a problematic discursive formation premised on maligning and subordinating the Oriental subject but one that, critically, must be repeated, "told (compulsively) again and afresh" (111). In the sense that anything that demands repetition is inherently suspect, the need to insist on a stratified differentiation from the Oriental subject exposes, as Bhabha puts it, "the ambivalence of colonial discourse" and "disrupts its authority" (126). The inscrutable Oriental is the epitome not only of the historical dehumanization of the Asian subject but also of the materialization of the use value of the Asian subject in the context of the global accumulation of capital: the coolie, in particular, sustained and prolonged the dominance of the British Empire well into the nineteenth century and therefore has the dubious distinction of being a "global" figure. The case of the inscrutable Oriental is invariably a question of language because it is the fact that the subject speaks a language that is unintelligible not to itself but specifically to the Western "listening subject" (Flores and Rosa 2015). It is only from the vantage point of the Western listening subject, who is presumed to establish the normative criteria for interlocution, that the Oriental can be rendered as inscrutable in the first place. The early encounter and thus construction of the global Asian subject, at least from the vantage point of Western modernity, was in this regard invariably a matter of language.

Another important reason for bringing up the figure of the inscrutable Oriental is to note that the inscrutability of the global Asian subject has not only been a matter of language or how the subject sounded: in the case of the coolie, it also indexed the ways in which the coolie's look, dress,

and behavior were used to discursively imagine the coolie as an inscrutable subject. In other words, language cannot be reduced to the purely "linguistic" but needs to be understood in the context of broader regimes of signification, including the multimodal, multi-semiotic, and multisensory. Returning briefly to Chow's (2014) work, the usage of "tone" in a way that "deliberately conflat[es] the visual and audial significations" of the term is intriguing (8).[1] Chow argues that such a usage "underscores the irreducibility of language as a phenomenological actor, one whose ways of revealing what is at stake can be quite surprising and spot-on" (8). What is additionally compelling about this usage of tone is that in the conflation of two modalities of language that are conventionally treated as different if not at times oppositional (why call it A/V, after all, if the audio and the visual are one and the same?), we are able to call into question the very category of language itself. In other words, if a given language might be conceived of as a discrete entity on the basis of its visual and audial differences from another language, one can't help but wonder what happens to the given language's presumed transposability (Gramling 2016) at the moment its sublingual modalities are rendered ineffectual.

If one considers the realities of the globalization of English in Asia, perhaps the conventional cognitive and geopolitical cartographies of language are worth revisiting (e.g., English as a dominant language in the United States, Asian languages in Asia). English has an undeniably hegemonic legacy in the region: the direct result of British colonialism and post–World War II US cultural imperialism. Its legacy is uneven, particularly with respect to the fact that in some nations English remains an official language (e.g., Hong Kong, India, and the Philippines) as a result of colonial-era language policy and planning measures. Surely, the English that is used in different regions of Asia is quite different from the ostensibly normative varieties associated with the "native speaker." This is not to mark them here as different and thereby "deficient." Indeed, from a purely descriptivist view, the usage of English at a given moment in time is reflective of a complicated series of developments starting with its foundation, toward its nativization and eventually internal diversification (Schneider 2007).[2] Given these realities, there is something of a consensus among researchers of World Englishes that local varieties of English in

regions such as Asia should be regarded not as the result of "lingual problems," to borrow Chow's expression, but as legitimate varieties in their own right. The late Braj B. Kachru (2005), for instance, the founding father of the intellectual paradigm of World Englishes, noted the important distinction between the expressions English as a language "in" Asia and English as a language "of" Asia, the former of which implies that the language simply exists in the region whereas the latter suggests ownership of English by Asians (3). Others have delineated a distinction between the semantic implications of the nominal versus the adverbial in labeling Asian varieties of English. It has been argued, for instance, that "Korea English," rather than "Korean English," be used to refer to usage for inter- and intranational communication purposes (Park 2009). Analogously, scholars have insisted on a differentiation between "China English" and "Chinese English," and of course, "Chinglish" (Cui 2006; Kirkpatrick and Xu 2002; Qiong 2004; Yang 2005). Even more compellingly, scholars have called for a reappropriation of "Chinglish," which has historically been used to denigrate the spoken English by Chinese if not Asians more generally, in order to acknowledge its wide range of pragmatic functions across intercultural communicative contexts (Heng Hartse 2014; Fang 2008; Li 2016; Xu and Detering 2017). One might hear in these developments echoes of the sentiments of the great Chinua Achebe (1975), who declared that even if English was at one point an imperial imposition in Nigeria, it was his language now and he intended to use it to empower himself and his community.

To return to the case of Global Asias and the fraught question of English/es in relation to Global Asias, perhaps we are at a moment when it is necessary to think beyond language "as such." What I mean by this is that debates about "English" all too often, and perhaps naturally, operate in the realm of the linguistic, though attending to the realities of everyday communication in the world of Global Asias might invite alternative ways of reconceptualizing our initial questions and concerns. Consider, for instance, Li Wei's (2011) study of Chinese youth in Britain, who produce spaces of communication among friends that are conducive to the fluid movement between Chinese and English. Importantly, such language practices do not occur in a vacuum, and interlocutors need to strategically

create spaces for such languaging to happen—in other words, it is just as much a matter of space as it is one of language. Similarly, Alastair Pennycook and Emi Otsuji's (2015) ethnography of marketplaces in multilingual immigrant regions of Tokyo demonstrates how interlocutors manage communication in diverse contexts while negotiating multiple languages. Critically, they find that many participants in such environments do not conceptualize languages according to quantifiable codes, with some even noting that they have lost count of how many "languages" they typically draw on. Even more crucially, their work shows how seemingly insignificant inanimate objects or even the spatial background elements (such as the layout of tables and chairs in a restaurant) play an important role in communication in globalizing contexts. Communication in Global Asias, in other words, has to do with so much more than just language "as such."

In summary, without dismissing the significant intellectual developments around language in the context of Global Asias, it would be productive, moving forward, to also focus our attention on questions beyond those of language "as such." This is not a call to outright dismiss questions of "language," although I would argue that Global Asias inquiry that is centered on or even attentive to the question of language would do well to reconsider what the regime of language is or is not in the first place. Certainly, there is still considerable work to be done to reimagine the binary of "English" versus "not English," a dichotomous line of reasoning that neglects the plurilithic realities of Englishes and one upon which the global Asian subject is imagined as linguistically inferior. In fact, even among users of Asian Englishes, there continue to be stratifications along geopolitical lines and even within local contexts, as the work of Ruanni Tupas (2015) reminds us. This is thus not a proposal for an either-or but rather a both-and: being mindful of language but also mindful of what is or is not language. Such considerations are not only important for Global Asias inquiry. Indeed, I would also argue that Global Asias inquiry is optimally positioned to answer the many important and also complicated questions about "language" and the shifting meanings of "language" into the twenty-first century.

Malaysian Literature in English, Global Anglophone Literature?
Imagining (a) Race out of English

Fiona Lee

Race:

1. *a competition; a situation in which individuals or groups compete to be first to achieve a particular objective*

The globalized nature of academic knowledge production today has resulted in what might be called the race for English. Scholarship written in English, particularly in the Global North, has a more dominant influence compared to knowledge produced in other languages, even in research fields that require fluency in multiple tongues. For example, Tharaphi Than (2021) notes that "for academics in Myanmar [doing research on Myanmar], 'arriving and making it in the academy' means learning the language of the West: acquiring linguistic skills and finding how their own research 'objects' are written in the Western canon." Similarly, Fan-sen Wang observes that the institutional drive for "global competitiveness" in Taiwan's academic humanities has incentivized scholars to write less in Chinese for local audiences in favor of publishing in internationally indexed English academic journals that "pander to the interests of the Anglo-American academy" (2017, 179).

In the discipline of English literature, English is not only a medium of scholarly communication; the language's aesthetic and cultural uses are also its object of analysis. This essay argues that the discipline's built-in self-reflexivity about how language makes meaning can benefit from a Global Asias praxis of examining the relationship between area, race/ethnicity, and diasporic studies. Specifically, I show how the evolving social, cultural significance of English itself, which can change according to when, where, how, and by whom it is being used, has shaped the knowledge hierarchies that inform and are informed by the analytical categories of area, race/ethnicity, and diaspora. To elucidate, I consider the place of Malaysian literature in English within the newly emergent field of Global Anglophone literature. The qualifier, "in English," not only underscores the diversity of languages that Malaysian literature encompasses (e.g., Malay, Iban,

Kadazandusun, Chinese, Tamil, Telegu, and so on); it can also serve as a metonym for the contentious debates about language and national identity that have figured prominently in the cultural politics of many diverse ethnolinguistic ex-British colonies. Global Anglophone literature, as I will explain, has increasingly become the field in which literary writing in English from postcolonial sites like Malaysia is situated and thus made legible as an object of study in Western contexts. A Global Asias praxis aids in identifying how Malaysian literature in English is differently conceived when it is situated in area studies (i.e., as a national literature) and diasporic studies (i.e., as a transnational literature written by Malaysians who have migrated overseas in the postindependence era as well as works that explore histories of Chinese and South Asian migration to the country during the colonial era), as well as the multiple racial regimes that apply to these respective fields (i.e., race in the colony, race in the postindependence era, race in imperial/global metropolitan contexts). Given that Global Anglophone literature, in theory, accommodates postcolonial, diasporic, and ethnic literatures from around the world, I am interested in which racial contexts the field privileges and which it overlooks.

The modern academic discipline of English literature originated as the study of England's literary culture, and its formation as such was shaped by its use to "civilize" the natives in the British colonies (Viswanathan 1989). In the wake of empire, however, English as a literary language could no longer be exclusively associated with White-Anglo culture; its instrumentalization to uphold racial hierarchies also resulted in its becoming a vehicle of creative, cultural expression for writers of different backgrounds throughout the world. From the vantage point of English literature, the growing dominance of English as a medium of academic knowledge production from the later decades of the twentieth century was also accompanied by the re-signification of English from being an imperial/national language to being a global one. In short, the race (i.e., competition) for English in the global academy is coupled with the erasure of race (i.e., exclusive ethno-national significance) out of English. These material conditions of academic knowledge production and disciplinary shifts determine Malaysian literature's terms of legibility within Global Anglophone literature. By considering the particular configurations of area, diaspora, and race/ethnicity that underpin how Malaysian literature is located within the

Global Anglophone, I highlight the otherwise obscured local/national histories and cultural politics that shape the work of Malaysian writers and the contradictions that are brought to relief as a result.

Race:

2. *a group of people sharing the same culture, history, language, etc.; an ethnic group*

The emergence of Global Anglophone literature signaled the discipline's widening geographical and cultural scope, effectively disarticulating English from referring solely to White-Anglo writing.[3] The discipline's expansion is thus also a deracination of English, one that adheres to the logic of neoliberal multiculturalism, whereby inclusion into an ever-widening field of study operates on the basis of difference and minoritization along the lines of area, methodology, and race/ethnicity. That "Global Anglophone" mainly derives its set of geographic coordinates in relation to British and American literature underscores the latter as core areas around which writing from the rest of the world is organized. The "global" in "Global Anglophone literature" can also be read as a call for alternative approaches to national paradigms of analysis, which have conventionally organized the discipline, by attending to diasporic cultural productions and histories of transnational migration. Yet, even if transnational approaches underscore the limits of national frameworks, the rubric of ethnic literature, with which diasporic literature often overlaps, tends to be configured as a subset of national literature—see, for example, Asian American, Asian British, or Asian Australian literatures. Though the diversifying impulse of the "global" is cast as progressive, English's hegemony has reinforced rather than revolutionized disciplinary knowledge hierarchies and kept prevailing norms intact.

The inclusion of non-Western writers in the Global Anglophone canon, for example, generally rests on a particular narrative of the imperial legacies of English in the postcolonial world. While the historical uses of English as an instrument of cultural imperialism are acknowledged, the language's reappropriation by postcolonial writers is cast as a form of resistance—a writing back to empire—by remaking English into a cosmopolitan, syncretic medium. This narrative holds to an extent in the

Malaysian context. A selection of short fiction published in the *Straits Chinese Magazine* (1897–1907), the earliest known English literary writing by locals in Malaya, highlights the racism of White colonial officers experienced by the Chinese community; while White readers may have encountered these works, the periodical's editorial contents and circulation also suggest that English had become an expressive medium for the Straits Chinese community to build an ethnic collectivity in the public sphere of letters, one that extended beyond the peninsula to reach the Chinese diaspora throughout Asia, the United Kingdom, and the United States (Patke and Holden 2010, 45; Khor 2008, 31). In the late 1940s, as the prospect of independence became imminent (it was obtained in 1957), literary activity among students at the newly established University of Malaya reflected a preoccupation with how to eschew the British literary influences they were taught and how English could serve as a vehicle for cultivating a shared Malayan cultural identity. The latter was expressed, for example, in the Engmalchin experiments of Wang Gungwu's poems published in *Pulse* (1950), in which he incorporates Malay and Chinese words to capture Malaya's polyglot society and vernacular English (Patke and Holden 2010, 51).

Yet, a different understanding of the Global Anglophone begins to emerge if we pay closer attention to the racialist paradigm of language bequeathed by colonial rule that shaped debates about national literature in the early decades of independence. Colonial education policies aided in making English an interracial lingua franca among the educated classes; unlike Malay-, Chinese-, and Tamil-medium schools, which catered to communities of these respective ethnolinguistic backgrounds, English-medium schools served a more racially diverse student body. Correspondingly, the English writing community was more multiracial and the language seemed more representative of the nation's diverse citizenry compared to its Malay, Chinese, and Tamil counterparts. In response, Malay ethnolinguistic nationalists asserted that the continued use of English reflected a colonial mind-set that undermined Malay's constitutional status as the sole national language, which also symbolizes the "special position" of Malays on the basis of their autochthonous (*bumiputera*) status. Yet, it would be overly simplistic to construe English and Malay as antagonistically representing multiracialism and nativist ethno-nationalism, respectively. Following the 1963 formation of Malaysia, which involved the merger of the ex-British colonies

of Sabah, Sarawak, and Singapore (which later separated in 1965) with peninsular Malaya, a contentious dispute arose between *bumiputera* groups about the use of English as an education medium. While the chief minister of Sarawak, Stephen Kalong Ningkan, recognized Malay's status as the national language, he maintained that the non-Malay Indigenous constituents of his state would be best served with English-medium schools; English, he argued, was the most efficient pathway to progress and modernization for Sarawak's Indigenous communities, which had been deprived of access to formal education during British rule. Despite acting within the state's rights, Ningkan's position was politically untenable to the peninsula-based federal government, which had been criticized by Malay language rights activists for extending the provision within the National Language Act to allow for the use of English in the government's legislative and judicial branches indefinitely. The issue sparked a political row that culminated in the removal of Ningkan from power and the implementation of Malay-medium education in Sarawak (Leigh 2018, 130–134). Ironically, several decades after implementing education policies to curb English's use as a medium of instruction and confining it as a language subject, at the turn of the twenty-first century, the government introduced English as a medium of instruction for math and science subjects on the basis that Malay-medium instruction had resulted in declining English fluency, which needed to be improved particularly in knowledge areas deemed vital for national economic development. This incident is noteworthy because it reveals conflicting meanings about English's significance in relation to Indigenous political and social interests. It also denotes the contradictory positions that the federal government has held on the use of English as an education medium in light of negotiating between the demands for Malay political hegemony and forces of globalized capitalism.

The multiple, contradictory meanings associated with English in Malaysia impact its development as a literary language but are seldom accounted for in the fields of postcolonial and Global Anglophone literature. English may be a global language, but how it comes to signify as global and with what implications differs depending on context.[4] From the Anglo-American academy's vantage point, the re-signification of English from imperial/national to global occurs when postcolonial writers gain recognition in the West. In Malaysia, however, the postcolonial state has,

on one hand, simultaneously endorsed the Malay ethnolinguistic nationalist framing of English as a neo/colonial language that threatens to supplant Malay and thus needs to be curtailed; on the other, it is promoted as an indispensable language of economic development in the era of globalized capitalism. Lost between these two significations of English, as Shirley Geok-Lin Lim notes, are its "nativised, locally constituted, improvisational, flexible, adaptable, creative and expressive" uses (2015, 11).

The deadly May 13, 1969, racial riots, fueled in part by competing ethnolinguistic racialisms between Malays and Chinese, followed by the formulation of the 1971 National Cultural Policy, which defined national literature exclusively as Malay writing, further emphasized the minoritized status of literatures in other languages including English. Yet, writers like Lim, who have emigrated to the United States, have gained critical international attention for their work, which continues to feature Malaysia and themes of exile, migration, and dislocation (similar authors include Ee Tiang Hong and Beth Yahp in Australia). More recently, transnationally mobile writers such as Tash Aw, Tan Twan Eng, and Preeta Samarasan, whose works are published by UK and US presses, have garnered international literary accolades. In narrating the experiences of Chinese and Indian diasporic ethnic minorities in Malaysia, these works have been read by academics as offering critiques of native ethno-nationalism and racial essentialism, in keeping with the tendency in postcolonial scholarship to highlight transnational literary works that critically spotlight regressive elements of postcolonial nationalism (see, for example, Gui 2013). Effectively, these internationally acclaimed works have become de facto national representatives of Malaysian literature in the world literary arena, overshadowing the prominence of Malay national literary laureates promoted by the postcolonial state. The irony of Malaysian literature in English, even when written by ethnic minorities of migrant heritage, gaining global recognition on the basis of its relative marginalized status becomes even more pronounced when we consider the increasingly endangered status of non-Malay Indigenous languages, despite their supposedly protected status following from the postcolonial state's pro-*bumiputera* stance.[5]

The paradoxes elaborated here draw attention to how English, and its attendant epistemological and ideological assumptions, confers global

legibility, to whom, and in what manner. While the international success of a few writers may have increased the visibility of Malaysian literature in English within the rubric of Global Anglophone literature, much remains to be done to explore literary histories and activities in English and other languages that do not hew to metropolitan trends. Doing this work requires area studies training, and Southeast Asian studies is relatively absent in English and comparative literature. Meanwhile, in Southeast Asian studies, which is otherwise dominated by anthropology, history, and political science as a result of its cold war origins, the study of Malay language and literary traditions tends to be given focus in the ethnolinguistically diverse Malay archipelago on the basis of its native status in the region; scholarship on literatures and languages of that area tend to be sited in different fields.[6] These epistemological arrangements—the assimilation of Malaysian literature into the Global Anglophone in English and the relative absence of non-Malay literatures in Southeast Asian studies—reflect what Aamir Mufti calls the "double logic of Orientalism and Anglicism," two oppositional yet complementary ways of conceptualizing the world (2016, 149). Whereas Orientalism refers to the conceptualization of the world as made up of distinct national cultural entities that correspond to their respective language and literary traditions (i.e., the underpinnings of area studies), Anglicism refers to a conceptualization of the world made up of disparate parts as a unified whole (i.e., the underpinnings of the Global Anglophone). This Orientalist-Anglicist double logic underlying institutional arrangements of academic knowledge production animate the politics of language and representation at the national and global levels. The Orientalist underpinnings of area studies may tacitly lend credence to Malay ethno-nationalism; yet, it also reinforces the idea of Malay literature as being the study of a particular place and race, resulting in its being overlooked in the arena of world literature, which is dominated by English as a "cultural system" (Mufti 2016, 146).

Race:

3. *a groove, channel, or passage, i.e., a water channel, especially one built to lead water to or from a point where its energy is utilized, as in a mill or mine*

To summarize thus far, the erasure of race that produces the Global Anglophone ironically relies on the racialization of postcolonial, ethnic, and diasporic writers in the sense that they are made legible primarily through their minoritized or marginalized positions in relation to dominant norms. For those of us situated in the English discipline, how do we work through and out of this bind? The work of Lloyd Fernando (1926–2008) offers valuable insights toward finding a race—that is, a passage—out of English.

A Ceylonese immigrant who grew up in Malaya, Fernando is mainly remembered for championing Malaysian literature in English in his role as novelist, editor of two Malaysian short story collections, and literary critic. As an English professor at the University of Malaya, Fernando introduced the subject of commonwealth literature to the department, a course the writer Shirley Lim took as a student and describes as pivotal for her development as a writer and literary critic (2018, 230). To mark his appointment as department chair in the late 1960s, Fernando presented a lecture, later published as "English, Literature, and Bilingualism in South East Asia" (1986). In the essay, Fernando begins by noting that the discipline of English literature could no longer be viewed as confined solely to the study of British literary culture in light of the language's global reach as a result of empire (1986, 84). His point was not just to address the hostility of Malay ethnolinguistic nationalists toward the subject, nor to anticipate the conservatism of his departmental colleagues (many of whom were expatriates teaching British and American literature), nor to assert the significance of Malaysian literature in English. Rather, his main aim was to address the rising dominance of the English language in all disciplines of academic knowledge production, a trend that is reflected in and supported by the assumption that the study of literature ought to be separated from the study of language. This separation produced the misleading view that literary studies, which is essentially a study of culture, could be disentangled from the study of language, understood as a scientifically driven linguistics approach, as a means of rationality. For Fernando, the larger concern that English's global expansion presented was not that it would threaten the existence of local literary and cultural traditions. Rather, it is English's prestige status as the medium of university education and its prevalence in all disciplines that cultivates an unquestioning acceptance of the forms of rationality encoded into the language as universal rather than as culturally situated. He writes:

> There is enough ground swell in our traditions to absorb what is best in the specifically British literary tradition and make it undergo a sea-change, if you like, in closer harmony with our ways of living. It is rather certain Western habits of thinking which are now deeply infused into the language to which we must be much more alert. This is a challenge which specialists in all branches of learning using the English language in Asia face, not just teachers of literature. And if we do not continue to nurture in many of our students and teachers the highest skill and understanding in the use of the English language, and that means the study of literature, we will certainly fall prey to more subtle and paralyzing forms of Western domination. (1986, 90)

Following the about-turn on English language education policies at the turn of the twenty-first century, the Malaysian government has presented English literature as a means of promoting language fluency. Predictably, these developments have stirred protests not just among Malay, but also Chinese and Tamil language rights proponents, harking back to the competing ethnolinguistic nationalisms fomenting in the 1960s when Fernando gave his lecture. Yet, for Fernando, the language mastery that English literary training can cultivate was only a side benefit; its main goal was to highlight the very limitations of working in English. The lesson to be drawn from English literature for the wider scholarly community is as follows: "Scholars must be readier to submit their researches to the test of two languages at least, and that means no longer their colleagues alone but the wide general lay audience in both East and West, whether literate or illiterate. Those who speak English alone will be quite unable to do this. Worse, they will remain permanently shut off from culture's buzz and hum of implication in Asia" (1986, 110).

Fernando's lecture audience presumably included Malaysian scholars who were fluent in English, in which proficiency was essential at this moment in history to obtain a university education, and at least one other language. In positing English as not the apex of learning but a barrier to greater knowledge, Fernando upends colonial language hierarchies without resorting to the politics of resentment that fuel nativist ethnolinguistic nationalisms. He harnesses the material power of English to forge a race out of English. Of course, English literature—as the Global Anglophone

attests—is no less susceptible to the rationalities of globalized capitalism and is not inherently amenable as a counterweight to the language's hegemony. Yet, as a world language that is no longer the exclusive provenance of a single culture, English can be harnessed to build a pathway out of its totalizing reach when we attend to the presence of other languages that have always surrounded it.

The Buried Promise of Community Languages
There's a Place out of English

Andrew Way Leong

For some readers, my titular phrase "there's a place" might suggest longings—variously queer, utopian, and diasporic—for love and community. "Somewhere" (far away, not here) "there's a place *for us*."[7] But what happens when "somewhere" is right here? What happens if searching for a place "beyond" English can mean struggling *in* place to discover the "entire worlds" that come *out* of one's place?

In the spirit of searching *for* place *in* place, this essay documents a historical "arrangement of force" among Asian studies and Asian American studies at my own place of work, the University of California, Berkeley. I turn to a period from the late 1960s to the early 1970s when the institutional structures of "Asian studies" and "Asian American studies" had not yet congealed into their present forms, a period when claims about Asian community languages in relation to English were, if not "in solution," then at least in a state of emergent suspension.[8] This earlier moment troubles the shorthand associations we now employ when orienting the place of language in discussions of Global Asias praxis, whereby Asian studies stands in for an "attentiveness to questions of . . . linguistic expertise," while Asian American studies stands for engagement with the (theoretical) "vocabularies" of "critical race and ethnic studies" (see Chen and Eubanks's introduction to this volume).

Like all maps, this simplified representation may be good enough to get us where we need to go. But it was not always, was never fully, and need not have been, the case that Asian studies practitioners emphasized linguistic expertise in Asian languages over critical and theoretical reflection; or

that Asian Americanists prioritized the language of theory (in English and English translation) over expertise in Asian languages.[9] Even though training in Asian languages is essential to Asian area studies, in practice, Asian language *instruction* and *instructors* have not been accorded corresponding, or "meaningful," pride of place (Jorden 1981, 13). And Asian languages were once, and could have always been, an essential prerequisite to Asian American studies.

Consider, for example, the following excerpt from the Asian American studies section of "A Proposal for the Establishment of the College of Third World Studies" (1974) at the University of California, Berkeley:

> The prospective major must also demonstrate his or her proficiency in one of the Asian American community languages: Cantonese, Japanese, Tagalog, Korean, or other Asian languages in Asian American communities. The language prerequisite may be met in either one of the following ways:
>
> (1) Successful completion of:
> . . . Community Cantonese
> . . . Community Japanese or satisfactory completion of OL-Japanese-1A-1B-1C
> . . . Community Korean
> . . . Community Tagalog
>
> (2) Demonstrated proficiency in speaking, reading, and writing by passing the language test given by Asian American Studies language course instructors.
>
> While this prerequisite is self-explanatory for the student whose area of concentration will be community studies and humanities, proficiency in an Asian community language is also an indispensable tool for the type of research undertaken in the social sciences concentration (A10).

Although the term "community," as a general abstraction, is an "amorphous keyword in Asian American studies" whose meaning is "highly contested" (Võ 2015, 31), in the specific context of institutional struggles at UC Berkeley in the 1970s, the functional definition of "Asian American

community languages" as "Asian languages in Asian American *communities*" served a clear purpose. This purpose is apparent when one observes the detail that, of the four enumerated languages—Cantonese, Japanese, Korean, and Tagalog—only one, Japanese, was then taught by "OL," or the Department of Oriental Languages. By designating the language courses taught by Asian American studies instructors as "community languages," the proposal implicitly argued that the prospective Department of Asian American Studies would serve the needs of local communities that Oriental Languages had historically failed to address.

What would have happened if this proposal had been accepted as written? What if such community language programs had been established and supported throughout North America?[10] What if you, or every one of your Asian Americanist colleagues, had ready access to all the time and support needed to develop and maintain proficiency in one or more Asian American community languages? What if Asian Americanist multilingualism were so taken for granted as to be a shorthand for the field, a normative expectation and not a notable exception?[11] Would we even be having these conversations about tactics and theories for Global Asias in our many centers and colleges for Third World studies? If we were, how would the terms of our conversations be different? *And what languages would we be speaking?*

The aim of these counterfactual questions is not to envision a utopian escape to a nowhere that does not and could never have existed, but to recover the buried lessons of past institutional struggles for present use. In theory, Asian American studies would always have been multilingual and Third World–oriented. This Asian American studies was once called "Asian studies," in the sense recalled by UC Berkeley Third World Liberation Front (TWLF) organizer Harvey Dong (2019): "I became committed to the idea of Asian American studies, or 'Asian studies' as it was called then. Many old-timers, such as me, automatically refer to Asian American studies as 'Asian studies.' . . . The idea for calling the department Asian Studies was to take back the state department-focused 'Asian Studies' term, and to bring anti-colonial, anti-imperialist, and anti-orientalist meanings to it" (124). The anti-colonial "Asian studies" now known as "Asian American studies" sometimes supplemented, but never superseded, its area studies counterpart. As a result, Asian American studies has been the object of

extensive internal and external criticism for its Anglophone and US-centric tendencies in *practice.* "Old-timer" Asian (American) studies would have focused on serious engagement with Asian community languages, but, as Colleen Lye (2014) has observed, later generations of Asian Americanists traded this in for the academic jargon of "(British cultural studies-mediated) French theory" (213). Lye's use of the phrase "later generations of Asian Americanists" might also suggest an overlap with later demographic generations of Asian *Americans,* whose quests for professional self-advancement have traded in, or sold out, community languages for the higher prestige and utility of English. Community languages would thus seem to be cast on the right hand of a division Lye (2014) glosses as "a split between high theory and local practice, between new ivory tower sophisticates and older community-oriented activists, or, disciplinarily speaking, between a literature-based cultural studies and a history-based one" (213). In other words, the "new" Asian American studies speaks a completely different language than the "old" Asian (American) studies—the mostly English language of high theory (in translation), versus the community languages of local practice.

But what if, instead of imagining an inevitable generational telos toward gaining professional English at the expense of other languages, we could imagine a bi- or multilingualism that reads across both the new and the old? In the context of thinking of how this perceived split in Asian American studies speaks more broadly to theories and tactics for the study of *global* Asias, I want to build upon Lye's (2014) suggestion that both the high theory and community language "sides" are, in fact, "linked strands of global Maoism," a current of thought that was "deeply influential on the cultural turn represented by poststructuralism in France and on Third World movements in the United States" (213).

In what follows, I read the emphasis on "buried knowledges" (*savoirs ensevelis*) in the lectures and writings of an icon of French poststructuralist theory, Michel Foucault (1926–1984), in close parallel with the "buried pasts" of Yuji Ichioka (1936–2002), a historian who is also credited as a coiner of the term "Asian American." The affinity between Foucault's and Ichioka's contemporaneous work on "buried pasts" in the 1970s suggests deeper connections between Foucault's and Ichioka's positions relative to New Left internationalist movements of the 1960s and 1970s. Reading

Ichioka and Foucault together can help illuminate the importance of a turn to genealogy, not as a generalized theoretical abstraction, but as a concrete practice for effectively combining the study of "community languages" with "knowledges of the people" (*savoirs des gens*).

Readers of this volume skimming for materials suitable for aerial survey courses or prospectus statements may find the remainder of this essay's emphasis on close comparative reading of two subterranean phrases—"buried pasts" and "buried knowledges"—to be frustratingly detailed. I would enjoin such readers to recognize that these feelings of impedance (of being buried by) masses of specific detail are central to the experience of this essay's main argument: any general or global survey of "language" in Global Asias is fundamentally damaged in its central substance to the extent that it does not include confrontation with the local granularity of *actual practice in specific, non-English languages.*

In hindsight, the 1971 article in which Yuji Ichioka first used the phrase "a buried past," "A Buried Past: Early Issei Socialists and the Japanese Community," might be understood as an important prototype for the multination and multi-language approaches at the core of present interest in studies of Global Asias. The article also makes the case that no real knowledge of a community is possible without deep engagement with the language, or languages, of that community. In this article, Ichioka argues that the past struggles that constituted the community of Japanese in the United States remain "essentially buried" because of the exclusions and limitations of one-sided, single-national approaches to the study of Japanese and American history. Turning to the buried past of Issei socialists in the 1900s and 1910s reveals, for Ichioka, an "early inchoate stage of the Japanese community," a period in which "conflict rather than unity may have been more characteristic" (15). Understanding the terms of this conflict requires more than just a focus on American "excluders" because the positions of Issei socialists and anarchists "cannot be understood without reference to modern Japanese history" (15). At the same time, however, Ichioka rejects conflation of Japanese American history with modern Japanese history: "To insist Japanese-American history must be studied alongside the modern history of Japan, however, does not mean the two are synonymous.

Japanese-American history after all is an integral part of American history" (15; hyphenation in original).

By 1974, the scope of Ichioka's "a buried past" expanded in two ways—first, from the specific example of early Issei socialists to the entire history of Japanese immigrants and their descendants, and second, from a critique of the limitations of single-national history to a critique of single-language (English) study of historical sources. In a preface written with the three other compilers of *A Buried Past: An Annotated Bibliography of the Japanese American Research Project* (JARP), Ichioka issued the following declaration: "Our ignorance of the history of Japanese immigrants and their descendants is not due to a lack of historical sources, but to the failure of past and present researchers to study existing Japanese-language sources. . . . At this juncture, the history of Japanese immigrants . . . remains essentially a *buried past* awaiting the serious student" (Ichioka et al. 1974, 1; emphasis mine). This passage is remarkably similar to one that appears in Ichioka's 2000 autobiographical reflection, "A Historian by Happenstance" (Ichioka 2006). Although the exact phrase "buried past" does not appear in this later passage, the similarities in other phrasing make it worthy of parallel comparison. "We know virtually nothing about Issei and Kibei literary writings, except for a few anthologies of Issei poetry translated into English. This sad state of affairs is not due to a dearth of sources. . . . These sources can be the basis of in-depth studies of Issei and Kibei poets and authors. Their writings, now preserved in the JARP Collection, only await a competent literary historian to give them their rightful voice and place in Japanese American literature and history" (293). To give voice to some of the questions that arise from reading these passages about "our ignorance" in 1973 and our (still) knowing "virtually nothing" in 2000, we might ask: Where were all the "serious" students? If there were any serious students to be found, then how could it be that, over a span of twenty-seven years, not one of them happened to be "a competent literary historian"? Just what kind of super-dense material was this "buried past" *buried in* for it to have required at least half a century to excavate?

Lecturing at the Collège de France two years after the publication of the *Buried Past* bibliography (Ichioka et al. 1974), Michel Foucault (2003) provided a potential answer to the last of these questions. The past, as a

set of "historical contents," is not covered by literal earth, so much as it is "buried, or masked in functional coherences or by formal systemizations" (7). For the purposes of studies of Global Asias, Foucault's insight provides a strong caution against overextension of aerial forms of global theory that, in their drive to clearly lay out terrain, replicate the techniques of the colonial surveyor, propagating formal systemizations that disqualify and bury "local" knowledges as superfluously detailed, specific, and thus irrelevant.[12]

What is at stake in excavating a buried past is not just an archaeology that unearths specific forms of buried knowledge, but a *genealogy* that couples these buried knowledges with the disqualified knowledges of minoritized peoples (*gens*) to imagine new forms of struggle. As Foucault puts it,

> It is the coupling of these buried knowledges of scholarship and knowledges disqualified by the hierarchy of expertise and the sciences that have given the critique of discourse over these last fifteen years its essential strength. In the case of one as in the other, in this knowledge of scholarship as in these disqualified knowledges, in these two forms of knowledge, subjugated or buried, what was at stake? It was the historical knowledge of struggles. In the specialized domain of scholarship as in the disqualified knowledge of the people, there lies the memory of combats, precisely that memory that, until then, had been kept to the margins. And it is here we can outline what might be called a genealogy. (2003, 8)

As a meta-example of what such a "genealogy" as a recovery of buried knowledges might look like, we can turn to the work of scholars such as Pal Ahluwalia (2010), who argues that despite formal systemizations of Foucault as an "essentially Eurocentric thinker who had little to say about the world outside of Europe" (598), this treatment obscures the "colonial roots" of Foucault's turn from archaeology to genealogy, a "transition undoubtedly triggered by his residence in the postcolony of Tunisia" from 1966 to 1968 (600). Kathryn Medien (2020) goes even further, arguing that "genealogical investigation" of Foucault's "Tunisian transformation" is crucial to "folding" the "Tunisian subjects, geographies, and histories erased from current accounts of Foucault back into our purview" (493). Foucault's

active support for Tunisian student activists in 1967 and 1968—"hiding a printing press in his garden to allow activists to print posters and newsletters," "donat[ing] part of his salary in support of his students' legal defence," and "compil[ing] and pass[ing] files of evidence" for the defense of imprisoned and tortured activists—presaged his later involvement "in the French prison struggle" through the establishment of the Groupe d'Information sur les Prisons (GIP; Prisons Information Group) (495–497). Mads Peter Karlsen and Kasper Villadsen (2015) concur, arguing that the "events in Tunisia unquestionably became the linchpin for an active political engagement in French political life upon [Foucault's] return to France in the autumn of 1968" (96).

Karlsen and Villadsen also draw an explicit link to global Maoism through the GIP's use of a strategy of direct investigation derived from Mao Zedong's outline of the "technique of investigation" in his 1930 pamphlet *Oppose Book Worship*. To engage in this form of direct investigation, the GIP sent "questionnaires about prison conditions distributed . . . to the prisoners by their families, ex-prisoners, lawyers and social workers" (Karlsen and Villadsen 2015, 103). Through this method, the GIP hoped to avoid speaking "for" the prisoners, but despite these hopes, the questionnaire format "invoked the genre of social science and inevitably elevated its authors into the position of scientists" (104). Nevertheless, the GIP's principles of investigation, and its critique of "theoretical 'specialists'" acting as "representatives of the people," anticipated Foucault's later "skepticism about 'global,'" or totalizing, "theories" (104).

Ichioka's own skepticism about global theories is readily apparent from his critique of the survey methods that dominated the sociological component of the Japanese American Research Project. The manner in which the JARP's sociological wing buried unruly historical contents through systematic frameworks was so direct as to be almost a textbook case. JARP had three original objectives: "1) to engage in historical studies on Japanese immigrants and their descendants; 2) to conduct sociological research and surveys; and 3) to collect and preserve historical source materials" (12). But Ichioka claims that "from the outset . . . the project devoted itself almost exclusively to the second [sociological] objective" (Ichioka et al. 1974, 12). As a result, "the project became, for all intents and purposes, a three-generational sociological research study, with the third objective—the

collection and preservation of historical sources—pushed into the background as an almost inappropriate appendage" (12).

Lest this account of JARP's sociological orientation seem extreme, it is worth turning to the self-characterizations of Gene Levine and Colbert Rhodes, the sociologists responsible for a 1981 summary of JARP findings titled *The Japanese American Community.* Considering themselves to be akin to experimental scientists, Levine and Rhodes wrote that the "project, over the years, provided us with a laboratory in which to test various notions about American ethnic processes" (4). Focused on organizing quantitative evidence under generalizable theoretical abstractions about "assimilation" and "cultural pluralism" (12–13), Levine and Rhodes relied exclusively on survey data. As "non-Japanese Americans," Levine and Rhodes freely admitted to making no "attempt to obtain . . . first-hand knowledge" of what it would be like to live in a "Japanese American community" (23). They also declared that they did not have "an Asian American perspective, if such a thing exists," and emphasized that they had also never "tried to acquire one" (23). Through this and other discursive maneuvers, Levine and Rhodes disqualified as either unnecessary, or potentially nonexistent, the knowledges (*savoirs*) of Asian Americans as a racialized or localized "people" (*gens*). Under a closed laboratory model, intentional acquisition of the "perspective" of any Asian American experimental subject would potentially compromise the investigators' "position" as "that of the researcher reporting data in an objective manner" free from "partisanship" (23). Within this perverse schema of social scientific knowledge making, ignorance—a complete absence of basic competence in the language in which most of the first generation of community subjects were interviewed—becomes a self-satisfying virtue. The study's only mention of how this lack of linguistic competence might skew the formation of "data" is quite literally buried in an endnote: "We recognize that a source of error is that we did not have a [standardized] Japanese-language interview schedule, with interviewers recording replies verbatim" (37n1).

In contrast to Levine and Rhodes's objectifying stance in *The Japanese American Community,* which attempted to define "community" through top-down surveys, Ichioka engaged with the historical source materials of the JARP as part of a long, extended practice of on-the-job language learning. As Ichioka (2006) recalls, "Fortunately, I had [historian] Yasuo Sakata

as my mentor. As we worked together on the accession work of organizing and annotating the JARP Collection, he taught me about the characteristics of Meiji-style writing, the meaning of old idiomatic expressions, and the secret of deciphering difficult passages. The accession work was my on-the-job training, so to speak. I learned a new grammar, a new vocabulary, and new idioms, all related, directly or indirectly, to Japanese immigration history, which prepared me for my future research work" (285). Ichioka's account also provides a vivid image of how engagement with the "buried knowledges" of scholarly erudition could provide a "historical knowledge of struggles" or "memory of combats" that parallels and can be coupled with memory found in the "disqualified knowledges of the people" (Foucault 2003, 8). Ichioka's (1988) accessions and research work included detailed and field-defining historical recoveries of Japanese American labor organizing and anti-exclusion struggles. This work was informed by, and consistently coupled with, Ichioka's engagement with the political struggles of his present place and time. As Eiichiro Azuma (2006) observes, Ichioka's essays "are full of fascinating conceptualization and interpretation, but he was impatient of fuzzy theorization without consideration of concrete social realities and historical contexts. Ever committed to social justice and the interest of his community, Ichioka knew [all] too well where he stood first and what he was concerned about most. 'Although bilingual and bicultural . . . I identify myself as an American committed to politically changing our country for the better'" (xxvi).

As we engage in the collective project of imagining the "somewheres" of Global Asias, we must take care that the "global" of Global Asias is not the totalizing "global" of "global" theories that subjugate and bury the knowledges of the people. These buried knowledges are what we seek to unearth in locally situated histories of struggles for community languages: that somewhere "out of English," but still right here, there has always been, and will yet be, a place for us.

Conclusion

In the same way that Mufti (2016) argues that thinking "beyond English" is not a matter of warfare, we hope we have shown in our collective inquiries here that the same could be said about looking and thinking "out of

English." We have sought a "space" out of English, a "race" out of English, and a "place" out of English. We thus hope our reflections embody the "variants of suspension" that Chen and Eubanks have proposed as productive epistemes for Global Asias inquiry. But perhaps there are other variants to consider as well. What about a "face out of English"? How can we reimagine, for instance, who—by dint of sheer racialized physiognomy—is or is not authorized to use English? Can the encounter with the face, described by Levinas (1999) as a site of determining whether another might be deemed human, help us make sense of the role of English and its often dehumanizing effects, within and across Global Asias? Can we also consider a "*base* out of English"? In other words, is there a way to feel settled or even "at home" out of English or, in our cases, in an English department? Or are we collectively reworking the English department as such from within to reimagine it *as* an intellectual base? Relatedly, must English be the base of—as in the basis of—Global Asias? Finally, what about a "*trace* out of English"? We have certainly attended to the problematic geopolitics of English especially in relation to Global Asias. But is there anything we can salvage? There are, maybe, some traces of good that might be found somewhere through some yet unknown variant of suspension, out of English.

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Pedagogy Forum

The question of language is pertinent to all areas of knowledge and disciplines generally speaking—including those proximate to Global Asias inquiry—even if the subject being studied or taught may not be about language per se. Accordingly, we hope that the pedagogical exercises and lexicon for talking about language that follow will generate critical reflection about how language inflects the reader's own teaching practices and be adaptable to a range of institutional contexts. These materials are of course not meant to be prescriptive but rather merely illustrative instances of pedagogical praxis that center questions of language in relation to Global Asias. We begin with Fiona Lee's section of "Language Stories" in order to introduce a classroom discussion exercise that maps how language as a material force shapes a person's situation or condition within a context and their relations with others. Becoming conscious of how language determines social power dynamics is facilitated by the everyday realities of language practice, and to that end the next section, "Languaging a Global Asias Syllabus," by Jerry Lee, invites us to imagine how these realities can in turn refine the pedagogical practice of collaborative syllabus design in a graduate seminar. In the third section, "Language for Community Translation Workshops," Andrew Leong takes us "out of English"—the department, the undergraduate classroom, and the graduate seminar—into a community workshop setting, where a series of short translation exercises and prompts unfold into broader discussions of free play and manual labor in the art and work of translation.

Language Stories

Fiona Lee

What is your first or most powerful memory of language? What images or ideas about language does this memory convey?

When and how did English become a presence in your life? How would you describe your relationship with the English language? How has English shaped your decisions about education and social life?

How many languages do you interact in and with? Are there certain languages that are associated with certain aspects of your identity? Is the self that you express in one language different from the self expressed in another?

What mis/conceptions have been made about you based on how you speak? How has your physical appearance shaped perceptions about your language abilities?

Sketch out a map of the places you regularly visit over the course of the day/week. What languages are associated with each place? How does your use of language change—whether in terms of accent, idiom, tone, etc.—depending on with whom you are speaking, where, and when?

As a supplement to teaching diasporic, postcolonial Anglophone literature, I developed this set of questions to invite students to critically reflect on the presence of English in their language stories. I use the term "language stories" to mean two things: (1) how language shapes our life stories by drawing attention to its function as a material force for shaping identity, community, and social relations, and (2) the stories we tell ourselves—such as historical or ideological narratives—to explain the significance of English in our lives. Students are encouraged to freewrite thoughts that come to mind as I read these questions aloud and to then share their reflections with one another in small groups. During class-wide discussion, I try to tease out the social meanings and functions of English that emerge through their shared observations. I also listen for commonalities and differences to highlight how a shared language can generate varied experiences and shape social relations within a community.

In this essay, I reflect on how the pedagogical exercise described might be useful for teaching Global Asias in and beyond the disciplinary context of English literature. In a discipline that prides itself on training students to be attentive to language's semiotic, aesthetic uses, works by diasporic, postcolonial Anglophone writers are uniquely positioned to explore how imperial histories shape English's current hegemony and what it means for minoritized subjects to work within the globally dominant medium. By virtue of writing in English, diasporic, postcolonial authors are often

positioned as spokespersons for the communities they write about and/or are from; they are often seen to be playing such roles, whether they claim to or not, because the language in which they write presupposes an audience different from the communities they write about, which may *and* may not be the case. The role of the writer as intermediary and the question of audience are particularly relevant to the research and teaching praxis of Global Asias scholars in general. In addition to underscoring the importance of cultivating critical reflexivity about language in our students, as my questions at the beginning of this essay aim to do, my reflections and questions that follow also seek to encourage collective contemplation and conversation about our teaching practices as scholar-teachers.

What different functions are associated with the multiple languages involved in making and teaching knowledge about Global Asias? What is the relationship between these languages?

How are institutional, cultural norms reflected in these language relations? How are these norms reproduced in the classroom? What ways of knowing do they inhibit and how can they be interrogated?

The multilingual, translingual nature of Global Asias can serve as a counterpoint to the monolingual tendencies of English literature. Teaching diasporic, postcolonial literature is an occasion for highlighting how Anglophone writing is embedded in multilingual contexts, thereby interacting with several languages and cultures. Yet, the positioning of Anglophone writers as intermediaries between cultures and as spokespersons for the local to a global audience is a reminder to consider the relationship between different languages involved in the study of Global Asias.

In classrooms where knowledge in Asian languages is recognized as ideal, if not essential, for learning about a subject or a field, language is often primarily approached as a means to obtain knowledge about a region, people, or culture. Yet, language is also a medium of knowledge production and circulation. As Caroline S. Hau (2020) notes in her essay "For Whom Are Southeast Asian Studies?" the question of who one's audience is determines what kinds of research inquiries are pursued. The pluralized

noun in the essay's title reflects the institutionalization of Southeast Asian studies in universities both within and beyond the region. Yet, Hau observes, it is research published in prestigious Anglo-American publications that has gained international prominence; work in other languages and work that does not directly address this audience is deemed less significant, including by Southeast Asian universities aspiring to boost their international rankings. The knowledge hierarchies expressed and sustained by English as a global scholarly medium, Hau further explains, can also foment tensions between scholars situated in different locations, as the following example from Filipino studies indicates. Given that scholarship produced in the Global South, even when written in English, tends to be rendered invisible, a few Philippines-based scholars have sought to dismiss the work of diasporic Filipino scholars, particularly those based in the United States, on the basis of their geographic location, whether by presenting them as "outsiders" who are distanced from their subject of study (Hau quoting Diokno 2005, 139), or as traitors for having left the country, thus rendering their scholarship questionable (Hau 2020, 70–71). In addition to recognizing that disparities in access to resources and power between Global South and North need to be addressed, Hau suggests that such accusations are premised on English-speaking, Philippines-based academics' "sense of entitlement to speak on behalf of the 'Filipino people'" and do not account for the relative marginalization of Filipino American academics in the Global North (71). As Hau's example illustrates, English links different sites of knowledge production around the world, each of which has its own set of social stratifications, via uneven power relations. In an academic culture that incentivizes competition over collaboration under such unequal conditions, English operates as a field of global visibility that pits scholars working within and across area, diasporic, and ethnic studies in contest with one another.

Hau's point about how language determines power relations between researchers, knowledge subjects, and audiences ought to be considered in classroom contexts. My own experience of having taught in English departments in three different countries—the United States, Australia, and Malaysia—has been an ongoing lesson about how the classroom is a microcosm of knowledge-power relations between teacher, student, and the subject of study that are mediated through language. While pursuing my

PhD in postcolonial Anglophone literature, I taught composition and literature courses at an urban public university system in New York City, which largely served first-generation college students from immigrant communities. This formative teaching experience connected me with pedagogical scholarship on teaching multilingual students and efforts by colleagues to redress how academic writing conventions—which are often shaped by broader social political norms—devalue students' literacies in other languages and cultures (see, for example, Alvarez 2017; Canagarajah 2002, 2013; Shaughnessy 1977; Wan 2014). Though my research field had trained me to analyze the relationship between language and power, it was only through teaching that I realized that it is not only through content, but also through the modes of academic writing and assessment for measuring performance where language and knowledge hierarchies can be reinforced or challenged.

Desire lies at the heart of all language learning, argue Suhanthie Motha and Angel Lin, and the pedagogical space is constituted by multiple desiring subjects—students, the communities in which students are situated, teachers, institutions, and the state—whose respective agendas may not necessarily align yet are co-constructed in relation to one another (2014, 335–336). Though Motha and Lin are writing specifically about teaching English to speakers of other languages (TESOL), their insights resonate with my experience in English literature classrooms. At a leading research university in Sydney, Australia, where education is the nation's third largest export, an international exchange student from Hong Kong shared that our postcolonial literature course had led her to reexamine her cosmopolitan aspirations for studying English literature in Australia, which she originally considered a marker of advanced fluency in the global lingua franca and cultural sophistication. Reading writers who grappled with being alienated from their own cultures and languages as a result of colonial education, she explained, made her aware of how little she had thought about Hong Kong's colonial history and sparked a desire to learn more about its impact on the present. In Malaysia, where I currently teach at a public university in Kuala Lumpur, the study of English literature has been increasingly viewed by government officials as a means of cultivating fluency in a language indispensable for economic development. In foregrounding English's imperial legacies to students to offer a counterpoint to this view, I grapple with the

challenge of how to develop a critical view of English's hegemony without echoing prevailing nativist ethnolinguistic sentiments that deem English—as well as other non-Malay languages—a threat to Malay's status as the sole national language. The point here is not simply that how a subject is taught may differ according to context and who one's students are. Attention to desire in the classroom brings into relief how the subject of language is a contact zone of multiple desiring subjects and, hence, deeply political.

How might attending to language serve as a means of marking one's position within the field of power relations that constitute an academic discipline?

How might practicing critical reflexivity train us to engage in dialogue and to listen well?

In the language stories exercise with which I began, the autobiographical nature of the questions is meant to enable students to gain a more immediate sense of how English writes one's place in and sense of the world by drawing from their own life experiences. If we are to urge our students to practice critical reflexivity, then as teachers, it is ethically imperative that we also undertake closer examination of our own language autobiographies and intellectual formations "not only to make our desires available to consciousness, but also to take the next step beyond, that is, to ensure that our desires and stances are visible to others, particularly to those we teach" (Motha and Lin 2014, 354). The end goal here is not necessarily for students or teachers to produce autobiographical narratives in relation to language. Rather, autobiography can be an entry point for coming into awareness of how language scripts the relations between students, teachers, and knowledge subjects, so that we might better address the power hierarchies that it (i.e., language) often upholds in academic contexts.

Languaging a Global Asias Syllabus

Jerry Won Lee

In what follows, I describe my approach to teaching my Global Asias graduate seminar at the University of California, Irvine. One of my main

areas of research specialization is applied linguistics, which is an interdisciplinary field of study invested in understanding real-world language issues and implications. As a consequence, my approach to the study and teaching of Global Asias is invariably shaped by, if not centered on, questions of language.

What would a syllabus for a Global Asias seminar that tries to take seriously the realities of language in the twenty-first century look like? Such a syllabus, whether at the graduate or undergraduate level, surely could not rely solely on material that is exclusively in English (as implied in this "Language" convergence). The syllabus in question would, at the very least, foreground the translational realities of Global Asias scholarship, attending to primary and secondary material that was produced originally in languages other than English. Even more important, I would argue, is that such a syllabus would reflect the realities of what might be called not "language" but "languaging."

Scholars of literature may be familiar with Rey Chow's 2014 book, *Not Like a Native Speaker: On Languaging as a Postcolonial Experience.* Chow's theorization of languaging begins with Alton L. Becker's (1995) description, which reflects the reality that a person "does not simply *use* language but is compelled, for one reason or another, to think carefully and repeatedly *about* it" (3). Becker recalls a moment when reflecting on the function of the grammatical structure of a language and realizing how inconsequential it can in fact be: "At that moment, as I was trying to remember the Burmese I thought I had once known, grammars and lexicons seemed beside the point, just things we do with languages, not things that are *somehow within* languages, not part of their being as languages. People like me *make* grammars and dictionaries—these artifacts are not in the minds of the users of languages. Grammars and dictionaries were not what was buried in my memory. This came to me with a force of a revelation" (Becker 1995, 3–4). For Becker, the form of language matters less than its function, a function that is made possible by an approach to language that accounts for the (embodied and textual) memories it invokes and the contexts in which it operates.

For Chow, languaging invites a series of important considerations to make sense of the complex language politics of Hong Kong, a former British colony whose official languages include English and Chinese. And while these are the two "official" special administrative region's sanctioned

languages, these do not account for numerous Indigenous Chinese languages and dialects, not to mention the countless mother tongue languages of migrant communities, including the languages of Southeast Asian and South Asian migrant laborers. Language in Hong Kong, in other words, has invariably been not only a multifaceted geopolitical issue but also one tied to the racialized legacies of colonial domination. If, Chow asks, certain subjects can be "racialized by language and languaged by race," then "are not their skin tones also disfigurements, the defective corrections of what is already deemed defective?" (2014, 9).

My treatment of languaging, then, does not treat language as a fixed grammatical system that we are expected to treat as sacred and immutable. Rather, languaging acknowledges the agentive role of humans in the use of language not as a system but as a resource (Canagarajah 2013), guided by a capacity to negotiate if not reconcile lexical and discursive meanings in situ. Li Wei's (2018) description of translanguaging comes to be particularly relevant for our purposes. Translanguaging is described as a "*process of knowledge construction* that goes beyond language(s)" (15; emphasis in original). It is therefore a "practical theory of language" that "comes out of practical concerns of understanding the creative and dynamic practices human beings engage in with multiple named languages and multiple semiotic and cognitive resources" (Li 2018, 27). While languaging can occur within an arbitrarily bound entity of a language as code, translanguaging occurs irrespective of, and at times even deliberately disruptive to, language as bounded and named entity. But even so, languaging more generally or translanguaging more specifically is reflective of an active process of making and shaping meaning through communicative resources.

When I refer, therefore, to "Languaging a Global Asias Syllabus," I am exploring the possibility of taking a Global Asias syllabus and subjecting it to the same process of negotiation that is reflective of the everyday communicative realities of Global Asias: to language it. I am, in other words, treating language as a verb and specifically as a transitive verb, suggesting that we need to rethink the syllabus as such, conventionally regarded as a static, fixed, and nonnegotiable document, almost akin to a legal contract (I have heard of colleagues, in fact, who require their students to sign the bottom of the syllabus as in an acknowledgment of the terms of the course, a "user agreement," if you will). Some forms of knowledge, after

all, cannot be systematically curricularized into an institutional space such as a syllabus in the first place. What if we, instead, treated it like we do language: dynamic, living, negotiable, and always in process?

My approach to languaging the Global Asias syllabus is quite simple. I first provide students with a list of potential readings for the term. These include various articles from journals such as *Verge: Studies in Global Asias* (University of Minnesota Press), *Inter-Asia Cultural Studies* (Routledge), *positions: asia critique* (Duke University Press), and the *Journal of Asian American Studies* (Johns Hopkins University Press), among others. I also provide students with a sample list of books in Global Asias, such as the following:

- Aneesh, A. 2015. *Neutral Accent: How Language, Labor, and Life Become Global.* Durham, NC: Duke University Press.
- Bui, Long. 2018. *Returns of War: South Vietnam and the Price of Refugee Memory.* New York: New York University Press.
- Chen, Kuan-Hsing. 2010. *Asia as Method: Toward Deimperialization.* Durham, NC: Duke University Press.
- Cheng, Anne Anlin. 2021. *Ornamentalism.* New York: Oxford University Press.
- Ching, Leo T. S. 2019. *Anti-Japan: The Politics of Sentiment in Postcolonial East Asia.* Durham, NC: Duke University Press.
- Chow, Rey. 2014. *Not Like a Native Speaker: On Languaging as a Postcolonial Experience.* New York: Columbia University Press.
- Gandhi, Evyn Lê Espiritu. 2022. *Archipelago of Resettlement: Vietnamese Refugee Settlers and Decolonization across Guam and Israel-Palestine.* Berkeley: University of California Press.
- Lee, Ching Kwan. 2018. *The Specter of Global China: Politics, Labor, and Foreign Investment in Africa.* Chicago: University of Chicago Press.
- Lee, Jerry Won. 2022. *Locating Translingualism.* Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- Ma, Ning. 2016. *The Age of Silver: The Rise of the Novel East and West.* New York: Oxford University Press.
- Nappi, Carla. 2021. *Translating Early Modern China: Illegible Cities.* Oxford: Oxford University Press.

- Nguyen, Viet Thanh. 2016. *Nothing Ever Dies: Vietnam and the Memory of War.* Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.
- Sakai, Naoki. 1997. *Translation and Subjectivity: On "Japan" and Cultural Nationalism.* Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press.
- Vogel, Erica. 2020. *Migrant Conversions: Transforming Connections between Peru and South Korea.* Berkeley: University of California Press.
- Yu, Timothy. 2021. *Diasporic Poetics: Asian Writing in the United States, Canada, and Australia.* Oxford: Oxford University Press.

The first two weeks are spent introducing students to the emergent discourse of Global Asias. To this end, texts such as Tina Chen's (2021) article in the *Journal of Asian Studies,* "Global Asias: Method, Architecture, Praxis," and Chen and Eric Hayot's (2015) editorial introduction to the inaugural issue of *Verge* figure to be particularly useful. For each of the following sessions, students are asked to select text(s) for a given class meeting and are assigned, individually or collaboratively, to lead part of the class discussion for that day based on the text(s). This approach invites students to select readings based on their individual scholarly interests (which is what they should be doing anyway) and provides professionalization as well through further experience teaching.

Some traditionalists, of course, might balk at this approach. How can a graduate seminar not be structured around the goal of providing students a solid foundation in a given topic? However, the reality, at least for me, is that Global Asias is not a "field" and much less a "discipline." As such, it should not be treated as dogma and with it a series of "canonical" or "required" readings. Rather, it is an emergent approach to knowledge production both in the sense of being emergent as in relatively new (popularized, no doubt, by the publication and rapid influence of *Verge*) and, more importantly, emergent as in dynamic and open to a variety of disciplinary orientations, methodologies, and epistemological vantage points. It makes sense, therefore, to treat a course on Global Asias accordingly, and this is one way we might go about languaging a Global Asias syllabus.

Language for Community Translation Workshops

Andrew Way Leong

In our research forum, Jerry Lee writes, "translation, and particularly translation into English, is the lifeblood of Global Asias inquiry." If translation is lifeblood, then who produces this blood? Whose work keeps this blood moving, or, to use a term highlighted by Fiona Lee, *racing:* "to or from a point where its energy is utilized"? Who makes this energy? Who uses it?

These by-whom / for-whom questions prompt me to consider pedagogy and translation work "out of English"—not just beyond the English department, but beyond the university classroom. The exercises and prompts that follow were designed for the specific needs of a community workshop gathering of Black, Indigenous, People of Color (BIPOC) translators and language learners interested in translating Japanese-language literary texts. As such, these materials were not designed for immediate use in general education or undergraduate/graduate survey courses on "global Asias." These materials could be used in such settings to provide examples of what university surveys of (English-language) translated or theoretical texts cannot help but fail to cover. Theoretical abstractions about language in Global Asias are well and good, but who has the time for fundamental *practice* in any one of the many specific non-English languages that might constitute a necessary part of studies of Global Asias? When can students confront the practical difficulties of *how* texts get translated into English, and *who* gets to translate them? In a more positive vein, these materials might gesture toward the horizon of a truer universality, a horizon where university studies of Global Asias would include, as a matter of course, the broad participation of marginalized communities working in any one (or more!) of many languages other than English.

I developed the exercises and discussion prompts that follow for Hybrid Hallucinations, a two-day online workshop organized in July 2021 by Kenji C. Liu and Lisa Hofmann-Kuroda. The day-two facilitator was Asa Yoneda; I was the facilitator for day one. The workshop's emphasis on bringing together a collective community appeared through the announcement's frequent use of first-person-plural pronouns (we, us, our): "In this workshop for BIPOC literary translators of Japanese, we will aim to address

these questions as we ask why there are so few of us working in Japanese literary translation today. How do our identities and experiences as BIPOC and/or heritage speakers shape our relationship to language, to the practice of translation, and our mode of engagement with the text? How might we organize collectively with one another to rethink and remake the practice of Japanese literary translation on our own terms?" (Liu and Hofmann-Kuroda 2021). Tasked with discussing why there are so few "BIPOC and/or heritage speakers working in Japanese literary translation," I wondered how my day-one lecture could draw attention to how the term "literary" embeds a series of assumptions about what literature is and who can produce literary translations.

To examine these distinctions, I put up a longish quotation from Jacques Derrida's (1981) gloss on Immanuel Kant's notions of "liberal" and "mercenary" art. Despite both authors' reputations for abstruseness, this passage (in Richard Klein's translation) is fairly straightforward:

> Art in general . . . cannot be reduced to craft [*Handwerk*]. The latter exchanges the value of its work against a salary; it is a mercenary art [*Lohnkunst*]. Art, strictly speaking, is liberal or free [*freie*], its production must not enter into the economic circle of commerce, of offer and demand, it must not be exchanged. Liberal art and mercenary art therefore do not form a couple of opposite terms. One is higher than the other, more "art" than the other, it has more value for not having any economic value. . . . Mercenary productivity . . . resembles that of bees: lack of freedom, . . . fixity of the program without reason and without the play of the imagination. The craftsman, the worker, like the bee, does not play. And indeed, the hierarchical opposition of liberal art and mercenary art is that of play and work. (5)

Despite revalorizations of handwork in the three centuries since Kant wrote *The Critique of Judgment,* the mercenary / liberal art distinction continues to linger in the division between "non-literary" and "literary" translation. Non-literary translation tends to be work for commercial purposes that employs "translators for hire." Literary translation usually pays less but can carry more cultural prestige.

The distinction between low language *work* and the "free play" of high literary *art* means that "language stories" under capitalism are also stories of labor: unwaged or under-waged, state subsidized or exempted. The mechanics of language learning and proficiency are also neither "free" nor spontaneous, but dependent upon systematically under-acknowledged and/or exempted forms of labor. These forms can be marginalized (read: feminized) as the unpaid or underpaid labor of mothers, nannies, teachers, and service workers. They can also be naturalized or made invisible by virtue of their pervasiveness: consider how national or official language learning is supported either by government entities or by entities granted sovereign exemptions for educational, religious, or charitable purposes.

In a manner similar to Fiona Lee's exercise, I asked workshop participants to consider how their own language knowledge and non/proficiencies might be dependent upon systematically under-acknowledged or exempted forms of labor and expropriation. These were some of the prompts I asked workshop participants to consider along the work/play axis:

> *When thinking about one's own, or others' marginalization or alienation from language-learning as well as the practice and profession of translation, consider:*
>
> - *What kinds of language work—performed by whom—have been marginalized and ignored, or celebrated or rewarded?*
> - *Who feels, or is, "free to play" or "free to make mistakes" in which languages?*

These general prompts could be used to initiate discussion among many groups of prospective translators for many possible languages. However, the point of the workshop was not just to have a general and ungrounded discussion that could occur in any place at any time, but to explore how concrete practice with a shared set of specific texts and translation problems could deepen our collective understanding of these questions.

To provide a specific illustration of how one might, as a workshop facilitator, select interlinked texts that (1) address the needs and interests of a wide range of community members and (2) enhance collective discussion of the questions just presented, I will now provide condensed versions of

the case study exercises I provided for the Hybrid Hallucinations workshop. Of course, I do not expect that facilitators interested in adapting these materials for other community groups will use these exact passages. What I hope instead is that the interlinked passages, which vary in length and linguistic difficulty, might illustrate ideas for selection and organization that might prove useful in other contexts.

The participants in the workshop received the worksheets and prompts a week before the online session and chose from one of four case study breakout sessions that were divided based on a combination of levels of difficulty (from absolute beginner to experienced translator) and topics of interest (e.g., translating dialogue or racialized/gendered vernacular speech). To facilitate participation of all groups in a collective discussion afterward, case studies 1 through 3 all included passages that focused on "hand work" in the writings of Japanese socialist poet Ishikawa Takuboku (1886–1912) and citations of Takuboku in the work of the novelist and playwright Nagahara (Hideaki) Shōson (1901?).[13] Since the through line among these case studies is the most direct, I foreground them here. Case study 2B and case study 4 included longer passages that delved deeper into representations of Japanese and Black women's vernacular language and labor.[14] My suggested English translations originally appeared at the very end of the worksheet as a reference, but for the present reader, I include them directly below the exercise text in italics. The original worksheet studies were also followed by more open-ended questions, but in the interest of condensing the materials, I have provided more directed summaries of the questions and the discussions they provoked.

The broad aim across all of these passages was to find ways to emphasize the manual labor, or "hand work," that underlies and sustains the art of translation. This emphasis also includes finding ways to value slips of the hand: errors and deviations. These are not just mistakes but possible traces of the freedom to err or to play.

Study 1

The first of the four case studies was oriented toward beginning learners of Japanese. Accordingly, the text was quite short, a thirty-one-mora tanka, or "short poem," published in a collection of Ishikawa Takuboku's poetry titled *Ichiaku no suna* (A handful of sand).

はたらけどはたらけど猶わが生活楽にならざりぢっと手をみる (石川啄木)

hatarakedo hatarakedo nao waga kurashi raku ni narazari jitto te o miru (Ishikawa Takuboku)

This poem was composed by Ishikawa Takuboku (1886–1912) and published in a collection titled *Ichiaku no suna* (A handful of sand) in 1910 (53).

Suggested translation: I work and I work but my life gets no better. I stare at my hands.

Although I provided a vocabulary sheet for reference, the first exercise was to ask participants to refrain from turning to the vocabulary sheet, and instead try reading the romanized text of the poem aloud several times to attune their senses to the poem as an auditory and haptic object. The facilitator asked participants to note what kinds of sound patterns and rhythms they noticed and then asked them to express what kinds of bodily sensations or feelings these patterns and rhythms produced. For some readers, this might include awareness of a 5-7-5-7-7–mora rhythm in the poem: *hatarakedo* (5) / *hatarakedo nao* (7) / *waga kurashi* (5) / *raku ni narazari* (7) / *jitto te o miru* (7). The second exercise was to ask participants to cut, paste, and move around various word options from the vocabulary sheet, as in refrigerator-magnet poetry, to experiment with moving component words into different possible sequences. As a concluding question, we asked participants to talk about how the final image of the poem features language about the body, or more specifically, "looking motionlessly" (or staring) at one's hands. We then asked the participants to think about how this body language, and the emotion it conveyed, might have been reinforced (or not) by the sound and rhythm impressions they experienced with the poem during their first, out-loud readings.

Study 2A

Building on study 1, study 2A was oriented toward participants interested in Japanese as a heritage language. Accordingly, I turned to a passage where colloquial speech rhythms and typesetting errors in a Japanese-language

Japanese American dramatic text might distort standard readings of the poem in study 1.

> 健吉（独言）：何んだ、これや素敵だ。實に立派な歌だ。働けど働けど . . . . . わがくらし楽にならず。じっと手を . . . . . 見るか、うまい。實にうまい。碌木はやつぱりえらいな。
>
> *Kenkichi (dokugen): Nanda, kore ya suteki da. Jitsu ni rippa na uta da. Hatarakedo hatarakedo. . . . . waga kurashi raku ni narazu. Jitto te o. . . . . miru ka, umai. Jitsu ni umai. Rokuboku wa yappari erai na.* (Nagahara 2007, 48–49)
>
> The soliloquy above is spoken by a character named Kenkichi in *Sariyukumono* (去り行く者 The ones who leave), a play written by Japanese American playwright Nagahara Hideaki (永原秀秋) and published in 1927. All kanji (including possible errors) appear as originally published in the 1927 edition of the play.
>
> *Translation: KENKICHI (in soliloquy): Oh, this is good. What a great poem. "Work and work . . . but my life gets no better—at my hands. . . . . I stare?" Magnificent. Truly magnificent. That Rokuboku is really something.*

The first prompt asked participants to compare the character Kenkichi's reading of the poem to the original poem in study 1. Participants could note that Kenkichi's reading includes long, twelve-dot speech pauses; they might also note that Kenkichi reads the poem in an manner that violates the 5/7/5/7/7 rhythm of Takuboku's original poem: *hatarakedo* (5) / *hatarakedo* (5) [PAUSE] *waga kurashi* (5) / *raku ni narazu* (6) / *jitto te o* [PAUSE] *miru ka* (8). Very close readers might also notice that in the play, the kanji characters identifying the poet as 碌木 (Rokuboku) differ slightly from the actual 啄木 (Takuboku). In the breakout discussion, participants were invited to talk about the possible significance of these differences. Could some of the distortions have been intentional techniques for playwright Nagahara to signal that Kenkichi had an uneven command of proper ways of reading Japanese poetry? How might a translator and actor collaborate to find ways of rendering this scene in an English adaptation?

Study 3

Building on studies 1 and 2A, study 3 was oriented toward readers of Japanese with more translation experience, and looked at another instance where Nagahara mis/quoted Takuboku for artistic effect.

Nagahara Shōson's serialized novel *Osato-san* was published in the *Rafu shimpo* (Los Angeles Japanese daily news) from November 7, 1925, to May 8, 1926. The protagonist, Osato, is contemplating the difficulties of taking care of her infant son, Tarō, and her alcoholic and gambling-addict husband, Ryōsaku.

> *Suggested translation:*
>
> "*I work and I work but my life gets no better, I glance at my hands."—Kaiboku.*
>
> *Tell me, will these dark days of mine ever end? How can I have suffered such agony and torment? Is there no God, no Buddha in this world? How can I possibly earn as much money as a man with these thin little arms of mine? And how will I take care of Ryōsaku and Tarō? Everybody says that thanks to the war, the economy's booming. That might be good news for a full-grown man, but there's no way a woman can get a well-paying job. Still, if I don't work, we don't eat, and I'll do anything to make sure that poor little Tarō doesn't go hungry. Even though Ryōsaku might deserve to starve, Tarō, my own flesh and blood, hasn't done anything to deserve a fate like that. I'll work myself mad—I'll take care of him. So what on earth am I going to do ? What kind of job can I get? What kind of living can I make? . . .*

In a manner similar to the question prompts for study 2A, we asked participants to compare "Kaiboku's" (喙木) poem to the Rokuboku (碌木) and Takuboku (啄木) versions. In particular, we focused discussion on the detail of a shift from the adverbial *jitto* (fixedly, motionlessly) to *sotto* (softly, quietly), where the difference of single initial sound, from *ji-* to *so-*, completely changes the emotional character and tenor of the quoted poem. We asked if, how, and why this kind of shift might be read in the gendered context of Nagahara's transposition of a poem written by a male poet (Takuboku) into an epigraph to a monologue by a female speaker.

At stake in all three interlinked translation studies and discussion prompts was a close attention to the importance of what we might call *translating by hand*—the careful and painstaking work and practice of attuning our senses and selves to the patterns and rhythms of other hands writing, or weaving, texts in other languages.[15] This work includes awareness of how what might look like very slight shifts, or slips of the hand, might index everything from the intentional techniques of a poet, playwright, or novelist to simple, but no less telling, traces of the fatigue of an overworked compositor setting lead type in a noisy printer's workshop.

Without presuming to intrude on the work of future facilitators, I wonder what other passages, in other languages, might help us attend to this work of the hand. I think, in English, of N. H. Osia's (1922) depiction of the bloody severed hand of a Korean nationalist heroine in *Hansu's Journey,* or Dhan Gopal Mukerji's (2002) passing mention, in *Caste and Outcast,* of a girl in a Japanese textile factory who, after making a "careless gesture," had her hand caught and "mangled" in the machinery (136–137). The point is not that texts "out of English" will magically restore the free play of all of these hands lost, severed, mangled, or buried in and by English. But perhaps, if we stare hard enough, or glance softly enough, we might finally feel their touch.

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Notes to Convergence 4

1. Sunny Xiang's (2020) *Tonal Intelligence* offers a particularly productive engagement with tone as an aesthetic to historicize the continuities of Oriental inscrutability within the long cold war.
2. According to Schneider (2007), there are five discrete stages of development in World Englishes: foundation (introduction of English), exonormative stabilization (local variety is refined according to norms established by an outside variety), nativization (local users can be categorically considered "native" speakers of the emergent variety of English), endonormative stabilization (local variety is further refined in accordance with internal norms), and finally internal diversification (the local variety is widespread enough to the extent that distinctions can be seen across conventional sociolinguistic markers such as region, class, gender, etc.).
3. For a discussion of the history of Global Anglophone literature and its relation to the earlier established, cognate fields of postcolonial literature and world literature, see the special issue "Forms of the Global Anglophone" in *Post45* (Anam 2019).
4. See, for instance, Akshya Saxena's *Vernacular English: Reading the Anglophone in Postcolonial India* (2023), whose account of the life of English in India as it interacts with other languages in the subcontinent demands a retheorizing of what it means to understand the Anglophone as global.
5. The Borneo Literature Bureau in Kuching, established in 1959 to publish books in the languages of Sarawak and Sabah, served a significant role in documenting Indigenous orature in print form, especially in the Iban language. Oral witness accounts suggest that when the Malaya-based federal body, Dewan Bahasa dan Pustaka (DBP, or the National Language and Literature Bureau) took over operations in 1977, all the books in Iban and other Bornean languages were destroyed (Postill 2006, 59).
6. Various scholars have interrogated the logic of Indigeneity that underpins the study of literature in area studies. For example, Shu-mei Shih and others (Shih, Thai, and Bernards 2013) have used the Sinophone as a concept to decenter mainland China in the field of Chinese literature and draw attention to the wide range of Sinitic cultural production happening in Malaysia and elsewhere in the world.

7. The opening phrase from the song "Somewhere" (Bernstein and Sondheim 1957).
8. For the metaphor of structures "in solution," see Raymond Williams's (1977) use of this phrase with respect to "structures of feeling."
9. For an analysis of Asian American literary studies' post-1990s "privileging of Anglophone literary production while neglecting to examine its reliance on the cultural capital of the English language," see Lee (2022, 32).
10. Note that, at present, the concept of "community languages" in California and the United States more broadly tends to be subordinated to "heritage languages" in constructions such as "heritage/community languages." By contrast, the phrase "community languages" appears more frequently in the language policy and planning discourse of other English-dominant nations such as Australia, Canada, and the United Kingdom (see Li 2018).
11. For the phrasing "notable exceptions" and a broader account of the dominance of "English-language texts" in "foundational studies of Asian American literature," see Lee (2015).
12. I have made this argument in greater depth in Leong (2015).
13. Hideaki is Nagahara's birth name, which he also used as his author name for plays. Shōson is a pen name that Nagahara used for his novels and short stories.
14. The full worksheet is available at https://tinyurl.com/4s3ec3a9.
15. In this vein, Poulomi Saha, in *The Empire of Touch* (2019), argues for "investing . . . in a practice of immanent sensuousness: not just what a body can do, or what a body can make, but the host of social relations and somatic practices that communicate by way of touch" (4).

Interleaf—New Roots/New Routes



Jill Samuels, *New Roots/New Routes,* 2022. 18″×24″. Acrylic paint, oil stick, and collage on paper.

CONVERGENCE 5

A/Geography

Unsettling the Geographical Imagination of Global Asias

Omer Aijazi, Jini Kim Watson,
and Shaolu Yu

Research Forum

Readers, welcome. What follows is a dialogue that developed out of a series of (virtual) meetings and discussions in spring 2022.[1] Refreshing Edward Said's ideas on imagined geographies, Tina Chen encouraged us to foreground the construction and deployment of the geographical designation, in this instance to think of Global Asias as imaginable "a/geography" (Chen 2021b). Upon being assigned the keyword "a/geography," we were initially both intrigued and confused. What is a/geography? Is it the opposite of, or undoing of, geography? Coming from three different disciplinary (or anti-disciplinary) backgrounds, our early conversations began a process through which we collectively worked through how a/geography relates to our disciplinary orientations and how it could inform our respective research agendas on Global Asias. Noting how our responses unlocked further questions, and that we had more questions than answers, we have written this convergence as an A&Q. By this, we mean a series of exploratory discussions that flip the conventional Q&A model to reflect the genuinely dialogic method with which we grappled with our keyword. As you'll see, the A&Q format also captures how we attempt to hold each other in conversation. There is tension—sometimes talking over one another, other times talking past. Listening is a gradual training of attention, we quickly realized; it is not a beautiful given. It can be inconvenient, bumpy, frustrating, even ugly.

If our training and positionalities sometimes kept us apart, we nevertheless found connections via drawbridges, tunnels, and side doors. For example, we share the same urgent call for decolonizing knowledge production of Asia and the value of counter-mapping. We also found ourselves returning to some of the same questions in different guises: Is geography tied to empire? How is empire tied to mapping? How is mapping tied to knowledge? And how do metaphors of spatiality inform epistemology? In terms of practicalities, we first generated a set of questions based on several rounds of discussions and then each took turns being first to respond. The three main questions address: geography's relationship to academic knowledge production; our understanding of what a/geography is and could be; and the possible anxieties or limitations that might attend the term. Belying this neat summary, however, questions and answers were

forged through collaboration, via an iterative and circular process, and represent far from a linear journey.

These questions and debates permeate and shape our individual essays, which follow the dialogue. That section allows us to delve deeper into the ways our own research perspectives speak to a/geography and Global Asias.

A&Q: Answers and Questions

What connects you to Asia? What brings you to this forum?

Omer Aijazi: I am an anti-disciplinary scholar of "South Asia" and a storyteller, working on questions of violence and repair in the disputed territory of Kashmir and its continuity with Northern Pakistan. By anti-disciplinarity, I mean an intellectual stance that centers epistemic violence at the heart of knowledge production. In other words, my scholarly accountability is not necessarily to the "discipline" but to the people and places where knowledge is extracted and concepts are applied.

Jini Kim Watson: I trained as an architect in Australia before turning to comparative literature and postcolonial studies for my graduate study in the United States. I write on Asian and Pacific literature and film in relation to three related research areas: postwar "Asian tiger" metropolises, decolonization and the global cold war, and contemporary migration regimes in the Pacific.

Shaolu Yu: I am a geographer, trained both in China and in the United States. My current research interests include migration and mobility, race and place, and Asian urbanism. I am also interested in applying cartography and geographical information systems (GIS) in visualizing and analyzing spatial data. My current research project is about the Chinese racial experience and Chinese grocery stores in the American South.

How can we understand the role of geography in the current canonization/compartmentalization/professionalization of academic knowledge production on Asia? How has geographical thinking played into the construction of your research areas?

Shaolu Yu: The meaning of geography varies across time and space. To give some background on the discipline from my perspective as a geographer, the main focus of geography before 1945 in the Western context lay in collecting, synthesizing, and integrating factual geographical information. Richard Hartshorne defined the ultimate purpose of geography as "to study areal variation/differentiation of the world" (Hartshorne 1939). Areal differentiation leads to regional geography, which divides the world into relatively homogenous and distinctive areas based on certain geographical features. Also, there are topical specializations within geography, such as climate geography, urban geography, economic geography, cultural geography, transportation geography, medical geography, political geography, and so on. It is inevitable that each topical geography produces its own regionalizations. For example, vegetation can be consistent within a particular geographical area, yet its language and culture might vary. Since 1945, as geography has grown and evolved, compartmentalization and canonization have been driven more by topical geography and methodological differences rather than regional geographies. For instance, geography was dominated by spatial analysis after World War II. Humanistic geography emerged in the 1960s out of criticism of spatial science for its lack of human concerns. More recently, there was a radical turn influenced by Marxism and structuralism, and a cultural turn influenced by postmodernism. The popularity of GIS in the 1990s revived the spatial analysis approach. Now all these different approaches are mixed in the formation of geography as a discipline, which continues to grow and evolve. Feminist Geographies, Queer Geographies, and Black Geographies represent vibrant sub-branches that forefront critical thinking on social-spatial relations.

Because of the move away from the focus on regional geographies, now the term "Asian geography" appears almost only in textbooks for general geographical education. In textbooks on world geography in the United States, for example, "Asian geography" is conveniently and imperfectly divided into East Asia, South Asia, Southeast Asia, and Central Asia. This system is similarly used in geography textbooks in non-Western countries. The compartmentalizations and regionalization of Asia are limiting, but paradoxically, this makes crossing the boundaries between subregions productive, and the fuzzy areas of junctures controversial and unstable, thus seeding spaces of disruption and resistance. I am not sure what would be a situation without compartmentalization, but that situation seems to assume homogeneity and totality.

Omer Aijazi: I am intrigued by your tracing of geography as a discipline, Shaolu, but I find this tracing to be partial. The enduring imperial legacies of geography, the mobilization of geographical knowledge for empire, remain understated. I am in agreement that geography has come a long way as a discipline, but it has nonetheless codified our ability to see Asia in particular ways. What are some lasting consequences of the discipline for knowledge production on Asia? What are some enduring "geographical truths" that are difficult to shake off, and how are they hindering future conversations? These are some questions on my mind that I think should be pursued in conversation with the map of the discipline you present.

Shaolu Yu: Yes, geography in the Western world certainly has a strong imperial and colonial past and present. However, vernacular geographies of different places in the world in various forms existed long before the birth of geography as a discipline in the West. Not to mention that the latter was largely founded on the exploitation of the former. Thus, to center the discussion on geographical knowledge as a colonial tool neglects the origins of geographical knowledge in local and Indigenous communities before the colonial era.

Additionally, the misconception of geography as a discipline to be only the production of geographical knowledge needs to be challenged. The core of geography is the study of human-environment relationships, which is far more than just geographical knowledge of a particular area. Also, the criticism and the alternatives of the production of geographical knowledge have long been vibrant movements within the discipline itself. For example, many geographers have been involved in criticizing the power of mapping and the production of geographical knowledge as a way of control and manifestation of power asymmetry (Crampton and Krygier 2005, 11–33; Kwan 2007, 22–34; Wood 2010; Dando 2018; Alderman, Inwood, and Bottone 2021, 67–78). This criticism leads to the birth of critical cartography and counter-mapping.

The human-environment framework is the core of my research as a geographer. For example, my research on Flushing in New York City focuses on the formation of the contemporary Chinatown as a result of racism and transnationalism and how the geography of Chinatown impacts the everyday physical and social mobility of its people (Yu 2016). Similarly,

my research on Chinese grocery stores in the Jim Crow South centers on the relationship between race and space (Yu 2021). That is, the racialization of space and spatialization of race perceptualize each other and maintain the plantation system and racial hierarchy in the American South. Mobility is also a geographical concept, which suggests the disruption of existing boundaries, be they physical, metaphorical, social, or racial. Mobility suggests and motivates human agency in terms of survival, resistance, and place making, as well as unsettled and remade identity formation while crossing borders/geography. Thus, geography is relational, dynamic, and disruptive, rather than being factual and static.

Omer Aijazi: "Discipline *is* empire," Katherine McKittrick (2020, 46; emphasis mine) tells us. Foucault (1977) also reminds us that the roots of disciplinary knowledge lie within the same mechanisms of control that established the modern prison and penal system in eighteenth-century France. At the same time, the relation between geographical knowledges held by Indigenous and local communities and those produced within geography as a disciplinary formation is indeed a complicated one. As you have also hinted, Shaolu, the very erasure of local knowledges arguably shapes the heart of the field. In my experience, much like what McKittrick and Foucault say, disciplines tend to shrink and constrain how we see the world, not the other way around.

Let me put this in context. My research takes place in the colonized territory of Kashmir—a contested borderland of sorts, caught between the state-seeking nationalisms of India, Pakistan, and China. For far too long, Kashmir has been made subservient to a "South Asian" historiography, blocking alternate discussions on its forms and futures. I want to interrupt Kashmir's reincarceration into the intellectual legacies of South Asia. But this hasn't been easy; the pushback has been intense. I think disciplines and disciplinary orientations pose a serious challenge to decolonial world-building.

It is important to pay attention to the underlying routes and roots of the geographical imagination that reincarcerate Asia within established modes of knowing, some of which have been harmful. A crucial reason why Kashmir remains stuck in the drama of nation-states is that we have been unable to imagine it as anything else. The very same imagination that

goes into the production of nation-states informs the formation of disciplines. Nation-states don't disappear from our analysis and future imaginaries because disciplines don't.

Jini Kim Watson: Omer, it's really helpful to understand the violent disciplinary orientations that have framed Kashmir, and I appreciate the way Shaolu has given us an entry into the changing discipline of geography. To my mind, Shaolu's work on the "racialization of space" and the "spatialization of race" is in the spirit of the kind of decolonizing disciplinary work that I think we are all aspiring to. It counters some of those "geographical truths" of the Jim Crow South by going beyond the assumed nature of Black/White dichotomies. This is also a fascinating case where mobility disrupts certain spatial boundaries, while other hierarchies persist or are recomposed.

Equally, I agree on the need to interrogate the "underlying routes and roots of the geographical imagination" (Omer) that constitutes Asia, especially those that remain so invested in the nation-state form. I have come to parallel questions less in terms of evolutions within the discipline of geography, and more through a postcolonial perspective and the way a variety of spatialized knowledge forms implicitly center Euro-America. Even now, historical change and global culture are usually conceived of as originating in the West and then transmitted to the rest of the world via colonialism or homogenizing processes of globalization. I think back to my architectural training in Australia, for example, where "architectural history" was simply the history of the "West" (from the Greeks through to Western Europe), and "architectural theory" was the philosophy and thought of Europe. Lewis and Wigen's (1997) important critique of the Europe-Asia geographical binary—whereby Asia has long been conceptualized more by its "supposed lack of Europeanness than by any positive attributes of its own" (41)—is still relevant to today's disciplinary formations. Speaking more specifically to my current fields of postcolonial and comparative literature, modern empires and imperial projects have indelibly shaped the way we think about race, place, culture, and language and, indeed, European geographical knowledge has structured the way literary studies itself has been organized. Until very recently, comparative literature departments were almost always dominated by European literature

and European literary theories, and built into the discipline was a geographical dispensation that determined the hierarchical value of languages. Asian-language literatures are by and large still sequestered in Asian studies departments and are usually not considered sites that "produce" literary or cultural theory. Meanwhile, in English departments, postcolonial literary studies has greatly widened the canon since the 1980s and 1990s, but typically privileged selected Anglophone literature from South Asia, Africa, and the Caribbean. Asian American literary studies was, until recently, circumscribed by questions of domestic national belonging and its place in the landscape of American "ethnic literatures," and has been kept apart from other Asian literatures. I see the recent turn to "Transpacific studies" and Global Asias as salutary in the rejection of those disciplinary silos.

To me, the work of decolonizing disciplinary spaces would be the opening up, reconceiving, and recomposing of these inquiries by anti-imperialist, anti-capitalist, feminist, Global South, and queer perspectives. Not being in the field of geography, I've thought less about whether that field is irredeemably limited by its imperial history and disciplinary presuppositions. But I've been deeply influenced by Marxist geographers and thinkers like Henri Lefebvre (1992), Neil Smith (1984), David Harvey (2001), and Ruth Wilson Gilmore (2007, 2022). We might also think of the Forensic Architecture group based at Goldsmiths College, London, which repurposes architecture and spatial analysis to investigate state violence and human rights abuses around the world. Might it be helpful to disaggregate something like "big G" geography—imperialist formations with their bordering functions and will to power—with "small g" geography, which might include counter-mapping, anti-capitalist, Indigenous, and alternative spatial knowledges?

Shaolu Yu: I appreciate your thoughts from a literary perspective, Jini, which is a new territory for me. This helps me understand the production of geographical knowledge within the disciplinary context of literary studies in the United States. Echoing Jini's architectural training experience in Australia, I am troubled by the lack of recognition given to geographical writings, mapping, and philosophy in Asian languages, whereas books on Western geographical thoughts and trends are celebrated and popular-

ized in Asia, to the point that scholars in Asia largely center geographical research and practices on trendy Western theories and methodologies, while neglecting our own roots and genealogy. I appreciate Jini's differentiation between "small g" and "big G," and I cannot agree more with Omer's criticism on geography and overall disciplinary knowledge production. But this criticism still centers on geography in the Western context. What about geography as a discipline in the non-Western world? What about geographical knowledge about Asia in Asia? And what are the relationships between Geography and geography?

Omer Aijazi: Returning to Jini's thoughts on decolonizing disciplinary spaces, I think the stakes for decolonizing disciplines are even higher than imagined within the broader academic house. The labor and intent of decolonizing is not the same as the work of interdisciplinary research, as sometimes understood—and I appreciate that is not your position either, Jini. Interdisciplinarity is a welcome move: opening the boundaries of canonical knowledge even if selectively is certainly encouraging. But this still represents an institutional understanding of "decolonizing"—one that is safe, obedient, and depoliticized. I think decolonizing evokes a far more disobedient sensorium that is not only about putting disparate fields in conversation with one another but also about interrupting the rationalities that govern field formation altogether.

Take South Asian studies' inability to break free from an India-centric reading of Asia as an example—a stance quickly undone by Kashmir, rendering South Asian studies a difficult, if not an impossible, intellectual home.

Jini Kim Watson: Omer, I now understand that your critique about decolonizing knowledge is a much more robust one: to get beyond the academic system of "obedient and depoliticized" knowledge writ large and the way radical work can get absorbed into the university's processes of valuation. I don't disagree with these points. My goals are perhaps more modest: rather than taking aim at disciplinarity itself, I am interested in telling *different* stories about Asia—stories that challenge its usual rendering in Orientalist and imperialist epistemes—using an eclectic mix of tools from postcolonial and inter-Asian cultural studies. The latter is where I hope to

open space for, as Shaolu puts it, "geographical knowledge about Asia in Asia." The wager is to appropriate certain tools and methods without taking on all the presuppositions of a discipline.

Shaolu Yu: I agree with both Omer and Jini on the colonial nature of the academic industrial complex, and that interdisciplinary work is certainly not immune from this system, which oftentimes perpetuates and reproduces oppression and privilege, in academic journal publishing, conferences, the job market, and so on. But I think the bifurcation of disciplinary versus interdisciplinary is limiting. Geography, like many other disciplines, is interdisciplinary itself. The annual conferences of the American Association of Geographers have scholars from different disciplinary backgrounds. I cannot think of one research method that is exclusively from geographers and for geographers. Similar to my point on regionalism in geography and the way it paradoxically creates fuzzy, controversial, and intriguing in-between spaces, so too the formation of disciplines can result in productive spaces between them. Interdisciplinary spaces do not exist without the compartmentalization of disciplines, and creative and radical spaces do not exist without structures. Yes, Omer, Foucault pointed out the similarities between disciplinary knowledge and incarceration, but isn't he himself a celebrated product of the system?

Omer Aijazi: Perhaps, instead of binary thinking, as Shaolu cautions, and keeping in mind the distinction between "big G" and "small g" geography as Jini suggests, we can imagine a relation of tension and accountability between the disciplines and interdisciplines, and other possible ways of apprehending Asia?

Michi Saagiig Nishnaabeg scholar Leanne Simpson writes, "While theoretically, we have debated whether Audre Lorde's 'the master's tools can dismantle the master's house,' I am interested in a different question. I am not so concerned with how we dismantle the master's house, that is, which sets of theories we use to critique colonialism; but I am very concerned with how we (re)build our own house, or our own houses" (2011). By placing pressure on disciplinary routes and roots that structure the geographical imagination, *what other futures may be forthcoming?*

What does a/geography mean for you? How do you understand a/geography? How does a/geography relate to other counter-mapping, decolonial, and remapping projects? What other knowledge forms on Asias can be enabled by a/geography? How can Asias be made differently legible by a/geography? How does a/geography help us understand movement and migration?

Jini Kim Watson: We've already had a lot of discussion trying to figure out what "a/geography" means! Perhaps we can start by thinking about the way this neologism puts pressure on geographical knowledge or shows the *construction* of geographical knowledge. The prefix "a" can mean several different things: "not" or "without" (as in apolitical, asymmetrical) or "toward" and "of" (as in aground, aside, or afar). The "a" in a/geography potentially straddles both of these meanings: it's not a negation of geography so much as a turning toward a different understanding of geography, a defamiliarization of our usual coordinates, so to speak. As we've already been discussing from our different standpoints, this is not a new endeavor. There are many kinds of deconstructions of geographical mappings and knowledge available: borderlands theory, Indigenous and other vernacular geographical knowledges (as the Indigeneity research group has demonstrated), Marxist geography, activist mapping projects, or the emphasis on movement in migration and transnational studies.

In terms of cultural theories of Asia—which I'm probably most familiar with—there is also a robust critical history of denaturalizing and interrogating what "Asia" is and how it has been defined, usually from the outside. Just a few of the major interventions would include Edward Said's *Orientalism* (1978), Martin W. Lewis and Kären E. Wigen's *The Myth of Continents* (1997), Gayatri Spivak's *Other Asias* (2003), Chen Kuan-hsing and Chua Beng Huat's *The Inter-Asia Cultural Studies Reader* (2007), Chen Kuan-hsing's *Asia as Method* (2010), Wang Hui's *The Politics of Imagining Asia* (2011), and Tina Chen's "Global Asias—On the Structural Incoherence of Imaginable Ageography" (2021a). These texts have diagnosed the way imperial spatial and geographical knowledge practices have produced "Asia" to buttress certain worldviews of it as the colonizable Orient, as cold war geopolitical territory, as an aggregate of nation-states, as hypercapitalistic Asia-Pacific Rim, and so on. Collectively, they point to the fact

that if we seek to produce accounts of inter-Asian resistances and revolutions, we must explore how conceptualizations of Asia are currently produced and maintained by dominant epistemes of empire, geopolitics, race, ethnicity, the nation-state, and globalization. This means there is a double thrust inherent to a/geographical thinking; it seeks to disclose the ways geographical and area knowledge is constituted in order to look for other geographies of dissent and solidarity.

Omer Aijazi: Building on your thoughts, Jini, it might also be worthwhile to consider a/geography as a speculative knowledge formation. Speculative knowledges assist us in reimagining future(s) that are contingent on reimagining the past and present. Palestinian artist Larissa Sansour and her collaborator Søren Lind illustrate this point beautifully in their film *In the Future They Ate from the Finest Porcelain* (2015).[2] The experimental film narrates a resistance group's quest to produce a "future history." The group makes underground deposits of elaborate pieces of porcelain so that in the future their claim to the existence of a people before their obliteration by colonial powers can be upheld. The work is a meditation on Britain's colonial past in the "Middle East" and the borders it instituted to limit Palestinian futurities amid the ongoing erasure of Palestinian territories and histories.

The majority of the world (Queer, Black, Indigenous, People of Color, the systematically marginalized and disempowered) *already* live in dystopia. A speculative future hints at the multiple openings and possibilities that arise from a tired present, where *we* have made it. For example, Afrofuturist writings describe a reality in which Black people thrive; Indigenous futurisms show a world where Indigenous peoples and their knowledge systems play a central role in the maintenance of the universe. There is now emerging work on Asian futurisms. It is possible to consider a/geography as a future-oriented inventory of possibility—*what can it enable?* A disaggregation of the expectations from geographical knowledge? If we do imagine the "a" in a/geography as a disavowal and a turning away, what are we then turning toward? A/geography gives me hope to think further about people, communities, places, that have been foreclosed by the pressures of geographical knowledge.

Whenever we try to make something legible, we open some aspects of the world and foreclose others. A/geography can perhaps enable us to

open those routes and roots that are routinely dismissed because they don't serve more centrally situated knowledge projects and standards of adjudication. It could help us paint the world anew in the service of those whom current modes of legibility dismiss/erase/annihilate.

Jini Kim Watson: I find this really intriguing, Omer. We typically think about speculative futures in terms of alternative temporalities rather than spatialities, so I like the way you are linking these futures to a/geographies. This helps us to ask: how is imagining a different, non-oppressive future dependent on imagining new relationships to topography, movement, lands, resources, and mapping? What do these look like? In my work, I'm interested in anachronist figures of history (defeated leftists, communists, political exiles) to think about the "energies and demands not just for another world that was never realized, but for the ongoing right to help define our political futures" (Watson 2021, 154). I find the example you mention by the Palestinian artist Sansour so poignant because the artist isn't so much producing a new future as creating a new *past* to be discovered by future generations. Obviously, unthinking the tyranny of imperial occupying bordering practices is key to such an imagination: what replaces it?

Shaolu Yu: I found it intriguing and exciting to consider Omer's thoughts on a/geography as speculative knowledge formation that opens multiple possibilities of truths, especially allowing spaces for historically marginalized communities. My immediate questions on this thought are: What are the relationships between the future and the past/present? What are we speculating from? And what are we speculating toward? In addition to the examples in art and media production, how do scholars speculate a different future?

Omer Aijazi: I am drawn to the question posed by Jini: "How is imagining a different non-oppressive future dependent on imagining new relationships to topography, movement, lands, resources, and mapping?" This to me, is a key offering of a/geography: a call to imagine *new* relations to geographical knowledge for *different* future(s) of Asia.

For me, a/geography is intertwined with epistemology: spatial metaphors inform how we come to know the world.[3]

Shaolu Yu: You both have helped me in thinking about a/geography. I initially thought of "a" as what Jini referred to as its first meaning: "without" or "not." A/geography immediately reminded me of the existential crisis within geography in the 1980s, in which with the rise of an increasingly globalized world, geography no longer seemed to matter as borders were crossed and distance was conquered by technological advances (Friedman 2006). If the world were moving toward homogeneity, then geography, with its focus on areal differentiation, would eventually disappear. So an important counterargument would be that globalization is a divergent and heterogenous process. Asias, being both recipients and drivers of globalization, are plural because of the differentiation of geography, history, culture, and political and economic systems. Thus, geography is more important than ever to understand an increasingly polarized and uneven world.

Our discussions have helped me understand that a/geography can mean the de-construction of geographical knowledge and defamiliarization of our usual coordinates. I echo with Jini that this attempt is not new. This brings me to counter/mapping and efforts to decolonialize geographical knowledge among geographers on the methodological aspects in research, teaching, and mapping. Discussions around critical cartography, participatory GIS, radical mapping, and counter-mapping are prolific (Crampton and Krygier 2005, 11–33; Kwan 2007, 22–34; Wood 2010; Dando 2018; Alderman, Inwood, and Bottone 2021, 67–78). One effort is to change the usual coordinate systems in cartography, which historically center Western colonial powers while misrepresenting countries in Africa and Asia. Among the most well-known examples is "Why Google Maps Gets Africa Wrong" (Wan 2014), which highlights that the world Mercator projection system distorts the size of Africa, South and Southeast Asia, and Latin America, making them appear to be significantly smaller in comparison to North America and Europe. Another example is the upside-down map, or South-up map. A usual world map represents North up and South down, which has significant psychological and material impacts on wealth and power distribution, with the Global North perceived as wealthier and Whiter, and the Global South as poorer and to be civilized. These upside-down maps or South-up maps attempt to challenge the power asymmetry and decenter Western colonial power.

Omer Aijazi: I am also interested in movement, spatial fluidity, and countermapping as departures from the overly determined geographies of Asia.

A series of maps depicting the shrinking Palestinian territories appeared in metro stations across New York some years ago, causing a stir (*HuffPost* 2012). This reminded me of how maps authorize geographical knowledge and are integral to the colonial experience. The "map" of Kashmir, a former princely state, is also routinely "modified" to conform to the imperial gaze. Kashmir's changing maps suggest not only historical change and political ambition but a sense of whimsy. The "official" map of Kashmir is dependent on who draws it (see figure 5.1). In 2020, Pakistan launched a "new political map" of the country, which claims Kashmir in its entirety (News International 2020). It is illegal in Pakistan to use any other version of the map. India too changed its "map" after unilaterally removing Kashmir's special administrative status in 2019. India has long embarked on a meticulous process of renaming and rezoning occupied lands accompanied by substantial demographic shifts—the changes are uploaded onto a new map each time. Pakistan's cartographical reading of Kashmir is an interesting departure, as it leaves the outer edges of Kashmir "ostentatiously unbounded—an astounding rebuttal of the universal dependence of national maps on borders" (Kabir 2009, 8).

Figure 5.1 suggests to me that maps are neither neutral nor apolitical, and that maps insist on particular readings of the world as empirical truths. The people of Kashmir are depicted as being dispersed among various competing nation-states. Through these maps, Kashmiris are codified as belonging to Pakistan, India, or China, erasing their historicity entirely. Can maps adequately depict that Kashmiris in fact live under continual colonial rule and that they have been violently detached from one another (Aijazi 2020)?

The exhibition *Defining Lines: Cartography in the Age of Empire,* which ran from 2013 to 2014 at the Nasher Museum of Art (Duke University), shows how maps evolved from aesthetic devices to instruments of legal authority between the sixteenth and twentieth centuries, and how maps were used as a form of political control and public perception management.[4] The legacies of imperial cartography are enduring. Hazard maps and disaster risk maps exceptionalize geography with grave consequences



Figure 5.1. Redrawing the Maps in Kashmir. Imperial Cartographies of Kashmir. © Stiftung Wissenschaft und Politik, 2020. Image courtesy of Christian Wagner and Angela Stanzel, "Redrawing the Maps in Kashmir: New Geopolitical Realities in the Conflict between China, India and Pakistan," Stiftung Wissenschaft und Politik, 2020.

when risk geographies coincide with geographies of the colonized. As Shaolu also points out, mapping has been reclaimed through participatory and counter-practices by Indigenous, Black, Brown, and Queer bodies to enable different geographical stories. The New York–based Iraqi performance artist Wafaa Bilal tattooed the names of Iraqi cities on his back followed by thousands of dots, each representing a life lost during the US invasion of Iraq (Pellegrinelli 2010). The artist created a map of pain, an affective map, to "provide diagnoses of and alternatives to the geopolitical and epistemological maps produced by the US global security state" (Kapadia 2016, 360–375).

Mapping suggests control and a particular relation to knowledge and geography. It suggests a mastery of sorts: phrases like "mapping the literature" and "mapping the field" are staples in academic training and writing. As suggested earlier, in my view, disciplinary borders and geopolitical borders are co-constitutive. Mapping suggests containment and stasis and a sense of fencing off in the realms of both knowledge production and geopolitics. Paradoxically, this fencing off can trigger movement: millions of asylum seekers annually make their way to Europe despite its increasing fortification and the perilous journey involved. The partition of the Indian subcontinent by the British resulted in the movement of some 15 million people. In my work with borderland communities in Kashmir, I read the daily movements and flows of human and more-than-human bodies as a reworking and reopening of Kashmir's imposed borders. Venturing far into otherwise inaccessible corners of the mountainous landscape with livestock for grazing or harvesting wild onions and mushrooms on perilous mountain edges can be understood as forms of emplacement that are paradoxically unbounded and generative. These are also counter-maps that refuse the foreclosures of the Line of Control, the 750-kilometer-long de facto border that arbitrarily splinters Kashmir into India and Pakistan. In these movements and flows, one can begin to find analytical and philological opportunities to articulate fully formed visions of Kashmir that are not beholden to the foreclosures of borders and borderlines. Against a backdrop of containment, stasis, and foreclosure, movement can help us imagine a *different* relationship to control and geographical knowledge, whether this is the movement of bodies read against the fixity of borders or the

flow of ideas, such as the travel of postcolonial theory to East Asia, while it is commonly reserved for South Asia, Africa, and the Caribbean.

Shaolu Yu: I appreciate Omer's criticism on mapping as a colonial and political tool, and I find it intriguing to view human movement as a way of counter-mapping. I feel the urge to defend maps, though, because they are merely a kind of media that deliver and perpetuate certain ideology and propaganda, similar to literature and films of that nature. Thus, the struggles with mapping are essentially the struggles with power. To shift this power dynamic is to prioritize mapping and diverse ways of production and distribution of geographical knowledge in local and Indigenous communities, and to empower marginalized communities with a variety of mapping and storytelling tools, which is what counter-mapping and critical cartography are arguing for. Additionally, voluntary GIS (geographical information systems), which is a platform for interactive mapping where individuals can contribute to mapping in a simple and democratic way, plays a major role in identifying communities' needs, especially during environmental disasters.

Circling back to the differentiation between "small g" and "big G," centering mapping on its colonial history ignores mapping practices by Indigenous communities long before colonial powers even existed. Mapping can be traced back to ancient times, when Indigenous communities around the world used maps for storytelling, survival, resource sharing, and celebration, which demonstrated a much more sustainable relationship between human and the environment. For example, the art exhibit at the Frist Art Museum in Nashville, Tennessee, titled *Ancestral Modern: Australian Aboriginal Art,*[5] was inspired by the maps made by Indigenous communities in Australia to identify and share resources such as water, food, and shelter. Not only did these "counter-maps" exist before colonial maps, but such Indigenous geographical knowledge was largely exploited by Western settlers for the purpose of colonization and the formation of Geography as a discipline.

Omer Aijazi: Maps, or shall I say counter-maps, can certainly provide openings for empowerment, emancipation, and freedom. Take the very powerful *Subjective Atlas of Palestine* (de Vet 2007), put together by

Palestinian artists and activists, as an example. I, too, in a previous life as a community planner, worked frequently with participatory mapping processes in contexts of disaster and war with these very hopes. I am trying to articulate the onto-epistemic suppositions of mapping, not negate its entire range of possibilities.

To my understanding, mapping is an attempt at legibility: seeking to foreclose people, place—life—within particular intellectual genealogies. Maps are "ideological constructions that *produce* the world through the spatial ontologies they advance," rather than merely reflecting it (Chen 2017; Wood and Fels 2008). They are self-referential systems of knowledge, committed to extending their own routes of legibility (Goeman 2012). Geographical knowledge, in many circumstances (but as Shaolu and Jini point out, not always), can become a natural ally to the disciplinary proclivities of imperial knowledge production where knowledge that is immediately locatable and clearly fenced off (i.e., knowledge that can be "mapped") is rewarded and venerated. Movement puts pressure on this fencing off, encouraging us to think of counter-maps that do not present Asia as bounded location. Putting pressure on the geographical imagination, or enriching it, can be thought of as an attempt at finding relations that have been dulled by colonial cartography and the many realisms of area studies and other forms of imperial knowledge production. I take a/geography as an invitation to think seriously about the nonrepresentational and imaginative geographies of Asia that disrupt the fixity of imperial cartography, a task I will attempt in my short essay that follows our dialogue.

Jini Kim Watson: I'm also unsure as to whether mapping is always an attempt to foreclose people, place, and life, as Omer says. How would we understand the Australian Aboriginal artworks that seek to make legible a community's understanding of history, culture, and Country through a visual and epistemological mapping? I think we are limited if we only think of "mapping" in terms of imperial maps that reproduce the statist knotting of territory, people, and sovereignty; as Shaolu points out, what is at stake is who holds the power to produce dominant cartographies.[6] When we look historically, geographical forms of knowledge (whether tied to

notions of race, bloodlines, ancestry, religion, progress, civilization, or "the people") have been historically flexible in serving whatever forms of social organization and power are ascendant.

But the idea of "finding relations that have been dulled by colonial cartography" is a wonderful phrase that encapsulates for me why moving beyond the positivism of bounded people/territory/culture is so important. It also suggests, in the mode of Édouard Glissant (1990), relation preceding and taking precedence over identity. In the spirit of including alternative mapping projects, I want to invoke the map of Afro-Asian connections shown in figure 5.2.

Each line represents the movement of a participant who traveled to attend the various major Afro-Asian and nonaligned movement meetings held from the 1950s to the 1970s, when efforts were made, following the 1955 Asian-African Conference in Bandung, to rethink global relationality *without* having to go through Europe and its colonially mandated order. This map visualizes a kind of methodology that we can find in inter-Asian cultural studies or comparative Global South studies: it produces a new geography of "centers" beyond London–Paris–Tokyo–New York—that of places such as Conakry, Cairo, Tashkent, and Bandung. It thereby usefully "multiplies" Asia, while also questioning the self-Orientalizing discourses that still inhere in many discourses of Asia. Organizations like the Afro-Asian People's Solidarity Organization and the Tricontinental spurred new literary and cultural networks and connections that have largely been forgotten in our own moment. Perhaps these modes of comparativity and inter-Asian, and inter–Global South solidarity, might also be called "a/geographical"?

Building on Omer's provocation regarding nonrepresentational and imaginative geographies of Asia, I would like to offer an idea of literary narration as a possible a/geographic method to counter imperial mapping. My work has examined the way narrative forms take up global processes and remap them in very different ways from Orientalist, colonialist, or nationalist ways. I'm thinking, for example, of an exquisite novel by the Korean dissident author Hwang Sok-yong, *The Guest* (*Sonnim,* 2001), which narrates the reverse journey of a Korean American pastor back to his tiny hometown in today's North Korea (Watson 2014, 69–87). The latter was the site of a horrendous inter-Korean massacre during the Korean War, in which the perpetrators remain contested by both North and South

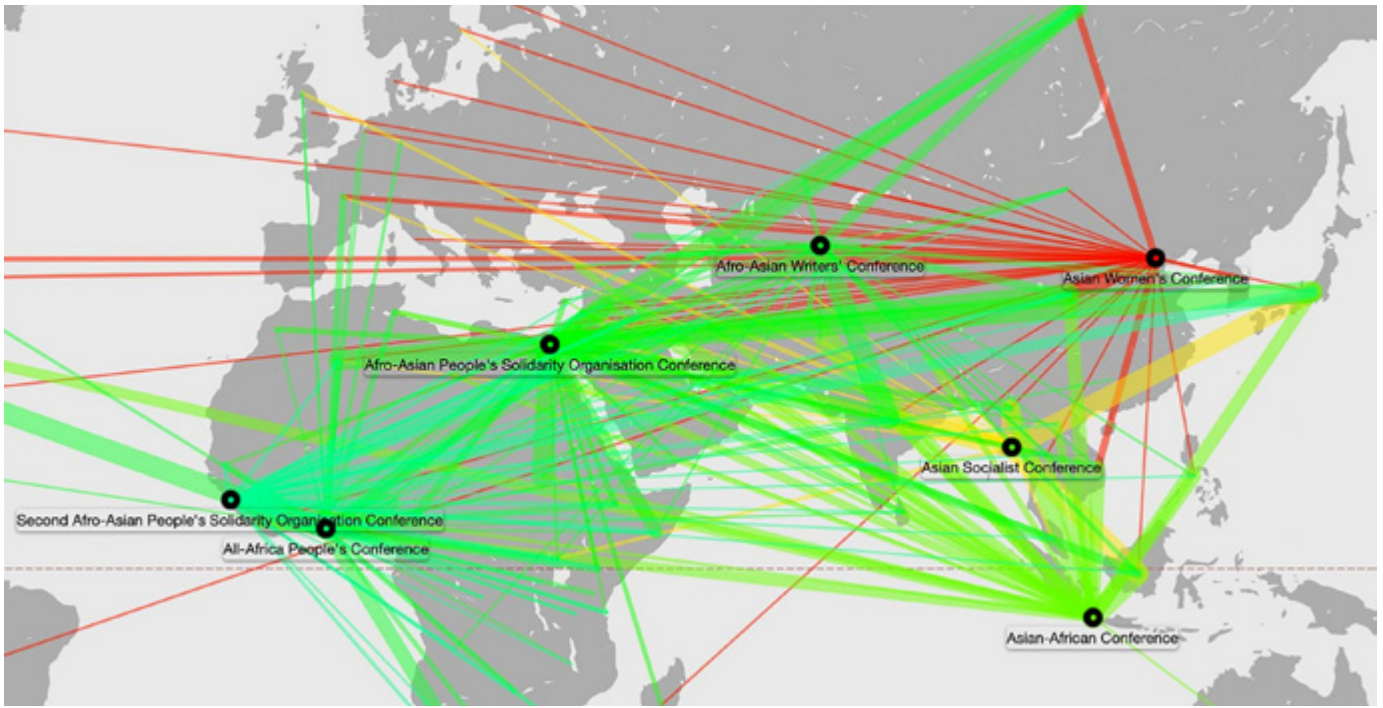


Figure 5.2. Map of Afro-Asian Connections, 2022. "Afro-Asian Networks Visualised," Afro-Asian Networks Project, https://afroasian.mediaplaygrounds.co.uk/.

Korea. The novel follows the elderly pastor's gradual journey from New York to Los Angeles, to northern China, to Pyongyang, to the town of Shinchŏn, and then, finally, to his home village of Ch'ansaemgol, in a complex aesthetic weave of time, space, and memory. What's interesting, formally, is that the moral and historical weight of the story grows in inverse proportion as he moves to ever smaller, more "insignificant" territorial sites. That is, the truth of the massacre is revealed only after he has left the "global centers" of New York and Los Angeles and returned to his home village, Ch'ansaemgol, a place that is literally unlocatable on Google Maps. The narrative therefore disrupts the geographic assumption of center and periphery, and questions the sedimented historical and ideological boundaries that have maintained the division of the Korean peninsula: North versus South; communist inhumanity versus Christian humanity; and the United States, the Soviet Union, and China as the protagonists of the war. Fictional narratives can function, in other words, as a mode of boundary- and time-crossing storytelling that can create alternative geographies of memory and solidarity across communities.

Shaolu Yu: Jini's Afro-Asian map and the counter-mapping within literary context, and Omer's comments on migration and counter-mapping open the door to geographies of comparativity and solidarity and remind me of the relations between movement and a/geography. Movement happens only when there are differences in geography, and reversely, movement reshapes geography. Difference in elevation makes rivers move, sustaining life on earth; difference in pressure makes air move, carving out mountains and valleys; difference in temperature makes oceans move, regulating the largest ecosystem of the planet. Similarly, differences in geography (political, economic, cultural, ideological, or environmental) make people move. And movement, in return, re/shapes geography, circling back to Omer's argument that human movement is a way of counter-mapping.

Migration from Asian countries to North America and Europe is among the highest flows of people in the contemporary world. This migration flow is largely driven by the disparity in economic opportunities and other social and political indicators. Human migration, along with the accompanying labor, capital, and talents, perpetuates geography of disparity. This reinforcing cycle of movement and geography also exists

in the rural-urban migration within Asia driven by the global capitalism system.

I'm interested in the way movement results in enclaves. Enclaves are formed for people on the move, such as villages in the cities (*cheng zhong cun* 城中村), where rural-urban migrants temporarily reside without equal access to housing and education in urban China due to the *hukou* system; Chinatowns, where some immigrants have never traveled outside its boundaries; and gated communities for elite expats in the most gentrifying neighborhoods in Asian cities, which resemble exclusive zones for White colonizers during the colonial era. In this case, movement allows geography to be crossed but the disparity aggravated.

On the other hand, human migration does reshape geography of culture and identity, imagined and/or materialized. The invention of Chinese American cuisines by Chinese immigrants in the face of exclusion and discrimination in the United States resulted from the interrelationship among globalization, labor, capitalism, and localization. Due to this ever-changing system where geography and movement are constantly transforming each other, perhaps a/geography opens the door to a messy and fluid understanding of geography.

It is important to recognize that not all movements are voluntary and that there are people who are in/voluntarily immobile. Physical mobility is intricately linked to social mobility, reflecting a broader structure of power asymmetry and social hierarchy. This includes refugees who were forced to uproot and relocate elsewhere due to wars and environmental disasters, people with disabilities who were neglected during emergency evacuations, and the left-behind children of rural-urban migrant workers in China. The COVID-19 pandemic has further revealed the disparities in spatial mobility across racial and socioeconomic lines. Situated in the mobility and transnationalism theory, my research on Flushing, New York City, delves into the paradox of transnational mobility and local immobility, and the dialectical relationship between voluntary and involuntary mobility among non-English-speaking Chinese immigrants (Yu 2016).

Omer Aijazi: And movement can happen for all sorts of reasons: enjoyment, curiosity—a sense of wonder. Dance is movement; protest is movement. In addition to migration, it may be worthwhile to also think about

those liberatory and aesthetic practices of movement that have an additional bearing on our mappings of Asia.

What anxieties does a/geography raise? Where are you stuck? What might its limits be?

Omer Aijazi: I am worried that if we are not careful, a/geography risks becoming yet another totalizing framework, replacing one site of interpretive foreclosure with another.

Shaolu Yu: To me, a/geography is not new, and the deconstruction of geographical knowledge is vibrant within geography and beyond. But no matter how we deconstruct geography, the effort is still limited to the knowledge reference system of Western countries. How do we embrace, archive, and prioritize Indigenous knowledge? Does the fact that we are all communicating in English already foreclose this effort? For example, in teaching the Asian Urbanisation through Cinema class, the fact that we have to seek Asian films that are out in the US market and subtitled in English is extremely limiting. I have similar challenges in finding readings or maps on Asian urbanization that reflect knowledge by Asian people. But most of these materials are written in local languages, which limit our options to materials produced by and for English speakers.

Another question in my mind is that it is always easier to deconstruct than to build. There are numerous scholarships on the deconstruction and decoloniality of geographical knowledge. But many of these have focused on criticism; what are the alternatives on the other side? Or should we leave it an open-ended question, rather than finding a closure?

Omer Aijazi: I am wondering, Shaolu, does something have to be "new" to be useful? For me, a/geography is a playful provocation to hold in tension the geographical imagination that we have become so accustomed to. I see it as an invitation to create a parallel imagination.

May I suggest a different imagination of critique and deconstruction altogether? Rather than thinking of them as the binary opposite of building, what if we consider them to be the very practices of building? A/geography *is* an attempt at an alternative; it is "the other side."

Jini Kim Watson: I like the idea of creating a "parallel imagination," Omer. While I think there are possibilities that a/geography opens up, I also wonder what this concept allows us to do that other concepts (counter- and Indigenous mapping, community GIS, deconstructing Eurocentric cartography) don't. And is geography in need of an "a/" more than other disciplinary formations? Should there be an a/anthropology, or an a/literature, or an a/economy? Following Omer's question about the relationship of "new" to "useful," is there a danger of one-upmanship where we seek ever newer meta-critical terms or pronouncements?

Shaolu Yu: I appreciate Omer's argument that deconstruction is part of building, and a/geography opens the possibility of a "parallel imagination." And the questions Jini poses perfectly articulate my concerns about the word "a/geography." I found that a/geography is too vague and broad; it is not different from what is already happening. Something doesn't have to be "new" to be "useful," Omer. But in what ways does a/geography inspire questions that are different from what have already been asked?

Omer Aijazi: Both of you have prompted me to think further about the adjudication of academic knowledge. I find myself reflecting on the largely uncontested assumption that knowledge that emerges from slow shifts within fields and disciplines (or a combination thereof) encompasses the "only" valid mode of legitimate knowledge production. Rather than thinking about knowledge generation through the incremental and additive + and the &, I am suggesting a sensorium of interruptions—the !, @, #.

Thinking of a/geography as a theoretical construct with a strictly traceable genealogy to dispel suspicion about its robustness, usefulness, and validity, I believe, is a kind of "paranoid" reading of the term, as queer theorist Eve Sedgwick would say (2003).

Perhaps, instead of trying to clearly fence out what a/geography is and isn't, that is, attempting an uncontested and defensible "mapping" of the term, what if we open the term further and farther so that it does not end up as another site of theoretical foreclosure?

In other words, what if we *don't* try to force a/geography into the frame of a "concept" and instead give up that sense of definitional control and certitude altogether? I am content with thinking about a/geography as an

open-ended horizon: an aspiration, a provocation, a reminder, an encouragement, a gentle push and a shove, a heartbeat.

Jini Kim Watson: I'm not interested in defending the borders of disciplines or adjudicating the gatekeeping function of "legitimate" academic knowledge. But let me say that I am interested in concepts. That is, what are the political, social, and cultural possibilities that are opened up by a new concept? Let's keep in mind that political and cultural practices themselves produce concepts—I don't think of concepts as being the domain of academic thought only.

Shaolu Yu: Thinking about the example of geography as a discipline, it is both incremental and interruptive. Interruptions do not come from nowhere, but from past knowledge. Otherwise, what is to interrupt? Because of the interruptions, disciplines are incremental and additive. I do not see them as an either/or but a both/and relation. And because of this circular process of building and interruption, the knowledge system continues to evolve.

Contemplating Jini and Omer's comments, I am reminded of bell hook's article titled "Choosing the Margin as a Space of Radical Openness" (1989, 15–23). No matter how I struggle with the "usefulness" of "a/geography," I appreciate the conversation we have had so far inspired by this word. Perhaps a third meaning of "a," other than "negate" and "deconstruct," can be "choosing the margin." And margin is the creative center.

Omer Aijazi: Thanks for summoning bell hooks, Shaolu! Your intervention made me think about *Tender Buttons* (Stein 2002). In the chapter "Rooms," Gertrude Stein further challenges the spatial imagination. She writes, "Act so there is no use in the center. A wide action is not a width. A preparation is given to the ones preparing" (63). Stein suggests that there *is* no center, no definitive vantage point. And "wide actions" or poetic descriptions don't lend themselves to scales of measurement. Instead, they act on behalf of the author to craft their subject—*preparation is for the one preparing.*

Jini Kim Watson: Perhaps we can agree that a/geographies index the potential for disruptions to Euro-imperial and nation-statist geographical imag-

inaries of the world. Those disruptions, however, might be more or less incremental, more or less interruptive. Our different objects of study and their temporalities will always demand different methodologies of thought and action.

This is evident in what follows, in which each of us takes a few pages to reflect on our individual research trajectories in relation to a/geographies and Global Asias. Our critical discussion of the term "a/geography" has made each of us rethink our work in certain ways. My piece discusses possible geographies of decolonization from the peripheral cities and subjects of Asia. For Omer, spatial fluidity and imaginative countermapping constitute a necessary borderland poetics for rethinking freedom in Kashmir. Lastly, Shaolu gives us a personal and intellectual history of her approach to Global Asias, focusing on Chinatowns, race, and transnational mobility and immobility.

Speculative A/Geographies of Kashmir

Omer Aijazi

The record on Kashmir—officially recognized by the United Nations as a disputed territory—reminds us that the nation-state is an unjust and unreliable adjudicator of life and politics. Ever since the formal retreat of the British Empire from the Indian subcontinent in 1947, the former princely state has remained subject to the violent cartographic imaginations of neighboring India and Pakistan, who have fought three major wars over it. Today, Kashmir, considered to be one of the most militarized regions in the world, is splintered between India and Pakistan; parts of it also fall under China. Arguably, Kashmir's colonial present is a result of the denial for it to become any other kind of political space (Bouzas 2019, 31). But, as Katherine McKittrick reminds us, cartographic rules can indeed be contested, and different seizures of geography are possible (McKittrick 2006), where, for example, Kashmiri bodies can move freely—unencumbered by military checkpoints, barbed wire, and borderlines.

Subject to an "ensemble of [colonial] spatial strategies" (Junaid 2013, 161) that are supported by an area studies model drawing on fixed and

territorial notions of the nation, Kashmir's once undivided territory serves as a powerful ground for an "imaginary homeland remembered in the past and also projected into the future" (Bhan, Duschinski, and Zia 2018, 5). Kashmir as an imagined future is a political and philosophical project, an element of South Asia outside the framework of containment. The task, as I see it, is to look for alternate spatial and intellectual imaginaries that seek to unmoor Kashmir from the foreclosures of South Asia.[7] Otherwise, the only alternatives that are forthcoming are those that are reliant on the very same cartographic rules and rationalities that have transfixed Kashmir into a geopolitical order that feels stuck and static in the first place.

Azadi

Azadi (a local word for "freedom") is a catchall word for Kashmiri desires for self-determination and sovereignty. There is an inherent multiplicity to *azadi*. A quote often attributed to Maqbool Bhat, a much-revered Kashmiri public intellectual and political elder, illustrates this: "For us, *azadi* means not just getting rid of foreign occupation of our beloved motherland, but also to remove hunger, poverty, ignorance, and disease, and to overcome economic and social deprivation" (Junaid 2016). Arguably, *azadi* is perhaps too readily mapped in the syntax of coloniality to narrowly mirror the long-forgotten plebiscite promised by the United Nations back in 1948, and as agreed upon by warring Pakistan and India. The plebiscite is meant to assist in the peaceful resolution of the conflict by allowing Kashmiris to vote on their futures using a "three-choice" polling instrument: (1) to stay with India or (2) merge with Pakistan or (3) become an independent state.

Polling was a common British practice to achieve "stability" in former colonies whose post-colonial status was "contentious" (Snedden 2005, 64–86). It was very much a techno-rational approach to reducing complex and multifaceted grievances into the nation-state format. This is not to say that the plebiscite is not important; in fact, it is perhaps the most crucial step in ascertaining *azadi* and really the only current way Kashmir has some legibility in the international order. But Kashmiri desires for *azadi* are also a demand for an open-ended horizon, a Kashmir yet to come (Aijazi 2023). And, if understood in its spirit, the promised plebiscite is an ask without

precondition, a site of generative experimentation and dialogue to honor the aspirations of the people of Kashmir. This is to say that the plebiscite should and must be held but that Kashmiri desires for *azadi* do not end there. *Azadi* can also be understood as a refusal of the "allure of the state sovereignty model" as echoed by Native Hawaiian scholar J. Kēhaulani Kauanui (2018, 195), opening up "multiple futures" (Goodyear-Ka'ōpua 2017). Wendy Brown reminds us that "sovereignty is spoken of today as if we know what we mean by it" when it remains "an unusually amorphous, illusive, and polysemic term of political life" (2020, 252).

A Borderland Poetics

Kashmir bears the markings of multiple borders. Sarah Green notes that borders, much like sex and gender, are historically and socially constructed and performed but are nevertheless real, having devastating implications for people (2012, 573–592). Chiara Brambilla points out that borders don't necessarily only pose closure and abrupt endings but also hint at a politics of possibilities to come (2021, 11–17).

Kashmir is commonly referred to as a borderland, referring to its peripheral status within India, Pakistan, and China, where Kashmir presumably sits at the outer margins of a desired national collectivity. It is also seen to occupy an "in-betweenness" through which it is understood and located on a map: *between* India and Pakistan, *between* India and China.

But Kashmir is not a margin, nor a periphery; rather it exceeds these mappings altogether. Its in-betweenness overrides location. If we reclaim the borderland as sites of indeterminacy capable of expansion and contraction (Aijazi 2018, 88–118), its liminal status cultivates hybridity and transborder encounter, which can challenge Eurocentric ways of organizing knowledge, people, and place (Hernandez-Wolfe and Acevedo 2021, 156–171). The "Kashmir borderland" as a concept metaphor counters the nation-state's master narrative and is an unsettled "zone of potentiality pertinent for studying flows and exchange, the bending and blending of identities" (Saraf 2020); an opportunity to reconfigure imaginative practices that transgress borders and boundaries.

Maya Mikdashi and Jasbir Puar invite us to embrace geographies of permanent war such as Kashmir as queer (Mikdashi and Puar 2016, 215–222). But caution is needed, Sabiha Allouche warns, to prevent

"outer-queer-(y)ing," "the forced and artificial subjugation" (Allouche 2020, 30) of fictive categories created by area studies (such as South Asia) to a solely Western-centric queer analysis. Put differently, if queer works against analytical containment, then what is the connection between queer and the Kashmir borderland?

The turn of the twentieth century equated heterosexuality with good citizenship. Likewise, Inshah Malik argues, the erasure of Kashmiri desire for sovereignty by an assimilationist, heterosexual, and invisibilizing nation-state is akin to a national desire for punishing and correcting sexual difference (2018, 180–194). In fact, continual military operations in Kashmir and state manipulation are forms of queer necropolitics that seek to erase Kashmiri desire (and life) (181). Malik shows us that in the drama of nation-states, Kashmiris are rendered queer precisely because they do not conform to the ideal image of the citizen, a thorn for homogenizing national discourses. Deepti Misri also notes, "looking toward the wrong future, refusing to get with the national program, the willful '*azadi pasand*' (self-determination-loving) Kashmiri political subject lives in queer time" (2020, 539–565).

Movement and Multitude

Amid the massive protests for *azadi,* shutter-down strikes, public processions to mourn the killed, and sit-ins for the forcibly disappeared, other kinds of aesthetic and liberatory practices are also unfolding in Kashmir. For example, several years ago, inspired by the Chinese artist Han Bing, the absurdist cabbage-walking movement arrived in Kashmir (Avila 2021). The performance takes the form of walking a cabbage on a leash in the streets of downtown Srinagar and elsewhere.[8] In an interview with one of the Kashmiri cabbage walkers, the artist notes that they want to fuse the absurdity of this performance with the choking structures of violence around them: the barbed wire, the military checkpoints, the army cantonments, the bunkers that have overwhelmed the Kashmiri landscape, restricting movement and flow (Noel 2016). Parkour has also made inroads into Kashmir, drawing in young people (mostly men) from all walks of life (Tamim 2014). For some, parkour is simply a sport and a performance; for others it is a form of protest against the excesses imposed on them, including curbs to their freedom of movement. The Facebook group

Kashmir Freerunning and Parkour Family—KFPF states that "the main purpose of Parkour is to teach participants how to move through their environment by vaulting, rolling, running, climbing, and leaping." Video clips of young Kashmiri men practicing parkour show them jumping, leaping, running—freedom movements, occupying and claiming space in unsuspecting yet joyous ways.[9]

Parkour is also an efficient way to safely escape from Indian soldiers during curfews and crackdowns, and is a community rooted in movement. The Kashmir Bicycle Movement is yet another example of a community rooted in movement. The aim of this group is ecological consciousness and to re/connect Kashmiris with their environment, giving a sense of another kind of *azadi.* One of the group's objectives, listed on its Facebook page, is to "reclaim certain tracks, paths, lanes exclusively for walking and cycling."[10] Participants counter-map the streets of Kashmir, claiming them back not only from automobiles and fossil fuels but also from the blockages and spatial control imposed by the Indian military. Occupation in Kashmir is experienced through spatial strategies of domination. Ananya Jahanara Kabir suggests that the taking up of bicycles by Kashmiris allows them to rethink *azadi* by regaining access to alleys and pathways dominated by the Indian military (Kabir 2013).

Cycling, parkour, and cabbage walking are investments in spatial fluidity and unfixity, a certain freeing of both region and subject. They are also an embodied reclamation of space in a militarized zone. In this reclamation lie cues to map Kashmir in ways that do not reproduce the "statist knotting of territory, people, and sovereignty" (Jini from our preceding discussion). They offer lines of flight from our inability to imagine across geographic, temporal, and experiential divides. In these movements—freedom movements—lie alternative political imaginaries where Kashmir is not a settled space. Rather, what is forthcoming is a Kashmir of movement and intensity, expanse and multitude. By insisting on Kashmir as a disorienting interstice, demands for *azadi* can also perhaps be more fully articulated. This, in turn, can facilitate important processes of internal experimentation—trial and error, crucial to gathering the wide range of ambitions embedded within desires for freedom.

A/Geographies of Decolonization

Jini Kim Watson

What would it look like to map a/geographies of decolonization in and across Asia? In our research forum, we discussed several examples of maps that exceeded colonialist, statist, or capitalist renderings of Asia. In my work, I've tried to trace alternative imaginary geographies that emerge beyond both the developmentalist economic "miracles" of East Asia and the cold war geopolitical divide between "free" and "unfree" Asia. Although I hadn't considered it in exactly such terms before, this work may be considered a/geographic because it revises sedimented and naturalized understandings of the region's internal and external boundaries: of successful development *here* versus the failures of underdevelopment *there;* of authoritarianism *there* versus liberal democracy *here.* Put otherwise, I am interested in telling the story of postcolonial modernization, urbanization, and political modernity in and across Asia in ways that complicate the way we think about these processes in their typically Euro-American frames. The goal, to quote Fernando Coronil, is to produce remappings "that represent . . . not only geography but history" (2019, 351). In terms of method, I approach disciplines, subject matter, and geographies with a comparative, and sometimes deliberately misappropriated, set of disciplinary tools from literary, urban, and cultural studies. Let me explain by way of examples that draw from my two major research areas.

I came to study the urban forms of Asian developmental "successes"—namely, South Korea, Singapore, and Taiwan (three of the much-touted Four Asian Dragons, with the fourth being Hong Kong)—after moving from Melbourne, Australia, to Gwangju, South Korea, in the late 1990s, where I was struck by the scale, density, and political-historical palimpsests of that southwestern provincial capital. In *The New Asian City* (2011), I questioned the apparently universal pathways of urban growth and industrial transformation, which I had absorbed during my architectural training (largely defined by the histories of European and American urbanism), by appropriating critical methods from postcolonial theory, Marxist geography, and inter-Asian cultural studies. In my study, Singapore, Seoul, and Taipei are burgeoning postcolonial metropolises that

exhibit their own logic of urbanism, one built on the wreckage of colonial histories, violent decolonization, cold war geopolitical divides, and rapid—sometimes militarized—capitalist modernization. Literary and filmic texts on these "rising" urban centers, I argued, reveal both multiple desires and conflicted histories of these urban transformations.

To take one example, postwar programs of urban growth were undertaken on a massive scale in Singapore, Seoul, and Taipei; these were hugely vexed operations that often involved the ruthless disciplining and concentration of urban labor forces. Yet this process nevertheless helped these nations insert themselves into the new postwar international division of labor and its shifting geographies of manufacturing. Rather than trace such processes in separate case studies, I was interested in how the spatiality of the literary or cinematic text calls forth *inter*-Asian stories and experiences beyond official nationalist historiographies that trumpet "miracle" GDP growth rates or skyrocketing export levels. What this narrative remapping shows is that triumphant stories of growth—urban, industrial, economic—look very different at the level of gendered, migrant, and classed social narratives.

Thus, in a foundational novel that documents Singapore's rapid economic development during the early years of the People's Action Party rule, Goh Poh Seng's 1972 *If We Dream Too Long* reveals the way the heady growth of the nation's productive capabilities is predicated on the shrinkage of both the individual's space and her sense of possible futures. This mode of alienation is given literary expression in the novel's repeated attention to the transformation of the cityscape by the mass construction of Housing and Development Board (HDB) apartment blocks, which replaced the colony's overcrowded port city and scattered *kampungs* with a ring of rationalized, high-rise housing complexes connected by an island-wide transportation network. In Hou Hsiao Hsien's films of the early New Taiwanese Cinema, I explore a parallel narrative mode that I call the "sideliner aesthetic." In films like *Dust in the Wind* (*Lian lian fengchen;* Hou 1986), we witness the simultaneously spatial and social alienation of rural youth who migrate to industrializing cities like Taipei or Kaohsiung. Hou's films aesthetically mediate the Nationalist Party's (Kuomintang, or KMT) post-1949 rule on the island and Taiwan's manufacturing takeoff through a muted, spaceless visual aesthetic.

At stake in telling such stories is moving beyond the "exceptional geographies" of Asia's now advanced industrialized countries—geographies promoted by Singapore's longtime prime minister Lee Kuan Yew through notions such as the First World Oasis in the Third, and by the World Bank's 1993 publication *The East Asian Miracle.* My tack in rethinking these geographies and urban spaces borrows from Chen Kuan-hsing's imperative to do inter-Asian comparative work, or to approach "Asia as method." I use my own idiosyncratic training in architecture, cultural theory, Asian languages (ongoing and never perfected), and postcolonial studies to create a new critical idiom, which allows me to think about the embeddedness of Asian cities in both regional decolonizing landscapes and the larger global frame of shifting capitalist cores and peripheries. Global Asias, to me, is very much as Shaolu put it in one of our conversations: "a dynamic process, rather than a static region."

In my more recent work on cold war political cultures of decolonization in the region, I again misappropriate and recombine certain disciplinary methodologies. For this research, I sought to interrogate the geopolitical boundaries of the "free world" in Asia, or those decolonizing countries that allied with the United States in the global fight against communism. *Cold War Reckonings* (2021) again takes an inter-Asia, comparative approach in order to consider cultural production on and of several authoritarian regimes: the military dictatorship in South Korea (1961–1987), PAP-governed Singapore under Lee Kuan Yew (1959–1990), the Marcos years in the Philippines (1965–1986), and Suharto's Indonesia (1965–1998).

In this project, I bring European and postcolonial thinkers on the problem of freedom—from Europe, Kenya, South Africa, the Caribbean, and Latin America—to bear on the region, while also building on recent scholarship from global cold war studies (Westad 2007). In a kind of methodological chiasmus, I marshal postcolonial theorists and Asian and Asian American studies scholars to trouble the assumed North Atlantic geography of the cold war, while global cold war scholars helped me recognize the blind spots of postcolonial thinking (especially that emanating from South Asia), in which "bipolar history [is relegated] to an analytic void" (Kwon 2014, 64–84). In other words, I use the decolonizing–cold war matrix to think about the way decolonization—typically figured as the

vertical relationship between colonizer and colonized—is cross-hatched by the East-West geopolitical contest of the cold war. Examining literature, film, and cultural production that emerged from this conjuncture, I read decolonization both as a fertile opening that enables new political possibilities and as an unstable nexus that too often was instrumentalized by nationalist regimes backed by that global "protector" of liberal freedom, the United States.

We might think of this project, too, as advancing an a/geographic rending of Global Asias. For a start, the geographies both of the cold war and of decolonization look rather different when reconfigured as imbricated processes. On the one hand, the cold war must be reconceptualized less as a bloodless North Atlantic ideological standoff and more as a set of hot wars and counterinsurgency campaigns that fractured Asia through devastating violence. On the other, our mental mapping of postcolonial studies and decolonization must also be altered. Comparing, for example, retrospective narratives of anti-communist violence in Indonesia's mass killings of 1965–1966 and in the Gwangju Uprising of 1980 (in Joshua Oppenheimer's *The Act of Killing* [*Jagal,* 2012] and Han Kang's *Human Acts* [*Sonyŏni onda,* 2014], respectively), this research reveals such sites as pivotal—and indeed central—to the *global* rollback of anti-capitalist, decolonizing demands. The fact that we so rarely remember these events or places on a global stage has everything to do with the way our apparently post–cold war, post-ideological present has been predicated on the very success of anti-communist violence. It also allows us to see how postcolonial studies has been shaped by its own centers and peripheries. Those violent, contested geographies of the global cold war in Asia remain deep but unacknowledged components of our neoliberal, postcolonial present.

Parts of this research aim to activate other geographic imaginings: the archipelago of Singaporean political exiles in London, Betong, or Shah Alam who are excluded from Singapore's spectacular rise to global modernity (Tan Pin Pin's *To Singapore, with Love* [2013]); or the black holes of political imprisonment on Indonesia's Buru Island or Camp Crame in the Philippines, which detained writers Pramoedya Ananta Toer and Ninotchka Rosca, respectively. These other imaginaries—or a/geographies—of decolonization's liberation struggles, I suggest, remain active possibilities in the literary and cinematic archives that were produced from

these conditions. They remain potent resources for our present and the various ongoing struggles for self-determination and decolonization.

Autobiographical Reflection on Global Asias—A/Geography

Shaolu Yu

> *I do not use other people's struggles as the basis for my research; I use my research as a basis for struggles of which I am a part.*
>
> —A. Kobayashi (1994, 78)

I feel conflicted about the term "Global Asias." To me, "global" suggests the power of top-down force. Global is colonial. Global is simultaneously homogenizing and polarizing. Asia, a geographical idea that is more imagined than real, is itself a colonial construct. There is no such thing as Asian food, nor Asian culture, nor Asian language. Asia, a geographical term, is further used as a racial construction by Western countries. Asia is exotic, Asia is threatening, Asia is yellow and brown, Asia is the other. Asian Americans are excluded from the imaginary of what an American should be.

"Global Asias" is my research focus. I study and teach Asian urbanization under the impact of globalization, and the Chinese diasporic communities in New York City and in the American South. Research and personal life are inseparable to me. I study Global Asias, and I live through the impacts of Global Asias. Thus, I choose the format of the autobiographical essay for the individual piece around the keywords "a/geography" and "Global Asias."

I grew up in mainland China in the 1990s during a time when the nation was just opening its market to the world. As the nation celebrated its increasing material abundance and influx of Western products, my family could not afford a meal in the newly opened KFC right down the street. Both of my parents were laid off, as all the previously government-owned industries went through privatization during the economic reform after China was officially accepted into the World Trade Organization

(WTO). From early on in my childhood, I learned that there is a cost to globalization.

Around 2010, I was conducting research for my master's thesis in urban geography and my focus was the booming central business district (CBD) in Beijing. Major cities in China were competing fiercely for foreign direct investment (FDI), and CBDs were built overnight to attract multinational corporations. Soon enough, the historical neighborhoods in the core of Beijing along with their *hutong,* street vendors, mom-and-pop corner stores, and elderly people playing chess in the alleyways, were replaced by skyscrapers, bars, Starbucks, shopping malls, gated neighborhoods exclusively for Western expats, and international schools for their children (figure 5.3). Beijing is New York is Tokyo is London. The postcolonial homogenization and "Manhattanization" of native vernacular geography are another cost of globalization, a cost that cannot be compensated by GDP or FDI.

In the year 2010, I joined the wave of international students and migrated to the United States, to pursue my doctoral degree in geography at the University of Connecticut. Feeling homesick and nostalgic, I took a



Figure 5.3. Shaolu Yu, *Pizza Hut in Historical Hutong,* 2022. Digital photograph.

trip to Chinatown in New York City. I was struck by the Chinese enclave formulated in the heart of Manhattan. Many Chinatownians work day and night in restaurants and sweatshops, hoping to realize their "American dream" and a better future for their children, while supporting a glamorous image of New York City as a cosmopolitan and multicultural global city. For some, this American dream became a nightmare. Others, such as transnational Chinese immigrants who benefited from China's economic boom and became "crazy rich Asians," brought their capital to Chinatowns, building upscale hotels, supermarkets, and apartment buildings. Gradually, the working-class Chinese were either pushed farther away from where they worked or pushed downward to the basement in substandard housing. My doctoral dissertation attempted to unpack this paradox of transnational mobility and local immobility among Chinese immigrants in Flushing, Queens, New York City, the largest Chinese community in the United States at the time of the study (Yu 2017). Globalization mobilizes immigrants at a transnational scale, yet paradoxically immobilizes them at a local scale (figure 5.4).

My relocation to the American South in 2015 brought me to Global Asia in history. After emancipation, White plantation owners in the South feared a shortage of Black laborers and the decline of their competitive advantage among the world's major cotton producers. They attempted to import Chinese coolies to work on cotton plantations, in the hope of replacing Black laborers. They legitimized the importation of Chinese people by racializing them as "docile and apolitical" in contrast to Black people, who were racialized as "dangerous and lazy." There started the appearance of Chinese immigrants in the South. But instead of working in cotton plantations, the Chinese immigrants opened grocery stores mostly located in Black neighborhoods (figure 5.5). These grocery stores served as one of the most racially intermingled spaces in the Jim Crow South, complicating the Southern landscape of labor, race, and culture (Yu 2021, 97–122). Globalization and migration are largely driven and shaped by racial capitalism, under which citizenships are contingent. As later generations of Chinese Southerners have gained mobility through education, they are still perceived to be perpetual foreigners and were deemed dangerous aliens during the COVID-19 era.



Figure 5.4. Shaolu Yu, *Intersection at Main and Roosevelt Avenues in Flushing, Queens, New York City*, 2022. Digital photograph.



Figure 5.5. Shaolu Yu, *Goon's Grocery Store, Clarksdale, Mississippi*, 2022. Digital photograph.

If the prefix "a" of a/geography means to "negate" in a global era, then I would argue for the opposite. Globalization, coupled with neoliberalism, does not make the world flat and geography meaningless. Far from that fantasy of a global village, globalization is a divergent, heterogenous, and polarizing process. Asias, being both recipients and drivers of globalization, are plural because of the differentiation of geography, history, culture, and political and economic systems. Global Asias occur not only within Asia but around the world, especially in receiving regions where generations of diasporic Asian migrants have left their footprints in cultural, economic, and social landscapes. So Global Asias are a heterogenous process that largely shapes an uneven world geography. Global Asias should be understood as a circular and dynamic process, rather than a static region. "Asias," rather than "Asia," suggests the coexistence of multiple truths, sometimes contradictory to one another. "Global" suggests that it is impossible to understand Asias without understanding its relationships with/in the global system, the relationships between global and local, between region and scale.

I would rather understand "a" as "trans": occupying and crossing the space of in-betweenness and margin, and challenging the boundaries between time, geographical regions, disciplinary traditions, and identities. "Trans" is deeply embedded in differentiation, heterogeneity, and power geometry, without which "crossing" will have no meaning. Thus, borders, localities, and cultural identities matter more than ever in a seemingly shrinking world. Complex and nuanced geographies and counter-geographies occur when these physical, social, cultural, and political boundaries are being crossed. Spaces of unrest, uncertainty, controversy, resistance, and empowerment are thus created. These zones of in-betweenness go beyond the structural dichotomy of the developing/developed world, of Black and White racial bifurcation, of origins and destinations, of us and them. As Gloria Anzaldúa wrote in her *Borderlands/La Frontera* (1987): "Living in a state of psychic unrest, in a Borderland, is what makes poets write and artists create."

Conclusion

What are your final thoughts on a/geographies?

Jini Kim Watson: Where to, for Asian a/geographies today? The question must be answered by asking about, probing, and intuiting those remappings that are currently impossible to imagine. In our current moment of renewed and self-reproducing authoritarian regimes, can we imagine a geography of liberation that could link Palestinian or Hong Kong's struggles for self-determination with leftist resistance to the revived Marcos regime, with opposition to the neocolonialist occupation of Kashmir—as Omer has importantly discussed? What connections and cartographies of solidarity are possible?

Omer Aijazi: There is *always* an alternative. The International Monetary Fund (IMF) is creating havoc in Asia. Countries spiraling into bankruptcy are being coerced into accepting the institution's anti-life policies: "TINA: there is no alternative," they are told.[11] I hope the reader walks away with the encouragement that there is *always* an alternative. And that the work of alternate world/s-building is difficult and contentious, and that no one is unequivocally qualified to take on this enormous task—but that shouldn't keep us from trying. The limits of our words form the limits of our world/s; a/geography is an addition to the growing lexicon on Asia, closely tied to epistemology—another keyword chosen for this volume. We selected a dialogical pedagogy to provide an alive portraiture of Global Asias—an imaginative task to which this book is dedicated.

Shaolu Yu: Yes on cartographies of solidarity, and yes on alternative geography. Perhaps "a/geography" could be "alternative geography."

After our heated and productive conversation about a/geography and Global Asias, the term "a/Global Asias" keeps appearing in my mind. While we are completing this essay, I am trying to find a feasible route to visit my parents in China, whom I have not visited for three years because of the pandemic: national COVID restrictions, border controls, lockdowns, quarantines, visa applications, reduced number of flights, and skyrocketing travel cost.

Perhaps the notion of Global Asias is romanticized, a Western-centric imagination, not far from Orientalism. Asias is not a singular place, but multiple and complex. And so often, "global" is equivalent to capitalism, neoliberalism, and Western standards. Singapore does not require visas for US citizens, but this privilege of border crossing is not granted to many other Asian countries. Does Global Asias center connections to the United States or interconnections among Asian countries? Have you heard of debates on Global United States, Global Australia, or Global Europe? Or perhaps they are global by default, because they are the "globe"?

In the spirit of a/geography, a/global is an alternative geography that decenters Western perspective, de-romanticizes a friction-free global village, and resists a singular narrative.

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Oppenheimer, Joshua, dir. 2012. *The Act of Killing* [Jagal]. Copenhagen: Final Cut for Real. Film.

Pellegrinelli, Lara. 2010. "Artist Tattoos Indelible Iraq Memorial into His Skin." NPR, June 1, 2010. https://www.npr.org/2010/06/01/127348258/artist-tattoos-indelible-iraq-memorial-into-his-skin.

Said, Edward W. 1978. *Orientalism.* New York: Pantheon.

Sansour, Larissa, and Søren Lind, dirs. 2015. *In the Future They Ate from the Finest Porcelain.* Video clip, 1:27. https://vimeo.com/148158228.

Saraf, Aditi. 2020. "Frontiers." In *Oxford Research Encyclopedia of Anthropology.* Accessed July 17, 2022. https://oxfordre.com/anthropology/view/10.1093/acrefore/9780190854584.001.0001/acrefore-9780190854584-e-145.

Sedgwick, Eve Kosofsky. 2003. *Touching Feeling: Affect, Pedagogy, Performativity.* Durham, NC: Duke University Press.

Simpson, Leanne Betasamosake. 2011. *Dancing on Our Turtle's Back: Stories of Nishnaabeg Re-creation, Resurgence and a New Emergence.* Winnipeg, Canada: Arbeiter Ring Publisher.

Smith, Neil. 1984. *Uneven Development: Nature, Capital and the Production of Space.* New York: Blackwell.

Snedden, Christopher. 2005. "Would a Plebiscite Have Resolved the Kashmir Dispute?" *South Asia: Journal of South Asian Studies* 28, no. 1:64–86.

Spivak, Gayatri Chakravorty. 2003. *Other Asias.* Malden, MA: Blackwell.

Stein, Gertrude. 2002. *Tender Buttons: Objects, Food, Rooms.* Los Angeles: Green Integer Books.

Tamim, Baba. 2014. "In Pictures: Kashmir's Parkour Generation." Al-Jazeera, August 31, 2014, https://www.aljazeera.com/gallery/2014/8/31/in-pictures-kashmirs-parkour-generation.

Tan, Pin Pin, dir. 2005. *Singapore GaGa.* Singapore: Infinite Studios. Film.

———. 2013. *To Singapore, with Love*. Film. Tan Pin Pin.

Wan, James. 2014. "Why Google Maps Gets Africa Wrong." *Guardian,* April 2, 2014. https://www.theguardian.com/world/2014/apr/02/google-maps-gets-africa-wrong.

Wang, Hui. 2011. *The Politics of Imagining Asia.* Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.

Watson, Jini Kim. 2011. "Introduction" and "Narratives of Human Growth versus Urban Renewal." In *The New Asian City: Three-Dimensional Fictions of Space and Urban Form.* Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press.

———. 2014. "A Not-Yet-Postcolonial Peninsula: Rewriting Spaces of Violence, Division and Diaspora." *Cambridge Journal of Postcolonial Literary Inquiry* 1, no. 1:69–87.

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Westad, Odd Arne. 2007. *The Global Cold War: Third World Interventions and the Making of Our Times.* Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Wood, Denis. 2010. *Rethinking the Power of Maps.* New York: Guilford Press.

Wood, Denis, and John Fels. 2008. *The Natures of Maps: Cartographic Constructions of the Natural World.* Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

World Bank. 1993. *The East Asian Miracle: Economic Growth and Public Policy.* New York: Oxford University Press.

Yu, Shaolu. 2016. "I Am Like a Deaf, Dumb and Blind Person": Mobility and Immobility of Chinese (Im)migrants in Flushing, Queens, New York City." *Journal of Transport Geography* 54:10–21.

———. 2017. "Mobilocality." *Urban Geography* 39, no. 4:563–586.

———. 2021. "Placing Racial Triangulation, Triangulating Place and Race: The Chinese Grocery Stores in the Mississippi Delta during the Jim Crow Era." *Annals of American Association of Geographers* 112, no. 1:97–122.

Pedagogy Forum

How can one teach a course on a/geographic understandings of Global Asias?[12] We offer here a syllabus of possibilities, a repository of resources and ideas that could be used for enlarging Asia/s as an intellectual formation and as a site of collaboration. As a work that intervenes in—rather than consolidates—knowledge production about Asia, it deliberately exceeds disciplinary boundaries and is as open-ended as possible. In the tensions and frictions embedded in the range of materials presented, emergent routes to Asia(s) are forthcoming outside the foreclosures of established knowledge pathways. Our aim is to unmoor Asia from current frames of legibility in favor of more expansive, experimental, and speculative a/geographies. The units are designed to be taken together or separately, as are the suggestions for student assignments and projects. Selecting and combining the suggested resources for different pedagogical outcomes is encouraged. The syllabus is organized around three analytics, divided here into three units: borderland, city, and mapping.

Unit 1: Borderland

The borderland is susceptible to hybridity and experimentation. It is where people are politically active, risks are taken, and change occurs. Borderlands are the frontiers of knowledge and aesthetics, where hegemonic normativity is questioned.

Listen. Podcast:

- Chace, Zoe. 2018. Episode 664: "The Room of Requirement, Act One: In Praise of Limbo." December 28, 2018. In *This American Life*. Produced by Zoe Chace. Podcast, 7:00. https://www.thisamericanlife.org/664/the-room-of-requirement/act-one-5.

  "There is a library that's on the border of Canada and the United States—literally on the border, with part of the library in each country. Producer Zoe Chace interviews journalist Yeganeh

Torbati about how lately, it's become a critical space for a surprising set of visitors" (from the podcast website).

Read. Historical and critical texts:

- Saraf, Aditi. 2020. "Frontiers." In *Oxford Research Encyclopedia of Anthropology*. https://doi.org/10.1093/acrefore/9780190854584.013.145.

  Diverse cultural and political institutions produce distinctive ideas of sovereignty, mobility, commerce, and community in the borderland.

- Giudice, Cristina, and Chiara Giubilaro. 2015. "Re-Imagining the Border: Border Art as a Space of Critical Imagination and Creative Resistance." *Geopolitics* 20, no. 1:79–94. https://doi.org/10.1093/acrefore/9780190854584.013.145.

  The imagination must be centered to make sense of creative resistance at the border.

- Guillo, Anna. 2016. "Border Art and Borders of Art, an Extra-disciplinary Approach." *antiAtlas Journal* 1. https://www.antiatlas-journal.net/01-border-art-and-the-borders-of-art/.

  On the border between art and knowledge, the map is a tool for explorers and world-builders.

Explore. Art and activism:

- Dictaphone Group. "Nothing to Declare." Performance intro. https://vimeo.com/64225987.
- Baaklini, Jad. 2013. "Nothing to Declare: A Review." Jadaliyya. https://www.jadaliyya.com/Details/29851.
- Noeth, Sandra. 2019. "Artistic Case Study: Dictaphone Group: *Nothing to Declare* (2013)." *Resilient Bodies, Residual Effects: Artistic*

Articulations of Borders and Collectivity from Lebanon and Palestine. Bielefeld: transcript Verlag, 145–174.

- "Defunct Railway Reflects a Country Divided." 2013. Free Library. https://www.thefreelibrary.com/Defunt+railway+reflects+a+country+divided.-a0342683205.

Nothing to Declare is a research-based lecture performance and video installation exploring borders within Lebanon, those between Lebanon and its neighbors, and across the Arab world. The project follows the journey of three women along Lebanon's old railway tracks, narrating their history and reflecting on borders as spaces of crossing, performance, and entrapment.

Write. Exploratory essay (suggested length 2,500 words, suitable for upper-level undergraduate students):

Guiding questions: When pushed to the margins, what new forms of political and aesthetic engagement are produced? How does embodied life trouble borders and boundaries? What opportunities and challenges do borderlands pose for our understanding of Asia/s?

Instructions: You are tasked with exploring a particular political, aesthetic, or lived practice arising from the Asian borderland. Choose a topic from the following list and use the sample resources listed for each topic to build your research outward, reflecting on the preceding guiding questions.

- Topic 1: Insurgent Music. Rap and hip-hop have arrived at the borderland.

  Associated Press. 2022. "'Resistance' Music Growing in Disputed Kashmir." Associated Press, July 4, 2022. Video clip, 3:04. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=PFRCRi2xpzo.

  Bakhsh, Zenira. 2022. "Dropping Bars, Slaying Stereotypes: The Rise of Kashmiri Female Rappers." *TRT World,* March 29, 2022. https://www.trtworld.com/magazine/dropping-bars-slaying-stereotypes-the-rise-of-kashmiri-female-rappers-55904.

  Inzmam, Qadir, and Haziq Qadri. 2021. "Political Hip-Hop Awakens Kashmir." *TRT World,* April 9, 2021. https://www.trtworld.com/magazine/political-hip-hop-awakens-in-kashmir-45750.

Islam, Muheet Ul, and Afzal Sofi. 2021. "Reviving 'Conscious' Hip-Hop in Indian-Administered Kashmir." *VOA News,* July 22, 2021. Video clip, 3:14. https://www.voanews.com/a/episode_reviving-conscious-hip-hop-indian-administered-kashmir-4754651/6117763.html.

Nabi, Safina. 2022. "Underground, but Undeterred: Why Kashmiri Rappers Sing in Secret." *Christian Science Monitor,* April 28, 2022. https://www.csmonitor.com/World/Asia-South-Central/2022/0428/Underground-but-undeterred-Why-Kashmir-s-rappers-sing-in-secret.

Rafiq, Shefali. 2021. "Koshur Hip-Hop: Inside an 'Underground' Cypher in Kashmir." *Kashmirwala,* November 1, 2021. https://thekashmirwalla.com/koshur-hip-hop-inside-an-underground-cypher-in-kashmir/.

- Topic 2: Art of Refusal and Resistance. Artist practice is pushing back against oppression and violence in Xinjiang, China.

Asman Collective (Archive). https://www.asmancollective.org/rise-performance-photos.

Camp Album Project. https://camp-album.com/about/.

Dagher-Margosian, Matt. 2020. "Preserving Uyghur Art and Culture amid Cultural Genocide." *SupChina,* May 5, 2020. https://supchina.com/2020/05/05/preserving-uyghur-art-and-culture-amid-cultural-genocide/.

University of British Columbia. Xinjiang Documentation Project. "Peasant Paintings." https://xinjiang.sppga.ubc.ca/teaching/visual-materials/peasant-paintings/.

University of British Columbia. Xinjiang Documentation Project. "Visual Storytelling." https://xinjiang.sppga.ubc.ca/teaching/visual-materials/visual-storytelling/.

- Topic 3: Culinary Histories. Eating, foraging, and cooking from family recipes and local ingredients show presence and continuity in a context of erasure.

Aijazi, Omer. 2019. "How to Be an Ally with Kashmir: War Stories from the Kitchen." *The Conversation,* August 18, 2019. https://theconversation.com/how-to-be-an-ally-with-kashmir-war-stories-from-the-kitchen-121801.

Bhutia, Anisa. 2022. "Cosmopolitanism, Food, and Memory: The Lhasa Restaurant of Srinagar." In *Routledge Handbook of Critical Kashmir Studies,* edited by Mona Bhan, Haley Duschinski, and Deepti Misri, 170–182. New York: Routledge.

Cho, Grace M. 2021. *Tastes Like War: A Memoir.* New York: Feminist Press at CUNY, 2021.

Dossa, Parin. 2014. *Afghanistan Remembers: Gendered Narrations of Violence and Culinary Practices.* Toronto: University of Toronto Press.

El-Haddad, Laila, and Maggie Schmitt. 2012. *The Gaza Kitchen: A Palestinian Culinary Journey.* Charlottesville, VA: Just World Books.

Himal Southasian. 2022. "Ways of Eating: A Mini-Series on Food in Southasia." *Himal Southasian,* February 21, 2022. https://www.himalmag.com/ways-of-eating-mini-series-food-in-southasia-2022/.

- Topic 4: Mobility and Movement. It is not so easy to get from point A to point B in Palestine.

Activestills. 2018. "Checkpoints: A Photo Essay by Activestills." Al-Jazeera. https://interactive.aljazeera.com/aje/2018/commuting-through-israeli-checkpoints/index.html.

Griffin, Maryam S. 2021. *Vehicles of Decolonization: Public Transit in the Palestinian West Bank.* Philadelphia: Temple University Press.

Israeli Information Center for Human Rights in the Occupied Territories. 2021. "List of Military Checkpoints in the West Bank and Gaza Strip." https://www.btselem.org/freedom_of_movement/checkpoints_and_forbidden_roads.

Peteet, Julie. 2017. *Space and Mobility in Palestine.* Bloomington: Indiana University Press.

Wick, Livia. 2011. "The Practice of Waiting under Closure in Palestine." *City & Society* 23:24–44.

- Topic 5: Human Rights Organizing at the Grassroots Level. "The Association of Parents of Disappeared Persons (APDP) has been engaged in documenting enforced disappearances in Kashmir since 1989 and has collected information on over one thousand such cases so far. On the 10th of each month, families of the disappeared come together under the aegis of APDP to hold a public protest in Srinagar to commemorate the disappearance of their loved ones and to seek answers from the state about the whereabouts of the missing persons" (from APDP, "What We Do," https://apdpkashmir.com/).

Association of Parents of Disappeared Persons (APDP). https://apdpkashmir.com/.

Fatima, Iffat, dir. 2018. *The Dear Disappeared.* Documentary, 47:14. https://apdpkashmir.com/the-dear-disappeared-2018-iffat-fatima/.

Zia, Ather. 2019. *Resisting Disappearance: Military Occupation and Women's Activism in Kashmir.* Seattle: University of Washington Press.

Unit 2: City

As sites that both *exceed* the nation—in terms of regional, imperial, or global networks—and operate *below* the nation—as local administrative, economic, and migration hubs—the complex cultural ecologies of cities in Asia are valuable for unsettling fixed cartographies and pluralizing Asia/s. *In this course, we use the city as a topographic anchor to consider literary and filmic narratives as counter-cartography.* Forged along, within, and against imperial cartographies, ethno-nationalist borders, geographies of "exceptional" Asian development, war, and migration experiences, the course texts make visible the complex set of forces that have shaped both urban sites and subjectivities. At the same time, we pay attention to the way squares, churches, barracks, malls, high-rises, streets, and subways function as contested narrative objects.

Each cluster of selected primary texts is paired with several key historical and critical texts, which help position and guide students' readings. A mixture of Anglophone and Asian-language (in translation) texts are included.

Part I. Cities of Encounter: Imperial Worlds and Subjects

Cities have been exemplary sites for the encounter between native, Indigenous, migrant, and imperial worldviews and subjects. They have therefore been crucial to perceiving, theorizing, and critiquing the racial, cultural, and geographical epistemologies of imperialism in Asia. How are anti-colonial subjectivities and movements imagined, figured, and narrated via spatial practices and tactics that exceed those of imperial geographical imaginaries? How are European and Asian sites brought into new relation through the transformation and traversal of colonial urban spaces?

Read. Historical and critical texts:

- Fanon, Frantz. (1961) 2004. "On Violence." In *The Wretched of the Earth.* Translated by Richard Philcox. New York: Grove.
- Hsia, Chu-Joe. 2002. "Theorizing Colonial Architecture and Urbanism: Building Colonial Modernity in Taiwan." *Inter-Asia Cultural Studies* 3, no. 1:7–23.
- Said, Edward. (1978) 1979. "Imaginative Geographies." In *Orientalism.* New York: Vintage.

Read. Literary texts:

- Rizal, José. (1887) 2006. *Noli me tangere* [Touch me not]. Translated by Harold Augenbraum. New York: Penguin.

  Manila, "San Diego": churches, barracks, mansions; Spanish colonial elites and the commoners; Filipino national

- Mao Dun. (1933) 2001. *Midnight* [Ziye]. Translated by Hsu Meng-hsiung. Amsterdam: Fredonia.

Shanghai: urban culture and consumption; labor; revolution; factories; stores

- Wu, Zhuoliu. (1946) 2006. *Orphan of Asia* [Ajia no koji]. Translated by Ioannis Mentzas. New York: Columbia University Press.

  Tokyo, Nanjing, Shanghai: the in-between Taiwanese colonial subject; comparative Asian urbanscapes

- Pramoedya, Ananta Toer. (1980) 1990. *This Earth of Mankind* [Bumi manusia]. Translated by Max Lane. New York: Penguin.

  Surabaya: urban modernity and print culture; nascent anti-colonial nationalist movement

Part II. Decolonization, Development, and War

The violent intersection of decolonization and the cold war in Asia forged new kinds of urban connections and solidarities, seen at one level in meetings such as the Asian-African Conference in Bandung, Indonesia, as well as in new migrant and refugee populations, rapid urban transformations, and changing experiences of the city. How can we approach the varied experiences, affects, and spatialities of decolonization through an urban lens? Texts in this section grapple with the violence of partition; refugee cities; cities and developmental regimes; rural-to-urban migration; experiences of war and exile.

Read. Historical and critical texts:

- Wright, Richard. (1956) 1995. *The Color Curtain: A Report on the Bandung Conference.* Jackson: University Press of Mississippi.
- Watson, Jini Kim. 2011. "Introduction" and "Narratives of Human Growth versus Urban Renewal." In *The New Asian City: Three-Dimensional Fictions of Space and Urban Form.* Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press.
- Alimia, Sanaa. 2022. "Introduction" and "Bulldozers and Violence in a Pakistani Settlement." In *Refugee Cities: How Afghans*

Changed Urban Pakistan. Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press.

Read. Literary texts:

- Chudori, Leila S. (2012) 2015. *Home* [Pulang]. Translated by John H. McGlynn. Dallas: Deep Vellum.

  Jakarta, Paris: post-1965 Jakarta; Indonesian exiles in Paris; diasporic community; food and cooking

- Huang, Chun-ming. (1974) 2001. "Sayonara/Zaijian" and "The Two Sign Painters [Liang ge youqi jiang]." In *The Taste of Apples*. Translated by Howard Goldblatt. New York: Columbia University Press.

  Taipei, Qishan/Kaohsiung: ethnic and gendered colonial legacies; spaces of leisure; construction labor and rural migrants; high-rise buildings

- Kim, Chi-ha. (1970) 2014. *Five Thieves* [Ojŏk]. Translated by Brother Anthony of Taizé. *Manoa* 27, no. 2:94–104.

  Seoul: architecture of corruption; slums, mansions; developmental dictatorship

- Liew, Sonny. (2015) 2016. *The Art of Charlie Chan Hock Chye*. New York: Pantheon.

  Singapore: graphic novel; authoritarian development; rewriting the "Singapore Story"

- Rosca, Ninotcha. 1988. *State of War: A Novel.* New York: Norton.

  Manila: colonialism, race, gender; urban revolt; pre- and postwar Manila

- Sidhwa, Bapsi. 1991. *Cracking India.* Minneapolis: Milkweed.

Lahore: partition violence; urban divisions; red-light districts; gender

Watch. Films:

- Ozu Yasujirō, dir. (1953) 2010. *Tokyo Story* [Tōkyō monogatari]. Tokyo: Shochiku. Film.

  Tokyo: postwar urbanism, Westernization, everyday life and the city

- Hsiao-hsien, Hou, dir. 1989. *City of Sadness* [Beiqing chengshi]. Taipei: Era Communications. Film.

  Keelung: interimperial transitions; 22.8 violence; White Terror

Part III. Neoliberalism and the City

The post–cold war era and the rise of neoliberal development in the region has seen widening gaps between rich and poor; the emergence of new urban consumer practices; and increased flows of people and goods as well as intensifying bordering practices. If Asian metropolises have often embodied the intersection of the colonial, the postcolonial, and the global, how might we understand them as both nodes of capitalist accumulation and sites of dispossession? This section explores a variety of literary and filmic genres that express such contradictions, including the "rags to riches" tale, speculative fiction, satire, and horror.

Read. Historical and critical texts:

- World Bank. 1993. *The East Asian Miracle: Economic Growth and Public Policy.* New York: Oxford University Press.
- Roy, Ananya, and Aihwa Ong. 2011. *Worlding Cities: Asian Experiments and the Art of Being Global.* Chichester, UK: Wiley-Blackwell.

Read. Literary texts:

- Adiga, Aravind. 2008. *The White Tiger.* New York: Free Press.

  New Delhi/Gurgaon: rural-to-urban migration; malls; gated apartment complexes; the rising tech city; class and caste

- Bae, Myung-hoon. (2009) 2020. *Tower* [T'awŏ]. Translated by Sung Ryu. Stockport, UK: Honford Star.

  "Beanstalk": 647-story tower as nation-state; speculative fiction; migration, urban surveillance, borders and security

- Shuang Xuetao. (2016, 2017) 2022. *Rouge Street*. Translated by Jeremy Tiang. New York: Metropolitan Books.

  Shenyang: post-market-reform China; working-class life; China's "rust belt"

Watch. Films:

- Wong, Kar-wai, dir. 1994. *Chungking Express* [Chongqing senlin]. Hong Kong: Jet Tone. Film.

  Hong Kong: Chungking mansions; romance; postcolonial/global; city as world

- Tan, Pin Pin, dir. 2005. *Singapore GaGa.* Singapore: Infinite Studios. Film.

  Singapore: city soundscapes; urban transformation; buskers; HDB blocks; MRT

- Bong, Joon-ho, dir. 2019. *Parasite* [Kisaengch'ung]. Seoul: CJ Entertainment Film. Film.

Seoul: urbanism of the haves and have-nots; subterranean lives

Write and Produce. Website or podcast (suitable for mid- to upper-level undergraduates):

Guiding questions: What role have representations of cities played in perceiving and complicating dominant spatial and cartographic imaginaries of Asia? How do urban forms enable a counter-mapping of subject positioning under imperial or global conditions? How do representations of urban spaces in Asia invoke affect, memory, labor, gender, modernization, and identity formation?

Instructions: In groups of two to three, write and produce either a website or a podcast that provides a lively, focused commentary on three to four texts from the course. Text or script should be the equivalent of ten to twelve pages (3,500–4,000 words) long. Aiming for a general, educated audience, make sure to include: adequate description of your texts; comparison across them in terms of theme, aesthetics, and specific treatment of urban spaces; and reflection on how your texts illuminate the critical and conceptual keywords of the course.

Unit 3: Mapping

We'll look at mapping of Asia in part I and mapping of Asian America in Part II.

Part I

Let's consider mapping Asia by Asia. How do maps of Asia made by Asia reflect and reinforce ideology and diplomatic relationships among Asian countries and between Asia and the world? This unit centers Japan as an example because of its well-documented cartography, which serves as both decorative art and practical guide for governing and administration. These maps trace Japan's history and geography in various global contexts, first as a place forced to open its border by the Western imperial power and then as a place becoming a colonizing empire itself.

Read. Historical and critical texts:

- Brotton, Jerry. 2014. "Empire: Kangnido World Map, 1402." In *A History of the World in 12 Maps.* New York: Penguin Books. https://www.sutori.com/en/item/kangnido-map-1402-europeans-were-not-the-only-ones-to-make-maps-in-fact-4144.
- Fedman, David. 2016. "Visions of a New Order in the Asia-Pacific." In *Cartographic Japan: A History in Maps.* Chicago: University of Chicago Press.
- Loh, Joseph. 2016. "Japan and the New Found World." In *Cartographic Japan: A History in Maps.* Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

View. Maps made in Asia:

- Kangnido World Map, 1402. Made in Korea. https://www.sutori.com/en/item/kangnido-map-1402-europeans-were-not-the-only-ones-to-make-maps-in-fact-4144.
- Map of Declaration of Greater East Asian Cooperation, 1942. Made in Japan. https://apjjf.org/-James-Orr/2692/article.html.
- Map of the World, Four Large Cities, early seventeenth century. Made in Japan. https://artsandculture.google.com/asset/four-large-cities-in-the-world-map-of-the-world-unknown-japanese-painter/NQFF3EzEWIpZyg.

Write. Short paper (1,500–2,000 words, suitable for introductory or intermediate undergraduates):

Guiding comments: The maps listed previously were the world maps made in Asia during different historical periods. Known as the earliest surviving map of the world made in Asia, the Kangnido map was produced in Korea under the influence of mapmaking in China during a time when China had dominant cultural influence in Asia. The second world map was made in an era when Japan was forced to embrace Western cultural influence through missionaries, traders, and military forces. The third map was made in Japan during World War II, as Japan declared its imperialism over

the Asia-Pacific region under the guise of building East Asian solidarity against Western colonialism.

Instructions: Compare and contrast these "world views" under various global and historical contexts, and refer to the assigned readings, while thinking about the following questions:

- What are the differences and similarities among the three maps' style, color, content, scope, and labels?
- Who were the cartographers?
- What were the purposes of the maps?
- Who were the political audiences of these maps?
- What were the differences in the relationships between Japan and Asia and Japan and the West that were reflected in these maps of three periods?

Part II

Let's turn now to mapping Asian America. What is the power of mapping? What are the relationships between mapping and social construction and control? What are some examples of counter-mapping as resistance against hegemony and for the formation of interracial/ethnic alliances? Part II will explore these questions by connecting the Chinatown map in the nineteenth century and the geography of anti-Asian incidents during the COVID-19 pandemic, as well as Latin Asian and Afro-Asian cartographies as counter-mapping practices that reshape the meaning of multiculturalism.

Read. Historical and critical texts:

- Thananopavarn, Susan. 2018. *LatinAsian Cartographies: History, Writing, and the National Imaginaries.* New Brunswick, NJ: Rutgers University Press.

This book recounts the overlapping and intersectional experiences among Asian and Latin Americans during the eras of US imperialism, World War II, and the cold war. In the call for resistance against Euro-American cultural pluralism, Thananopavarn attempts to decenter the United States and

argues that the Latin America contact zones should be the center of understanding multiculturalism in an increasingly transnational world.

- Yu, Shaolu. 2022. "Placing Racial Triangulation, Triangulating Place and Race: The Chinese Grocery Stores in the Mississippi Delta during the Jim Crow Era." *Annals of the American Association of Geographers* 112, no. 1:97–122.

This article documents the Black-Chinese space in the American South during the Jim Crow Era.

View. Maps of Asian Americas:

- Official Map of Chinatown in San Francisco, 1885. Cornell University Library. https://digital.library.cornell.edu/catalog/ss:3293857.
- Map of anti-Asian racism incidents since the COVID-19 pandemic. https://fordschool.umich.edu/news/2021/anti-asian-hate-poverty-solutions-supports-u-m-chronicle-location-nature-more-1000.

Write. Short paper (1,500–2,000 words, suitable for introductory or intermediate undergraduates)

Guiding comments: This assignment will help students reflect on the impacts of mapping on racial construction of Asian Americans in history and how that was transformed into anti-Asian racism during the COVID-19 pandemic.

Instructions: Look closely at the color scheme, legends, labels, scope, and any other major cartography elements of the two maps, while thinking about the following questions:

- Is mapping neutral? Why or why not?
- What are the possible social impacts of the Chinatown map on Chinese communities in the United States?
- What geographical patterns do you see in the map of anti-Asian racism during COVID-19? What are the connections between the Chinatown map in 1885 and the map of anti-Asian incidents in 2022?

Make a Map. Counter-mapping (suitable for introductory or intermediate undergraduates):

Guiding comments: This assignment will draw connections between literature and cartography. Read the introduction of *LatinAsian Cartographies* by Susan Thanaanopavarn and select one of the following chapters: chapter 1, "Imperialism and LatinAsian Cartography"; chapter 2, "WWII and Patriotic Racism"; chapter 3, "Cold War Epistemologies"; chapter 4, "LatinAsia Contact Zone."

Instructions: After finishing the assigned readings, draw a map of what Latin Asian cartography means to you. Add a 300-word reflection essay to explain your map by connecting it to the literature. Similarly, referring to the reading on Chinese-owned grocery stores in the Mississippi Delta by Shaolu Yu, what does Afro-Asian cartography look like?

Notes to Convergence 5

1. You will note that we have listed our names in alphabetical order. Unlike the conventions of some disciplines that give priority to the "first author," this research forum was executed with equal input from all three collaborators. We also want to acknowledge the meticulous work of Radhika Shah, who assisted us in the preparation of the final manuscript.
2. The trailer for the film can be viewed online: https://vimeo.com/148158228.
3. A generous insight shared by Naveen Minai, also an author in this volume.
4. See *Defining Lines: Cartography in the Age of Empire,* n.d.
5. See the exhibition's web page: *Ancestral Modern: Australian Aboriginal Art from the Kaplan & Levi Collection,* Frist Art Museum. 2017, https://fristartmuseum.org/exhibition/ancestral-modern-australian-aboriginal-art-from-the-kaplan-levi-collection/.
6. For more on the problematic naturalization of spaces, territories and peoples, especially in Western conceptions of geographical others, see Coronil 2019, 354–356.
7. I take up this ambition full on in my book (Aijazi 2024).
8. Watch the performance online: Kashmiri Cabbage Walker, "Walking the Cabbage in Lal Chowk Srinagar, Kashmir Dec. 20, 2015," April 29, 2016. YouTube video, 1:45, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=xA4B4TRA_fA.
9. See Kashmir Freerunning and Parkour Family—KFPF Facebook page, https://www.facebook.com/ kfreerun?ref=br_rs; Kashmir Freerunning and Parkour

Family—KFPF, "Sunday Parkour," October 25, 2020, Facebook, https://www.facebook.com/watch/?v=4582053378533702; Peerzada Adil Iqbal Shah, "Parkour and Numaish . . . A New Experiment," Facebook, September 14, 2021, https://www.facebook.com/1247955452/videos/727622354861292; Peerzada Adil Iqbal Shah, "Major missing.. . . . ," Facebook, June 7, 2021. https://www.facebook.com/1247955452/videos/10218318597096803/.

10. See Kashmir Bicycle Movement Facebook page, https://www.facebook.com/KashmirBicycleMovement/.
11. TINA (not to be confused with Tina Chen, the coeditor of this volume) is a totalizing phrase that can be traced back to the Victorian philosopher Herbert Spencer, and later to Margaret Thatcher, and their love of capitalism and free markets.
12. These pedagogical materials were created with equal input from all three collaborators. Note that all web links included here are active at the time of publication, acknowledging that not all will necessarily remain so. This reflects the decentralized nature of mapmaking and the fact that knowledge production is not always captured via official institutions.

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